



THE EMOTION THESAURUS:

*A Writer's Guide to
Character Expression*

SECOND EDITION



EXPANDED
to 130 entries

ANGELA ACKERMAN
& BECCA PUGLISI

THE EMOTION THESAURUS:

A Writer's Guide to Character Expression

Second Edition

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OceanofPDF.com

THE EMOTION THESAURUS: A WRITER'S GUIDE TO CHARACTER EXPRESSION.

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~To AAD and SDJ, with all our love~

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INTRODUCTION TO THE SECOND EDITION

When we first released *The Emotion Thesaurus* almost seven years ago, it was with enormous trepidation. This was our first nonfiction project, and what we didn't know about self-publishing would have filled its own book. What we did recognize was our own difficulty conveying character emotion in a way that would engage readers. This problem is a big one, because only when the character's emotions are clearly shared can readers become more involved. We wanted to ensure that our character's feelings would trigger the reader's own emotional memories, encouraging empathy that would draw them deeper into the story. Based on a hunch that other writers also had this problem, we set out to provide a solution with *The Emotion Thesaurus*. It wasn't clear just how common the problem was until we saw the response to our book—a response that continues to amaze and humble us.

Our hypothesis confirmed, we dug deeper into this topic, and as we expanded our own knowledge, it became clear that we had more to share. Hence, our decision to release an updated edition of *The Emotion Thesaurus*.

The instructional material in the first part of the book continues to offer its unique how-to cocktail of writing emotion and show-don't-tell tips but with some powerful new additions. It's been expanded to include a section on how dialogue can and should be used to convey a character's feelings. We've also explored the critical part subtext plays in natural conversation and how it can be written to show hidden emotion. And because backstory figures so heavily into characterization, we've added information on what research should be done to establish your character's wounding events and emotional range, which will allow you to write their responses realistically and consistently.

As for the emotions themselves, we now have a total of 130 entries, each of which contains a list of the physical cues, thoughts, and internal sensations that, chosen thoughtfully, will enable you to create the perfect responses for your character. We've added power verbs so you can choose stronger words to describe associated actions, and sets of escalating and de-

escalating emotions to help you visualize where a character might naturally go next.

In short, we hope you'll find the second edition of *The Emotion Thesaurus* to be even more useful than its predecessor. Our goal, as always, is to give you the methods and brainstorming tools that make it easier to write emotional moments that are fresh and evocative.

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THE POWER OF EMOTION

All successful novels, no matter what genre, have one thing in common: emotion. It lies at the core of every character's decision, action, and word, all of which drive the story. Without emotion, a character's personal journey is pointless. Stakes cease to exist. The plot line becomes a dry riverbed of meaningless events that no reader will take time to read. Why? Because above all else, readers pick up a book to have an emotional experience. They read to connect with characters who provide entertainment and whose trials may add meaning to their own life journeys.

As emotional beings, feelings propel us. They steer our choices, determine who we spend time with, and dictate our values. Emotion also fuels our communication, allowing us to share meaningful information and beliefs with others. And while it may seem that most exchanges happen through conversation, studies show that up to 93% of communication is nonverbal. Even in instances where we try not to show our feelings, we are still sending messages through body language and vocal cues. Because of this, each of us becomes adept at reading others without a word being said.

As writers, we must take our innate skills of observation and transfer them to the page. Readers have high expectations. They don't want to be told how a character feels; they want to experience the emotion for themselves. To make this happen, we must ensure that our characters express their feelings in ways that are both recognizable and compelling to read. Thankfully, the media for conveying emotion are customizable, so with a bit of elbow grease, writers can craft original, authentic responses personalized to every individual in the story.

VEHICLES FOR SHOWING EMOTION

Dialogue is what we use to articulate our ideas, thoughts, beliefs, and needs, all of which are driven by our emotional state. What we feel always propels us, but it is rare to refer to those feelings directly in conversation. So while dialogue is a proven vehicle for sharing a character's emotions, it rarely should do so alone. To convey feelings well, a writer should also utilize nonverbal communication, which can be broken down into four additional vehicles: vocal cues, body language, thoughts, and visceral reactions.

Vocal Cues are shifts in the voice that supply readers with valuable hints about the speaker's emotional state. In conversation, there isn't always time to think about how to react, so while a person might disguise their true feelings by choosing their words carefully, their tone of voice or the flow of words won't be as easy to control. Hesitations, a voice that changes tone or pitch, words that suddenly slide out faster—all of these are terrific indicators that a character's emotions have changed and there's more to the exchange than meets the eye.

Vocal cues can be especially useful for showing the feelings of a non-point-of-view character, since, in most written viewpoints, their direct thoughts cannot be shared with the reader.

Body Language is how our bodies outwardly respond when we experience emotion. The stronger the feeling, the more we react and the less conscious control we have over movement. Because characters are unique, they will express themselves in a specific way. Combine the vast number of physical signals and behaviors found in this book with the individuality of each character, and a writer's options for showing emotion through body language and action are virtually limitless.

Thoughts act as a window into the mental process that corresponds with an emotional experience. A character's internal monologue is not always rational and can skip from topic to topic with incredible speed, but utilizing that mental response to express emotion is a powerful way to convey how they see their world. Thoughts also add a layer of meaning by illustrating how people, places, and events affect the POV (point-of-view) character and can help showcase their voice.

Visceral Reactions are the most powerful form of nonverbal communication and should be used with the most caution. These internal sensations (heart rate, light-headedness, adrenaline spikes, etc.) are raw and uncontrolled, triggering the fight-flight-freeze response. Because these are instinctive reactions, all people experience them. As such, readers will recognize and connect with them on a primal level.

The very nature of these heightened responses requires writers to take special care when using them. Relying too much on internal sensations can create melodrama. Also, because visceral reactions are limited, a writer can inadvertently use clichéd phrasings when describing them. A light touch is

needed with this type of nonverbal communication, as a little goes a long way.

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CHARACTER RESEARCH: WHAT TO KNOW TO WRITE AUTHENTIC EMOTION

In the real world, no two people are alike, which means each of us expresses emotion in our own way. Some people find it perfectly natural to share what they feel with those around them, experiencing little to no discomfort with their emotions being on display. Others find the idea of revealing what they feel horrifying and will avoid situations that could lead to such vulnerability. Most fall somewhere between these extremes. This spectrum of expressiveness is called an **emotional range**, and it will influence not only which feelings a person overtly shows but when and how they will manifest. While each person tends to stick to a specific area of the spectrum overall, situations where emotions are heightened can cause a shift one way or the other.

Interestingly, while we are each unique in our expressiveness, this individuality originates from the same place for everyone: our collective pasts. Upbringing, education, experiences, beliefs, and personality will all determine who we are and how we go about showing our emotional selves to the world.

As writers, one of our biggest goals is to create characters who are true-to-life, so we want to strive for this individuality when we consider how they will express themselves. The best way to do this is to spend time digging into each character's backstory and uncover details that will show us how to design their reactions.

Backstory planning often gets a bad rap, because some writers dump that information into a scene as exposition, believing that readers must know every detail to fully understand the forces at work in the character's life. The reality is that most backstory is for the writer, not the reader. Like a GPS is helpful for navigating a new city, understanding key details about a character's life prior to the story's start makes it easier to write actions, choices, and decisions that will align with who they are. Not only will this draw readers in through active characterization, it also creates intimacy and puts the character's emotions directly on display through specific behaviors and mental processes.

The amount of backstory planning each character requires will vary depending on their role in the story, but since everyone is a product of the past, there are two universal areas worth exploring: the **important people** in your character's life and the **impactful experiences** that have stayed with them.

Because we're social creatures, when it comes to navigating life, we tend to look to others, especially those who are closest to us. They help us form beliefs and values and teach us how to behave and what to feel. Unfortunately, the people who have the most access and influence are not always the most supportive or functional, meaning not all our life lessons are positive ones. This is important to remember when thinking about who from your character's past served as an example or influenced them. Specifically ask yourself: *Who shaped my character's views on emotion, and did they pass on functional or dysfunctional attitudes and behaviors?*

For example, a character whose parent belittled her every time she cried as a child learns an unspoken lesson: it is better to hide emotion than share it openly. After being repeatedly invalidated in this way, the character will most likely become evasive or even lie about what they feel because they believe anything else will lead to ridicule and judgment.

Likewise, people who serve as positive influences for your character will convey healthy ideas about emotion. A character with an older brother who vocalized his feelings and used them to positively sway others will see that emotions are powerful and can become a vehicle for change. Provided our character looked up to his older sibling, he will likely adopt this same attitude and behave the same way, understanding that other people will connect to him better if he shows what he feels.

Just as important people in your character's life helped shape how they express emotion, certain experiences can also be formative. Imagine a natural disaster, perhaps a flood that destroys much of your character's neighborhood. In the aftermath, he's utterly devastated by the destruction of his home and feels powerless at seeing the grief of his neighbors who have suffered a similar loss. When TV crews show up, he can't hold back what he feels, and he breaks down on camera, which causes an outpouring of support from the rest of the city. People come forward to bring food, offer everyone a place to stay, help with clean up, and donate needed items. Not only will this wave of compassion and empathy help alleviate the

character's despair, it will instill the belief that sharing your feelings results in getting what you need most. After this experience, it's very likely he will feel more comfortable displaying his emotions openly.

In addition to these two important backstory considerations, here are other areas worth brainstorming so you can zero in on how to show each character's feelings.

BASELINE REACTIONS

To understand how a character might react to the big moments of conflict and upheaval in the story, we need to establish a baseline of how they behave in everyday situations. Take the typical "long line at a grocery store checkout" scenario. In front of your character are six people, including the current customer who not only has more than the allotted fifteen items, he's constantly requesting price checks on them. How will your character react? Will he wait quietly, hating the slowness but knowing it would be futile to speak up? Or after a minute of fidgeting and fuming, will he drop his basket on the floor and shout at the cashier to open more registers?

In the first case, the character's baseline becomes obvious: it will take a lot more than a few wasted minutes to rile him up. But if the second reaction is his default, we know that when life starts chucking lemons at him, his rage cannon will fire.

Establishing this baseline will help you maintain consistency throughout the story. And if you want to push a character closer to one end of their personal emotional range, you'll know how hard the screw should be turned. So imagine a few benign scenarios that could be part of your character's normal day—a car that won't start, being late for an appointment, waking up sick, or plans changing at the last minute. It's worth the effort to imagine your character in situations like these to get a feel for how they will react.

DEMONSTRATIVE OR RESERVED

Another aspect to consider when determining emotional range is the natural level of expressiveness for your character. Some people are more reserved while others are demonstrative, and this preference shapes the types of expression they'll use.

Imagine a character learning that her adult children who have been living abroad will be returning home for Christmas. A reserved character may sit down to handle the surprise, a full smile brightening her expression. Her voice could warble as she speaks or she might reach out to her husband and give his hand a quick squeeze. A demonstrative character would react with more vigor, jumping up to crush her husband in a hug or making animated hand gestures as she rattles off every thought in her mind surrounding the happy news. Understanding your character's tendencies will help you plan body language and verbal cues accordingly.

COMFORT ZONES

Not everyone feels comfortable sharing emotion in all situations. Your character's expressiveness will likely shift depending on where they are and who they're with. In private, people generally don't hold back, but being around others can trigger a high degree of self-consciousness. If they feel exposed or are worried about being judged, they might rein in their emotions. However, if your character is surrounded by people they trust or others experiencing the same emotions, he or she will be more comfortable expressing their feelings. As a rule, if the character believes it's safe to show what they feel, they typically will; if they don't, they won't. Plan your scenes with this in mind.

Remember that the character's comfort zone will also extend to dialogue. Some people prefer to communicate more of what they feel while others remain tight-lipped. Likewise, your character will be more comfortable opening up to certain people, so let the nature of their relationships dictate how much is shared in each conversation. For ideas on how to convey hidden emotion through dialogue, see the section on subtext.

STIMULUS VS. RESPONSE

Not all characters have the same interests, fears, or beliefs, so how they feel in a given scenario will vary, eliciting different reactions. Imagine a spider crawling across the table where three of your characters are eating lunch. Carla is the first to notice it meandering through the wasteland of takeout wrappers and salt packets. She sucks in a strangled gasp and jerks back, causing her chair legs to shriek. The second to see it is Diane, who

leans away and crosses her arms. Finally, Therese spots the leggy creature. She smiles, plucks a discarded straw wrapper off the table and nudges the spider in a direction away from the group.

The same moment, the same stimulus...and three different responses. This is the nature of emotion. Carla's response is fear-driven. Diane displays wariness, assessing the spider as a non-threat while still protecting her personal space, clearly not wanting the creature to come closer. Therese is not bothered at all and only wants to send the spider on its way before one of her companions (likely Carla) demands its execution.

When it comes to various circumstances, we can't assume that every character will have the same reaction or even feel the same emotion. Life experiences and personality will ultimately decide how your character responds to any given stimulus. It may complicate things when members of the story's cast view the same situation through their own lens, but this incongruity can benefit writers, providing another great way to highlight the originality of emotion-driven behavior.

EMOTIONAL SENSITIVITIES AND INSECURITIES

A final way to ensure a unique emotional range for your character is to understand what insecurities and sensitivities lurk within. Every character will have soft spots: emotions that are avoided because they are uncomfortable or generate insecurity. Whenever one of these emotions crops up in a scene, your character will feel cornered, causing an instinct response to kick in: Fight, flee, or freeze.

These powerful, volatile reactions are an excellent way to show your character's deeper layers and can often offer readers clues about an **emotional wound**—a painful event that your character experienced but has never moved past. Like an anchor dragged through life's choppy waters, this old trauma creates relationship friction and holds her back from happiness and achievement. If you're writing a change arc, the emotional wound can derail your character's life. It must be examined and overcome if she is to grow and change into someone stronger who can handle the challenges standing between her and the story goal.

To illustrate the power of emotional sensitivities and how they can be used, consider this example:

After the ceremony, everyone mingled, their voices filling the garden. Linda drew in the scent of magnolias from her bouquet and then exhaled, casting out the last of her jitters. The wedding had gone perfectly; the wind behaved, no guest was short a chair, and no one in the bridal party had tripped or suffered a wardrobe malfunction during their walk down the grassy aisle. She could finally relax.

Sarah, the bride, stood in the middle of the lawn talking to a few guests. Sunlight glowed against her cheekbones and glinted off the scatter of crystals sewn into her dress and veil, a truly beautiful bride. After all her friend had been through these last years—losing her mother, the multiple miscarriages—Sarah deserved this perfect day with Tom.

Linda checked on the photographers setting up near the old oak and judged them close to ready. As maid of honor, she needed to keep everyone on a timeline, so she went to gather up the bride.

Before she could get there, Sarah bolted toward an older woman wearing a matronly purple dress and enveloped her in a hug. “Nana, you made it!”

Nana. The word knifed through Linda, jolting her to a stop.

“Silly girl. A delayed flight couldn’t keep me from making it to your special day.” She pulled back and cupped Sarah’s cheeks. “Such a beauty.”

Sarah took her grandmother’s weathered hands in her own. “I hope you know what it means to me, that you’re here. You’ve always taken care of me, and—”

“I love you, girl. Always will. Enough for both your mother and me.”

Linda’s eyes grew hot, a contrast to the cold weight crushing her lungs. This moment, this beautiful moment, was killing her.

“Oh gosh, Nana. Let me find my maid of honor so I can introduce you. She’s like a sister to me, and the only reason I’m still sane.”

Linda darted behind a group of wedding guests. The buzz of conversation drowned out Sarah calling her name, and Linda quickened her pace, heading for the French doors that would take her inside. The light was too bright, the rose garden too filled with sweetness. She couldn't breathe. She also couldn't tell her best friend that meeting her grandmother would be the most painful thing she could ask Linda to do.

It's clear in this example that something traumatic happened in Linda's past that involved her grandmother. Whatever it was, the stain of it is so great that watching her best friend share a loving, supportive moment with her Nana is too painful to bear, and so she flees.

Not only does this situation shine a spotlight on Linda's emotional sensitivities, it also provides a window into her past in a very active, non-dumpy way. Readers will now want to know more and keep reading in hopes of discovering exactly what happened. They will also root for Linda, hurting when she hurts, and wishing for her to find happiness so she can be freed from her difficult past.

Once you've established your character's sensitivities, you can use them to write scenes that evoke powerful feelings. This is easily done via the setting. Embedding **triggers** (like Sarah's grandmother) to awaken these insecurities or touch on a past wound allows you to reveal the point-of-view character's feelings. It also helps readers see exactly what is causing the elevated reaction.

USING DIALOGUE TO WRITE EMOTION

Once you've figured out who your character is and how their emotional responses are likely to manifest, you're ready to start writing. As was mentioned previously, communication happens both verbally and nonverbally, so writers need to be adept at using both to show a character's emotional state. Let's start with the former.

Dialogue is the primary way we communicate with others, using it to share ideas and information. It's also a big part of how we connect with people. This desire for closer relationships is why we go for coffee with friends, date our spouses, and nag at our kids to tell us about their day: we want to strengthen our connections, and the surest way of doing that is by sharing our feelings with each other. This happens because displaying our emotions requires vulnerability—peeling back the outer layers of shielding to reveal one's fragile heart—which almost always results in a deepening relationship.

One of the most natural ways to reveal your character's emotions is through their conversations with others. And it's important to get this element right, because readers are keenly aware of how these verbal exchanges work in real life. If you want to write dialogue that showcases your characters' feelings and rings true for readers, keep the following tips in mind.

UTILIZE PERSONALITY AND BACKSTORY

There's a reason you did all that research discussed in the previous section—because who your character is will determine how they respond emotionally to their circumstances. As an example, consider someone who must initiate a tricky conversation with their boss. How the exchange goes will be largely determined by the character's personality. Here's how it might look for someone who is timid or uncertain:

Jason tapped on the doorframe. The battle-axe didn't look up, just kept slashing through numbers on her sales report.

“Um, Mrs. Swanson?”

No response.

He shifted his weight, wondering how to proceed. He couldn't mess this up. He couldn't miss another of Kristina's games.

Jason shuffled half a step into her office. "Um...about this weekend? I know your email said I needed to work, but...Well, I kind of already have plans—"

"Cancel them," she said in a tone that was as forgiving as her Sharpie.

When he didn't answer, she looked up. His gaze dropped to the rug.

This conversation makes sense for a character with Jason's personality. But if the character were confident and not afraid of confrontation, it would go differently:

Dominic gave the door a rat-a-tat before opening it. "Hey, Mrs. Swanson."

Silence.

He cleared his throat, clenching his hand around the doorknob. "I can't work this weekend. I have plans."

"Cancel them," she said, not bothering to look up.

Heat shot through his insides, bringing him to his full height. "You can't make me work last minute." His voice was louder now, and he didn't care. "I can stay late on Monday but not this weekend. Best I can do."

That got her attention. She gave him her patented glare, and he glared right back. If she thought she could intimidate him with a staring contest, she'd never met his twelve-year-old.

Both characters begin this scenario with nervousness, but that emotion manifests differently based on the character's personality. This is why it's so important to do your background research beforehand, so you'll know your character's tendencies and how they're likely to respond when a curveball comes.

COMBINE THE VERBAL AND NONVERBAL ELEMENTS

When we think of dialogue, we almost always equate it with speech. But the truth is that dialogue consists of more than just the words being spoken. Body language is another component that's a part of every exchange. Omitting it will result in unnatural dialogue that will yank readers right out of the story. As an example, take a look at Jason's conversation with only the speech included:

“Um, Mrs. Swanson?”

“Um...about this weekend? I know your email said I needed to work, but...Well, I kind of already have plans—”

“Cancel them.”

While this still conveys Jason's nervousness, it says very little about his personality, and it reads awkwardly because this isn't how dialogue works. People shift positions when they speak, move around, and may even interact with objects as a way to focus. These movements, important for underscoring emotion, can also characterize, killing two birds with one stone and adding dimension to the scene.

The small actions that occur within a conversation are referred to as “beats” by Browne and King, authors of the excellent resource *Self-Editing for Fiction Writers*. Beats serve many purposes, one of which is to reveal how a character feels about the words they're saying. Jason's beats (the tentative tap on the door, the shifting weight and shuffling footsteps, his inability to hold her gaze) express his nervousness loud and clear. Cumulatively, they accomplish a secondary purpose by also revealing personality.

Vocal cues—changes in the voice and speech patterns—are also in evidence when the character is feeling emotional. We see this in Jason's hesitations and Dominic's volume getting louder.

So as you're crafting a conversation, consider your character's words carefully, but also think about what the emotion might be doing to their voice. And be sure to include beats that confirm for the reader what the character is feeling while also telling a little something about who they are.

TAKE IT EASY ON THE TAGS

Since we're talking about the words between the words, let's touch briefly on dialogue tags. These are the attributions that let you know who's talking—*he said*, *she muttered*, *they shouted*, etc. There are a lot of choices, and some of them do express emotion. Hissed words express a clear feeling, as do those that are mumbled, yelled, or sung. But after a while, these unusual tags begin to stand out and can give your writing an overworked or melodramatic feel.

This doesn't happen as much with the simple *said*, which is so common as to be virtually invisible on the page. Unless you overdo it, it can be used by all characters and won't feel repetitive. As far as expressive tags go, a good rule of thumb is to save them for important scenes or moments of high emotion. Use them sparingly and they'll work for your story instead of against it.

Another thing to remember is that tags aren't always necessary. If you're worried about readers being confused about who's talking, you can take care of this with well-written beats. Looking back at the previous examples, though quite a few words are exchanged, there is only one direct tag in each. But because of the associated beats, the conversations are easy to follow.

USE VOCAL CUES TO SHOW CHANGES IN EMOTION

As was mentioned earlier, the voice itself is another tool that can be used to show a character's emotional state. It's one of the first things to change when a strong feeling comes on, and initially, it's very hard to mask. If you can capture that brief moment when control of the voice is lost, you can indicate clearly to the reader that an emotion is in play. Consider doing so by experimenting with the following vocal elements.

Pitch: Does the voice get high and shrill or go low and rumbly?

Volume: Does the character move from a moderated volume to almost yelling? Does the voice drop to a near whisper? Is it clear that they're struggling to maintain a reasonable volume?

Tone: Does a clear tone turn breathy or husky when someone is aroused? When the character is close to tears, does the voice become brittle or cracked? Does it lose all expression and become flat when anger hits?

Speech Patterns: Does your verbose character suddenly clam up? Does her timid, verbally stumbling counterpart start running at the mouth? Does poor grammar appear in a well-educated character's dialogue? Does a stutter or lisp announce itself?

Word Choice: What words might slip into a character's vernacular when they're feeling emotional that they wouldn't normally use? Profanity and slurs? Words and phrases from their first language? Pat clichés?

If you've established a baseline for your character's normal speech and vocal patterns, a change can clue readers in that there's been an emotional shift. A word of warning, though: many of these cues can be used for multiple feelings. A trembling voice could indicate sadness, fear, uncertainty, anger, or nervousness, and without more information, the reader won't know which one the character is experiencing. For this reason, it's important to pair vocal cues with thoughts (if the point of view being used allows you to do so) or body language. Providing the situational context will also clarify things for readers.

MAKE YOUR DIALOGUE WORK HARDER

Conversations in real life are complex; while they're mostly about sharing or gaining knowledge, that's seldom the sole purpose of an exchange. Yet we often use dialogue in stories to do just that: reveal information to either the reader or another character. This can result in an info dump, with the author dropping a heavy load of backstory or narrative in the middle of the action. Info dumps are discouraged because they're boring and they slow the pace, causing reader interest to flag.

This doesn't mean that dialogue isn't a good vehicle through which to share information, because it is. That just shouldn't be the only purpose. To keep your verbal exchanges sharp and multi-dimensional, ask yourself the following question: What do my characters want from this conversation?

People have different reasons for communicating with each other. Some do it to connect while others just want to be affirmed (*Wow, Anne, that's so insightful!*). An overbearing person might seek control by dominating verbal interactions with his peers. Someone else might want to appear self-important by sharing juicy tidbits with their neighbors. On and on it goes.

When you know your character's goal in a conversation, you'll have a better idea of what they might do to achieve it: steering the exchange in a certain direction, manipulating the other party, avoiding topics, disengaging at a certain point, etc. This knowledge will give you a better idea of how the conversation will go.

It's also important to note that the participants may be looking for different things. This can lead to inherent conflict, since opposing goals will result in someone—possibly both characters—not getting what they want. Imagine Character A initiating a conversation because she's romantically interested in Character B, while Character B is responding because being friendly with Character A will get him something he wants (esteem, business connections, an alibi, etc.). Someone is going to be thwarted in this scenario—either immediately or down the road—and frustrated desires typically result in an influx of emotion, which is always good for piquing reader interest.

So, absolutely, use those verbal exchanges to reveal the information you want to get across, but don't do it in a vacuum. Keep the conversation interesting by considering each character's goal and using that knowledge to infuse emotion into the exchange.

SUBTEXT: WHAT LIES BENEATH

Writing realistic and evocative dialogue isn't easy. The mechanics can be tricky, but ample resources exist to help, and with enough practice, it can be mastered. But there's another truth we need to keep in mind if we're going to write dialogue effectively, and that is simply this: our communications with others are rarely straightforward. On the surface, it may seem like we're engaging in some simple back-and-forth, but if you look deeper, our conversations are, to some degree, carefully constructed. We withhold information, hide our emotions, dance around what we really mean, avoid certain topics, downplay shortcomings or emphasize strengths—all of which lead to exchanges that aren't totally honest.

Given this knowledge, if we write conversations between our characters that are completely candid, they're going to fall flat because that's not the way people generally deal with each other. Subtext is a huge part of dialogue, and it's often tied in some way to emotion, so we need to be able to include it in our characters' interactions.

Simply defined, **subtext** is the underlying meaning. In a conversation, you have all the obvious things happening on the surface—the words, the “acceptable” emotions on display. But then there are all the hidden elements that the character isn't comfortable sharing: their true opinions, what they really want, what they're afraid of, and emotions that make them feel vulnerable. These underlying elements are the subtext, and they're important because the character wants and is actively seeking (often on a subconscious level) to keep them hidden. This results in seemingly contradictory words and actions as the character tries to overtly convey something that isn't 100% true.

As an example, take a look at this exchange between a teenaged daughter and her dad.

“So how'd the party go?”

Dionne plastered on a smile and buried herself in her Instagram feed. “Great.”

“See, I knew you'd have a good time. Who was there?”

Her mouth went dry, but she didn't dare swallow, not with Dad watching her over his coffee mug. Despite the hour, his eyes

were bright and searching, twin spotlights carving through the mocha-infused fog.

“The usual. Sarah, Allegra, Jordan.” She shrugged. *Nothing to see here. Move along.*

“What about Trey? I ran into his mom at the office yesterday and she said he was going.”

“Um, yeah. I think he was there.” She scrolled quicker, the images blurring by.

“He sounds like a good kid. Maybe we could have him and his mom over for dinner.”

Her stomach lurched. “Oh, I don’t know.” Her phone trembled and she abandoned it, sitting on her hands to keep them still. “We don’t really hang with the same crowd.”

“Oh.” Dad grabbed an apple from the bowl before heading out. “Well, think about it. Couldn’t hurt to branch out and get to know some new people.”

Once his feet hit the stairs, Dionne blew out a shaky breath. How could her dad be so smart at work and so stupid about people?

Clearly, Dionne isn’t being honest with her dad. She’s conveying that everything’s fine, but under the surface, we see a different story: something happened at the party, it involved a boy she’s now avoiding, and she doesn’t want her father to know about it. While Dad is kept in the dark, the reader becomes privy to Dionne’s true emotions: nervousness, fear, and possibly guilt.

This is the beauty of subtext in dialogue. It allows the character to carry on whatever subterfuge she deems necessary with others while revealing her true emotions and motivations to the reader. It’s also a great way to naturally add tension and conflict. Without the subtext, this scene is fairly boring, just two people having a morning chat. With it, we can almost see the story playing out, with Dionne desperately trying to keep her secrets while it becomes increasingly difficult—maybe even unhealthy—to do so.

So how do we include subtext in our characters’ conversations without confusing the reader? Ironically, it’s fairly straightforward. It just requires combining the vehicles for showing emotion that were shared earlier—

dialogue, vocal cues, body language, thoughts, and visceral reactions. To see them in action, let's take a closer look at how they were used with Dionne.

First, we have her dialogue, which is unreliable; to some degree, we all go a little Pinocchio when we start talking, and Dionne is no exception. Her words subtly scream *status quo*: nothing happened at the party and she doesn't feel anything in particular. But her body language (the plastered-on smile, frantic social media scrolling, trembling hands) and visceral reactions (dry mouth, lurching stomach) tell a different story. Her thoughts are also purely honest; being private, this is how thoughts work.

The nonverbal vehicles are like annoying little brothers and sisters, tattling on the dialogue and revealing true emotion. When you put them all together, they fill out the character's narrative and paint a complete picture for readers to see.

OTHER TECHNIQUES TO SHOW HIDDEN EMOTION

Over- and Underreactions

When you've done the background work on a character, you know how they'll react to ordinary stimuli and will be able to write reliable responses. Readers become familiar with the character's emotional range and have an idea what to expect. So when the character responds to a situation in an unexpected way, it sends up an alert for readers that says, "Pay attention! This is important."

Sometimes this occurs with an overreaction; a seemingly normal situation comes along and the character freaks out. Not only does this tell the reader that something unusual is going on, it also creates an opportunity for the character to fly off the handle and cause more problems, worsening their situation.

Underreactions are more subdued and so contribute less ancillary conflict, but they are just as effective at revealing hidden emotion. Imagine a situation the reader knows should stun or disturb the character, but when it happens, they get...nothing, or an obviously controlled reaction. A downplayed response shows just as clearly that the character is afraid to

show their true feelings and so can be a good way to hint at undisclosed emotion.

Every story should include these scenarios that set the character off and cause them to react in unusual ways. Most of the time, the triggers will be tied to their backstory. The research you conducted on their wounds and sensitivities can provide you with specific situations or people that can be used to provoke the character in the story.

Tics and Tells

No matter how adept a character is at hiding their feelings, they all have their own tells—subtle and unintentional mannerisms that hint at deception. As the author, you should know your characters intimately. Take a close look at them and figure out what might happen with their body when they're being dishonest.

It could be a physical signal or behavior, such as covering the mouth, spinning a wedding ring, or biting the lip. Maybe it's one of the vocal cues discussed earlier. It might be a true tic, like a muscle twitch or excessive blinking. Figure out what makes sense for your character, then employ that tell when they're hiding something. Readers will pick up on it and realize that, when it's in play, everything is not as it seems.

Fight, Flight, or Freeze Responses

In the most general sense, the fight-flight-freeze response is the body's physiological reaction to a real or perceived threat. We see this in everyday interactions: when a person invades someone's space, stops what they're doing mid-action, or literally flees the scene. It also happens on a smaller scale in our conversations.

Remember that every character has an underlying purpose for engaging with others. When that purpose is threatened or the character feels unsafe, the fight-flight-freeze reflex kicks in. You can utilize this to great effect if you know which response your character tends toward.

Fight responses are confrontational in nature and may include the character turning toward an opponent to face them directly, squaring up her body to make herself look bigger, or insulting the person to put them on the offensive. Characters who lean toward flight will have reactions centering

around escape: changing the subject, disengaging from a conversation, stepping back to take oneself out of the group, or fabricating a reason to leave. If the character's fear or anxiety is triggered, they may simply freeze up, losing their ability to process the situation or find the words they need and being unable to act until something external happens to free them.

When characters exhibit a fight-flight-freeze response in conversation, even if their emotions aren't obvious, the reader will recognize that they're feeling threatened. This not only builds empathy on the character's behalf, it may also create intrigue as the reader pays closer attention to figure out why they're responding this way.

Passive-Aggressive Reactions

Passive aggression is a covert way of expressing anger. If a character is angry but doesn't feel comfortable showing it, they'll often default to certain techniques that will allow them to get back at the person without revealing how they really feel. By employing sarcasm, framing insults as jokes, giving backhanded compliments, and not saying what they really mean (*We're good*, or *I'll get right on that*), characters are able to express their feelings in an underhanded way that others may not recognize or know how to deal with.

This can be a tricky technique to use, because, by definition, passive aggression masks the truth. But you can reveal it through a character's thoughts, the physical signals they exhibit in private (particularly just after an interaction), and the cues they express when the other person isn't looking.

ADDITIONAL IDEAS FOR BRAINSTORMING FRESH EMOTION

With so many aspects to juggle, describing emotion in an evocative way can be a challenge. It's hard work to write something fresh-yet-familiar that puts readers into the character's emotional shoes so they can share the moment. Our thesaurus entries will help you brainstorm emotional expressions that can be transformed into unique descriptions befitting your character, but if you need ideas to supplement that information, try one of the following techniques.

MINE YOUR MEMORIES

Sit back from the keyboard for a minute and think about what emotion your character is feeling. There may be several, but one will be the root cause of the others. When you identify it, think about a time when you experienced this same emotion. Then, if you're comfortable doing so, recreate that moment in your mind and allow your body to respond to the memory. For example, let's pretend that we're dealing with guilt. What do you notice about your body—is there a faint, sour taste in your mouth? Is your stomach bunching up? Does your throat feel painful or constricted?

If it helps, get up and wander around. Pay attention to how your body moves in this instance of remembered guilt: are your arms curled around your torso or is your posture slumped? Are your eyes closed or open? Do you feel itchy, tingly, or uncomfortable?

Don't forget to pay attention to your thoughts; they can create a window for readers to look through and see exactly what your character is feeling and what's causing their reactions. Are you fixating on the people involved, perhaps someone you let down? Are you thinking about how awful it would be if others knew your secret? In fact, what would you do if someone came into the room right now and asked you about this situation?

Keep mining, paying attention to all aspects of yourself, inside and out, until you find an expression or response that would work well for your character. Then write it in an original way that fits their personality and emotional range.

PEOPLE WATCH

While you don't want to be labeled as creepy, watching people can yield great ideas for body language (and dialogue, if you happen to overhear their conversation). Look for everyday opportunities: waiting for your bill to arrive at a restaurant, shopping at a store, standing at a counter while a barista makes your coffee. Be respectful, but don't shy away from locations that could provide high emotion, because people who are visibly upset, excited, or frustrated are treasure troves of unique body movements.

If you do manage to overhear a conversation, pay special attention to vocal cues and speech patterns. Challenge yourself to spot pitch shifts, hesitations, throat-clearings, and other clues that are masking hidden emotions or are alluding to the speaker's true intentions.

TAKE NOTES DURING SCREEN TIME

Another terrific way to observe how people express a range of emotions is to pay attention to TV shows and movies. Unless they're purposely breaking the fourth wall, actors won't have the benefit of sharing an internal monologue with the audience. This means they must show what they feel through action and dialogue. Keep a pen and pad handy and jot down any well-expressed cues you might want to fold into your own storytelling.

If you aren't much of a moviegoer, you can also take notes as you read, paying attention to how other authors describe body language, expressions, vocal cues, internal sensations, and thoughts. While you should never reuse them verbatim in your own work, tracking strong, evocative description is a good way to recognize skillful showing and will give you a better idea of how to do the same but in your own way.

COMMON PROBLEMS WITH WRITING NONVERBAL EMOTION

It should be clear by now that both verbal and nonverbal communication are necessary and can be used in tandem to convey character emotion. We've discussed the verbal component at length. Now let's look at some of the common traps associated with nonverbal emotion and how to bypass them.

TELLING

By definition, nonverbal emotion can't be told. It has to be shown. This makes it difficult to write because telling is easier than showing. Here's an example:

Mr. Paxton's eyes were sad as he gave her the news. "I'm sorry, JoAnne, but your position with the company is no longer necessary."

Instantly, JoAnne was angrier than she'd ever been in her life.

This exchange is fairly easy to write—but not so easy to read. Readers are smart and can figure things out for themselves. They don't want to have the scene explained to them, which is what happens when a writer tells how a character feels. Another problem with telling is that it creates distance between the reader and your characters, which is rarely a good idea. In the preceding example, the reader sees that Mr. Paxton is reluctant to give JoAnne the bad news and that JoAnne is angry about it. But you don't want the reader to only see what's happening; you want them to feel the emotion and experience it along with the character. To accomplish this, writers need to show the character's physical and internal responses rather than stating the emotion outright.

JoAnne sat on the chair's edge, spine straight as a new pencil, and stared into Mr. Paxton's face. Sixteen years she'd given him—days she was sick, days the kids were sick—making the trip back and forth across town on that sweaty bus. Now he wouldn't

even look at her, just kept fiddling with her folder and rearranging the fancy knickknacks on his desk. Maybe he didn't want to give her the news, but she wasn't gonna make it easy for him.

The vinyl of her purse crackled and she lightened her grip on it. Her picture of the kids was in there and she didn't want it creased.

Mr. Paxton cleared his throat for the hundredth time.

"JoAnne...Mrs. Benson...it appears that your position with the company is no longer—"

JoAnne jerked to her feet, sending her chair flying over the tile. It hit the wall with a satisfying bang as she stormed out of the office.

This scene gives the reader a much better opportunity to share in JoAnne's anger. Through the use of thoughts, sensory details, a well chosen simile, specific verbs, and body cues that correspond with the featured emotion, readers can see that JoAnne is angry, but they also feel it—in the straightness of her spine and the cheap vinyl in her grip, in the force it takes to send a chair flying across the room simply from the act of standing.

An example like this also reveals a lot about the character. JoAnne is not well-to-do. She has children to support. She may be angry, but she's also strong minded, family-oriented, and proud. This information rounds out JoAnne's character and makes her more relatable to the reader.

Showing takes more work than telling, as word count alone will indicate, but it pays off by drawing the reader closer to the character and helping to create empathy. Once in a great while, it's acceptable to tell the reader what the character is feeling: when you have to pass on information quickly, or when you need a crisp sentence to convey a shift in mood or attention. But the other ninety-nine times out of a hundred, put in the extra work and you will reap the benefits of showing.

CLICHÉD EMOTIONS

The grin that stretches from ear to ear

A single tear pooling in the eye before coursing down the cheek

Quivering knees that knock together

Clichés in literature are vilified for good reason. They're a sign of lazy writing, a result of settling on the easy phrase because coming up with something new is too hard. Writers often fall back on clichés because, technically, these tired examples work. That grin implies happiness as certainly as knee knocking indicates fear. Unfortunately, phrases like these lack depth because they don't allow for a range of emotions. The single tear tells you that the person is sad, but how upset is she? Sad enough to sob? Shriek? Collapse? Will she even be crying five minutes from now? To relate to your character, the reader needs to know the depth of emotion being experienced.

When writing a certain emotion, remember to think about your body and what happens to it when you're feeling that way. For any given emotion, there are literally dozens of internal and external changes that, when referenced, will show the reader what your character is feeling. The lists in this thesaurus are great for providing ideas, but your own observations are just as helpful.

Secondly, know your character. Individuals do things differently—even mundane activities like brushing their teeth, driving, or making dinner. Emotions are no exception. Not every character will shout and throw things when angry. Some speak in quiet voices. Others go completely silent. Many, for various reasons, will cover their anger and act like they're not upset at all. Whatever your character is feeling, describe the emotion in a way that is specific to him or her, and you're almost guaranteed to write something new and evocative.

MELODRAMA

If all emotions were of average intensity, they'd be easier to describe. But emotions vary in strength. Take fear, for instance. Depending upon the severity of the situation, a person might feel anything from unease to anxiety to paranoia or terror. Extreme emotions will require extreme descriptors, while others are relatively subtle and must be described as such. Unfortunately, many writers make the mistake of assuming that to be gripping, emotion must be dramatic. Sad people should burst into tears.

Joyful characters must express their glee by jumping up and down. This kind of writing results in melodrama, which leads to a sense of disbelief in the reader because, in real life, emotion isn't always so demonstrative.

To avoid melodrama, recognize that emotions run along a continuum, from mild to extreme. For each situation, know where your character is on that continuum and choose appropriate descriptors. Just as extreme emotions call for extreme indicators, temperate emotions should be expressed subtly. The indicators for intermediate emotions will lie somewhere in the middle.

It's also very important that your character follows a smooth emotional arc. Consider the following example:

Mack tapped his thumb against the steering wheel, one arm dangling out the window. He smiled at Dana but she just sat there, twisting that one loop of hair around her finger.

"Worried about your interview?" he asked.

"A little. It's a great opportunity but the timing's awful. There's too much going on." She sighed. "I've been thinking about cutting back. Simplifying."

"Good idea." He nodded along with the radio and waved at the biker thundering past on his Harley.

"I'm glad you agree." She faced him. "I think we should break up."

His foot slipped off the gas pedal. The air grew heavy, making it hard to breathe. The car veered toward the middle line and he let it drift, not caring whether he lived or died.

Unless Mack has a psychological reason for doing so, he shouldn't jump from placidity to depression in a matter of seconds. A realistic progression would be to move from contentment to shock, then disbelief, and finally to grief. Done thoughtfully, this emotional arc can be shown with relatively few words:

"I'm glad you agree." She faced him. "I think we should break up."

His foot slipped off the gas pedal. “What are you talking about?”

“Mack. We’ve been headed this way for awhile, you know that.”

He gripped the steering wheel and took deep breaths. Sure, things had been rough lately, and she kept talking about needing some time to herself, but she always came around. And she’d definitely never uttered the words *break up*.

“Look, Dana—”

“Please, don’t. You can’t talk me out of it this time.” She stared at the dashboard. “I’m sorry.”

His insides twisted. He darted a look at her, but she was curled against the door now, both hands resting easy in her lap.

They were totally breaking up.

Make sure that your character’s feelings progress realistically. Map out the emotional journey within the scene to avoid elevated emotional responses that don’t make sense.

All of this is not to say that real life doesn’t produce extreme emotion. Birth, death, loss, change—some situations call for intense responses that may go on for awhile. Many writers, in an admirable attempt to maintain believability, try to recreate these events in real time. This results in long paragraphs or even pages of high emotion and, inevitably, melodrama. Though real life can sustain this kind of intensity for long periods of time, it’s nearly impossible for the written word to do so in a way that readers will accept.

In these situations, avoid melodrama by abbreviating. This method is often used for other real-life scenarios—conversations, for instance. Small talk is left out to keep the pace moving forward. Mundane tasks are also cut short, because the reader doesn’t need (or want) to see the entire car washed, a piece at a time, while Bob ponders a problem at work. In the same way, extensive emotional scenes should be long enough to convey the appropriate information, but not so long that you lose the audience. Write the emotion well, develop empathy in your reader, maximize the words that you do use, but don’t overstay your welcome.

OVER-RELIANCE ON BODY LANGUAGE

It can't be overstated: body language is incredibly important for showing the character's emotion to readers. Without it, conversations will read as stilted and unnatural, and for readers to figure out a character's emotional state, they'll have to rely solely on the words being spoken—which we know aren't always reliable.

As in so many areas of writing, context is king, and the conveying of emotion is no exception. Without the proper context, readers can't be sure which emotion the character is feeling. Are the fidgety fingers a sign of excitement, nervousness, unease, or impatience? Even if it's combined with an elevated heartbeat, that doesn't narrow the field. The missing piece that the reader needs is the *why*: Why is the character exhibiting these behaviors? Proper context answers this question, and it's often provided through the character's thoughts and dialogue.

When a person is gripped by a strong emotion, they don't tend to think in terms of that feeling. An excited person doesn't think to himself, *I'm so excited!* because he already knows it. Instead, he thinks about the cause of the excitement—perhaps by mentally counting down the days to a loved one's visit or summarizing a recent phone call from a college admissions office.

Physical reactions show what emotion is present, and the thoughts show why it's there. Both must be included for it all to make sense.

OVER-RELIANCE ON DIALOGUE OR THOUGHTS

Because nonverbal writing is harder to master, it makes sense that some writers shy away from it, choosing to rely more on thoughts or dialogue to express what a character is feeling. But an over-reliance on either leads to problems.

“Are—Are you sure?” I asked.

“Without a doubt,” Mr. Baker replied. “It was neck-and-neck right up to the end, but you came out ahead. Congratulations, William!”

“I can't believe it,” I said. “Valedictorian! I'm so happy!”

Word choice is important in expressing emotion, but it will only go so far. After that, the writer is reduced to weak techniques like telling the reader what's being felt (*I'm so happy*) and over-using exclamation points to show intensity. Without any action to break up the dialogue, the conversation also sounds stilted.

On the other hand, conveying emotion solely through thoughts has its problems, too.

My pulse was pounding somewhere in the 160 range. I did it! Valedictorian! I was sure Nathan would come out ahead—he was a phenom in the physics lab, and he'd been a ghost at school all month, practically living in the library.

I threw my arms around Mr. Baker. I'd think about this later and cringe with embarrassment, but right now, I didn't care. I'd done it! Take THAT, Nathan Shusterman!

Technically, there's nothing wrong with this sample. Bodily cues, both internal and external, are included. It's clear to the reader that William is excited. Yet it doesn't ring true. Why? Because this monologue screams for verbal interaction with others. Mr. Baker is there and has clearly been talking to William. For William to be so incredibly excited and not say anything comes across as...odd.

Internal dialogue is an important part of any story. There are many scenes and scenarios where a paragraph or more of contemplation is appropriate. This isn't one of them. For this scene, and for the majority of scenes, emotion is much more effectively conveyed through a mixture of dialogue, thoughts, vocal cues, and body language.

My pulse jittered somewhere around the 160 mark. No, I'd heard him wrong, been tricked by an over-active, sleep-deprived, twisted imagination.

"Are—" I cleared my throat. "Are you sure?"

"It was neck-and-neck right up to the end, but you came out ahead. Congratulations, William."

The leather chair squeaked as I collapsed into it. Valedictorian. How'd I beat out Nathan, who'd been a ghost all

month, practically living in the library? Not to mention that A- I scraped in physics.

“But I did it,” I whispered.

Mr. Baker stood to shake my hand. I jumped up and threw my arms around him, lifting him off the floor. Later, I’d remember this and die of embarrassment, but right now I didn’t care.

“I did it. Take THAT, Nathan Shusterman!”

“Knew you had it in you,” he said in a strangled voice.

When expressing emotion, vary your vehicles, using both verbal and nonverbal techniques for maximum impact.

MISUSING BACKSTORY TO ENHANCE READER EMPATHY

Every character is unique, influenced largely by events from the past. One surefire way to gain reader empathy is to reveal why a character is the way he is. Take the movie *Jaws*, for example. The first glimpse we have of shark hunter Quint, he’s raking his none-too-clean fingernails down a chalkboard. Hardly endearing. As the movie progresses, the viewer’s dislike is justified through his crass manners and bullying of young Mr. Hooper. But once he tells his story of the sinking of the *Indianapolis* and his many days and nights treading water with the sharks, the viewer understands how he became so hardened. His behavior hasn’t changed and we still don’t like him very much, but we empathize with him now. We wish him better than what life has served up to him.

This is just one example of the importance of backstory in building reader empathy. People are products of their past. As the author, it’s important for you to know why your characters are the way they are and to pass that information along to readers. For more help on developing your character’s backstory and discovering his resulting personality, we recommend checking out the other books in our thesaurus series.

The difficulty comes in knowing how much of the past to share. Many writers, in an attempt to gain reader empathy, reveal too much. Excessive backstory slows the pace and can bore readers, tempting them to skip ahead to the good stuff. Undoubtedly, Quint’s path to crusty and crazy contained

more than that one unfortunate event, but the rest didn't need to be shared. That one story, artfully told, was enough.

In order to avoid using too much backstory, determine which details from your character's past are necessary to share. Dole them out through the context of the present-time story to keep the pace moving. For inspiration, consider your favorite literary characters, even those who may have been unlikable. Revisit their stories to see what clues from the past the author chose to reveal, and how it was done.

Backstory is tricky to write well. As is true of so many areas of writing, balance is the key.

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USING THE EMOTION THESAURUS

We've established that emotion powers a scene and, when written well, propels readers out of apathy and into the character's emotional experience. Writing authentic emotion is not always easy, but to create breakout fiction, writers must come up with fresh ideas to express their characters' feelings.

Emotion is strongest when both verbal and nonverbal communication are used in tandem. The Emotion Thesaurus can supply that critical nonverbal element writers need to fire up an emotional hit that will leave a lasting impression on readers. Here are some final ideas on how to use this book to its fullest:

IDENTIFY THE ROOT EMOTION

Certain situations can arouse a single, easily identifiable emotion. But more often than not, human beings feel more than one thing at a time. If you are struggling with how to convey this conflict to the reader, take a step back and identify the root emotion. This is the catalyst that dictates any other feelings your character might also experience. Once you've found the root emotion, look to the corresponding thesaurus entry for a range of suggestions. The **May Escalate To** field can also provide a logical progression for where your character's feelings might be headed. Once you've clearly shown the root emotion, you can layer in other emotions to a lesser degree and map out the full experience. Similarly, if the situation shifts or is heading toward a resolution of sorts, you can source the **May De-Escalate To** field to see what emotions might come next.

UTILIZE THE SETTING

If you're looking to add natural emotion in a scene, the setting may provide the answer. Many writers don't put much thought into where their scenes take place, believing that any number of locations could be used to equal effect. But this is shortsighted. Why not include a setting that already contains inherent emotion for the character—maybe one that is painfully rooted in the past? Doing so can set them up for disappointment, trigger old wounds, or put their feelings on edge and increase their chances of doing something foolish—all of which can serve your story well.

Settings can also be used on a micro-level. Instead of the location itself holding significance, perhaps the items and people within it do. Or maybe it contains the props you need to highlight a character's emotional state. Someone in the kitchen might sweep a wine glass off the counter in a fit of rage. An office setting could also work, though the same anger may require some control, ranging from a slammed office door to tense posture and fingers pounding the keyboard. When referring to the entries in this thesaurus, a writer should keep in mind the character's setting in order to create organic and unique emotional responses.

LESS IS MORE

Using too many cues to describe a character's feelings can slow the pace and dilute the reader's emotional experience. Sometimes this happens when a writer fails to identify and focus first on the root emotion. Other times, it's the result of choosing too many weak descriptors. Strong imagery will paint an immediate picture, so always strive to create concrete body language and vocal cues for the reader to interpret. Watch for overlong emotional passages that slow the action. Always think like a reader, and keep those pages turning.

TWIST THE CLICHÉ

Whenever possible, writers should use fresh ideas to convey emotion. But let's face it...some descriptors work well. That's why they crop up in novels again and again. Each thesaurus entry includes a myriad of possible cues; if you find yourself leaning toward a traditional response like eye rolling or fist clenching that can be seen as cliché, twist it first.

Take shivering, for example—a common visceral indicator to imply fear or discomfort. Shivers run up the spine, down the spine...these are tired phrases that can turn off readers. Sure, the sensation fits, but why not come up with something new? Why couldn't a shiver swarm over the back of the legs? How about using a simile that likens a shiver to leaf-cutter ants marching along a vine? Better yet, don't call it a shiver at all. Instead, describe the sensations of tightening skin or hair being raised. Never be afraid to experiment. There are many ways to take an old expression and twist it into something unique.

VIEW ENTRIES AS A LAUNCHING POINT

Body movement, actions, visceral sensations, and thoughts are as individual as the characters experiencing them. The list accompanying each thesaurus entry is not designed as a one-size-fits-all set of options. It is meant, rather, to prompt writers to think about the many possible behavioral beats at their disposal so they can choose the most suitable options and transform them into an evocative and unique emotional description.

Each character comes from a different background and has a unique personality, meaning some options in the entries will be a good fit while others will not. Their comfort level around others will also influence how they express emotion. With this in mind, entries should serve as a brainstorming tool and encourage writers to take the next step and create fresh, individual ways to show a character's emotional state.

TRY RELATED EMOTIONS

If you're struggling to find the perfect physical response, visceral reaction, or thought, try reading through the entries of similar emotions. Each entry contains different cues. Studying the lists for related feelings may spark an idea for something new.

ADD AN AMPLIFIER

Getting your character into the right emotional state isn't necessarily easy because they don't always go willingly. When they need an extra push, consider adding an amplifier. Emotion amplifiers are states that stimulate emotion and make a character more volatile. Hunger, boredom, pain, illness, etc. will deplete a character's emotional reserves and ramp up the stress, putting them on edge and impacting their decision-making abilities. Keep possibilities like these in mind when you need to drive your character's emotions.

VISCERAL REACTIONS AS PHYSICAL INDICATORS

Sometimes, the strongest emotional responses are instinctive (visceral) ones that occur mostly internally and are therefore difficult for others to notice. This becomes a problem for writers who want to show a character's

emotion while remaining true to their third- or first-person point of view. In these cases, writers should focus on visceral reactions that have a physical “tell” attached to them. For example, sweating, blushing and shakiness have an external component that can be seen by others. Utilizing these cues allows a writer to describe a visceral reaction without damaging the integrity of the point of view. Because of the external signs that accompany these unique internal sensations, we have included them in the **Physical Signals and Behaviors** field.

A FINAL WORD

We created this book to help writers brainstorm stronger expressions of their characters’ emotions, and we urge you to remember that these entries are meant to be a starting point, not a cut-and-paste tool. Using the book as such would only lead to boring, one-note writing, and your story deserves to shine! While writing compelling descriptions always takes more work (since it requires us to dig deeper), it’s worth the effort, and your readers will thank you for it.

We hope *The Emotion Thesaurus* will become a useful companion on your writing journey, traveling with you from one book to the next. Happy writing!

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THE EMOTION THESAURUS

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ACCEPTANCE

DEFINITION: Letting go willfully; making peace with change to obtain balance and understanding

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

One's shoulders and torso loosening slightly as tension ebbs

Taking in a cleansing breath

Nodding

A smile that grows

Stretching, shaking out one's arms, rolling the shoulders, or curling the toes to release tension and embrace a new mindset

Lifting one's head to make eye contact

One's gaze going from unfocused to focused

Eyes that brighten after making the decision to move forward

Verbalizing one's decision to let go: *You know, I'm okay with it, or This will work out.*

Moving closer to other people; no longer feeling as though one needs distance

Welcoming others into one's space (offering a hand, gesturing someone to come near, etc.)

Mirroring another's body language to build rapport (facing them, adopting their gestures)

Shaking someone's hand

Making a joke to lighten the mood

Grinning genuinely

Offering a suggestion as a peace offering: *Why don't we go for lunch? I'm buying.*

Touching to offer personal contact (e.g., a light touch on their arm or shoulder)

Politeness with others; listening intently

Sitting with one's palms facing up

Lifting one's hand to the chest
Engaging in conversation
A light tone of voice
Open body posture (arms away from the body, legs slightly apart, chest out, etc.)
Giving someone an embrace or accepting one
Being honest with others
Lighthearted laughter
Strong eye contact during conversation
Asking for advice out of true interest or to make someone feel valued
Discussing and making plans with others

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A chest that loosens or feels lighter
Breath that comes a little easier

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A lessening need to review past struggles and obstacles
Being cautiously optimistic
Thinking about the future and what new things it will bring
Experiencing a mood boost when realizing that certain worries or stressors can be let go
A willingness to forgive (oneself or others) to move forward
A desire to share the moment with others
Thoughts turning to the new situation and how one can best move forward
Being ready to let go of past upsets

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Confidence
Feeling happy and full of purpose (having a clear direction, knowing what goals to pursue, etc.)

Forging strong, genuine relationships
Clear-headedness and optimism
The ability to let go of anger and worry more quickly
Feeling more connected to others or the world
A willingness to trust (other people, a process, one's decisions, etc.)

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

A heavy, thoughtful sigh
Tapping one's lip with a finger in thought
Asking further questions for clarification on something or to delay giving a response
Pursing the lips and tipping the head from side to side, as if weighing one's choices
Lighthearted teasing: *I guess you can live here. We needed someone to change the litter box anyway.*
Setting mock conditions: *Okay, you can move out, but you must promise to call every Sunday!*
Dragging out one's words to pretend that coming to a decision is a struggle
Pretending to pout or otherwise hide one's enthusiasm
Keeping one's choices and feelings a secret until the time is right
Asking for more time to think it over

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Satisfaction](#), [Peacefulness](#), [Connectedness](#), [Excitement](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Doubt](#), [Reluctance](#), [Regret](#), [Uncertainty](#), [Vulnerability](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Brighten, care, embrace, grin, hold, hope, hug, join, laugh, lift, listen, meet, nod, plan, profess, rise, share, smile, squeeze, tease, touch, welcome

WRITER'S TIP: *When you raise the stakes in the story, don't forget to also show the POV character's emotions grow more intense. Whenever there's more on the line, there's more weight tied to the feelings being experienced.*

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ADMIRATION

DEFINITION: A feeling of warm approval and appreciation

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

A smile that reaches the eyes (which are glossy and bright)

Prolonged eye contact

Eyebrows that flash up and hold

Head tilting slightly to the side

Leaning forward

Nodding slightly while grinning

A flush visible in the cheeks

Reaching out to the one who is admired

Offering a compliment

Lowering the head briefly

An enthusiastic, warm greeting

Inviting another into one's personal space

Lightly shaking one's head and smiling upon thinking of the other person

Active listening (nodding while the other speaks)

Mirroring the body language of the one admired

Laying a hand on the back or shoulder of the other

Clasping hands behind the back

Shifting weight to lean toward the one admired

Open body posture (facing toward another, a welcoming stance)

Relaxed arms

A warm squeeze at the end of a handshake

Asking questions and requesting opinions

Asking for more detail, allowing the other more air time

Being agreeable

Adjusting clothing (straightening, smoothing) to make a good impression

Laughing more often

Caretaking: *Can I get you something, a drink?*

Offering praise: *You did great up there, a natural speaker!*

A warm tone of voice

Friendliness

Being more talkative than normal

Not interrupting

Going out of one's way (staying late, making time for another during busy periods, etc.)

Respecting the time of the one admired: *You have lots of people to see so I'll let you go.*

Being more understanding and forgiving if a conversation or meeting is rushed

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

The heart rate picking up slightly

Stomach flutters

Body heat rising

Overall looseness in the muscles

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Lending more weight to the opinions and actions of the one admired

Being open-minded and trusting

A desire to learn from or be privy to personal details or opinions

A feeling of well-being while in the presence of the admired

Feeling gratitude for the opportunity to spend time together

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Clapping, cheering, fist pumping

A handshake using both hands

Making favorable comparisons: *I hope one day I'm in your position or*
Wow, you're just so good at that. Maybe if I stick close enough I'll pick up

your skill!

Inviting closeness: *I'd love to have you over for dinner sometime.*

Prioritizing the other person and making time for them

Bringing the one admired up in conversation with others and singing their praises

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Breaking eye contact to look away briefly

Busying oneself so one isn't caught staring

Waiting at the fringe of a group but not moving toward the subject to engage

Taking deeper breaths to try and slow one's heartbeat

Listening in to a conversation with the one admired but not directly conversing with them

Hesitating before jumping into the conversation or introducing oneself

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Eagerness](#), [Adoration](#), [Inspired](#), [Envy](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Valued](#), [Pleased](#), [Curiosity](#), [Satisfaction](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Adore, applaud, aspire, bestow, brag, build up, clap, commend, congratulate, envy, flatter, gaze, greet, honor, imitate, invite, linger, marvel, praise, profess, recognize, recommend, respect, salute, thank, vouch, watch, welcome

WRITER'S TIP: *If your character wants to give up, give them a reason to go on. What core beliefs do they hold that they will go to the mat to defend? What injustices or atrocities are just too morally painful to bear?*

ADORATION

DEFINITION: The act of worship; to view as divine

NOTES: The subject of adoration can be a person or thing

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Lips parting

A slack or soft expression

Walking quickly to erase the distance

Mirroring the subject's body language

Touching one's mouth or face

Reaching out to brush, touch, or grasp

Steady eye contact, with the pupils appearing larger

Leaning forward

Stroking one's own neck or arm as a surrogate

Pointing one's torso and feet toward the subject; having an open body posture

A flushed appearance or radiant glow

Inhaling deeply—anchoring oneself in the moment and taking in the scent of the subject

Nodding and smiling while the subject speaks

Releasing an appreciative sigh

Laying a hand over the heart

Frequently moistening the lips

Pressing the palms lightly against the cheeks

Skimming one's fingertips along the jaw line

Eyes that are bright and glossy

Showing agreement (murmuring affirmations, offering words of support, etc.)

Speaking praise and compliments

Keeping trinkets, pictures, or articles that one associates with the subject

Constantly talking about the subject to others

Displaying rapt attention (a lifted chin, body stillness, good posture, etc.)

Losing awareness of the external environment or other people

Visible shakiness

Reduced blinking

Closing the eyes to savor the experience

Speaking with a soft tone

A voice that cracks with emotion

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A quickening heartbeat

Breathlessness

Feeling one's pulse in the throat

Having a dry mouth

One's throat growing thick

Growing warmer as one's body temperature rises

Tingling nerve endings

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A desire to move closer or touch

Fixating one's thoughts on the subject

Acute listening and observation

Ignoring distractions

An inability to see the subject's flaws or faults

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Obsession or possessiveness

Fantasizing

Believing that the feelings are mutual

A sense of destiny (of belonging together)

Stalking

Writing and sending letters, email, and gifts

Taking risks or breaking laws to be near or with the subject

Weight loss

Poor sleep patterns

Jealousy towards those who frequently interact with the subject

Taking on traits or mannerisms of the subject

Carrying something that represents the subject (a picture, jewelry, etc.)

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Clenching or hiding one's hands to hide sweating or shaking

Avoiding conversations about the subject

Watching or observing from afar

Staying out of the subject's proximity

Blushing

An unsteady voice

Sneaking looks at the subject

Creating chance run-ins

Writing secret letters, keeping a personal journal, etc.

Lying about one's feelings regarding the subject

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Love](#), [Obsessed](#), [Desire](#), [Frustration](#), [Hurt](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Conflicted](#), [Disappointment](#),
[Embarrassment](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Adore, awe, covet, crave, enchant, enthrall, grasp, idolize, infatuate, need, obsess, pine, reach, spellbind, stroke, tease, touch, worship, yearn

WRITER'S TIP: *Body cues should create a strong mental picture. If the movement is too drawn-out or complicated, the emotional meaning behind the gesture may be lost.*

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AGITATION

DEFINITION: Feeling upset or disturbed; a state of unrest

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

A reddening of the face

A sheen of sweat on the cheeks, chin, and forehead

Flexing one's fingers repeatedly

Rubbing the back of the neck

Patting pockets or digging in a purse, looking for something lost

Clumsiness due to rushing (knocking things over, bumping tables, etc.)

A gaze that bounces from place to place

An inability to stay still

Jamming or cramming things away without care

Abrupt movement (e.g., causing a chair to tip or scuff the floor loudly)

Flapping one's hands or displaying jerky movements

Becoming accident prone (e.g., bashing one's hip on a desk corner)

Dragging the hands through the hair repeatedly

Forgetting words; being unable to articulate one's thoughts

Backtracking to try and undo something said in haste

Adjusting one's clothing

Avoiding eye contact

Speaking in a wavering voice or talking roughly

Not knowing where to look or go

Guarding one's personal space—e.g., crossing the arms to block contact

Taking too long to answer a question or respond

Throat-clearing

Overusing *ums*, *ahs*, and other verbal hesitations

Turning away from others

A bobbing Adam's apple

Pacing

Making odd noises in the throat

Rapid lip movement as one tries to find the right thing to say
Flinching if touched
Feet that shift and move when one is standing or sitting
Minimizing another's compliments and refusing to be placated
Fanning oneself or unbuttoning a top shirt button
Tugging at a tie, collar, or scarf as clothing begins to feel restrictive
Rolling one's eyes when the person isn't looking

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Excessive saliva
Feeling overheated
Stiffening hair on the nape
Light-headedness
Short, fast breaths due to a tightness in the chest
Sweating
Tingling skin as sweat forms
A jittery feeling in one's belly

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Mounting frustration that causes thoughts to blank
Compounding mistakes due to rushing
A tendency to lie to cover up or excuse one's behavior and overreactions
Anger at oneself for freezing up (negative self-talk)
Trying to pinpoint the source of discomfort
Mentally ordering oneself to calm down and relax

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Flight responses (looking for an escape route or fleeing the room)
Snapping at others
Adopting a defensive tone

Not caring about damage (e.g., scattering papers and files during a frantic search)

Being on edge due to the constant agitation

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Changing the subject

Making excuses

Joking to lighten the mood

Staying busy with tasks to avoid dealing with the source of the emotion

Shifting attention to others and putting them in the spotlight

Responding minimally when the subject comes up or the person makes an appearance

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Flustered](#), [Frustration](#), [Anxiety](#), [Anger](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Admiration](#), [Defensiveness](#), [Resignation](#), [Regret](#), [Unease](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Annoy, berate, bother, bristle, chafe, cram, curse, disturb, erode, faze, fester, flush, flutter, frustrate, fume, grate, incite, irritate, jam, jerk, offend, rankle, rattle, rile, ruffle, shake, stew, tap, toss, twitch, undercut, vex, wince

WRITER'S TIP: *A ticking clock can ramp up the emotions in any scene. As the character hurries to complete a task or meet a need, mistakes caused by rushing might open the door for a richer emotional ride.*

AMAZEMENT

DEFINITION: Overwhelming astonishment or wonder

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

A widening of the eyes

A slack mouth

Becoming suddenly still

Sucking in a quick breath

A hand covering one's mouth

Stiffening posture, with visible tension in muscles

Giving a small yelp

Gulping, stuttering, or sputtering

Rapid blinking followed by open staring

Flinching or starting, the body jumping slightly

Taking a step back

A slow, disbelieving shake of the head

Voicing wonder: *I can't believe it!* or *Look at that!*

Pulling out a cell phone to record the event

Glancing to see if others are experiencing the same thing

Pressing a hand against one's chest, fingers splayed out

Leaning in

Moving closer, reaching out, or touching

Eyebrows rising

Lips parting

A wide smile

Spontaneous laughter

Pressing one's palms to one's cheeks or the sides of the head

Jerky hand movements near the face

Speechlessness

Repeating the same things over and over

Walking a step or two only to turn around and come back

Squealing dramatically

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A heart that seems to freeze, then pound

The sound of blood rushing in one's ears

Rising body temperature

Tingling skin

Stalled breaths

Adrenaline spikes

A dry mouth

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Momentarily forgetting all else

Wanting to share the experience with others

Giddiness

Disorientation

Euphoria

An inability to find words

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

A racing heartbeat

Shortness of breath

The knees going weak or even collapsing

Feeling overwhelmed, as if the room is closing in

Light-headedness due to a loss of spatial awareness

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Holding oneself tight (self-hugging)

Walking in jerky, self-contained strides

Clasping one's hands and pressing them tightly to one's chest

Looking down or away to hide one's expression

The eyes widening a bit before control is asserted

The mouth snapping shut
A stony expression
Taking a seat to hide the emotion
Making excuses if one's reaction is noticed
Forcing a cough to give oneself a moment to regain control

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Curiosity](#), [Disbelief](#), [Excitement](#), [Awe](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Happiness](#), [Gratitude](#), [Satisfaction](#),
[Curiosity](#), [Inspired](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Admire, astound, awe, blink, daze, dazzle, delight, disbelieve, enamor, entertain, gape, gasp, gaze, haunt, hypnotize, intrigue, jerk, marvel, murmur, peer, share, spellbind, spring, stagger, study, stun, touch, twist, witness, wonder

WRITER'S TIP: *To add another layer to an emotional experience, look for symbolism within the character's current setting. What unique object within the location can the character make note of that perfectly embodies the emotion they are feeling inside?*

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AMUSEMENT

DEFINITION: Appealing to the sense of humor; experiencing entertainment or delight

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

A shiny or rosy face

Raised or wiggling eyebrows

Snorting or laughing

Chuckling or cackling

Displaying a wide grin

Exchanging knowing looks with others

Witty commentary and observations

Turning away and bursting out in laughter

A playful pinch, nudge, or shove

Squinting, eyes lit with an inner glow or twinkle of mischief

Smirking or offering a bemused smile

Clutching at another person for support

Gasping for air

Slapping one's knees or thighs

Drumming one's feet against the floor

Falling against someone, shoulder to shoulder

"Drunken" behavior (weaving, staggering, etc.)

Repeating the punch line or a select word to spur more laughter

A high voice

Holding one's sides

Whimpers of mirth

Spewing food or drink if laughter hits while eating or drinking

Falling to the ground and rolling on the floor

Sniffing as one's nose runs

Crashing into things; being clumsy but not caring

A wide-eyed look that gets others dissolving into laughter again

Bending double and gripping one's knees
Making gestures or funny expressions to escalate the laughter
Holding onto a chair or wall for support
Giggling, making faces, and winking
Plucking at clothes to cool oneself down

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A pain in the ribs or stomach
Wheezy breaths
The body temperature jumping up
Weakness in the limbs, especially the knees

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A need to sit down
Replaying the humorous event
Embellishing the event in one's mind, increasing the mirth
Wanting to keep the amusement going by adding to it with others
Feeling lighter; one's worries or concerns evaporating for the moment

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Uncontrollable laughter
Laughing so hard it becomes soundless
The body quaking
Shaking the head emphatically
A loss of body control (weak muscles, having a hard time staying upright, etc.)
Begging people to stop
An inability to form words
Breathlessness
Eyes tearing
A sweaty, disheveled appearance
Loss of bladder control

Needing to leave the room

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Clamping the lips together

Holding a hand up as if to say *No more!*

Shaking the head

Swallowing laughter

Wiping at the mouth

Avoiding eye contact with others

Covering the mouth and biting one's lips to hide a smile

A reddening of the face

Turning away to collect oneself

Confining a laugh to a snort

Pressing a fist against the lips

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Happiness](#), [Satisfaction](#), [Elation](#), [Moved](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Admiration](#), [Connectedness](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Banter, beam, cackle, catcall, chuckle, clap, dance, entertain, giggle, grin, heckle, holler, hoot, howl, impress, joke, kid, laugh, mime, mimic, nudge, poke, prank, shout, smile, smirk, snigger, snort, tease, tickle, titillate, titter, wheeze

WRITER'S TIP: *To add tension to a scene, include someone who carries emotional weight with your character. Who frightens them, creates anxiety, or makes them more volatile?*

ANGER

DEFINITION: Strong displeasure or wrath, usually aroused by a perceived wrong

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Flaring nostrils

Noisy breathing

Sweating

Holding the elbows wide from the body, with one's chest thrust out

Sweeping arm gestures

Handling objects or people roughly

A high chin

Legs that are planted wide

Baring one's teeth, glaring

Repetitive, sharp gestures (shaking a fist, etc.)

Cutting people off when they speak

Jerky head movements

Eyes that seem to bulge

Flexing the fingers or arm muscles

Cracking one's knuckles

Rolling up one's sleeves or loosening a collar

Eyes that are cold, hard, or flinty

Entering another's personal space to intimidate them

Jeering, taunting, and deploying a cutting wit

A tightness in the eyes or expression

A reddening of the face

Lips that flatten or curl

Closed body posture (crossing the arms, etc.)

Nails biting into one's palms

Pounding one's fists against thighs, table, a wall, etc.

Slamming doors, cupboards, or drawers

Punching, kicking, and throwing things
Stomping or stamping
A vein that pulses, twitches, or becomes engorged
Laughter with an edge
A shaking or raised voice; yelling
Deepening one's tone
Deploying sarcasm; insulting others
Picking fights (verbal or physical)
Snapping at people
Visible sweat on one's skin

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Grinding one's teeth
Muscles quivering
Pulse speeding
A pounding heartbeat
The body tensing
Heat flushing through the body

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Irritability
Poor listening skills
Jumping to conclusions
Irrational reactions to inconsequential things
Demanding immediate action
Impetuosity
Taking inappropriate action or risks
Fantasizing violence

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Exploding over little things
Ulcers and hypertension

Skin problems, such as eczema and acne
Damaging one's own property to vent
Longer recovery time from surgeries, accidents, and other trauma
Road rage
Taking anger out on innocent bystanders

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Using a carefully controlled tone
Drawing in slow, steady breaths
False smiles
Passive-aggressive comments
Avoiding eye contact
Slanting the body away from the source of anger
Withdrawing from the conversation
Hiding one's hands and feet so clenching and twitching can't be seen
Excusing oneself for a brief time
Headaches
Experiencing sore muscles and pain in the jaw

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Rage](#), [Hatred](#), [Obsessed](#), [Vengeful](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Bitterness](#), [Emasculated](#), [Frustration](#),
[Irritation](#), [Annoyance](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Blaze, consume, explode, flare, inflame, provoke, quake, rage, redden, restrain, rile, seethe, shout, simmer, surge, tremble, trigger, vent

WRITER'S TIP: *Pay special attention to the events leading up to an emotional response. If the plotting feels contrived, the character's reaction will seem contrived as well.*

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ANGUISH

DEFINITION: Emotional or mental distress; acute suffering

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Manic pacing
Rubbing the back of one's neck
Tugging one's hair
Not eating or drinking
Visible sweating
Skin bunching around the eyes
A pained stare
Hands clenching into fists
Rubbing the wrists or wringing the hands
Restless fingers
Jumping at sounds
Grinding one's teeth or clenching the jaw
A corded neck
Moving about; being unable to settle in one place
Muscles jumping under the skin
Curling one's toes
Repeatedly touching an object that symbolizes safety
Audible stress in one's voice and tone
Picking at one's lips, skin, or nails
Clutching at oneself (self-soothing reactions)
Shivering, moaning, sobbing, or weeping
Yelling or shouting; becoming emotionally unstable
Checking and rechecking the time
Asking those in authority for updates
Shoulders that curl over the chest
Bringing one's legs up close to the body's core
Turning away from others while muttering

Seeking corners in confined spaces
Beating at walls or surrounding objects for a release

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Sore muscles, stiffness, and cramping
Pain in the back of the throat (difficulty swallowing)
Elevated body temperature
Nausea

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Thinking irrationally
Praying, bargaining, and making mental promises
Believing in anything that promises a positive outcome
Fixating on the source of suffering
A willingness to put oneself in harm's way for emotional relief

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Screaming for release
A gaunt appearance, wasting away, and premature aging
Posture that bends or crumples
Vomiting or dry heaving
Hyperventilation
Poor coloring; dark circles under the eyes
Wrinkles and sagging around the eyes and mouth
Alcohol, drug, or medication dependency
Bald patches
Facial tics or repetitive mannerisms (hair tugging, body rocking, etc.)
Cutting, scratching, or other self-destructive behaviors
Depression and suicidal thoughts or attempts

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Wincing

Gritting one's teeth
Facial tension
Uncontrolled shivering and hand tremors
Muscle tightness
Furtive movements
Hiding expressive gestures like hand wringing
Bitten nails with bleeding quicks
A downturned mouth or pinched lips
Pressed lips that tremble
Engaging in hard manual labor (to expend energy and exhaust oneself)
Minimal speaking (one-word answers, shaking or nodding the head,
etc.)
Chain smoking
Drinking heavily

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Desperation](#), [Tormented](#), [Depressed](#), [Hysteria](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Hurt](#), [Guilt](#), [Unease](#), [Uncertainty](#),
[Vulnerability](#), [Self-Pity](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Blister, burn, consume, distress, endure, groan, howl, inflict, moan, overcome, pain, pierce, seize, sob, strangle, suffer, suffocate, torment, writhe

WRITER'S TIP: *Don't be afraid to challenge your character's morals. Putting them in situations that are outside their comfort zone will make them squirm, and the reader will too.*

ANNOYANCE

DEFINITION: Aggravation or mild irritation

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

A pinched expression

Sighing heavily or with exaggeration

Statements suggesting impatience: *Here, I'll do it.*

Narrowing eyes

Crossed arms

Tapping a foot

Swatting at the air as if to remove obstacles

Tics and tells (a throbbing forehead vein, fingering a collar, etc.)

One's lips pressing into a white slash

Clenching the jaw

Grimacing, sneering, and frowning

Complaining

Folding the arms across the chest

Hands that briefly clench

Making pointed suggestions to alleviate the annoyance

Tugging at clothing (jerking down a cuff, forcing a zipper up, etc.)

Cocking one's head and then shaking it

Raising one's eyebrows and giving a glassy stare

A gaze that flicks upward

Minutely shaking the head

Changing one's stance (shifting weight or position)

Propping the head up with a fist

Holding one's head in the hands

Opening the mouth to criticize, then stopping short

Taking a deep breath and holding it in

Finger-tapping a tabletop

A smile that slips or appears forced

Snapping a pencil tip, using unnecessary force
Pacing
Light sarcasm
Asking a question that has a painfully obvious answer
A sharp tone
Speaking in short phrases
Visible tension in the neck, shoulders, and arms
Rigid posture
Cords twanging in the neck
Rubbing the brow as if to ward off a headache
Avoiding the person or object of annoyance
Pressing a fist to the mouth

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A headache
Stiffness in the neck or jaw
Raised body temperature
Sensitivity to noise

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Berating thoughts
Straying attention
Thinking of an excuse to leave
Making unkind mental comparisons
Wishing to be somewhere else

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

A reddening face
Rough handling of objects
Taking over someone else's job or duties
Grinding one's teeth
Throwing the hands up in a gesture of surrender

Stalking off to get some air
Shutting down; not speaking or responding
Pulling someone else into the situation to divert attention and allow one to exit

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Nodding tightly, as if holding back from speaking an insult
Switching to another job to keep one's hands and thoughts busy
Attacking a task to divert one's energy
Forcing oneself to remain in the presence of the annoyance
Faking interest; barely holding impatience at bay
Carefully controlling one's voice and tone
Focusing one's gaze elsewhere in an attempt to ignore the source of annoyance

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Frustration](#), [Anger](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Conflicted](#), [Indifference](#), [Acceptance](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Avoid, bother, bristle, clench, complain, discomfort, displease, exhale, fidget, fluster, grate, grind, grit, grumble, intrude, irritate, mutter, nettle, pester, prickle, push, rasp, reach, rub, scrape, sigh, taunt, tire, unnerve, unsettle

WRITER'S TIP: *Don't get caught up on the eyes to convey emotion. While eyes are often the first thing we notice in real life, they provide very limited options for description possibilities. Instead, dig deeper, showing how the character behaves through their body movement, actions and dialogue.*

ANTICIPATION

DEFINITION: Hopeful expectation; to await eagerly

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Sweaty palms

Trembling hands

Crossing and uncrossing one's legs

Frantic planning for the event

List-making

Clasping one's hands to the chest

Being unable to think or talk about anything else

Fidgeting as if movement will make things go faster

Bouncing on one's toes

A bright-eyed look as one engages with others or the environment

Fussing with clothes and rearranging things

Waiting at a window, hovering at the door or by the phone

Checking and rechecking one's hair or makeup in a mirror

Gossiping with others, sharing excitement, and giggling

Closing the eyes and squealing or releasing a mock growl

Jittering a foot against the floor

Covering one's face and then peeking

Biting one's lip

Fake swooning

Asking questions: *How long? When? What is it?*

Wetting the lips

Closing the eyes and sighing

Pacing

Rhythmic movements (swinging one's legs back and forth, etc.)

Obsessive clockwatching, or checking and rechecking email

Phoning or texting friends to talk about what's coming

Grabbing another person and saying *Tell me!*

Leaning in

Picking at food because one is too excited to eat

Begging someone for details, an answer, or to get a look at something

Sensitivity to touch

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A fluttery, empty feeling in the stomach

Breathlessness

A pounding heart

Tingling all over

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Daydreaming

A desire for perfection; running through mental lists to ensure one's prepared

Fearing that something will happen to screw things up

A lack of concentration

Imagining what will happen

Becoming self-critical (questioning clothing choices, one's abilities, etc.)

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Sleep loss

Frustration or impatience

Short-temperedness and irritability

Neglecting everything else (responsibilities, friends, family, etc.)

Fantasizing or building up the event far beyond its reality

Overthinking (e.g., organizing every minute detail)

Going overboard in preparation (e.g., dressing over-the-top)

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Sitting unnaturally still

Pressing one's lips together
Rubbing sweaty hands on one's clothes
Pretending to read a book or watch TV
A corded neck
Clamping one's hands tightly together
Avoiding conversation
Sneaking glances at a clock or doorway
Feigning boredom
Telling oneself that it doesn't matter
Acting interested in something else
Rolling one's shoulders and neck as if they're stiff
Changing the topic

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Excitement](#), [Desire](#), [Jealousy](#), [Pleased](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Disillusionment](#), [Disappointment](#),
[Indifference](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Arouse, await, beam, beg, bounce, buzz, clench, excite, expect, flutter, gleam, glow, grin, heighten, hope, lean, quiver, race, shiver, sparkle, speculate, stir, strum, tense, thrill, tingle, tremble, whet, wonder

WRITER'S TIP: *If a critique partner voices confusion over the emotional reaction of one of your characters, check to make sure the stimulus trigger is prominent. Showing the cause-effect relationship is vital when conveying authentic emotion.*

ANXIETY

DEFINITION: An intense feeling of unease and worry, sometimes without cause

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Rubbing the back of the neck

Crossing the arms, forming a barrier to others

Standing with one arm clasping the other at the elbow

Clutching a purse, coat, or other object

Wringing one's hands or rubbing at the skin in a self-soothing way

Twisting a watch or ring

Scratching

Hands repeatedly rising to touch one's face

Fingering a necklace (especially if it is a symbol of comfort)

Rolling one's shoulders

Bouncing a foot

Glancing at the clock, phone, or doorway

Holding the stomach and bending forward slightly

Clutching one's hands

Rocking in place

Twisting one's neck, as if it's sore

Biting at the lips or nails

Head shaking

Shifting, unable to get comfortable

Blowing out a series of short breaths to gain control

Digging in a purse or pocket to keep the hands busy

Becoming easily distracted

Adjusting clothes, as if they chafe

An inability to eat

Rubbing one's arms and looking around

Bouncing a curled knuckle against the mouth

A darting gaze
Increased awareness of one's environment
Starting at noises or sudden movements
Excessive swallowing
Repeatedly checking a phone for messages
Impatience
Praying
Muttering under the breath

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Feeling too hot or too cold
Restless legs
Dizziness
A churning stomach
Increased thirst
Tingling in one's limbs
A tightening chest and accelerated breathing
Feeling like one's insides are quivering

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Thinking about worst-case scenarios
Engaging in self-blame
Seeking reassurance from others
Time feeling like it's slowing down
Experiencing discomfort in close spaces
Irrational worries
Mentally beating oneself up for being unable to control this feeling
Replaying the events that caused this feeling

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Excessive sweating
A ragged appearance

Talking to oneself under the breath
Rocking in one's seat
Heart palpitations, hyperventilating, or even panic attacks
Emergence of fears, phobias, or OCD-like symptoms

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

A false smile
Tightness in the eyes
Avoiding conversation
Finding somewhere to be alone
Doing things to appear normal (e.g., ordering food but not eating it)
Feigning interest in something nearby
Closing one's eyes in an attempt to stay calm
Smoothing or stroking one's hair as a soothing gesture

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Fear](#), [Desperation](#), [Paranoia](#), [Panic](#), [Hysteria](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Wariness](#), [Vulnerability](#), [Relief](#), [Gratitude](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Bother, brood, carve, chase, choke, dig, distract, drill, fluster, gnaw, grate, insist, jar, jerk, jump, natter, pace, pester, pound, press, question, rattle, rub, shake, speculate, squeeze, startle, strain, struggle, sweat, twist, unsettle, upset, wring

WRITER'S TIP: *For each scene, identify the emotion you need to show and think in terms of three...what three ways have you reinforced the character's feelings through verbal and nonverbal communication?*

APPALLED

DEFINITION: An emotionally disturbing shock due to something offensive

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS

Flinching or jerking back from the source

The lips curling or pulling back in disgust

An audible intake of breath

A gaping mouth

Eyes bulging, followed by rapid blinking

Looking away or down while stepping back

The eyebrows drawing close together

The jaw going slack

Slowly yet forcibly expelling all breath as one tries to process what's happening

One's lips moving as words refuse to immediately form

One's posture straightening, the muscles visibly tightening

Clasping a hand over one's own mouth

Grabbing the fabric of one's shirt in a fist (at chest level)

Briefly covering one's mouth and then moving the hand to one's breastbone

Putting a hand out as if to ward off what one has witnessed or was told

Swallowing before speaking

Asking *What?* sharply (if the shock resulted from something another said)

Saying *Oh my God*, or *Did you see what he did?* as one tries to process

One's shoulders rolling forward as the chest caves, making the neck seem to shrink

Rubbing at the chest

Appearing to go white in the face

Legs drawing together as one's stance tightens

Rubbing hands against one's clothing as if trying to rid them of something

Backing away; increasing personal distance from the source

Turning away and raising the hands to the face

Responding with broken sentences as one tries to find the right words

Raising a hand to the temple and shaking one's head

One's voice rising in volume

Gesturing wildly as one discusses the situation with others

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

The gut tightening as one forces out all breath

A dry mouth

Light-headedness as one's breath briefly gets trapped in the lungs

One's palm (or fist) growing hot from a forced exhale

A feeling of disorientation

A flush of heat in the face and neck as shock transforms into anger

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Mentally replaying what one has just witnessed or experienced

Sharpened focus on and scrutiny of the source

One's thoughts leaping forward to possible repercussions of what one has just learned

Not wanting to be touched

Feeling a rush of disappointment in those responsible

Looking for someone or something to blame

A need for answers, to know why, to understand how this outcome came about

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

The eyes growing hot and tearing up

Becoming extremely inarticulate or incapable of speaking altogether

Going over the moment again and again in one's mind

Berating oneself for not seeing this coming or for misplacing one's trust
Disbelief leading to disillusionment (in others, a specific person, society, etc.)

Growing angry and confrontational (fight)

Needing to escape because one can't deal with the situation (flight)

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Eyes that widen slightly

Tightness in the face

A gaping mouth that is quickly closed

The lips pressing into a tight, flat line

Rapid swallowing

Not speaking to avoid giving away one's feelings

Turning away from the source or avoiding eye contact to try and collect oneself

Hesitating or clearing the throat to compose oneself before changing the subject or redirecting attention elsewhere

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Anger](#), [Disgust](#), [Resentment](#), [Defiant](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Disbelief](#), [Disappointment](#), [Disillusionment](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Back away, balk, blanch, bristle, flinch, gape, gasp, horrify, offend, rankle, rattle, recoil, repel, shake, shock, shrink, sicken, snap, squawk, stagger, startle, stumble, stutter, swallow, taint, unseat, unsettle, wince

WRITER'S TIP: *Emotions aren't always pure or beautiful; sometimes characters feel things that will reveal their dark side. Don't be afraid to show these moments when it's important to the story. Readers will recognize they come from a place of truth and appreciate the author's honesty to write them.*

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APPREHENSION

DEFINITION: A stress state caused by the anticipation of misfortune or adversity

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Watching the clock or door (or checking one's phone for a text, etc.)

Chewing the inside of a cheek

Wetting or biting the lips

Rocking slightly with a faraway look (an inward gaze)

An uneven stride or hesitating before moving

A fixed look of concentration

Growing unusually quiet

Offering a flash of a smile that doesn't reach the eyes

Needing to get up, move, or do something

Gripping the hands together

Repeatedly pinching the skin between the thumb and forefinger

Picking at one's cuticles

Touching the face frequently (scratching a cheek, rubbing an eyebrow, etc.)

A strained voice

Impatience with others

Rapping one's fingers against the thigh, or tapping a loose fist against the lips

Taking periodic deep breaths with long exhales

Smoothing down one's clothing

Changing one's clothing frequently (if one will be judged for one's appearance)

Grimacing; displaying a pained look

Fidgeting and touching things; needing to keep one's hands busy

Going into planning mode (talking out options, making notes to oneself, etc.)

Starting tasks only to abandon them due to a lack of focus

Being unable to engage fully with others (relaxing, conversing, sharing activities, etc.)

Picking at food due to a lackluster appetite or displaying the opposite in the form of restless snacking

Drinking too much coffee, smoking too much, vaping far more than usual, etc.

Difficulty following conversations unless they center on one's worries

Rubbing one's arms as if they're cold

Needing to talk things out with others (even strangers) to process feelings

Asking others for their take on the situation

Soliciting information from people in the know to better understand what one is up against

Turning to those who have navigated this situation or challenge before

Listing possible problems and obstacles on paper

Talking to oneself

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A tightness or tingling in the chest

Dryness in the mouth caused by frequent swallowing

Feeling the throb of one's heartbeat during still, quiet periods
(increased blood pressure)

Light-headedness

An upset stomach

Feeling itchier than normal

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A fixation on whatever is causing the apprehension

Creating a mental tally of what could go wrong

Thinking back to other experiences where apprehension was warranted

Proactively building strategies to deal with possible complications

Engaging in self-talk to encourage positive thinking and optimism
(which only half-works)

Sensitivity to loud or unusual sounds

Thoughts that won't turn off

Wishing time would hurry up

Difficulty sleeping, or falling asleep but quickly waking up again

Over-preparing (studying, over-packing, checking and re-checking documents, etc.)

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Second-guessing one's decisions and actions

Being risk-averse and taking extra precautions

Reversing a choice due to irrational superstitions or the idea that "safe is better than sorry"

Being impatient with others; displaying rudeness

Lashing out over small things

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Asking questions in a roundabout way that circle one's concerns or fears

Trying to stay active to distract oneself from worry

Nodding to oneself and speaking with optimism

Apologizing and making an excuse for any unusual behavior that draws attention

Feigning fatigue or boredom to appear at ease to others

A smile that appears frozen or that disappears quickly

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Dread](#), [Fear](#), [Tormented](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Vulnerability](#), [Relief](#), [Unease](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Agitate, clasp, conceal, confess, disguise, dread, fidget, fuss, grow, lean, obsess, overthink, pace, pinch, question, redo, reevaluate, rethink, reverse, seize, shift, startle, strain, tighten, tremble, undo, unsettle, voice, wait, watch, waver, worry

WRITER'S TIP: *The emotional spectrum is vast, yet often we only see more prominent “core” feelings being described. Go off the map! Incorporate a variety of feelings to provide a richer experience for your readers.*

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AWE

DEFINITION: Euphoric-like wonder at being in the presence of something vast enough to change one's perceptions or understanding of the world

NOTES: Awe can enlighten or terrify (based on whether the character can handle what they have experienced), since it often leaves a person feeling small and insignificant. For the negative emotional reaction, please see the HORROR entry.

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Ceasing all movement

Tension leaving one's body

The shoulders dropping

One's mouth falling open slightly (a slack jaw)

The neck tipping back

A deeper intake of breath

Unabashed staring

Slowly releasing a deep breath

Being rendered speechless (or becoming less articulate)

Forgetting to blink; having a fixed gaze

Laying a hand against the breastbone

Grabbing the sides of one's head and then sliding one's fingers down the cheeks

Remaining still for an extended time, not wishing to interrupt the surreal moment

Being overcome with a desire to get closer (taking a step, reaching out, etc.)

Moving carefully (having a lighter touch, taking slower steps, etc.)

Speaking softly as to not break the spell

Repeating *Wow*, or *This is unbelievable*.

Fumbling a hand toward someone else to draw their attention to the source or event

Sitting down to observe and absorb, casting aside other priorities

Wrapping one's arms around oneself

Uncontrolled trembling

Slowly sliding from a standing to a sitting position

Squatting down, as if to rest one's legs while taking in the spectacle

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Goosebumps sliding along the back of the neck

The heart rate picking up

Light-headedness

An expanding feeling in the chest

Feeling fully awake and energized in the aftermath (adrenaline rush)

Swallowing to relieve dryness from one's mouth hanging open

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Concerns and worries falling away

Forgetting what one was in the middle of doing

Feeling utterly present in the moment

Heightened senses; acute awareness of sensory stimuli (colors, smells, sensations, etc.)

Noticing and cataloging "the little things" as part of the experience

A desire to share the moment with others; feeling a sense of connection

Curiosity being awakened, resulting in mental questions and observations

Ignoring discomforts and distractions easily; staying fully focused on the experience

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

A willingness to take risks if it increases one's connection to the event or experience

Legs that wobble (going weak due to overstimulation)

Tears sliding down one's face

Being so present in the moment one forgets to record the experience on a cell phone

A desire to travel, have new experiences, or connect with the world in a meaningful way

Increased generosity and compassion

Being more willing to help others

One's mind returning to the experience afterward to revisit the feeling

Feeling different than before, like one is more awake or aware

In the aftermath, experiencing a "reset" of what's important in life

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Turning away, breaking eye contact (with effort), and shrugging

Sneaking glances at the event or situation rather than keeping one's focus there

Speaking when there's no need, just to "break the spell"

Minimizing the importance of the current moment by relaying a past story or experience that was more awe-inducing

Fidgeting on purpose to appear restless or bored (flicking open a lighter lid and closing it over and over, jangling keys, exploring one's pockets, etc.)

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Euphoria](#), [Adoration](#), [Desire](#), [Obsessed](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Moved](#), [Connectedness](#), [Admiration](#), [Happiness](#), [Peacefulness](#), [Satisfaction](#), [Humbled](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Astound, bask, calm, comfort, dazzle, fascinate, floor, gape, gawk, hearten, inspire, listen, mesmerize, mystify, praise, revel, savor, shiver, silence, spellbind, strike, stun, stupefy, thrill, tingle, touch, transfix, tremble, whisper, wonder

WRITER'S TIP: When you're describing a character's emotional reaction through the eyes of another character, think about the depth of their relationship. If it's close, a simple hair tuck or half-wave could be steeped in meaning which the point of view character can then share with the reader.

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BETRAYED

DEFINITION: A state of wounded outrage at being dehumanized and disrespected by someone of value

NOTES: When a character feels betrayed, reactions will vary depending on how personal the relationship was. This state often embraces a progression of complicated emotions: shock, disbelief, and denial that eventually turn to acceptance, hurt, or outrage.

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

- One's posture stiffening suddenly
- Flinching (especially if the betrayal is revealed through something said)
- A shocked, deeply pained look (the eyebrows drawing together, an inward stare, etc.)
- Closing the eyes while lowering one's head
- Poking a tongue against a cheek while exhaling
- A deliberate, angry shaking of the head, with the mouth forming a round "O"
- Letting out a forceful breath
- Difficulty forming words immediately
- Forearm muscles that twitch and grow taut
- The head cocking to the side
- Making fists (possibly quaking and whitening from the tension)
- Lips that are pinched tight
- An intense, cold stare
- Rubbing at the hair on one's crown and then grabbing a fistful
- Kneading at one's chest
- Holding one's head while seated and asking *Why?* or saying *I can't believe this.*
- Quick, jerky movements

Increasing personal distance (backing up, creating space between oneself and others, etc.)

Shielding the body (crossing one's arms, moving to stand behind a chair, etc.)

Nostrils that flare

Clumsiness that escalates one's rage

Throwing or shoving something for release

A voice that grows rough or thick

Speaking in short bursts or letting out a long tirade

Needing to sit down but being unable to stay seated for long

Swearing, name-calling, and making verbal judgments

Clenching or grinding one's teeth

Rising in height, the spine going stiff as anger takes hold

Pinching the bridge of one's nose and pushing out slow, deep breaths to try and calm down

Revealing secrets or sensitive information about the person to others

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Pressure or pain as one sucks in the cheeks to bite down on them in anger

A sharp pain or sudden tightness in the chest

Blurring vision and a sensation of heat as one tries to fend off tears

Pain in the throat

Growing hot as the body temperature rises

Pain in the palms from fingernails digging into skin (clenched fists)

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A primal urge to hit or destroy something (fight)

Vacillating between disbelief, hurt, and rage

A desire for revenge

Feeling deeply vulnerable and exposed

Recalling past interactions with the betrayer and analyzing them for missed signs

Wanting to be alone to process what's happened (flight)

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Negative self-talk for not seeing this coming or for offering trust in the first place

Self-loathing for a perceived inner weakness (naivety, gullibility, etc.)

Fantasizing about the betrayer getting what they deserve

Making plans to bring the betrayer's actions to light so they are held accountable

Seeking revenge and engaging in violence

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Going from animated and engaged to withdrawn and nonverbal

Taking longer than normal to respond in a conversation

Making an excuse to leave

Laughing it off

Showing false empathy: *I'm sure he had a good reason, or She must have been in a bad place.*

Acting as if this outcome was expected

Being the bigger person even though it hurts deeply (responding with grace)

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Appalled](#), [Rage](#), [Vengeful](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Disillusionment](#), [Insecurity](#), [Wariness](#), [Powerlessness](#), [Bitterness](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Ache, alienate, blindsides, bruise, carve, clench, cripple, crush, cut, daze, demoralize, destroy, devastate, erode, eviscerate, falter, grieve, hinder, impede, insult, jeopardize, offend,

rattle, ravage, resent, retaliate, scathe, shake, shock, strike, suffer, tarnish, undermine, upset, violate, weaken, wound

WRITER'S TIP: *All people, and therefore all characters, make associations when exploring their world. For each setting, think about any emotional attachments a character may have to it based on their past experiences. Then, use these associations to evoke mood.*

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BITTERNESS

DEFINITION: Deep hostility and unhappiness caused by unfair treatment

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Snarky commentary designed to take away from someone else's good mood

Tilting the chin downward so one can look "down" on someone

A pinched mouth and sour expression

A direct stare that lacks warmth

Speaking matter-of-factly

A tightness in one's eyes

Looking upward and disparagingly shaking one's head

Taking offense easily

A closed body posture (arms crossed in front of the chest, increased personal distance, etc.)

Minimizing the accomplishments of others: *That's because her daddy's well connected.*

Complaining constantly

Sneering

A set jaw

Saying things like *There's nothing to forgive* but not meaning it

Having strong opinions about everything

Interrupting, especially when someone is sharing something positive

Sharp or stiff movements that allude to controlled anger

Being unable to relax, especially when one is close to the source of the emotional pain

Fixating on the perceived injustice (stalking someone on social media who was involved in a betrayal, for example)

Pointing out the faults and flaws of others

Telling people what they should do or how they can do it better

False smiles or enthusiasm at someone's good news
A hard edge to one's voice and words
Starting arguments or being argumentative
Lashing out at others over little things to mask one's pain regarding the real issue

Nursing grudges and bringing up the past
Rarely saying *Thank you* or showing gratitude
Choosing not to help when one could (especially if one feels slighted by the individual making the request)
Being quick to lay blame
Angry outbursts that are out of proportion to the circumstance
Keeping secrets to have power over someone
Being two-faced
Stiffness when touching others, such as when one is accepting or giving a hug
Being prone to illness

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Tightness in the chest
A jaw that aches
Headaches or body pain
Sensitivity to touch

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Believing that someone else is to blame for one's circumstances
Having trust issues
Believing others could have intervened and prevented one's pain
Refusing to take responsibility for negative outcomes
A desire to get even or force someone else to experience one's pain
An inability to forgive
Being quick to judge
Jealousy and envy over even the smallest things

Moods that often run either hot or cold

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Isolation

Playing the martyr; being unable to move on from an event

Being unable to engage in small talk with others

Negativity that seeps into all aspects of one's life

Health issues

Losing friendships (due to one's negativity, a toxic outlook, etc.)

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Making passive-aggressive comments

Giving small, tight smiles

Speaking positively but showing negativity through one's actions (e.g., offering congratulations while furiously drying dishes or dashing off a memo)

Giving backhanded compliments: *Good job. I didn't think you had it in you.*

Making oneself scarce once good news is shared

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Anger](#), [Rage](#), [Vengeful](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Resentment](#), [Irritation](#), [Disappointment](#), [Self-Pity](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Berate, betray, blame, boil, bristle, complain, disbelieve, dredge, fester, flame, flare, gall, glower, heat, insult, irritate, jab, judge, mutter, point, poke, provoke, quarrel, resent, seethe, shock, smolder, spar, spit, sputter, struggle, sulk

WRITER'S TIP: *With emotion, get personal. A tragic situation like a news story about a lost child on TV will affect everyone, but if the child is someone special to the character who is watching, the effect is tenfold.*

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CERTAINTY

DEFINITION: A state of absolute belief; to be without doubt

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

A strong decisive nod or rapid nodding

Unwavering eye contact

A lack of hesitation to commit or volunteer

Speaking in absolutes: *The vote will go through*, or *There's no way to recover from this*.

Thrusting the chest out

Touching others to get their attention (grabbing an arm, etc.)

Having good posture (shoulders back, drawing up to full height, etc.)

Head lifted high, exposing the neck

Being decisive (making decisions quickly, not needing to ask for advice or input)

Even breathing, exuding calm

A wide, open stance

Quietly observing; not needing to prove oneself

Inviting questions and being willing to answer them

Moving closer to others or showing a willingness to let others in one's personal space

Responding to questions quickly and firmly

Citing facts and past experiences to back up one's belief in conversation

Speaking confidently and positively, without any need for subterfuge or insults

Waving a hand dismissively when others show doubt

Smiling at concerns or worries to display their groundlessness

Having an answer for every question

Becoming more verbal or emphatic (if conveying one's conviction is needed)

A firm handshake

Disengaging in a judgmental tone if others don't fall into line: *Well, good luck, then.*

Being the first to act or react

A willingness to approach or engage

A voice that is firm

Speaking one's mind; not beating around the bush

A noticeable lack of fidgeting, touching the face, or fiddling with things

Stating opinions rather than making suggestions

Making grandiose statements on where one stands: *I'm right about this. I'd bet my house on it.*

Moving with confidence (no hesitation, a direct stride, etc.)

Becoming smug and dismissive

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

An expanding feeling in the chest

A vibration in the mouth, throat, and chest that accompanies humming (if one's certainty allows one to let go of all worries)

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Feeling kinship with those who share the same certainty or conviction

Being willing to commit without knowing all the details

Focusing on information that supports one's belief and dismissing the rest

Forming a mental case (examples to use, information to cite) to convince others to align with one's viewpoint

A mind-over-body mindset, allowing for increased endurance, fortitude, and stamina

Having a strong mental focus

A sensation of being untouchable, as if one is invincible

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Increased self-confidence

Choosing a leadership role so one can have influence (if this is important)

A need to warn any who will be negatively impacted if they don't agree

Becoming closed to new information that's contrary (ignoring facts, refusing to converse)

Taking risks without thought

Being comfortable making far-reaching plans and going out on a limb

Increased impatience with those who constantly try to interfere or sway one's convictions

Pushing one's view and even becoming argumentative if the stakes are high

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Asking others for their input or advice

Asking questions that one knows the answers to: *It's a good sign he agreed, right?*

A smile that one quickly masks

Avoiding eye contact, or breaking eye contact by looking down

Backpedaling to make people think that one's mind isn't set: *But you never know, right?*

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Confidence](#), [Fearlessness](#), [Smugness](#), [Pride](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Surprise](#), [Conflicted](#), [Confusion](#), [Unease](#), [Doubt](#), [Worry](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Affirm, agree, assert, assure, avow, charge, claim, commit, convert, convince, credit, engage, entrust, express, fixate, forecast, foresee, give, influence, know, lead, magnify, motivate, obey, plan, praise, preach, predict, proclaim, push, reassure, reinforce, rely, secure, serve, sign, state, support, trust, voice, volunteer

WRITER'S TIP: *How a character views their world should always be filtered through their emotions. What they are concerned about, desire, fear, and what impacts their self-identity will steer emotions and change how they perceive each setting.*

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CONCERN

DEFINITION: Sincere regard for (or having a personal interest in) someone or something

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Eyebrows drawing together

Tilting the head and making strong eye contact

Opening one's mouth to speak, pausing to collect one's thoughts, then continuing

Looking inward and blinking rapidly

Leaning in while moving closer

Growing still to better observe

Making a micro-movement toward the object of concern, then stopping

Asking pointed questions to better understand the importance of what's unfolding

Nodding and blinking as someone explains in more detail

Raised eyebrows

Pursed lips

Entering the personal space of the person one is concerned about

Asking *Are you okay?* or *What does this mean for you?*

Maintaining an open body posture to include others

Lowering or deepening one's voice

Pinching one's chin while listening or thinking

Touching the face more often

Asking questions and requesting clarifications to understand the situation in full

Covering the mouth or rubbing at the lips in thought

Pulling out a phone to make a note or do further research

Physically touching a person who is the focus—offering a light squeeze, rub, or tap

Pointing the knees toward the speaker (while sitting) and leaning in

Cutting people off or interrupting—not out of rudeness but from a need to know

Prompting another with questions so they'll reveal more detail

Offering platitudes: *We'll get this figured out*, or *I'm sure everything will be fine*.

Giving well-meaning (and possibly unsolicited) advice

Validating another's concerns: *That makes sense*. *I can see why you're worried*.

Speaking in terms of *we*, not *you*, so others feel supported

Offering comfort in small ways (providing a seat or drink, going for a walk with them, etc.)

Offering to step in, use one's resources, investigate, or run an errand to help

Volunteering one's time to a project or initiative in hopes of resolving a problem

Making promises to offer support, show that one cares, or prove commitment

Using one's connections to try and help another navigate this situation

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

One's pulse picking up

Muscles tightening

Body tension from strained attentiveness

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A hyper-focus on the person or thing one is interacting with

Forgetting other priorities or responsibilities in the moment

Paying more attention to cues (verbal and physical) to better understand how another feels

Listening intently

Scanning the mannerisms of others for clues as to the stakes involved or possible situational undercurrents

Reading into things; analyzing

A desire to help, encourage someone, or fix the situation

One's mind skipping ahead to possible consequences, fallout, and repercussions

Feeling protective of another

Looking backward to try and understand how things ended up in the current state

Thinking about how this new information will personally impact oneself

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Following up (with phone calls, texts, visits, etc.)

Obsessive thoughts about the situation or person

Investigating independently to gain new insight or more information

Crowd-sourcing (asking others to weigh in) in hopes an idea or solution will hit

One's mind going to the worst-case scenarios

Being unable to let go

One's mind constantly turning back to the problem or situation

Needing reassurance that one is viewing things the correct way

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Brushing the situation off as if it isn't important

Changing the topic

Shrugging and nonchalance

Making excuses to leave so one can think about how to help

Talking louder and without hesitation

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Anxiety](#), [Frustration](#), [Impatience](#), [Worry](#), [Pity](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Relief](#), [Acceptance](#), [Curiosity](#), [Hopefulness](#), [Gratitude](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Advise, assist, bolster, consider, devote, embrace, empathize, examine, express, focus, help, include, involve, listen, question, reflect, relate, repeat, research, rivet, support, touch, volunteer

WRITER'S TIP: *To check if your emotional showing is on point, ask WHY: Why does the character care so much? Why does this moment impact them so deeply? The answers should be clear through your description and narrative.*

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CONFIDENCE

DEFINITION: Having faith in one's influence and ability

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Strong posture (shoulders back, chest out, chin high, etc.)

Walking with wide steps and a steady gait

Strong hygiene and personal grooming

Holding the hands loosely behind the back

Touching one's fingertips together (tapping, forming a steeple, etc.)

A gleam in one's eye

Sharing a smile or playful grin

Winking or giving someone an easy nod

Keeping one's hands out of the pockets

Appearing relaxed (slouching against a wall, humming, etc.)

Taking up space (legs spread wide, arms loose at the sides, etc.)

Approaching people with ease and inviting them into one's personal space

Looking others directly in the eye

Arms swinging while walking

Choosing the middle, not the sides (be it a couch or a room)

Using exaggerated movements to draw attention to oneself

A booming laugh

A tilted-back head

Speaking boisterously

Offering witty commentary

Giving a half-shrug or a grin that conveys secret knowledge

Lighthearted teasing

Flirting

A strong handshake

Leaning back in a chair, hands behind the head

An easygoing manner

Stretching

Showing comfort in the proximity of others

Initiating contact; approaching others directly and without hesitation

Telling jokes

Adding to or steering a conversation

Hosting events (getting the guys together for a football game)

Openness when dealing with people

Appearing unbothered by what others may think

Leaning in to talk or listen

Asking questions to gain knowledge; being able to shelve one's ego

Increased physical contact; becoming touchy-feely

Running one's hands through one's hair or flipping the hair back

Assuming a pose that draws attention to one's best attributes

Leading rather than following

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A downward pull in the shoulder muscles as one's arms hang relaxed
and tension-free

Easy breaths

Lightness in the chest

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A sense of calm and ease

A positive outlook

Interest in whatever's going on

A desire to help by using one's skills to improve a situation or fill a
need

Aiming for bigger goals that will stretch oneself

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Doing or saying things outside of the norm without anxiety or concern

A willingness to try new things and embrace challenges

Adaptability; taking on new roles as needed
Obsessively talking about an achievement or material object
Reacting with anger or jealousy if one's reputation is impugned
Bragging and showing off

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Minimizing compliments
Modesty
Changing the topic to bring others into the spotlight
Downplaying one's own comfort level to make others feel better
Asking for opinions or advice
Sharing the accolades with others: *I couldn't have done it without their help*, or *We make a good team*.

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Satisfaction](#), [Pride](#), [Smugness](#), [Contempt](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Doubt](#), [Reluctance](#), [Regret](#), [Uncertainty](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Act, aim, assert, assist, avow, beam, believe, boast, bolster, build, command, commit, delegate, empower, encourage, exude, hearten, help, influence, inspire, lead, motivate, persuade, rebel, restore, shape, steer, thrust, wink

WRITER'S TIP: *It is natural to hold back or hide our true scope of emotions in the presence of others. When writing a conflicted protagonist, it is critical to show through action the emotion the character wants to convey to others while also expressing their true feelings to the reader.*

CONFLICTED

DEFINITION: Experiencing opposing emotions

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

The lips pressing together in a slight grimace

Increased swallowing or blinking

Wrinkling the nose

A smile that wavers

A gaze that ping-pongs and avoids direct eye contact

Start-and-stop gesturing (reaching then hesitating, changing direction mid-stride, etc.)

Broken dialogue and self-interruptions

Making apologies for one's unfocused responses

Opening and closing the mouth

Struggling to find the right words

Soft head shaking

Voicing support in a tone that lacks enthusiasm

Becoming quieter and less animated

Scratching one's neck or cheek

Rubbing or pulling at an ear

Asking questions to gain more insight

Talking to others about similar experiences or situations

Gathering opinions on what others would do

A need to sit down and reflect

Rubbing or pinching the bottom lip

Making a *Hmmm* noise in the throat

Tilting the head in a side-to-side rhythm

Pulling in and then slowly releasing a deep breath

Apologizing for one's lackluster reaction, citing mixed feelings

Requesting some time to digest everything

Tapping one's index finger against the lip

The brows pulling in as one looks downward
Rubbing at the middle of one's forehead while one's eyes are closed
Voicing conflict or surprise: *This is a tough decision*, or *Sorry, you caught me off guard*.

Knees that bend, then straighten
A restless stance
Pacing
Rubbing a hand through the hair
Smoothing one's clothes or touching items to keep the hands busy
Cancelling gestures (smiling while shaking the head, nodding and grimacing, etc.)
Holding one's elbow while the opposite hand makes a fist against the mouth
Blowing one's cheeks out, then swallowing the air or releasing it
Holding one's hands out and "weighing" them in the air
Forcing enthusiasm because it's the right thing to do
Subdued or delayed reactions

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Headaches
A heaviness in the body
Tightness in the chest
A sinking feeling in the stomach

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Weighing the pros and cons
Researching or seeking information
Guilt toward those who may be negatively affected by a final decision
Playing *What if?* to understand the repercussion of a situation
A need to verbalize the internal conflict
A desire to retreat and go somewhere quiet to think
An inability to focus on anything but the internal conflict

Drawing on moral beliefs to help one decide

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

A disheveled look (hair out of place, clothes rumpled, etc.)

Obsessive information gathering; looking for the “key” solution

Stomach upset, poor diet, or a loss of appetite leading to weight loss

Stress headaches

Difficulty sleeping

A loss of self-confidence

Avoiding making any decisions at all

Hair loss

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Citing that one is not the ideal candidate to make the choice

Making excuses to avoid the situation

Suggesting that a break is needed in order to regroup

Making a joke to alleviate tension or lighten the mood

Giving a distracted nod to what’s being said

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Confusion](#), [Overwhelmed](#), [Frustration](#),
[Anxiety](#).

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Doubt](#), [Reluctance](#), [Regret](#), [Uncertainty](#).

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Agonize, backpedal, battle, blur, clash, compete, contradict, divide, fray, perplex, question, reevaluate, second-guess, skew, split, stop, straddle, strain, struggle, undo, vacillate, waffle, wage, waver, weigh, wonder, worry, wrestle

WRITER'S TIP: *In scenes where information must be shared, characters should still be moving, acting, and revealing emotion to keep the pace flowing smoothly.*

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CONFUSION

DEFINITION: A state of befuddlement or bafflement

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Difficulty completing a task

Fumbling

Using *um* and *uh* hesitations or an uncertain tone

Grimacing or frowning

Excessive swallowing

Scratching at one's cheek or temple

Rubbing the chin

Repeating back what was said as a question

Touching the base of the neck

Showing one's palms and shrugging

Stuttering or having a difficult time finding the right words

Body posture that loosens or collapses

Tilting one's head to the side while pursing the lips

The head flinching back slightly

Trailing off when speaking

Running the hands through the hair

Eyebrows that squish together

Pulling or tugging on an ear

Asking someone to repeat what was said

One's gaze clouding or going distant

Rubbing one's forehead or eyebrows

Asking questions to buy time

Biting the lip

Rapid blinking

Hands touching the lips, mouth, and face

Glancing around as if looking for answers

Wandering a short distance to think, and then returning

Turning away to gather one's thoughts
A slight headshake
Talking around the situation in hopes that clarity might come about
A mouth that opens but nothing comes out
Blowing out the cheeks, then releasing
A blank look; a slack expression
Staring down at the ground
Asking for affirmation: *Are you sure?*
Tapping a fist against the lips
Poking one's tongue into the cheek
Dry washing one's hands

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Rising body heat
Fluttering in the stomach
A tightening chest
Feeling overheated

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Thoughts that freeze
Hoping for an interruption to delay answering
The mind racing, searching for answers
Feeling exposed and judged

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Flight responses
Failing grades
Not being trusted with responsibility or decision making
Loss of respect from others for unfinished or inaccurate work
Broken or unfulfilled promises
A lack of productivity leading to a loss of self-esteem

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Nodding or agreeing, to avoid attention

False confidence

Assuring others that everything is under control

Smiling and nodding while waving a hand

Physical touches to reassure others (a clap on the back or shoulder, etc.)

Steering the conversation to a different topic

Launching into a flurry of activity

Making promises

Showing a sudden interest in other things

The face reddening and starting to sweat

Using “word filler” to stall for time

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Flustered](#), [Frustration](#), [Resignation](#), [Insecurity](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Acceptance](#), [Curiosity](#), [Relief](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Addle, analyze, baffle, bewilder, confound, consider, disorient, disrupt, double-check, doubt, embarrass, entangle, evade, excuse, flush, fluster, frustrate, fumble, heat, lie, misdirect, misinform, misinterpret, perplex, ponder, question, repeat, stall, stutter, think, vacillate, waver, wonder, worry

WRITER’S TIP: *Men and women often experience and express emotions differently. When writing a character of the opposite sex, consider getting a second opinion to ensure a character’s reactions, thoughts, and feelings are authentic.*

CONNECTEDNESS

DEFINITION: To experience a meaningful state of closeness with others, the world, or the universe itself

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

A genuine smile (that reaches the eyes, lasts a long time, isn't forced, etc.)

Eyes that light up

A face that softens as all tension leaves it

Holding or squeezing the hand of another who feels the same bond

Hugs that last

Touching the face of another (a stroke of the cheek, touching foreheads together, etc.)

Asking questions out of genuine curiosity and interest

Open, welcoming body posture (facing people head on, standing at ease, reaching out, etc.)

Taking deep, cleansing breaths

Moving closer to those one feels a kinship with (erasing distance)

Sitting cross-legged and leaning back, using one's arms as supports

Turning one's face upward

Spending more time observing, appreciating, and interacting with nature

Closing the eyes and taking in a deep breath before exhaling

Humming or singing (if one is prone to doing so)

Lighter movements and steps (gracefulness)

Leaning towards others

Lighthearted joking or teasing with those one feels connected to

Discussing more personal things in conversations

Sharing deeper thoughts, worries, or fears as it feels natural and safe to do so

Being honest and transparent in conversations

Giddiness or playfulness

Laughing more

Welcoming questions and answering without holding back or feeling self-conscious

Touching (laying a hand on another's arm or shoulder) to enhance the feeling

Interacting with one's immediate surroundings (running one's fingers over the fabric of a hand-stitched pillow on a couch, inhaling a pleasant scent, etc.)

A willingness to help (jumping in to assist, spotting what needs to be done and acting, etc.)

Doing things out of kindness, not obligation (being thoughtful, bringing a gift, etc.)

Making oneself physically vulnerable because one feels completely safe (lying back in the grass, approaching wildlife, standing with the arms thrown wide, etc.)

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Goosebumps (from heightened tactile sensitivity)

A pleasurable tingling in the skin (sensitivity to warmth and touch)

A pull in the shoulders as one's upper body slackens into a relaxed state

Tingling in the nasal passages from pulling in deep, contented breaths

An expansive feeling in the chest

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A lack of judgment or desire to judge others

Feeling deep appreciation for all things

Being less attached to physical possessions

Appreciating others and feeling centered in the moment

Engaging in prayer or deep thoughts about the world and one's place in

it

Thinking about one's shortcomings and how to be better (a desire to grow)

A lack of self-consciousness

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

A need to be with those who make one feel complete

Sharing deep, intimate thoughts and ideas that are a core part of one's identity

Increased confidence; feeling more capable

Embracing challenges and bigger tasks in an effort to benefit the wider world

Becoming a deeper thinker

Spending large amounts of time in nature or with other people
(depending on who or what one is connecting to)

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Hiding one's hands behind the back or in pockets to avoid reaching out

Avoiding eye contact with those one feels kinship with

Busying oneself with tasks to seem preoccupied or focused elsewhere

Avoiding conversation (to avoid saying something that gives one away)

Being overly polite or formal

Leaving a place that one feels connected to, thereby minimizing its importance to others

Spending time alone rather than with another

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Happiness](#), [Satisfaction](#), [Awe](#), [Wanderlust](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Peacefulness](#), [Valued](#), [Happiness](#),
[Confidence](#), [Sappy](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Accept, affect, appreciate, attach, belong, bind, brush, care, cherish, close, hold, hug, join, link, lock, match,

meld, mesh, motivate, need, nurture, revere, seal, sense, serve, sync, touch, transcend, transfix, twin, want, wed, welcome

WRITER'S TIP: *Another way to help readers understand the character's emotion better is to tie it to a universal experience. For example, a character could compare their frustration to a recurring dream where they must make a critical phone call but keep dialing the number wrong.*

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CONTEMPT

DEFINITION: A lack of reverence or respect; to hold in disregard

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Crossing one's arms to show a closed body posture

A downturned mouth

One's head tilting away

Sneering

Shaking the head and sighing or muttering

Mocking another through words or derogatory actions

Rolling the eyes

Using sarcasm

Gossiping

Snorting loudly

Buzzing the lips to be rude (blowing a raspberry)

Baiting the other person

Turning the body at an angle instead of facing the other person head-on

Walking away

Waving dismissively while refusing to answer a question because it's not worth the effort

Stiff posture

Fingers curling

Refusing to respond or engage

Lowering the chin to look down on someone

A cold look (devoid of emotion, head tilted down during eye contact, etc.)

A pinched mouth

A hard, distinctive jaw line

Smirking as the person speaks

Ugly laughter

Making jokes at another's expense

Adopting a hard tone and using forceful language
Flashing a cold smile to show insincerity
Spitting in the direction of the one provoking contempt
Sticking a tongue out
Holding a wide stance, with the chest thrust out
Talking over someone, ignoring them, or refusing to recognize their input
Revealing someone's mistakes to peers or publicly calling them out
Refusing to acknowledge someone's contribution or position

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Rising blood pressure
A tightening in the chest
Stiffness in the neck and jaw
A roiling heat in the belly

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Negative thinking
Unkind observations and mental insults
A hyperawareness of the one causing this feeling (even when pretending to ignore them)
A desire to verbally tear down or hurt another person
Wanting to expose the subject's ignorance

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Swearing and offering insults
Yelling and arguing
High blood pressure
A vein throbbing visibly in the forehead
Thoughts of violence
Breaking rules or ignoring processes because one has no respect for those who made them

Angrily dismissing someone from one's presence
Leaving the room (excusing oneself, cutting a meeting short, etc.)

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Flushed skin
Biting at the inside of the cheek
Pressing the lips together to keep from speaking
Dry washing one's hands
Purposefully not looking at the source
Feigning interest in something else
Turning away to ignore the source
Becoming unresponsive
Pushing on the diaphragm to keep the anger in
Leaning back with one's arms crossed
Moving away and creating more personal distance

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Disgust](#), [Scorn](#), [Anger](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Agitation](#), [Conflicted](#), [Indifference](#), [Pity](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Belittle, betray, convict, destroy, discard, dismiss, disrespect, expose, eye, glare, ignore, insult, loathe, mistreat, overlook, override, prosecute, provoke, punish, reject, sabotage, scorn, sidestep, sneer, spit, spurn

WRITER'S TIP: *When revising, look for instances where emotions are NAMED. Nine times out of ten, this indicates a lack of confidence that the emotion is shown clearly through thought, sensations and body language. Strong verbal and nonverbal cues negate the need to explain the emotion to the reader.*

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CURIOSITY

DEFINITION: Inquisitiveness; a desire for knowledge

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Tilting the head to the side

Raised eyebrows

Body posture that perks up

A slow smile that builds

Repeating a statement as a question

Leaning forward and sliding one's chair closer

Pausing to examine

Eyebrows furrowing and then releasing

Blinking

Gazing at the source with sudden focus

Shifting from casual conversation to pointed questions

A softened voice or tone that may contain wonder

Crossing one's arms while observing

Prying or snooping

Nose-wrinkling

Posing hypothetical questions

Lingering touches

Stopping to pay attention (halting a current activity, like a fork pausing halfway to the mouth)

Straining to hear; shushing others to be quiet

Eavesdropping

Cupping an elbow with one hand while tapping the lips with the other

Squinting or pushing one's glasses up

Bending, kneeling, or squatting to get closer

Tilting one's body toward the source

Shuffling, creeping, or edging closer

Exploring the senses (e.g., smelling something new for the sake of knowing)

Verbally expressing interest: *Oh, look at that!* or *Isn't that amazing?*

Pulling on someone's sleeve to get them to join or follow

A still demeanor to aid in observation

Lips that are slightly parted

Nodding slowly

Poking or prodding at something

Talking to oneself to work through new ideas and thoughts

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Breaths that hitch or briefly stop

An increased pulse

Tingling at the base of the neck

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A need to know, touch, or understand

Forgetting what one was about to say or do

A compulsion to detour toward something new

Temporary cessation of worries, stress, or actions

A desire to investigate or experiment

Increased awareness of sensory information

Wonder or interest at how something works or why it's there

Impatience with people who protect the status quo and don't want to learn or grow

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Fidgeting or tics

Hypersensitivity to the source of interest

Obsessive thoughts

Pointed or even rude questions

Snooping or sneaking about to satisfy the need to know

Blowing people off through one's single-minded pursuit of knowledge or information

Becoming frustrated when one's efforts are thwarted, or one can't find answers

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Keeping one's eyes down

Holding one's hands in the lap

A lack of eye contact

Providing an excuse to linger or move toward the source

Pretending to ignore or be unaware of the source

A sidelong look

Using one's hair to hide an interested glance

Feigning boredom

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Eagerness](#), [Amazement](#), [Awe](#), [Conflicted](#), [Intimidated](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Disappointment](#), [Discouraged](#), [Indifference](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Approach, ask, attract, creep, desire, examine, explore, fascinate, follow, inquire, interest, intrigue, investigate, invite, lean, listen, marvel, peer, poke, prod, pursue, question, reach, test, touch, wonder

WRITER'S TIP: *Smell triggers memory. Take advantage of this sense and build olfactory description into the scene. This will draw readers in and make them feel part of the action.*

DEFEAT

DEFINITION: The feeling of having been mastered, conquered, or bested

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

The chin lowering to one's chest

Hands that go limp

Holding one's palms up and out

Slowly shaking the head

A lack of eye contact

Staring down at one's hands or feet

Going quiet, muttering, or being unresponsive

Unsteadiness; a lack of balance

Agreeing to hurry things along to end the agony of this moment

Arms hanging at one's sides

A long, low sigh

A thick, emotion-choked voice

Stumbling

Rubbing at the eyes to hide redness or tears from others

Backing away and creating a bubble of personal space

Cheeks that burn

A bobbing Adam's apple (thick swallows)

Hunched or rounded shoulders

Sagging posture, the back bowed

Hands hidden behind the back or in pockets

Chin tremors

Arms clutching one's body as if to hold it together

Lackluster movements; being devoid of energy

Toneless responses

Vacant eyes

Slumping into a chair

Holding one's head with the hands
Covering the mouth and nose with one's hand

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Feeling a pulse in one's throat
One's heart thudding dully in the chest
Wheezing breaths
Feeling like one's head is spinning
Chest pain or numbness
A sour taste in one's mouth
A lack of energy
Tears or heat behind the eyelids
A painful lump in one's throat
Limbs that feel too heavy to lift or move

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A desire to flee or be alone
Shame
Worrying that others will feel let down or disappointed
Mental fatigue
Wanting time to pass quickly but feeling trapped in this moment

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

A quaking or trembling body
Uncontrollable tears
Pleading or begging
Collapsing; the knees giving out
Self-loathing

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Shaking the head
False bravado

Trying to maintain eye contact
Demanding a rematch
Repeating the word *No*
Shouting or cursing
Laying the blame on others
Making accusations of cheating or underhandedness
A chin that juts sharply
The lips pressed flat
A flinty gaze
Using anger to feed strength

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Resignation](#), [Powerlessness](#), [Vulnerability](#),
[Shame](#), [Humiliation](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Shock](#), [Hopefulness](#), [Gratitude](#), [Relief](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Ache, beat, bleed, blindside, cave, collapse, crumple, displace, drag, knock, master, oust, outsmart, overcome, overpower, overthrow, pummel, sap, smash, steamroll, strangle, stun, subdue, suffer, surrender, topple, whip, yield

WRITER'S TIP: *To reveal quieter emotions, try using contrast. For example, pairing an easygoing character with someone who is highly volatile will help their own milder body cues stand out clearly.*

DEFENSIVENESS

DEFINITION: Resisting attack; defending against a perceived danger or threat

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Stepping back to increase the distance between oneself and the perceived danger

Leaning away

Crossing the arms over one's chest

Rigid body posture

Squinting, the brow lowering

Sucking the cheeks in

Shaking the head as if to remove any mental foggyiness

Sputtering, gaping, or shouting

Holding an object as a shield (a book, a folded jacket, etc.)

A darting gaze (gauging the distance to an exit, looking for a weapon, etc.)

Licking one's lips

Rapid blinking that leads to a wide-eyed look

Hands up, palms toward the aggressor

Fixedly staring at the person while talking in a low, firm voice

False bravado (flipping one's hair, a snort of dismissive laughter, etc.)

Raising one's voice to encourage the other to back down

Crossing the legs (if one is seated and feeling vulnerable)

Body shielding (turning at an angle)

Interrupting or talking over a rival to gain the upper hand

Looking to others for backup

Blowing out a noisy breath

Going on the offensive and verbally attacking the accuser

Deflecting blame

Flinching or jerking back

Speaking quickly while struggling to be articulate
A hand splaying across one's upper chest in a sign of innocence
A stiff neck, cords standing out, and a bobbing Adam's apple
The chin lowering and pulling back against the neck
Wagging a finger or berating another for their accusations
Rising color in one's cheeks
Visible sweating
Dragging others into the situation for support
Verbalizing disappointment or denial
A voice that hardens over the course of an argument
Jerky movements; a loss of fluidity to one's actions
Excessive swallowing

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Feeling the thrum of one's own pulse due to raised blood pressure
Dry mouth and an intense thirst
A body that feels hot
The stomach tightening and hardening

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Scrambling thoughts as one tries to diffuse the situation
Anger, shock, and feelings of betrayal
Sifting memories for evidence (to support innocence or challenge accusations)

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Eyes darting for an exit or escape (flight response)
Shouting
Bringing up past examples when one supported the accuser or saved the day
Citing an opponent's shortcomings
Increasing one's personal space

Storming away

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Maintaining an even tone

Offering a fake smile

A forcibly calm demeanor

Changing the subject

Denial (shrugging, forcing a laugh, etc.)

Calmly stating that one doesn't need to prove anything

Not leaving or walking away, despite discomfort

Attempting to reason through facts, not emotion

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Resentment](#), [Suspicion](#), [Anger](#), [Fear](#),
[Vulnerability](#), [Self-Pity](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Unappreciated](#), [Confusion](#), [Skepticism](#),
[Relief](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Avoid, balk, bristle, confront, counter, cover, criticize, deflect, deny, disagree, dismiss, dispute, dodge, downplay, guard, insist, lie, oppose, plead, proclaim, push, react, reject, resist, screen, shield, sidestep, stall, stammer, threaten, yell

WRITER'S TIP: *When writing a character's emotional response, consider their comfort level. Characters are more themselves in the company of people they feel safe with. But if they feel vulnerable or uncertain, their reactions will change.*

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DEFIANT

DEFINITION: Boldly resisting an opposing force, even in the face of defeat

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Drawing oneself up to full height (erect posture, tense muscles, etc.)

A sharp chin thrust or lift

Crossing the arms

A gaze or stare that is challenging and full of judgment

A curled lip; smirking

Refusing to obey (or behaving the opposite way one is expected to)

Shoulders pushing back and the chest jutting out

Refusing to be the first to break eye contact

Jerking one's head sharply ("tossing" the head)

Inhaling deeply, the nostrils flaring

Visible tightness in the jaw and neck

Flexing the fingers and drawing them into fists

Stepping into the personal space of others

Placing one's hands on one's hips

Attempting to appear larger by taking up more space—e.g., widening one's stance

Using personal knowledge to attack a rival's position or statement

Forceful movements (slamming a door, pushing a chair in harder than is needed, throwing things, etc.) to vent one's anger

Purposeful actions to incite an opponent (rejecting a gift, ignoring directions, etc.)

Being unable to sit or remain still

Sassiness or rudeness; verbal sparring

Deploying sarcasm (in one's tone, the words used, in one's smile, etc.)

Heated arguing, which may escalate to yelling and swearing

Refusing to apologize

Refusing to be dissuaded or placated

Communicating one's fixed position, belief, or view in absolutes: *I'll never back down.*

A straight-backed stride when walking away

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A throbbing in the chest or throat (the heart beating faster due to increased blood pressure)

Ribs that tighten, creating pressure in one's core

A flush of heat in the face and neck

Tension in one's muscles

Narrowed vision

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Thoughts being clouded by frustration and anger

Reacting before thinking, thereby escalating a situation or burning a bridge

Struggling with focus and concentration, or shifting mental gears to something else

Being unable or unwilling to see things from another's view

Analyzing an opponent for weaknesses that can strengthen one's position

Refusing to negotiate unless one's core demands are met

Mentally justifying actions that break rules or create fallout

Hanging onto anger and being unable to forgive

Needing to have the last word

Using anger to mask fear or uncertainty

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Speaking in a hostile tone

Making threats

Refusing to set disagreements aside (becoming fixated on undermining or besting an opponent, starting a feud, seeking revenge, etc.)

Blatant disobedience regardless of the consequences

Allowing one's anger to escalate to violence

Cutting ties with people who disagree: *You're either with me or against me.*

Lunging toward someone

Hurling insults and gestures (giving someone the finger, mooning someone, etc.)

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Body tension (tightness in the muscles, sharp posture, etc.)

Clenching the jaw

Lips that are clamped tight, appearing bloodless and flat

Speaking in an uneven voice, the words sounding strained or forced

Quiet acts of subversion (doing small things that will damage or undermine a foe)

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Anger](#), [Rage](#), [Schadenfreude](#), [Fearlessness](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Unappreciated](#), [Conflicted](#), [Confusion](#), [Regret](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Arch, argue, bash, belittle, brandish, bristle, call, challenge, confront, criticize, dare, defy, demand, dispute, embarrass, fight, flaunt, fling, glare, hit, hurl, ignore, jerk, jut, lunge, mock, offend, oppose, provoke, punish, push, rebel, reject, resist, seethe, shout, shriek, slam, snarl, spit, stare, subvert, test, threaten, undermine

WRITER'S TIP: When drafting, if you are unsure of how to show an emotion, use a telling placeholder like She shivered in fear. Then, look for the named emotion when revising, remove it, and write something fresh to show. This way, you will not be pulled out of the creative flow.

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DENIAL

DEFINITION: A refusal to acknowledge truth or reality

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Engaging in verbal disagreements

Backing away

Vigorous head shaking

Waving someone off

Dialogue in the negative: *Don't blame me, or I had nothing to do with it.*

Speaking emphatically with finger pointing or other hard gestures

Raising one's palms

Shrugging

Tucking in the upper lip

Arms crossing one's chest

Placing a hand against the breastbone

A slackened mouth

Speaking rapidly and not letting others get a word in

Rationalizing or justifying

Shuffling backward

Speaking slowly and stretching out one's words: *What? No way!*

Leaning back and creating space

Warding someone or something off

Raised eyebrows

Widening eyes

The pitch of one's voice rising

Emphatically saying *No*

Slanting the body away from an accuser

Rubbing at the ears, covering them, or pulling on an earlobe

Questioning someone's source or the facts

Constant interrupting to prevent the other person from speaking

Smiling and shaking the head as if the other party is completely deluded

Questioning someone's motives; reacting as if being attacked

Making an "X" motion with one's hands

Eye contact dropping (if one is unsure or lying)

Responding in short, choppy sentences

Sweating

Staring down at one's hands

Stroking one's sleeve in self-comfort

Making demands (for someone to leave, to stop talking, etc.)

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

The mouth going dry

A lump forming in one's throat

Feeling heavy or numb

Heat rising behind the eyelids

Tingling in the stomach

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Replaying past events in order to understand them

Thoughts centering on the facts of the situation

The brain scrambling to find a logical excuse

Anger or hurt at being put in this situation

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Blaming others

Supplying alternative facts to prove one's position

Pleading, crying, or begging to be believed

Becoming closed-minded; refusing to listen

Wanting to be left alone

Needing to escape

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Refusing to argue or respond to an accusation

Steady eye contact

Explaining calmly that one is not in denial

Voicing *We'll see* comments

Supplying reasons to convey that a viewpoint is invalid

Repeating the truth as one sees it and sticking to it

Using a steady, even tone

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Defensiveness](#), [Hurt](#), [Guilt](#), [Anger](#), [Conflicted](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Shock](#), [Vulnerability](#), [Disillusionment](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Abandon, beg, blame, block, challenge, decline, deflect, disavow, dismiss, dispute, evade, feign, flee, hide, ignore, negate, pretend, quash, refuse, refute, reject, resist, reverse, shift, shrug, shun, sidestep, snub, withdraw

WRITER'S TIP: *Make a list of your body language crutches (frowning, smiling, shrugging, head shaking, etc.). Use your word processor's search and replace feature to highlight these so you can pinpoint where the emotional description needs some freshening up.*

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DEPRESSED

DEFINITION: A state of withdrawal; extreme sadness and reduced vitality

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

A gaunt appearance

Notable weight loss or gain

Eyes that blink infrequently

Wet or red eyes from crying

Staring down at one's hands

Becoming non-reactive to stimuli or noises

Lying in bed with no motivation to get up

Saggy posture (a bent neck, drooping shoulders, etc.)

Resting the head on one's hand

Tangled hair, overlong nails, and other signs of letting oneself go

Wearing the same clothes day after day

Shuffling steps and lethargic hand movements

Obsession with an object that represents loss (a photo or trinket)

A vacant stare

Making excuses

Poor conversation skills

Stating outright that one doesn't care about one's own well-being

A downturned mouth

Lines in the face

A slack expression

Dark circles under one's eyes

An inability to sleep, or sleeping too much

Poor eating habits

Illness

A tone that lacks strength or vitality

An unclean home, room, or office space

Ignoring phone calls or visitors
Premature aging (wrinkles, tired eyes, gray or white hair, etc.)
Giving up one's interest in hobbies
Failing grades at school or a lack of success at work
Choosing isolation
Dropping out of activities and moving away from friendships
Picking at food or finding food tasteless
Being unable to focus on tasks (work, school, home life, etc.)
Forgetting appointments, conversations, and meetings
Bulky or dull clothing choices
Non-responsiveness to others, even family

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A hollowness in one's chest that somehow feels heavy
A slow pulse
Shallow breathing
Aches and pains
Constant fatigue

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Feeling unmotivated
Struggling with a self-critical mindset
Desiring to live in the past or be alone
Poor observation skills
Obsessive thoughts (a focus on the negative, expecting bad things to happen, etc.)
A negative outlook in general; bleak observations about the world and the people in it
An inability to concentrate
Losing track of time
Thoughts of self-harm
An aversion to noise, crowds, and stressful situations

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Eating disorders

Manic behavior (hair pulling, OCD, paranoia, etc.)

Wishing life was over; attempting or thinking about suicide

Embracing danger and risk

Addiction to medication

Hoarding

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Slight pauses before reacting

Emotional displays that seem forced or false

Heavy self-medicating or drinking

Wearing false, overly bright smiles

Pretending to be ill to avoid social situations and people

Lying in general

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Self-Loathing](#), [Worthlessness](#), [Homesick](#),
[Regret](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Loneliness](#), [Conflicted](#), [Vulnerability](#),
[Hopefulness](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Ache, collapse, cut, deepen, doubt, endure, engulf, give up, hurt, overcome, overwhelm, sink, slow, struggle, succumb, suffer, weep, worsen

WRITER'S TIP: *It isn't enough to show emotion; a writer needs to make the reader feel it. Think about the core visceral sensations you experience when feeling strong emotion, and if appropriate, utilize them to convey a similar experience to the reader.*

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DESIRE

DEFINITION: A yearning to initiate or strengthen a relationship with another person

NOTES: Desire is a strong emotion, particularly as it relates to other people. While desire is often associated with romantic relationships, it can be applied to other people, such as a character who wants a more satisfying relationship with their children, parents, a sibling, or a friend. For information on desire as it relates to things or intangibles, see the **LONGING** entry.

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Firm, intense eye contact

Hands moistening

Stroking one's arm as a surrogate for the person

Mirroring the person's movements

Trembling

Lowering one's voice when speaking

Leaning in or forward

Moving closer to the person to erase the distance

Relaxing one's posture; muscles losing tension

Facing the person straight on

Eyes shining, becoming glossy, and softening

Frequent touching of the face and lips

Hands clenching briefly, then releasing

Becoming tongue-tied or inarticulate; stuttering or stammering

A slight flush of the skin in the face and neck

Knees loosening and feeling weak

Responding immediately when called upon

Casting furtive glances at the person

Positioning oneself near the person one desires

Touching or holding the person close
Holding in a breath
A slow smile that builds
Moving carefully, to set the person at ease and keep from scaring them
off

Subconsciously thrusting out one's chest
Lifting one's chin to expose the neck
A lingering touch; brushing up against the object
Touching or stroking one's own throat
Lips parting
Slightly parting the legs
The tongue darting out to touch or lick the lips

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A strong awareness of one's own heartbeat
The sensation of being flooded with warmth
The mouth becoming moist with increased saliva
Feeling one's hair rise on the arms and nape of the neck
Fingers aching or tingling with the need to touch
Quickening breath or breathlessness
Hypersensitivity to touch and texture
Fluttering or even mild pain in the chest
Light-headedness
A shiver that brings pleasure; nerve endings that stir and tingle
Bodily cravings of being touched by the person

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A desire to erase all distance; actively looking for a way to get closer
Impatience
Taking opportunities or meeting challenges to prove one's worth
Wanting to care for and put the person's needs first
A loss of inhibitions; becoming more spontaneous

A need to touch and explore
Preoccupation with the person's scent
Focusing on the person's positive qualities

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

A willingness to endure suffering or hardship to get closer to the person
Obsessive thoughts
Centering all aspects of one's life on being with the person
Neglecting friends, family, work, and other interests
Fixation on self-improvement, education, or goals leading to achievement
Shedding bad habits or flaws to appease or impress the person

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Glancing away for a brief time; feigning interest in something else
Making a display of engaging in conversation with others
Forcing a slow gait rather than rushing to be with the person
Not touching or being alone with the person
Being 100% "up" in public, then falling apart in private

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Adoration](#), [Love](#), [Lust](#), [Determination](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Disappointment](#), [Devastation](#), [Inadequate](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Ache, aspire, burn, caress, chase, covet, crave, devote, express, focus, follow, motivate, need, possess, pursue, quest, reach, seek, seize, touch, want

WRITER'S TIP: *Emotion should always lead to decision making, either good or bad, that will propel the story forward.*

DESPAIR

DEFINITION: Losing all hope; becoming despondent

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Shoulders dragging low, the arms losing all tension

A caved-in chest

A slack expression

A hanging head

Letting out a hard sigh and closing one's eyes

Eyebrows that pinch together

A pained expression

The mouth opening but no words coming forth

Slumping where one stands or sits

Weakly throwing up one's hands

Hands that slide loosely into one's lap

Leaning forward, with the hands draping limply over one's knees

Taking shallow yet audible breaths

Sagging back in one's seat, hands falling to one's sides

Tipping one's head back to look heavenward, then letting it flop forward

Hair that hangs in one's face

Stumbling—one's feet dragging and catching with each step

Reddening eyes

Making no attempt to wipe loose tears away

Placing one's hands over the face

Kneading one's chest with the heel of one's hand as if to stop the pain

Grabbing fistfuls of hair while propping up the head with one's hands

Knees that weaken and then catch (while standing)

A hitching chest or open sobbing

An uncontrollable cry or moan

Lacking the strength to support oneself (falling into a seat or against a table or wall)

Whispering *Oh God*, or *No, it can't be*.

Shaking one's head slowly with one's eyes closed

Lips that pinch together or grimace

Laying one's head down on the arms (at a table)

Weakly slinging an arm around someone in comfort

A body that appears to shrink

Retreating inside oneself (not responding to people's questions or reacting to touch)

Saying things without a filter and not caring who is listening: *We're all doomed*.

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A sudden heaviness or numbness

Dizziness

A head that pounds

A heart that aches

Limbs that tingle with fatigue

A thickening in one's throat

Feeling one's heartbeat in one's throat

Eyes growing wet, the vision blurring

A mouth that feels gummy with excess saliva

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Losing track of time

Recycling bleak thoughts: *That's it, she's gone. I'm alone. I can't do this without her.*

Feeling as though things are happening too quickly to process them

Numb emotions; ceasing to care about who is watching or observing

Distorted observations (reacting slowly to movement, not processing what someone says, failing to recognize someone immediately, etc.)

Mentally shutting down

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Falling into a depressive state

Turning to alcohol or drugs for comfort

Thoughts of suicide or attempting suicide

Bluntness; saying hurtful things and not caring

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Trying to put on a brave face (smiles that flicker and go out, false enthusiasm, etc.)

Throwing oneself into a task to keep one's mind off what has happened

Keeping secrets so others maintain their hope

Lying to others; telling them that things are fine when they are not

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Bitterness](#), [Devastation](#), [Grief](#), [Depressed](#), [Defeat](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Powerlessness](#), [Sadness](#), [Vulnerability](#), [Hopefulness](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Cave, crumble, cry, cut, defeat, demoralize, drain, dread, droop, fall, lose, numb, pain, rail, sag, shrink, slacken, stumble, surrender, weaken

WRITER'S TIP: *Visceral sensations are powerful, but if used too often, they can lose their strength. Save them for when you really want to make a big emotional impact in a scene.*

DESPERATION

DEFINITION: A state of hopelessness that leads to rashness

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Feverish, over-bright eyes

A darting gaze

Quick movements

Pacing

An inability to sleep or eat

Finger twitches and other compulsive, repetitive movements

A herky-jerky walk

Reaching or touching in hopes of gaining help or favor

Facing danger head-on

Acting in ways that push the limits of endurance

Anxiously muttering to oneself

Grabbing fistfuls of one's hair and pulling (using pain to focus on action)

An emotion-choked voice

Fluttery hand movements

Moaning

A voice that shakes

Rocking in place and rubbing the hands along one's crossed arms

Trying to bargain, ignoring another's cues of disinterest or anger

Shaking and trembling

Curling the arms over the head

Hugging one's shoulders, the chin resting against one's chest

A neck that appears stiff, cords visible

Strained forearms

Eyes that appear wet, darting and not settling

Teeth biting down on the bottom lip

Wringing one's hands or repeatedly flexing the fingers and making fists

Shoulders curling, a bent spine
Shaking one's head in denial
Protective posture (chin to chest, arms holding the body tightly, etc.)
Dragging nails down the cheeks, leaving marks
Squeezing one's biceps while the arms are crossed
Sweating profusely
Swearing in a voice that gets progressively louder

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A racing heartbeat
A dry mouth
A sore throat from pleading, crying, or begging
A heightened level of pain resistance
Tightness or pain in the chest
Excessive or manic energy

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Constant planning and obsessing
Irrational thinking and poor judgment
A willingness to do anything
Ignoring the law or society's values
Casting morality and good judgment aside
Sacrificing others or lesser goals, desires, and needs if necessary
Disregarding another's feelings if they conflict with one's goal

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Crying, sobbing, wailing, or screaming
Beating one's fists against something to the point of injury
Pleading, abasing, or disregarding personal worth or pride
Extreme risk taking
Offering an exchange: *Take me instead, or I'll go, you stay.*
Pushing past one's limits to find needed strength

Refusing to be persuaded

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Holding oneself tight

Believing a lie if it offers hope

Retreating internally to cope; shutting the world out

Difficulty sitting still

Clock-watching

Reassuring others

Fixing one's hair and clothes to appear unaffected

Taking advantage of a distraction (e.g., watching a movie or TV show)

Curling the hands into tight fists

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Anguish](#), [Dread](#), [Anger](#), [Determination](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Overwhelmed](#), [Hopefulness](#), [Gratitude](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Beg, betray, cling, clutch, corner, cry, dare, deny, drive, fight, flee, force, gamble, grab, grasp, grope, harass, implore, plead, plunge, pray, promise, resort, risk, scramble, search, steal, strain, strive, take, threaten, wail

WRITER'S TIP: *Clothing choices are individual and project an image of one's personality. When creating unique emotional body language, think about how a character's clothing can be utilized to reveal their insecurities or vanities and show feelings of self-worth.*

DETERMINATION

DEFINITION: Firm intention on achieving a goal; decisiveness

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Being the first to speak

Moving into someone's personal space

Using articulate words and short, strong sentences

A steady, lower-pitched voice

A furrowing brow

Tight muscles

An alert gaze

A set jaw

Strong eye contact

A curt nod

Forming the hands into a steeple

Mirroring the leader's movements

Using affirmative words: *Yes*, and *I will*.

Pressing the lips together

Tightening fists

Organizing one's things; being prepared

Standing solidly, at the ready

Planting one's feet in a wide stance

Leaning in, hand on one knee

Holding one's chin high, with the neck exposed

Pushing up one's sleeves

Shoulders pushing back, displaying a strong posture

Precise movements

Sharp hand movements (jabbing a finger for emphasis, etc.)

A fast-paced stride

Asking pointed questions

Holding one's legs straight out, with the knees uncrossed

Thrusting the chest out
Offering a firm handshake
Inhaling deeply through the nose, then exhaling through the mouth
Exuding calm and focus
Practicing a skill
Making preparations or conditioning the body
Studying or gathering information
Accepting criticism so one can improve

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A fluttery feeling in the chest
Increased internal temperature and heartbeat
Muscles tightening in readiness

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Planning for obstacles and strategizing ways to overcome them
Mentally encouraging oneself to succeed
Active listening
Having an acute sense of purpose; setting goals
Ignoring distractions or discomforts
Extreme mental focus on the objective
Running through what one must say or do
Dismissing negative thoughts

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Conditioning for the task in advance
A muscle clenching along the jaw line
Headaches and muscle strain
Ignoring pain, stress, or any outside elements
Sacrificing what is needed to achieve the desired result

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Purposely adopting a languid pose
Feigning disinterest (yawning, shrugging, etc.)
Meaningless gestures (scrutinizing cuticles, checking for split ends, etc.)

Placing one's hands in one's pockets
Engaging in banter or non-threatening conversation
Asking benign questions
Laughing or making jokes meant to disarm
A lack of eye contact
Closing one's eyes as if one is relaxed or dozing

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Hopefulness](#), [Confidence](#), [Satisfaction](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Frustration](#), [Disappointment](#), [Insecurity](#), [Acceptance](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Anticipate, battle, compete, condition, confront, counter, dedicate, defend, deliver, devote, dive, fight, focus, harden, persevere, plan, prevent, prioritize, push, resist, sharpen, strengthen, strive, tackle, target, withstand

WRITER'S TIP: *Never underestimate the power of texture. The way an object feels against the skin can create a powerful reaction (positive or negative) and add to the reader's emotional experience.*

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DEVASTATION

DEFINITION: Overwhelming shock and sorrow

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Asking someone to repeat the news out of utter disbelief

Laying a splayed-out hand against one's chest

Needing to sit or be supported

Covering one's face with both hands and collapsing

Stopping what one was doing mid-task

A pained expression, with eyes that cloud or focus inward

Brows that pull together and down

A gape that widens

Slow shakes of the head that become wider and faster as the news sinks
in

Not knowing where to look or what to do

Expelling an audible breath

One's chest caving, the spine curling forward

Using a hand to support one's head or rub at the forehead

Being at a loss for words (speaking in fragmented sentences, starting
and stopping, etc.)

Pressing a palm over one's mouth and then letting it fall away or pull
down

Arms that drag at one's shoulders, with the limbs going loose

Sagging back into a chair

A voice that goes weak or cracks

Eyes that fill with tears

A shaking hand reaching to cover the mouth

Repeating negatives: *It just can't be*, or *I don't believe this is
happening*.

Receiving a hug but being too numb to return it

Not responding to questions

Not knowing what to do with one's hands
Staring down, with the neck bent forward
Shuffling steps
A strangled sob
Letting out a grief-choked wail or scream
Swaying slightly on one's feet
Sinking to one's knees
Leaving without explanation (flight)
Loosening one's grip, which leads to dropping an item or letting something go

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A sudden weakness in one's limbs
Pressure building in the chest from forgetting to breathe
Dizziness
Tingling in the chest and stomach that signals dread
A heart that hurts
Feeling numb all over

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Being unable to believe what one is seeing (if one is experiencing the cause firsthand)

Imagining the event unfolding as it is described (if one is hearing the news secondhand)

Immediately remembering the last time one was in contact with the affected person, people group, or place

Thinking of the people most deeply affected and how they are taking the news

Sudden regret: *Why didn't I visit more often? and I should have told her what she meant to me.*

Feeling relief, followed by guilt: *Thank goodness Joe stayed home, or he'd be dead too.*

Struggling with even the small things; feeling overwhelmed

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Being unable to eat, sleep, or engage in normal activities

Cutting the source of pain from one's life (giving up a passion, quitting a job, etc.)

Progressing into grief but never moving past it

Becoming a hollowed-out version of oneself (lacking vitality, drive, or personality)

Emotional numbness that prevents connection with people or the world outside

Losing the will to live

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Withdrawing from the situation to be alone (flight)

Saying nothing and retreating inside oneself

Self-medicating to numb the emotional pain

A chin that quakes with one's effort to keep in tears

Throwing oneself at a task (e.g., funeral arrangements) to avoid the pain of grief

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Powerlessness](#), [Grief](#), [Despair](#), [Depressed](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Loneliness](#), [Neglected](#), [Wistful](#), [Acceptance](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Ache, beg, buckle, clutch, collapse, console, cry, cut, destroy, disbelieve, gasp, grieve, hold, hurt, moan, mourn, pray, quiver, rock, sag, shake, slacken, slouch, stare, sting, stutter, suffer, tear, tremble, twist, undo, weep, wheeze

WRITER'S TIP: *Opening up about difficult feelings signals an important breakthrough for a character on their journey of change. To be realistic, it won't be easy; emotional pain is hard to face and harder to talk about. Show this stress and struggle using vocal cues and body language.*

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DISAPPOINTMENT

DEFINITION: A state of dismay due to being let down

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Lowering one's head

Lips pressing tight into a grimace

Shoulders dropping or slumping slightly

A hunched posture

Looking up with hands raised in the *Why me?* position

Collapsing onto a chair or bench

A frustrated shake of the head

A bitter smile

A heavy sigh

Briefly covering one's face with one's hands

Breaking eye contact

Bending the neck forward

Slowly shaking one's head

Tilting the chin down and frowning

Muttering or making a noise in one's throat

Swallowing hard

Sagging against a door or wall

Reaching out to steady oneself

Dropping the head, eyes closed

Stumbling mid-stride

One's face going slack and paling slightly

Pressing hands to one's temples

Weaving hands into the hair and pulling

Frowning or wearing a stony expression

Watering eyes, an inward focus

Wincing

The mouth falling open slightly

Looking around in confusion or shock
Attempting to hide (covering the head, ducking one's chin, turning away, etc.)
Hands that hang, lifeless and loose
Hands fluttering like they've lost track of what they should be doing
Feet shuffling or kicking at the ground
Rubbing at the back of one's neck
A voice that drops or goes quiet
Whispering *No* or cursing under the breath
Biting or chewing at the lip
Clutching oneself (gripping the elbows, rubbing the arms, etc.)
Pressing a hand to the abdomen
Slinking away (flight response)

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A heart that feels like it's shrinking
A clenching stomach followed by the sudden onset of nausea
Ribs that grow tight, restricting one's breath
Breaths that hitch, or momentarily forgetting to breathe
A heaviness in the body

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A feeling of dread or hopelessness
Defeatist thoughts and negative self-talk
Wanting to be alone
Feeling worthless

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Flushed cheeks (embarrassment)
Berating oneself
Wallowing (drinking too much, listening to depressing songs, etc.)
Obsessing over why things happened the way they did

An inability to move on
Avoiding future goals that are not a sure thing

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

A slight lip press
Dropping the shoulders, then hitching them up again
Offering false cheer, a weak smile
Making a joke as if it doesn't matter
Citing a backup plan or listing more options
Making promises
Clasping one's hands in one's lap
Congratulating the victor

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Depressed](#), [Defeat](#), [Resentment](#), [Anger](#),
[Inadequate](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Resignation](#), [Acceptance](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Break, cloud, cope, crush, dampen, defeat, deplete, derail, dismay, drag, droop, fail, falter, forfeit, frustrate, mourn, pummel, sigh, slacken

WRITER'S TIP: *Characters experiencing raw emotion often react without thinking—either through dialogue or action. Rash behavior creates the perfect storm for increased tension and conflict.*

DISBELIEF

DEFINITION: Withholding belief; a refusal to see the truth

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

The mouth slackening

Eyes widening

Looking down or away, or doing a double-take

Rubbing at an eyelid or brow

Being at a loss for words

Turning away and covering the mouth

One's expression blanching, going pale

Asking *Are you sure?* type questions

Scratching one's jaw

A shake of the head

Rubbing absently at the arms

Verbalizing shock: *Are you kidding?* or *Impossible!*

Moving back slightly, increasing one's personal space

Showing one's palms

Lifting a single eyebrow and cocking the head

An unfocused gaze

Rapid blinking

Running the hands through one's hair

Gaping or stuttering

One's mouth opening and closing

Hands dropping to one's sides

The posture slumping slightly

The neck bending forward, then stiffening back up

Hands carving through one's hair, holding it back and then releasing it

Pulling glasses down and looking over the rims

Openly staring

Covering one's ears

Repeating *No* and other negatives: *It's not true!*

Folding the arms over the stomach and bending forward slightly

Staring at one's palms as if they hold the answers

Jiggling, tugging, or tapping the earlobe

Waving something off

Making accusations: *You're lying.*

Refusing to listen to the people sharing the bad news

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A tingling in one's chest

A hardening or clenching stomach

A small intake of breath (gasp)

Light-headedness

Restricted breathing

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Making an immediate moral judgment (either good or bad, wrong or right)

Thoughts scrambling to understand

Attempting to reason or glean more information

Pretending to have misheard

Growing angry but not knowing where to direct it

Thinking back to the last time one was with the person being discussed

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

A restless stance

Arguing; trying to poke holes in the information one is being given

Walking away—refusing to listen or discuss it further

Voicing the emotion over and over: *I just can't believe this*

Difficulty speaking; giving choppy responses

Holding a hand up to ward off the truth

Demanding those with influence do something to change the outcome

Closed body posture (the arms creating a barrier across the chest)

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Changing the topic

Making excuses for one's behavior: *Sorry, I've not been sleeping well.*

Supporting the outcome; acting like one was "in the know" all along

Reassuring others of one's belief, commitment, etc.

Asking questions to glean information without giving away disbelief

Clearing one's throat, pinching at one's Adam's apple, or laughing nervously

Coughing, then pretending a drink went down wrong

Offering fake platitudes: *Interesting*, or *Well, that's good then.*

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Denial](#), [Anger](#), [Overwhelmed](#), [Resignation](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Doubt](#), [Uncertainty](#), [Resignation](#), [Acceptance](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Bulge, deny, freeze, frown, fumble, gape, gasp, grunt, question, recoil, reel, refuse, retreat, shake, shock, slacken, splutter, sputter, stammer, stare

WRITER'S TIP: *While melodrama is usually a bad idea in fiction, it can be used effectively to characterize an over-the-top character.*

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DISCOURAGED

DEFINITION: Deprived of courage, spirit, or confidence

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Displaying low interest in one's surroundings

Slumped shoulders

Hands lying still in one's lap

Trudging; walking with a slow, heavy step

A bowed head

Holding one's head

Sitting bent over, with one's hands or elbows on one's knees

Rubbing or covering one's face with the hands

A vacant stare, slackness in the face

A voice that is quieter and lower in pitch than normal

Sitting limply (the head back against a wall, arms beside one's body, legs outstretched, etc.)

Leaning against supports instead of standing tall on one's own

Not participating in conversations

Eyes that look tired

A partial smile offered out of habit or because it's expected

Speaking in monosyllables

A body that curls in on itself

Getting drunk or high

Going quiet for long periods of time

Sleeping a lot

Shutting down others who try to encourage: *What's the point? Just accept it.*

Always being on the verge of tears

Becoming emotionally volatile (lashing out, jumping quickly to anger, etc.)

Frequent sighing

A downward gaze
Being very still
An overall decrease in one's energy and enthusiasm levels
Agreeing because it's easier than arguing or it just doesn't matter anymore
Avoiding conversations that touch on the source of one's discouragement
Becoming confrontational about other things as a way of regaining some level of power

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Lacking mental and physical energy
A sense of heaviness in one's limbs
A constricted throat

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Thinking poorly of oneself or the cause of the discouragement
Giving up on one's dreams or goals
Emotional numbness
Berating oneself for wanting this goal (instead of settling for the status quo)
Sluggish or slow-moving thoughts
Feeling an overall lack of urgency, as if nothing is important
Pessimistic thinking that makes it difficult to make future plans

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Depression
Becoming risk-averse
Losing faith in the people, beliefs, or organizations one used to count on
Becoming negative, skeptical, cynical, or bitter
Discouraging others from trying to succeed or be happy

A lack of interest in hobbies and passions

Major changes in one's appearance (gaining or losing weight, looking years older, etc.)

Being easily frustrated and quick to anger

Giving in to apathy

Throwing caution to the wind; becoming reckless

Lacking the motivation to make a change or try again

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Over-the-top exuberance meant to mask one's true feelings

Exhibiting positive emotions (happiness, joy, contentment, etc.) in a way that seems forced

Hiding or denying one's tears

Surreptitiously avoiding the topic of one's discouragement (not going certain places, steering conversations away from the subject, etc.)

Feigning disinterest; pretending one wasn't really invested in the goal anyway

Putting on a happy face in front of others, then falling apart when one is alone

Self-medicating in private

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Anger](#), [Defeat](#), [Disillusionment](#), [Self-Loathing](#), [Indifference](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Acceptance](#), [Hopefulness](#), [Self-Pity](#), [Bitterness](#), [Disillusionment](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Abandon, alienate, cave, choke, daunt, deny, disengage, distract, droop, drowse, exhaust, flop, forfeit, frown, give up, hide, laze, lost, lumber, mumble, ostracize, pass, punish, sag, shun, slack, slouch, slump, trudge, weaken, wither

WRITER'S TIP: *Disappointments will happen throughout a story to your characters, creating an opportunity to showcase different behaviors. What will each do if things don't go their way: talk it out, get angry, wallow in self-pity, something else? Pull from their personalities, and experiment!*

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DISGUST

DEFINITION: An aversion, usually to something distasteful;
revulsion

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

A curling lip

An open mouth with the tongue pushing slightly forward

Wrinkling one's nose

Flinching, recoiling, or shuddering

Swallowing hard, then pinching the lips shut

Leaning back, the neck disappearing

Stroking the throat and grimacing

Turning one's back to the source

Eyes that appear cold, dead, or flat

Refusing to look

Shaking one's head and muttering

Walking away to regain one's composure

The toes curling up

Pulling up a collar to cover the mouth and nose

Spitting, coughing, dry heaving, or throwing up

Putting a hand up and backing away

Repeating what someone has said, purposely devoid of all emotion

Dry washing the hands

Pressing a fist against the mouth and puffing out the cheeks

Rubbing at one's exposed forearms

Covering the mouth

Making a choking noise in the throat

Jerking away from contact, or even the suggestion of contact

Pressing hands against the stomach

Demanding that someone stop speaking or desist what they are doing

Violently rolling the shoulders as if one's clothing is creating discomfort

Using a purse or jacket to create a shield

Offering evasive answers

Eyebrows lowering and pinching together

Pressing one's knees together

Narrowing one's stance (e.g., bringing the feet together)

A face that blanches

Rubbing at one's nose or mouth

Speaking in an unsteady voice

Losing track of one's words

Cringing away from the source

An expression that appears pained, the eyebrows furrowing

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Having trouble swallowing, or feeling like one is choking

Excessive saliva; a need to spit

A sour or bitter tang in the mouth

Nausea or a heaving stomach

A burning in the throat

The skin tightening (crawling flesh sensation)

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A compulsion to flee

Feeling unclean

Wishing to be somewhere else

The mind replaying what was seen in agonizing detail

Being unable to concentrate properly

A sensitivity to smell and touch

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Focusing on cleanliness (showering, rubbing skin raw, etc.)

Hyper-protectiveness of personal space
Acting jumpy or jittery when one is near the source
Becoming unresponsive or less verbal
An intense need to flee the source

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Offering a watery smile while maintaining a safe distance
Hesitating while forcing oneself to come closer
Maintaining eye contact, no matter how difficult
Waving a hand as if something doesn't matter
Slowly walking closer, but keeping the arms close to the body
Standing away and reaching in with one hand
Heavy, jerky movements

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Scorn](#), [Fear](#), [Anger](#), [Horror](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Shock](#), [Reluctance](#), [Unease](#), [Wariness](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Churn, curdle, faint, flee, grimace, heave, nauseate, purge, recoil, reject, repel, retch, roil, shake, shrink, shudder, sicken, spit, spurn, swallow

WRITER'S TIP: *With extreme emotions that trigger an immediate fight-or-flight response, it's important to know which "side" fits best with your character's personality. All actions should line up with this choice.*

DISILLUSIONMENT

DEFINITION: Hurt and disappointment upon discovering that one's belief is false or trust in someone has been misplaced

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Rapid blinking while the rest of the face goes slack

Cocking the head and displaying a fixed look as one wrestles with a sudden discovery

Posture that stiffens, then droops

Stumbling slightly as realization kicks in

Laying a hand against one's chest, then pulling the front of one's shirt into a fist

Stuttering; trying to form sentences but failing

Breaths coming faster and deeper, with the chest visibly rising and falling

Looking at the source, then away, and then back in utter disbelief

Holding one's head in one's hands

Uttering *No*, or *It can't be*.

Arms wrapping around oneself in a self-soothing manner

The eyes widening while one's head moves forward

Being open-mouthed and incapable of speech

Citing evidence that supports old beliefs: *But you promised you'd quit!*

Putting one's hand up in a warding off gesture

Rapid breathing while glancing upward

A mouth that trembles

A visible shudder that goes through the entire body

Pinching one's lips with tented hands while shaking the head

Stepping back to increase one's personal space

Clutching at a totem that symbolizes one's belief (a cross, a gift from the subject, etc.)

Backing up and stumbling because one is not attentive to one's surroundings

Recoiling from those who offer comfort

Doubting the messenger: *You must be wrong. He'd never do that.*

Voicing shock

Openly staring at the subject with a pained look that contains hurt and anger

Weaving one's hands into the hair and pulling slightly to try and anchor one's emotions

Color bleeding from one's face (shock) or suddenly flushing (anger)

Offering excuses to cling to previously held beliefs: *But they forced you, right?*

Leaning forward to catch signs of guilt (when one is with the individual involved)

Staggering away from the person or thing representing one's disillusionment

Shaking the head and cutting the person off so one can process the information

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Feeling cold all over

An unsettling heaviness or ache in the chest

The stomach hardening

Ribs tightening

A shudder that shakes one's core

MENTAL RESPONSES:

The mind flashing to events or moments that first made one believe

Experiencing epiphanies in the form of signs one didn't pick up on at the time

The mind racing for explanations due to an extreme desire to disbelieve the evidence

Thoughts jumping from memory to memory as one wonders if the accusations could be true

Feeling so disoriented one begins to question related beliefs

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Growing unsteady—needing to support oneself or sit down

Sarcasm and the need to hurt with words

Spilling secrets to cause the subject pain

Yelling, pointing fingers, moving aggressively, and other signs of anger taking over

Lashing out with violence (running at someone, trying to hurt them, etc.)

Running away out of an inability to cope (flight)

Becoming embittered toward the person, organization, or idea one was once loyal to

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Denial (shaking one's head, making excuses, arguing, etc.)

Excessive anger at people revealing the deception

Clinging to and verbalizing one's reasons why other people are wrong about this

Walking out in anger; refusing to listen

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Anger](#), [Bitterness](#), [Humiliation](#), [Disgust](#), [Betrayal](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Skepticism](#), [Disappointment](#), [Neglected](#), [Inadequate](#), [Embarrassment](#), [Shame](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Abandon, ache, blame, break, bruise, confuse, damage, denounce, distress, ditch, forsake, humiliate, hurt,

injure, insult, paralyze, question, quit, rattle, renounce, shock, shout, spit, stun, stymie, tremble, wound

WRITER'S TIP: *Make sure to show how a character's emotions escalate or shift in a tense scene. This causes anticipation for what is to come.*

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DISSATISFACTION

DEFINITION: Being unsatisfied and discontent

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Eyebrows that pull close and down, creating a forehead crease

Grimacing and shaking the head

Becoming more vocal and contrary

Crossing the arms and looking down

Rubbing at the back of the neck

Twisting or crushing an empty water bottle to relieve frustration

Rubbing the legs while seated

Breaking eye contact with others

A pinched, unhappy expression

Muttering something unkind under the breath

Rolling the eyes, sighing, or letting out a derisive snort

The stride slowing when one approaches the source of dissatisfaction (a person, a job, etc.)

Growing more insistent or emphatic in conversation

Demanding someone “do it again” until it’s right

Perfectionistic tendencies

Complaining or grouching

Shifting position (turning the torso, moving the arms frequently, etc.)

Feet that point away from the people one is engaged with

Staying out late to avoid going home (if one’s home life is the source of dissatisfaction)

Restless sleeping

Replaying the day’s events with a focus on the negative

Waking before the alarm clock and dreading it going off

Finding it hard to relax

Pacing or moving about frequently rather than remaining in one place

Asking revelatory questions: *You ever wish you could just hit the reset button and try again?*

Going through the motions rather than participating (at work, in relationships, at church, etc.)

Having no patience for small talk

Pulling away from others to be alone

Holding grudges

Growing angry quickly; letting small things get under one's skin

Always wanting more or something better

Talking about the past and better times

Self-medicating—drinking, gambling, smoking weed, or taking pills to escape

Playing hooky to get out of obligations, then lying about it

Seeking control by hyper-focusing on inconsequential things (e.g., circling the parking lot endlessly because one refuses to get stuck with a bad spot again)

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Headaches (increased blood pressure)

Hardness in the gut

An overall feeling of jitteriness due to exhaustion from poor sleeping habits

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Feeling lost and directionless

Feeling trapped (in a bad marriage, in an unfulfilling job, by an illness, etc.)

Frequent thoughts about the unfairness of life or how others are to blame

Focusing on the negative; having a pessimistic outlook

Resenting people who seem happy and content

Mentally comparing oneself to others

Daydreaming about one's problems being solved (winning the lottery, a bad boss being transferred, etc.)

Becoming obsessed with finding a way out of one's situation

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Constant worry

Taking risks (to improve one's situation or to feel excitement and vitality)

Going through a mid-life crisis

Chasing the wrong things, such as investing in get-rich-quick schemes

Having an affair

Insomnia

Depression

Stress-induced maladies (ulcers, hypertension, etc.)

Being unable to feel gratitude

Becoming bitter and jaded towards others or the world in general

Flight (leaving one's job, one's family, etc.)

Appearing older than one is (frown lines, broken blood vessels in the nose and cheeks, etc.)

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Busying oneself with work or family to avoid thinking about one's needs or wants

Deferring a yearning: *Someday I'll travel like my sister, or I'll learn to paint next year.*

Encouraging others so one can live through their successes

Playing the martyr: *Just because I was cheated out of my dreams doesn't mean you have to be.*

Manically trying new things in hopes of finding the "magic" that will change one's life

Buying things to get a brief burst of happiness (retail therapy)

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Depressed](#), [Contempt](#), [Anger](#), [Bitterness](#),
[Resentment](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Frustration](#), [Resignation](#), [Wistful](#),
[Acceptance](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Agonize, belabor, clench, clutch, complain, covet, desire, displease, disrupt, dwell, expect, fail, frustrate, grate, gripe, grouse, hamper, infuriate, interrupt, irk, irritate, miff, moan, mutter, resent, rouse, spurn, sulk, thwart, worry, yearn

WRITER'S TIP: *To show a character's emotional growth and maturity, provide a situation early on that will cause them to overreact. Then, when a similar circumstance arises later, they can handle it in a much better way.*

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DOUBT

DEFINITION: To lack confidence in or consider unlikely

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

One's brows drawing closer, the face tightening

Looking down or away

Avoiding eye contact

Pressing the lips together

Shuffling one's feet

Shoving one's hands into pockets

Throat-clearing

Thumbing the ear

Asking questions without clear answers to imply that more thought is needed

Checking and rechecking one's appearance (self-doubt)

Delaying tactics (suggesting time to review options, etc.)

Pauses, *ums*, or other conversation fillers

Taking a slight step back

Lingering at the edge of a group or event

Biting one's cheek

Declining an offer of support

Running hands through the hair (and other signs of restlessness)

Pulling or tugging at one's clothes

A smile that appears tight

A hesitating nod

Rocking on one's heels and pretending to study the floor

Cocking the head while raising an eyebrow

Swallowing more than usual

Tipping one's head side to side, weighing an idea or choice

Tapping the fingers together while steepled

Slightly clenched fists

A deep, weighted sigh
Pursing the lips
Shrugging
Shaking the head
Asking for assurances or clarification
Arguing or questioning
Citing possible repercussions
Rubbing the back of the neck
Fiddling with a ring or button to avoid eye contact
Putting a hand over the face and closing the eyes
Drawing in breath and holding it for a time before releasing it
Tactfully offering alternative suggestions
Hesitation (accepting a leaflet with reluctance, etc.)
Crossing the arms or legs
Asking a third party to weigh in, hoping to sway someone's decision

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Ribs that tighten slightly
A light quiver in the stomach

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Worrying over the current path
Looking ahead to possible collateral damage
Second-guessing a prior decision (in choosing someone for the job, supporting an idea, etc.)
Searching for ideas on how to circumvent the situation
Dredging up evidence to sway opinions
Hoping or praying it will work out

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Avoiding speaking or agreeing openly
Looking for ways to distance oneself from the situation

Sharing a look with an ally; raising the eyebrows to convey a message
Wincing as others rally behind a weak solution

Fearmongering: *This could really blow up if you're wrong. Remember how George got fired last year?*

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Coughing as one agrees or supports a doubtful decision or stance

Mimicking confidence (straightening, speaking in a booming voice, etc.)

Lying or misleading others

Making excuses for not agreeing immediately

Reassuring others of loyalty, commitment, etc.

Offering to handle the problem

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Worry](#), [Disbelief](#), [Unease](#), [Suspicion](#), [Insecurity](#).

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Skepticism](#), [Conflicted](#), [Curiosity](#).

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Backpedal, challenge, counter, delay, discredit, dismiss, dispute, dwindle, exit, fade, falter, fidget, flounder, hang back, hesitate, procrastinate, question, regret, reject, research, scoff, stumble, stutter, tank, vanish, waffle, waver

WRITER'S TIP: *When steering your character through scenes that allow for emotional growth, don't forget to also provide setbacks. The path to enlightenment isn't smooth for anyone, including our characters.*

DREAD

DEFINITION: A deep fear of a future event or circumstance that leads to a strong desire to avoid it

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

- Clutching arms to one's chest
- Shoulders curling forward, caving the chest in
- A bent neck
- Leaning back or away from the source of discomfort
- Dragging footsteps
- Hanging back
- Making excuses to leave
- Speaking in a quiet voice
- Offering one-word responses
- A hunched posture and a drooping head
- Clasping one's knees tightly together
- Avoiding eye contact
- Turning the torso (shielding it from the source of one's discomfort)
- Lifting the shoulders as if to hide one's neck
- Sweating
- Rocking slightly
- Hands that tremble
- Moving to the back of a room
- Following the main group, leaving a buffer of space so one can retreat or flee if necessary
- Seeking the safety of darkness, an exit, etc.
- Hesitating before entering a room
- Holding one's elbows tightly against one's sides
- Making oneself appear smaller
- Flinching or cringing at loud noises
- Increased swallowing

Arms crossing the stomach in a protective huddle
Fidgety movements (twisting one's wrists, rubbing hands on one's pants, etc.)
Clutching comfort items (a necklace charm, phone, etc.)
Repeatedly dragging the palms down one's pant legs
Chewing at one's lips or inner cheeks and making them bleed
A pale or sickly complexion

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A roiling stomach or a dropping sensation
A heavy or sluggish heartbeat
Chills
Cold fingers
Tingling in the chest
A weighted chest
Difficulty breathing
A sour taste in the mouth
An ache in the back of the throat
Difficulty swallowing
Dizziness
Shakiness in the limbs

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Thoughts of escape; wanting to hide
Wishing time would speed up
An inability to see a positive outcome
Imagining the worst-case scenario and wishing for rescue
Sensitivity to sound and movement

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Shaking or shuddering
Jumping at sounds

Flinching if touched
Seeking any excuse to avoid what is to come
Hyperventilating
Bargaining and pleading

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Acting like one is simply feeling under the weather
Attempting to escape via distraction (with TV, a book, or music)
Focusing one's thoughts to keep fear from taking over
Keeping still

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Anguish](#), [Powerlessness](#), [Terror](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Nervousness](#), [Uncertainty](#), [Wariness](#),
[Insecurity](#), [Hopefulness](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Brace, collapse, cringe, crumple, fear, grip, imagine, obsess, panic, relive, retreat, shake, shiver, shrink, shrivel, suffer, sweat, tremble, worry

WRITER'S TIP: *Maintain an overall perspective of the character's emotional range. A strong manuscript will always expose the reader to several contrasting emotional experiences that fit within the context of the protagonist's growth.*

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EAGERNESS

DEFINITION: Enthusiasm for what is to come

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Leaning forward

Eyes that glow

Rushing one's words

Speaking in a bubbly or loud tone

Rapt attention

Rapidly nodding the head

Using excitable language

Agreeability to whatever is suggested

Fiddling with an object to keep the hands busy

Squeezing the hands at one's sides

Strong eye contact

Talking over others or interjecting to add to the conversation

Offering suggestions to ensure the event is successful or runs more smoothly

Raising a hand immediately to be called on

Asking questions to get information

Rubbing the hands together

Leaning forward with a hand on the knee

Sitting at the edge of a chair

Allowing others into one's personal space

Licking one's lips and smiling

Feet pointing forward

Shoulders straight and back

Using animated gestures

Bouncing on one's toes

Moving, fidgeting, or pacing

Blowing out a long breath and smiling

Eyes that are wide and rounded, with very few blinks
Hands clutched together
Head up, alert
A fast walk, jog, or run
Sharing a look or wink with another
Clambering closer to a group or event
Whispering in hushed, excitable tones
Scuffing a chair closer to the table
Arriving early
Volunteering one's time to help make the event better
Quirking an eyebrow and smiling
Friendliness, even with those not in one's social circle
Pulling or prodding others to hurry up
Moving toward others who share one's mindset (and away from those who don't)
Paying close attention to instructions

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A fluttery stomach
Increased heartbeat
An expanding feeling in the chest
Breathlessness
Adrenaline that causes hyper-alertness

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Focused listening
Strong organization and preparedness
An inability to concentrate on anything else
Desiring to share and include others
Losing all inhibitions
A positive outlook and thinking pattern
A willingness to take on responsibility, help, or lead

Making quick decisions due to being completely committed to one's path

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Preparing early, often hours or days before needed

Planning or obsessing over every detail

Seeking perfection

Hurrying or rushing to make things happen quicker

Daydreaming and imagining what the future experience will be like

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Clamping the hands in the lap, forcing oneself to sit still

Tight muscles

Slowing one's speech; concentrating on being articulate

A series of deep breaths

Taking up a task or chore to pass the time

Feigning disinterest by adopting a loose and relaxed posture

Making a slight detour as a ruse

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Excitement](#), [Schadenfreude](#), [Impatience](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Satisfaction](#), [Disappointment](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Advance, agree, animate, approach, babble, flock, hasten, help, join, jump, lean, pounce, pursue, run, rush, snatch, urge, volunteer, wish

WRITER'S TIP: *To generate friction in dialogue, give the participants opposing goals. A heightened emotional response is the natural result of not getting what one wants.*

ELATION

DEFINITION: In high spirits; a state of exhilaration

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

High color, a flushed appearance

A smile or grin that cannot be contained

Laughing

Squealing, screaming, shouting, or hollering

Falling to one's knees

Jumping up and down

Talking over one another

Holding the arms up in a "Victory V"

The head tipped back, one's face turned to the sky

Running a victory lap

A beaming face, with strong color and sheen

Embracing others

Dancing in place

Whooping loudly

Not caring what others think; a lack of self-consciousness

Enjoying communal happiness; feeling part of the crowd

Repeating words over and over: *Wow!* or *This is amazing!*

Flinging out the arms and legs, taking a wide stance

Thrusting the chest out

The eyes wide and glowing

Grabbing at the sides of the head in an *I can't believe it* gesture

High energy (a bouncing walk or run, skipping, etc.)

Hugging, kissing, or other displays of affection

Breaking into a run

Happy tears and shining cheeks

Throwing something into the air—a hat, books, confetti, a helmet, etc.

Sweating

Drawing in deep breaths
Thrusting a fist into the sky
Spinning in place, the arms flung out
Welcoming others into one's personal space (arms out, open posture, etc.)
Tapping a fist against the chest and thrusting it at others involved (teammates, etc.)
Becoming highly talkative and expressive

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Warmth radiating throughout the body
Racing heartbeat
A drumming in the chest
Feeling ultra-awake, rejuvenated by adrenaline

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Thoughts scattering; being too excited to think straight
Wanting to be surrounded by family and friends
Feeling vindicated for the effort, sacrifice, or hard work
Revisiting the hurdles leading to this moment
Gratitude to those who helped make this possible
A desire to thank or acknowledge those who contributed to this moment
A need to touch a symbol tied to this moment (a trophy, the grass on a field of victory, etc.)

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Tears streaming down the face
Loss of motor control; becoming clumsy as all tension leaves one's body
Trembling muscles
Sinking to the ground, exhausted
Breathlessness

Losing one's voice from screaming or shouting
Speechlessness

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

A grin that can't be contained, no matter how hard one tries
Bottling up one's breaths to try and calm down
Self-hugging to contain the feeling
Closing the eyes and covering the mouth
Quivering with the effort of controlling oneself
Looking down to hide a grin

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Euphoria](#), [Pride](#), [Schadenfreude](#), [Gratitude](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Satisfaction](#), [Happiness](#), [Peacefulness](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Beam, boast, cheer, clasp, crow, cry, dance, dazzle, explode, express, flood, flush, glow, grin, grip, hug, inflate, intoxicate, laugh, mesmerize, pump, rejoice, shout, soar, surge, swell, thank, thrill, vault, wave, whoop

WRITER'S TIP: *Make a list of the body parts you incorporate when expressing emotion. Are there ones you don't use at all? Challenge yourself to come up with a unique cue by using one of those parts and substituting it for a gesture that is overused.*

EMASCULATED

DEFINITION: A weakened state due to a perception of being stripped of power, authority, or a role tied to one's identity

NOTES: Emasculation is traditionally attributed to males, but in the right circumstances, it can be experienced by any gender.

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Dropping the shoulders and ducking the chin

The chest caving slightly

Maintaining fleeting eye contact, or avoiding it all together

Rubbing at the back of the neck

Pulling at an earlobe

Directing a burning stare at the ground or away from the person stealing one's power

A visible flush in the face and neck

A sudden stillness in the face but visible tension in the jawline

Hiding one's hands (in pockets, etc.) and looking down

Not speaking up, even when one has important ideas to share

Swallowing more often

Sweating

Touching the face more than usual

Shrinking slightly as the shoulders hunch

Visible tension, especially in the forearms

Slanting away from the person who is judging and stealing one's power

Glancing toward the exit

Growing quiet or appearing to zone out

Rocking stiffly and almost imperceptibly

Engaging in small, self-soothing motions (e.g., rubbing an arm)

Disengaging from the conversation

Making excuses to leave: *Well, I must go. Lots to do.*

Agreeing, in hopes of shortcutting the painful experience and heartache
Apologizing or mumbling a response
Smiling along with jokes at one's expense in hopes the situation will
end quicker
Hidden hands (in pockets, behind one's back, etc.) that fist and shake
Lashing out: *You have no idea what you're talking about!* or *Lay off,*
I'm doing the best I can!

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Heat in one's core, neck, and face
An unpleasant tingling across the back of the neck
Tension in the jaw from clenching one's teeth
Difficulty swallowing (feeling a lump)
One's pulse rushing in the ears
Chest pain
Hardness in the gut

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Keeping quiet to keep the peace, and resenting it
Negative self-talk that lowers one's self-worth
A distorted sense of time (painful moments seeming to out)
Being caught in a mental loop of second-guessing oneself
Asking others for advice and opinions so one will feel validated
Thinking of comebacks afterward and getting mad for not coming up
with them sooner
Fantasizing about revenge or giving an aggressor their comeuppance
Feeling small and insignificant, like one's actions and thoughts don't
matter
Experiencing jealousy around people one views as "better", such as
those who are successful, well respected, in great physical shape, or
amazing parents or spouses

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Underachieving to avoid disappointing others and oneself

Becoming more of a follower than a leader (even if one desires to lead)

Unhappiness and dissatisfaction with one's life

Depression

Keeping secrets (a private bank account, guilty pleasures, interests no one knows about, etc.)

Acting out (engaging in violence or adopting behaviors that embrace risk or danger)

Pessimism about the future

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Projecting insecurity by disempowering others and cutting them down

Boasting, controlling conversations, and being overly opinionated when it's safe to do so

Inserting oneself when it isn't appropriate (taking over, giving unsolicited advice, etc.)

Becoming a people-pleaser

Overcompensating (with material possessions, one's physique, one's hobbies, etc.)

"Falling in line" to negate the need for the aggressor to publicly display control, avoiding personal humiliation

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Humiliation](#), [Insecurity](#), [Shame](#), [Anger](#), [Self-Loathing](#), [Vengeful](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Stunned](#), [Uncertainty](#), [Relief](#), [Gratitude](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Break, crumble, cull, cut, dampen, decline, dim, drain, fade, falter, flag, hurt, isolate, lose, muffle, pain, redden, reduce, retreat, sap, shame, shrink, sink, steal, stumble, stutter, subdue, totter, weaken, wilt, wither, wound

WRITER'S TIP: *When emotionally charged, does your character think before acting, or act without thinking? Whatever their default is, put them in a situation that causes them to do the opposite.*

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EMBARRASSMENT

DEFINITION: A lack of composure due to self-conscious discomfort

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

A flush that creeps across the cheeks

Visible sweating

The body freezing in place

Grimacing or swallowing

Ears that turn red

The chin dipping down

The chest caving, the spine bent

Hands curling around one's middle

Feet shuffling

Clearing the throat and coughing

Covering oneself (crossing the arms, closing a jacket, etc.)

Pulling at one's collar

Rubbing the back of the neck

Wincing

Covering the face with one's hands

Cringing or shaking

Fidgeting and squirming

Touching the forehead

Slanting one's body away from onlookers or an aggressor

Stuttering and stammering, growing more frustrated as words refuse to come

Flinching away from touches

Speechlessness or a weakened voice

The toes curling up

Knees pulling together

Arms tucking in at the sides

Sliding down in a chair

Looking down, unable to meet someone's eyes
Shoulders slumping or curling forward
Responding with anger (shoving, punching, etc.)
Gritting one's teeth, pressing the lips tight
Shoving one's hands in one's pockets
Fiddling with shirtsleeves
Hiding behind a book
Shielding oneself (having a death grip on a purse, etc.)
A walk that accelerates into a sprint
Using the hair to hide one's face
Glancing about for help, an exit, or escape
Tugging a hat down low or pulling a hood over the head
A trembling chin

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Excessive swallowing (a lump in the throat)
Light-headedness
A tingling that sweeps up the back of the neck and across the face
A tightening chest
The stomach hardening or dropping with a manifestation of dread
The face, neck, and ears feeling impossibly hot
Rushed breathing and a rapid heartbeat

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A compulsion to flee (fight-or-flight)
Muddled or panicked thoughts
A disconnect where the mind struggles with belief: *This can't be happening!*
Thoughts searching for a solution

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Bursting into tears

Running from the room or situation
Plummeting self-esteem
Fear of public speaking or being on display
Withdrawing from groups, activities, and social interaction
Loss of appetite and resulting weight loss
Obsessing about the embarrassing event; reliving it

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Pretending to not have heard or seen
Intensely concentrating on something else; actively ignoring others
A fake smile as one tries to laugh it off
Changing the topic in any way possible
Lying or deflecting attention by assigning blame to another

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Humiliation](#), [Depressed](#), [Regret](#), [Shame](#),
[Anger](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Insecurity](#), [Relief](#), [Gratitude](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Blush, bolt, burn, cringe, cry, curl, duck, escape, flee, flush, gasp, hide, pain, retreat, run, scurry, shame, shrink, squirm, stammer, suffer, sweat

WRITER'S TIP: *Be wary of showing emotion too readily through the act of crying. In real life, it takes a lot to reach a tearful state, so it should be the same for our characters.*

EMPATHY

DEFINITION: To intimately identify with (and possibly experience) another's feelings through the ability to place oneself in their emotional shoes

NOTES: Sympathy and empathy are close in nature but aren't the same. Empathy occurs when a character feels connected to someone through a meaningful shared emotional experience. Sympathy is more surface-level, prompting one to provide comfort and support without necessarily becoming personally attached. For ideas on the latter, please view the SYMPATHY entry.

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

- A softening of the features
- Eyebrows drawing together
- A pained look (if one is sharing another's negative feelings)
- Steady eye contact that is comforting, not invasive
- Offering a small smile that communicates acceptance
- Reaching out to touch (to show connectedness)
- Choosing words with care (to show understanding, be inclusive, or raise someone up)
- Leaning in to listen without interrupting (no judgment)
- Moving closer; closing the distance
- One's body facing the other person straight on
- Cupping a shoulder or placing a hand on the other's back to provide comfort while wishing someone would offer this comfort in return
- Rubbing at one's own chest and the pain or tightness one feels there
- Adopting a soft tone, rich with understanding and acceptance
- Asking questions to allow the other to experience the relief of answering as it will help them better understand their own narrative
- Crying with the other person

Physical contact (knees or legs touching, pulling the other in, etc.)

Mirroring the posture and body language of whomever one is connecting with

Going to someone and offering to talk or just sit with them

Cancelling plans or appointments to be fully present in the moment

Using empathetic foresight to lessen another's burdens (safeguarding their privacy, offering care, handling tasks for them, etc.)

Acknowledging a shared burden: *This is so hard, isn't it?*

Verbalizing and sharing happy feelings: *Today couldn't be better, could it?*

Increased touchy-feely behaviors (holding hands for an extended time, drawing the other in so shoulders touch, etc.) when the experience is joyful

Consoling the person verbally: *I know it's difficult*, or *We'll get through this together*.

Offering truth (e.g., sharing a personal experience to provide the other person comfort)

Physical affection (squeezing another's hand, hugging, holding them close, a kiss on the cheek if it is appropriate, etc.)

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A sharp pain in the chest

Tightness in the throat

A feeling of overall heaviness

Difficulty swallowing due to having a lump in the throat and holding back tears

Shakiness or weakness (if one's emotions are overwhelming)

The sensation of phantom pain

A light, floaty feeling in the chest (if the situation is pleasing)

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A need to help or fix (if the situation is negative) or a desire to enjoy the moment (if the circumstances are positive)

Feeling frustration when others don't understand the situation as one does

The ability to forgive quickly by attributing any wrongdoings to stress and circumstances
Disconnecting from personal concerns to take on the emotions and concerns of another

A desire to escape before one's painful emotions become visible

Feeling discomfort at witnessing another's physical pain

Being mindful and tactful when others are in emotional stress

Wanting to remove another's suffering while being aware of one's inability to do so

Letting go of prejudice or pre-conceived notions and focusing on connection

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Being despondent because the pain is too much

Feeling emotionally drained or depressed

A need to be alone to sort out one's feelings after the crisis has passed

Showing kindness and compassion whatever the situation

Pessimism or disillusionment brought on by an inability to see a reason for suffering

Feeling light, a renewed sense of optimism when the moment of empathy is positive

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

A voice that sounds "off" (choked with emotion, gravelly, etc.)

Words that don't match behavior (saying something gruff while showing compassion)

Backing down from a tough stance: *You can stay the night. Or...a few nights if you need to.*

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Admiration](#), [Humbled](#), [Valued](#), [Love](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Connectedness](#), [Hopefulness](#),
[Peacefulness](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Accept, awaken, brush, care, clasp, connect, develop, echo, encourage, endure, entrust, entwine, evoke, express, feel, hold, hug, link, listen, love, need, nurture, relive, respond, seek, sense, squeeze, stir, touch, undergo, weave together

WRITER'S TIP: *In some situations, your character will be emotionally steady while in others, they will be a hot mess. For the latter, ask yourself why this is. If it is the result of an unresolved emotional wound, how can you use this to further the inner conflict of the story?*

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ENVY

DEFINITION: Resentful awareness of an advantage enjoyed by another, paired with a longing to acquire that advantage

NOTES: The advantage can be a person, an object, or an intangible (popularity, lifestyle, career, accomplishments, etc.)

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Staring or glowering

The mouth turning down

The lips parting slightly

A tightening under the eyes

A thinning mouth

The chin poking forward

Squinting

A slight baring of the teeth

A pouty bottom lip

Crossing the arms over the chest

Rounding the shoulders and curling inward

Leaning closer

Reaching for the thing one desires

Flaring nostrils

A coveting gaze that drifts to the symbol of envy (the advantage)

Being snarky or rude, seemingly without cause

Shoving one's hands into one's pockets

Twitching hands

Hands tightening into fists

Muscles bunching

Turning away from the advantage and stalking off

Swallowing frequently

Rubbing the hands over one's clothing

Muttering about the unfairness under one's breath
Positioning oneself so the feet and torso are facing the advantage
Licking or sucking on the bottom lip
Sweaty hands
A reddening of the face
Rubbing at or massaging one's chest
Stroking or pinching one's throat
Taking a step toward the person or object one wants
Obsessive behavior (stalking, making a plan to acquire the advantage,
etc.)

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A quick heartbeat
The ribs squeezing tight
Rising body temperature
A pulling sensation in the gut
The mouth drying as one sucks in breath through clenched teeth

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A strong desire to touch, hold, and own
Anger at the unfairness or injustice of the situation
Unkind thoughts about the other person
Frustration
Scheming ways to acquire what another has
Self-loathing
Fantasizing about the advantage
An inability to commit to or focus on anything else
Dissatisfaction with what one does have
A feeling of entitlement: *I deserve it*, or *That should be mine!*

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Feeling that life isn't worth living without the advantage

Grabbing or stealing the coveted object
Fighting or arguing with the envied one to release frustration
Falsely belittling or minimizing the attributes of the desired advantage or object
Irrational thinking
Anger at the advantage itself (if a person) for choosing someone else
Making demands: *Give it to me.*

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Congratulating the person or offering them praise
Forcing a smile
Acknowledging the object and complimenting it
Attempting not to stare
Watching from a distance

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Determination](#), [Resentment](#), [Anger](#),
[Depressed](#), [Jealousy](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Defeat](#), [Insecurity](#), [Embarrassment](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Admire, arouse, burn, confess, consume, covet, desire, devour, elicit, gaze, gnaw, provoke, resent, rouse, stir, suffer, tempt, tinge, vex, want, wish

WRITER'S TIP: *When crafting the details of a fight scene, remember that less is more. Too many details create a play-by-play feel which can come across as mechanical.*

EUPHORIA

DEFINITION: A transcendent state of intense pleasure, happiness, and well-being

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Unrestrained smiling or laughter
One's head tipping back and the eyes closing
The mouth opening in wonder
Eyes going as wide as they can
Thrusting the chest out and up
Letting out a gasp
All tension leaving the body
Repeatedly laying a hand on the chest and lightly pressing down
Pulling in deep breaths and holding them before releasing them
Becoming more affectionate (hugging, touching, etc.)
Happy tears and laughter
Arms held high above the head in a "Victory V"
Jumping and pumping the fists
Dropping to one's knees with the head tipped back
Celebrating (flag waving, crushing others in a bear hug, shouting and whooping, etc.)
Temporary breathlessness
Slurring slightly or drawing out one's words
Spinning around to take everything in
Visible gooseflesh; rubbing at the arms and shivering with pleasure
Stretching out—lying on the grass with one's limbs spread wide, for example
Rapid speech and declining articulation
An instant release of stress (the body going slack)
The face and neck flushing with color
Grabbing onto the sides of one's head and tipping it back

Changes in the voice (growing higher, taking on a breathless quality, etc.)

Holding the arms out to the side, palms up

Wrapping one's arms around oneself and squeezing, to hold the feeling in

Interacting more with one's sensory environment (especially through touch)

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Weightlessness

Warmth infusing the body

A tingling surge that starts in one's head or chest and spreads outward

The stomach fluttering

A racing heart

An expansive feeling in the chest

Light-headedness

Sunbursts or spots in one's vision

MENTAL RESPONSES:

The mind emptying of all concerns and worries

Engaging in mental exploration and daydreaming

Stimulated senses (colors, smells, textures, etc. becoming more intense)

A feeling of "being carried away" or experiencing a higher state of being

The cessation of pain or discomfort

Feeling powerful and capable of anything (invincibility)

Viewing the world through a lens of serenity and connection

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Heightened creativity and a sudden desire to express it (via writing, art, etc.)

Taking risks due to feeling invincible and powerful

Feeling energized and at peace

Hallucinations

A pleasant sensation of dizziness

The belief that everything in one's life has aligned, and one will be taken care of

Seeking to share the experience with others and feel more deeply connected

An increased capacity for empathy, compassion, and altruism

Being more likely to take time to notice beauty in all forms

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Flinching or jumping slightly

A sharp intake of breath

Losing track of what one was doing or saying

Turning away to hide one's joyful smile

A smile that keeps creeping back onto one's face

Losing track of the conversation

Making excuses: *Sorry, I felt light-headed for a minute, or Can you repeat what you just said?*

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Awe](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Elation](#), [Satisfaction](#), [Connectedness](#), [Moved](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Bask, bathe, captivate, climb, comfort, dazzle, drift, elate, enthrall, fill, float, flood, infuse, inhale, intoxicate, leap, mesmerize, overflow, peak, radiate, rapture, reap, seep, share, shine, soak, soar, sweep, tremble, weep, welcome

WRITER'S TIP: *Whenever you are using thoughts to show the character reflecting on what they feel, make sure the language you use fits their voice, age, worldview, education, and life experience.*

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EXCITEMENT

DEFINITION: The state of being energized or stimulated and provoked to act

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

A wide grin

Eyes that sparkle and gleam

Bouncing from foot to foot

Squealing, hooting, yelling, and laughing

Telling jokes

Chest bumping with others

A loud voice

Singing, humming, or chanting

Slam-dunking trash into a barrel after a game or event

Babbling or talking over one another in a group setting

Fanning oneself

Clutching one's fists to the chest and squeezing the body tight, then releasing

Pretending to faint

Clutching at oneself for comedic effect to amuse others

Verbalizing thoughts and feelings without hesitation

Lifting someone up or swinging them around

Acting hyper, immature, or foolish out of a sense of fun

A ruddy complexion

Moving about, being unable to stay still

Good-natured shoving and pushing

Waving the arms and being demonstrative

Drumming one's feet against the floor

Hugging others

Grabbing onto someone's arm and holding it

Bumping shoulders with others in one's group

Raising up or bouncing on tiptoe
Phoning or texting to share news or pass on the excitement
Speed-talking with others, heads close together
Throaty laughter
Getting the giggles
Friendly demands: *Tell me! Show me! Let's go!*
A body that's constantly in motion (nodding, bobbing, weaving, pacing, etc.)
Walking with a fast-paced strut
Making eye contact with others; showing confidence
Displaying affection with friends or loved ones

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A lightness in the chest
A fast pulse
Feeling like one's insides are vibrating
Dry mouth
Heightened senses
Breathlessness
Feeling energized and awake due to an adrenaline rush

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Camaraderie with others
Imagining what could happen
Enjoyment of the communal energy
Impatience
Being agreeable to ideas and suggestions that align with the energy one feels

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

A need to run, jump, scream, or whoop it up
An intense desire to share the feeling with others

A beaming face
A racing heartbeat
Sweating
A hoarse voice from screaming, yelling, or shouting
A loss of inhibitions

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Controlling one's movement with intent
Biting down on a smile
Swallowing a laugh or shout of glee
Smoothing down clothing as a way of releasing one's energy
Eyes that glow with an inner light
Nodding rather than speaking

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Amazement](#), [Happiness](#), [Elation](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Satisfaction](#), [Disappointment](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Bounce, bubble, build, buzz, drum, fill, glow, grip, gyrate, intensify, jiggle, jump, laugh, leap, mount, pound, pump, quicken, quiver, race, squeal, stir, suppress, surge, swell, tingle, tremble, vibrate, whirl, whoop, yell

WRITER'S TIP: *If you're stuck on how to show an emotion, form a strong image of the scene in your mind. Let the scene unfold, and watch the character to see how they move and behave.*

FEAR

DEFINITION: To be afraid of; to expect a threat or danger

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

The face turning ashen, white, or pallid

Body odor and cold sweats

Wiping clammy hands on one's clothing to rid them of sweat

Trembling lips and chin

Tendons standing out in the neck

Veins beating a visible pulse beneath the skin

Elbows pressing into the sides, making one's body as small as possible

Freezing, feeling rooted to the spot

An inability to speak

Rapid blinking

Tight shoulders

Staring but not seeing

Eyes that are shut or crying

Hands jammed into armpits or self-hugging

One's breaths bursting in and out

Leg muscles tightening as the body gets ready to run

Looking all around, especially behind oneself

A shrill voice that one cannot control

Lowering the voice to a whisper

Keeping one's back to a wall or corner

Shaking uncontrollably

Flinching at noises

Gripping something so hard one's knuckles turn white

Stiff walking, the knees locking

Beads of sweat on the lip or forehead

Grabbing onto someone to feel protected

Eyes appearing damp and overly bright

Stuttering and mispronouncing words
Tremors in the voice
Jerky movements, squirming, cringing, and bumping into things
Licking the lips and gulping down water
Sprinting or running
Sweeping a shaky hand across the forehead to get rid of sweat
Gasping and expelling one's breath
Slapping a hand over the mouth to silence one's uncontrolled
whimpering
Pleading with or talking to oneself

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Shakiness in the limbs (causing increased clumsiness)
A racing heartbeat that causes pains in the chest
The sensation of one's hair lifting on the arms and nape of the neck
Dizziness and weakness in the legs and knees
A loosening of the bladder
Holding one's breath, or gulping down breaths to stay quiet
A stomach that feels rock hard
Hypersensitivity to touch and sound

MENTAL REACTIONS:

Wanting to flee or hide due to a sense of impending doom
The sensation of things moving too quickly to process
Images of what-could-be flashing through the mind
Flawed reasoning
Jumping to a course of action without thinking things through
A skewed sense of time
Mistrusting one's own judgment (when it comes to safety and security)

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Uncontrollable trembling

Fainting

Exhaustion or insomnia

The heart giving out

Panic attacks, phobias, or depression

Substance abuse

Withdrawing from others

Tics (a repetitive grimace, a head twitch, talking to oneself, etc.)

Resistance to pain from rushing adrenaline

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Denying fear through diversion or changing topics

Turning away from the cause of the fear

Attempting to keep one's voice light

A watery smile that's forced into place

Masking fear with a reactive emotion (anger or frustration) or showing false bravado

Overindulgence in a habit (nail biting, lip biting, scratching the skin raw, etc.)

Telling jokes in a voice that cracks

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Anger](#), [Terror](#), [Paranoia](#), [Dread](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Agitation](#), [Overwhelmed](#), [Wariness](#), [Relief](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Cast, creep, cry, flee, flutter, force, freeze, gasp, gouge, grab, gulp, hiss, jar, jump, overcome, panic, paralyze, pierce, quiver, rush, seize, shake, shriek, shrink, startle, strike, swivel, throb, torment, tremble, unleash, vibrate

WRITER'S TIP: *Prime readers for an emotional experience by describing the mood of a scene as your character enters it. If your character is antsy, the reader will be too.*

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FEARLESSNESS

DEFINITION: Feeling dauntless in the face of intimidation, fear, and challenge

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

A calm exterior (strong eye contact, a neutral expression, the head steady, etc.)

Good posture, legs spread slightly, arms at the sides in a state of readiness

Leaning in to pay closer attention

Shoulders back and the chest out

Observing and asking questions to better understand the situation

Rubbing hands against one's pants so they are free of sweat

Shaking out one's hands or arms to enter a state of readiness

Closing and opening the fists to prepare for action

Engaging in positive self-talk: *Okay, you can do this.*

Moving forward and closing the distance to others, to danger, etc.

A curt nod

Lifting the chin

A purposeful stride with no hesitation

Moving to the front of a crowd

Being direct (e.g., calling someone out for being rude or wasting time)

Blowing out a deep breath, the mouth forming an "O"

Speaking economically; using less words (staying mentally focused)

Using an even, serious tone

Choosing words with care (to neutralize a situation, avoid being viewed as a threat, calm people down, or provoke the other party into making a mistake, etc.)

Impatience at long-winded answers or inaction

Falling only to get right back up

Walking forward without looking back

Flexing one's fingers

Making one's own decisions rather than leaving them up to others

Engaging in meditation practices (to become centered and hone one's focus)

Showing a lack of self-consciousness—changing clothes in front of others when time is of the essence, for example

Being self-sufficient yet unafraid to ask for help when it is needed

Making bold claims: *I know I can do it*, or *It's a matter of when, not if*.

Making plans for the future regardless of one's circumstances

Quoting statistics, facts, and historical successes that support one's endeavor

Going toe-to-toe with an adversary that others would avoid

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A tightness in the chest that one mentally forces to loosen

Tingling and light-headedness (adrenaline)

A rushing sound in the ears (rapid heartbeat)

Muscles tightening in the torso

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Being self-aware and self-accepting (of flaws, limitations, strengths, etc.)

Observing before reacting

Imagining the worst-case scenario so one can proactively think past it

A willingness to experiment and try new things

Embracing struggle rather than running from it

Seeking out mentors and experiences to help one become more capable

Adopting a mind-over-matter mentality

Determining to deal with the problem right away instead of putting it off

Hypersensitivity to sound and movement

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Refusing to put on an act to impress others
Learning to compartmentalize in emotion-driven situations
Challenging one's fears (climbing a building if one is afraid of heights, for example)
Pushing past one's limits—e.g., ignoring pain and other distractions
Being highly logical (reasoning things out in one's mind)
Being goal-oriented
Doing what's right rather than what's easy
Working out, strength-training, eating well, etc. to stay in top condition

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Voicing common worries to make oneself seem unsure
Forcing oneself to hesitate before jumping into a new situation
Asking for permission
Hunching the shoulders and avoiding eye contact with others
Letting others go first (into a new situation, into danger, etc.)
Debating the pros and cons of action as if one is uncertain

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Confidence](#), [Vindicated](#), [Smugness](#),
[Anticipation](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Conflicted](#), [Reluctance](#), [Acceptance](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Act, buck, challenge, charge, conquer, dare, defy, discipline, eliminate, endure, exert, explode, expose, grip, join, kick, manipulate, meet organize, plunge, press, propel, prove, pull, research, risk, rush, seize, shove, strain, stride

WRITER'S TIP: *A character's emotional responses reflect their deepest self. Take the time to explore their past and understand how their backstory will steer specific behaviors and actions.*

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FLUSTERED

DEFINITION: Feeling overwrought and self-conscious due to confusion, uncertainty, or frustration

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Breaking eye contact with someone

Blinking rapidly

A sharp intake of breath

A flush appearing in the face and neck

Using speech disfluencies (*ums, ahs*) to stall while trying to salvage a conversation

Stumbling over one's sentences

Sputtering and struggling to find the right words

A nervous smile

Scraping a hand through one's hair or tucking it behind an ear

The mouth opening and closing without speaking

Touching the face repeatedly

Making excuses that sound scattered or hastily put together

Lying to cover up perceived weaknesses or goof-ups

Clumsiness and jerky movements

Giving a quick shake of the head

Tapping or rubbing the forehead with one's fingertips

Self-deprecation: *Well, that was a stupid thing to say, wasn't it?*

Shielding or turning the body to the side rather than facing someone directly

Changing direction multiple times

An inability to stay still

Second-guessing oneself

Retreating from the conversation

Being unable to move on until a mistake is corrected (when giving a speech, teaching, etc.)

A strangled-sounding laugh

Throat-clearing

Making a joke to alleviate the situation or save face

Apologizing or talking rapidly

Pressing a fist against one's thigh

Squeezing or pinching oneself (an arm, wrist, the skin between the thumb and forefinger, etc.) to try and regain focus

Turning to a physical task to busy one's hands (clearing a table, straightening pillows, etc.)

Briefly cupping the back of the neck with one's hand

Heat entering one's tone

Deflecting (blaming another, arguing, changing the focus to something else, etc.)

Becoming emphatic to regain control: *No, I'm fine. I've got it. I'll have it to you Monday, really.*

Glancing around for a rescue

Refusing help that is offered

Diverting attention: *It's too warm in here, don't you think? Let's open a window.*

Allowing someone to enter one's personal space if the cause is positive (such as a signal of romantic interest)

Stepping back to increase personal space if the cause is negative (being criticized in the presence of one's peers, for example)

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

An increase in internal temperature

Heat in the face (blushing)

Tingling or tightness in the chest from not getting enough oxygen (holding one's breath, not taking enough breaths, etc.)

A prickling along the back of the neck

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Feeling insecure or vulnerable
A loud, critical inner voice (for reacting this way)
Heightened awareness of being in the spotlight
Feeling as though time has stopped or slowed
A desire to flee that one must fight to overcome
Racing thoughts bent on regaining control of the situation

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Clamping the mouth shut to avoid exacerbating the situation
Uncontrolled blushing and visible sweating
Allowing someone else to take over
Making an exit regardless of the consequences

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Feigning disinterest to minimize the importance of the current moment
Asking a question that will cause a reaction and put the spotlight elsewhere

Denying being flustered: *No, you just caught me off guard, that's all.*

Manipulating the situation: *You two introduce yourselves while I get us drinks.*

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Frustration](#), [Agitation](#), [Embarrassment](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Annoyance](#), [Uncertainty](#), [Self-Loathing](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Addle, agitate, annoy, babble, blurt, blush, dart, dazzle, drop, fidget, flush, frustrate, gape, hamper, hesitate, hinder, joke, panic, rattle, squeeze, stare, struggle, stumble, torment, twitch, unbalance, undermine, upset, waffle, wobble

WRITER'S TIP: Sometimes a character will fight the emotion they are feeling. If this is the case, think about how their body language and dialogue may be at odds, and show that struggle.

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FRUSTRATION

DEFINITION: Vexation caused by unresolved problems or unmet needs; the feeling of being hindered

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Pinching the lips together

Placing the arms behind the back, gripping one wrist with the other hand

Rushed speech

Tapping one's fingers to release energy

Pointing with an index finger

Scratching or rubbing the back of the neck

Shaking the head

Jerky movements (talking with the hands, changing direction mid-stride, etc.)

Signs of restlessness, such as pacing in short spans

Stiff posture and rigid muscles

Clenching the jaw

Speaking through the teeth with forced restraint

An impatient snort or sneer

Cursing under the breath

Drawing breath and releasing it before speaking

Stretching the hands out wide, then relaxing them

Baring one's teeth

Throwing the hands up in an *I give up* gesture

Stalking away from someone; leaving in a huff

Lashing out; attempting to hurt someone through name-calling and personal jabs

Speaking without thought in a way that could lead to regret

Slamming a door

Grabbing one's hair in clumps and looking up at the sky

A heavy sigh
Laying one's head down on the table
Stilted speaking
Tension in one's voice
Running the hands through the hair
Fists tight, fingernails biting into the palms
A pinched, tension-filled expression
Pounding a fist against the tabletop
Scrunching up the face and then relaxing it, trying to regain calm
Holding one's head in one's hands
A high chin (exposing one's neck without fear)
Arms crossing in front of the chest
Clumsiness due to rushing (slopping coffee, knocking something over, etc.)
Theatrical groaning

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

The throat closing up
A hardening of the stomach
Tightness in the chest
Signs of high blood pressure (a headache or pounding in one's ears)
Jaw pain from clenching the teeth

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Extreme focus on problem solving
Replaying a scene or event over and over in one's mind, obsessing over it
Self-talking to calm down and think straight
A need to ask questions and rehash information
Forcibly trying to rein in one's emotions before it damages relationships

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Shouting, yelling, ranting, screaming, or criticizing

Pleading or bargaining: *Please stop!*

Storming out of a room

An inability to sleep or relax

Profuse sweating

Using more force than is necessary (a stomping type of walk, throwing an item instead of handing it off, etc.)

A display of violence (kicking, grabbing, shaking, or destroying something in release)

Engaging in tantrums—screaming, flinging the body to the floor, crying, etc. (if one is immature)

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Swiping at tears, trying to hide them

Silence or minimal responses

Briefly closing one's eyes and taking a deep breath

Scraping a hand over the face as if to wash away emotion

Excusing oneself and leaving

Trying to shake or roll tension from the shoulders

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Contempt](#), [Anger](#), [Impatience](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Annoyance](#), [Conflicted](#), [Regret](#), [Indifference](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Bottle, burst, crush, grip, grit, growl, incite, infuriate, inhibit, mutter, pace, push, shake, simmer, steam, stew, stifle, torment, twitch, unleash, vent

WRITER'S TIP: *Use a character's intuition to draw the reader more fully into the scene. If you show what has primed it clearly, the reader's own gut will respond, and they will pay extra close attention. Remember that the flash of intuition must pay off in some way to complete the circle.*

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GRATITUDE

DEFINITION: Thankfulness; feeling grateful or appreciative

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Eyes that are soft and filled with an inner glow

Clasping another's hand or forearm

Tapping a loose fist against the chest

Placing a hand on the chest

Tearing up

Laying a hand on one's heart, then gesturing to a person or group

Pressing fingers to smiling lips

Repeating one's thanks and appreciation

Holding onto someone's hand for longer than necessary

Hugging and showing affection

A light squeeze during a handshake

A smile that has a genuine build and lights up the face

Steady eye contact

Saying *Thank you*

Moving into another's personal space, or welcoming others into one's own

Forming a steeple with the hands and pressing them to one's lips

Offering praise for others

An emotion-rich voice

Offering small touches to connect with others

Laying a hand on someone's back or shoulder

Nodding, the eyes glowing

Offering a gift, favor, or boon of appreciation

Raising one's palms to the sky and looking up

Complimenting others

Clapping vigorously

The body and feet pointing forward

Offering a wave or two-fingered salute
Tipping the head back for a moment and closing the eyes
Bowing or curtsying
Blowing a kiss
Offering a wave of thanks
Needing to pause or swallow to rein in one's emotion before speaking
Vowing to repay the responsible party in time

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Tingling warmth in the limbs
A release of all bodily tension
A feeling of expansion in the chest
A heart that feels full
A comfortable warmth in the face
Weakness in the knees

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Desiring to repay another's kindness and support
Feeling overwhelmed in a good way
Wanting to drink in the moment, to remember this feeling forever
A desire to celebrate others and make them feel special, too

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Worship
Falling to one's knees
A desire to do anything to repay the responsible party
Joyful tears
A feeling of connection and love

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Closing the eyes
Ducking the head to hide one's expression

Avoiding eye contact with others
Quick, darting glances to express a hidden thanks
Offering a distraction or changing the subject
Clearing the throat before speaking (to steady one's tone)

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Satisfaction](#), [Peacefulness](#), [Happiness](#), [Elation](#),
[Connectedness](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Overwhelmed](#), [Uncertainty](#), [Vulnerability](#),
[Confusion](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Appreciate, beam, bow, cherish, clasp, envelop, evoke, express, extend, hug, include, meet, nod, offer, overflow, profess, promise, radiate, reach, rise, select, share, shine, squeeze, swallow, tap, thank, touch, voice, warm, whisper

WRITER'S TIP: *Make it a goal to offer the reader something unexpected in every scene, be it an emotional reaction, a roadblock to trip the character up, or a snippet of dialogue that sheds new light on the events unfolding.*

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GRIEF

DEFINITION: A deep and painful sorrow over a personal loss, which is often a loved one

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Shaky hands

Movements that lack strength

A vacant look and slack facial expression

A sudden loss of breath, or struggling to find one's breath

Rubbing at one's chest

Lashing out at others

A loss of appetite

Refusing to eat

Lips that tremble and press together

Holding or wearing a cherished item or gift belonging to the one who died

Forgetting to change clothing or attend to one's hygiene

Wanting to be left alone

Barely speaking, or speaking in a voice that cracks or lacks strength

Breaking things to vent one's emotions

Losing track of conversations

A collapsed body posture (appearing small or frail)

Feeling heavy (bowed shoulders, arms that drag, having no desire to move, etc.)

Uncontrollable crying or screaming

Praying for strength (if one is religious)

Writing in a journal to the person who passed on

Attending counseling

Losing track of time

Pacing from room to room, touching objects and mementos

Refusing to sleep, or sleeping to escape

Self-medicating
Clinging to loved ones out of a need to have them close
Rubbing at one's wrists, shoulders, knees, etc. to try and relieve body pain
Repeatedly telling others about the circumstances surrounding one's loss
A sensitivity to noise (flinching, rubbing at one's ears, etc.)
Avoiding people and social functions
Eyes that appear red and raw

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

An overall feeling of weakness or numbness
Low energy
Irregular heartbeats and dizziness
A tightness in the chest that will not loosen
The sensation of one's heart being heavy
Stabbing stomach pain, nausea, and digestive sensitivity
Body pains and headaches
Frequent swallowing due to a feeling of constriction in the throat
Eyes that feel dry, achy, or swollen from extended crying
Body chills

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Mental fog, forgetfulness, and losing track of time
Viewing the day-to-day concerns of others as superficial or meaningless
Fixating on one's regrets surrounding the source of loss
Frequently dreaming of one's loss
Irrational thoughts and anxiety
Guilt for being alive
Sad thoughts that come and go
Painful longings to touch and hold who or what one has lost
Anger at others who have moved on quickly

A renewed interest in spirituality
Anger at God; doubting one's faith
Profound loneliness
A lack of motivation
Apathy for others and their needs (impatience with small talk, etc.)
Feeling that one is going crazy and fearing this state of grief will last forever

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Depression and possible suicide attempts
Premature aging
A significant weight loss or gain
Paranoia and obsession regarding the well-being of loved ones
A loss of control when self-medicating (drinking too much, overdosing, etc.)

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Not wanting to talk about the person who is gone
Getting rid of the person's personal items (boxing them up, donating them, etc.)
Adhering to a strict and often busy routine
Throwing oneself into work or a project to avoid dealing with one's pain
Pulling away from others who are reminders of one's loss
Moving to a new home or city
Extreme behavior shifts (e.g., engaging in promiscuity to avoid getting attached again)

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Anger](#), [Bitterness](#), [Guilt](#), [Despair](#), [Depressed](#), [Vengeful](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Devastation](#), [Overwhelmed](#), [Loneliness](#), [Acceptance](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Buckle, cave, clutch, collapse, cry, despair, mourn, pain, pucker, shake, shudder, shuffle, slump, sob, tremble, weave, weep, whisper, wilt

WRITER'S TIP: *When showing emotion, spend more airtime on describing whatever the POV character is most focused on. What has their attention will have the reader's attention, too.*

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GUILT

DEFINITION: A feeling of culpability over an offense (either real or imagined)

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Averting or lowering one's gaze

Turning away or shifting about

The chin dipping to the chest as one's posture slumps

Blushing

Scratching at the face

Reacting defensively; short-temperedness

Consuming antacids

Repetitive swallowing

Lying

Sweating

Grimacing and lip biting

Avoiding a person or place

Talking too much or too fast

Keeping at a distance

Rubbing the nose or tugging at a collar

One's shoulders drawing up, the elbows tucking into the sides

Closing or curling one's hands inward

Stuttering, growing flustered, a voice that cracks

Joking to lighten the mood or distract others from the truth

Seeking comfort by touching one's own hair, neck, or clothing

Pinning the arms against the stomach

Becoming unnaturally quiet or still

A quivering chin

Muttering tearfully to oneself

Anxious movements (pawing a hand through the hair, pacing, etc.)

Taking a deep, pained breath and closing the eyes

Staring down at one's feet and focusing on one's knees (if sitting)
Palms hidden (stuffed into pockets, held behind the back, etc.)
Darting glances at the person who was wronged
Following the one who was wronged, trying to convince oneself to confess

Inflicting pain on oneself as a penance
Destroying one's own possessions
An inability to join in fun activities or be with friends
Looking pale; having a harried or haunted look
Not showing up for work or school
Avoiding the people one believes have been wronged
Cutting oneself down in front of others; vicious self-deprecation

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Tightness in the chest
Skin sensitivity, or skin that feels more itchy than normal
Pain in the back of the throat
Upset stomach and a loss of appetite

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Replaying what happened, making it bigger in one's mind
Thoughts filled with self-loathing
Wishing one could go back and change what happened
Feeling anxious and desiring to confess or share the pain or burden with another
Brooding, retreating inward, and withdrawing from others
Paranoia that others know and are passing judgment
An inability to concentrate on anything else

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

A lack of interest in one's own appearance or wellness
Drinking until passing out (to forget)

Exhaustion or even insomnia
Depression
Nightmares
Crying, sobbing, and hitching breaths
Flight responses—running away, unable to deal with the consequences
Growing reclusive and cutting oneself off from others
Self-mutilation
Self-loathing
Wanting to take one's own life as a way out (or even attempting suicide)

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Becoming excessively resourceful or helpful to make up for earlier failures

Fidgeting and throat-clearing
Hiding one's mouth behind a hand
Changing the subject and deflecting attention
Verbally denying having anything to do with the event

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Conflicted](#), [Regret](#), [Shame](#), [Remorse](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Doubt](#), [Reluctance](#), [Regret](#), [Uncertainty](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Absolve, admit, burden, conceal, confess, deny, escape, haunt, imply, lessen, project, prove, punish, purge, riddle, suffer, tinge, torment, torture

WRITER'S TIP: *Character bibles can help you keep track of hair, eye and clothing choices for each character, keeping the continuity from the first page to the last.*

HAPPINESS

DEFINITION: A state of well-being or joyful contentment

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

An upturned face

Smiling

Humming, whistling, or singing

A relaxed appearance

Telling jokes and laughing frequently

Raised, prominent cheekbones (from smiling)

Eyes that dance, sparkle, or shine

A bubbly or light voice

Rapid speaking

Buying gifts for others or offering tokens of kindness

Stretching out the legs and adopting a wide, open stance

Giving someone the thumbs-up

Sitting up, straight and alert

Fluid movements

A polite manner

Offering compliments

Swinging the arms while walking

Stepping lightly, skipping, or swaying in place

Initiating physical contact with others

Infusing one's speech with positive words

Showing a talkative nature and courtesy with strangers

Spontaneity

Lightly rapping one's fingers (as if to internal music) on a leg or other surface

Swinging or tapping one's foot to an easy beat

Satisfied, catlike stretches

Expressing enjoyment of the senses (swaying to music, savoring food, etc.)

Nodding or leaning in and enjoying the act of listening (actively showing interest)

Bouncing on the toes and waving enthusiastically

Offering encouragement and support

Quick movements, with no hesitation

An overall visage that glows or radiates

Holding the arms out wide as if to hug the world

Initiating random acts of kindness

Becoming more talkative

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Heat that radiates through the chest

Tingling hands

Lightness in the limbs and an overall feeling of weightlessness

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Positive thinking

Desiring to spread joy and make others feel good

Noticing the small things (smelling the roses, so to speak)

Helpfulness and patience with others

Being at ease with the world; content

A bright outlook (glass half full)

A desire to be with loved ones or friends

Fearlessness

Benign risk-taking for fun

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Joyful tears

Shaking with excitement

Big movements (leaping, pumping a fist, running, dancing, etc.)

Shows of affection and happy bursts of screaming, shouting, laughter, or giggles

Laugh lines

Generosity, compassion, and the desire to improve the lives of others

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Pressing the lips tightly together to keep from smiling

Bouncing lightly in place

Taking deep, calming breaths

Grabbing onto something to anchor oneself rather than move toward the source

Carefully masked features but with eyes that betray the true emotion

Putting away happy thoughts to savor later

Intense concentration on something or someone else

Hiding a joyous expression with one's hair

Holding a hand over the mouth to cover a smile

Pinching oneself and using the pain to help contain the emotion

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Elation](#), [Gratitude](#), [Satisfaction](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Inspired](#), [Valued](#), [Pleased](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Animate, appreciate, beam, brighten, caress, cheer, clap, embrace, encircle, energize, express, extend, fill, gather, glow, greet, help, host, include, jump, laugh, radiate, rejoice, relish, savor, share, smile, thrill, toast, wave, welcome

WRITER'S TIP: *To increase tension in a scene, think about what is motivating your character, and which emotions could get in the way. Introduce an event that creates the very emotions the character wishes to avoid.*

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HATRED

DEFINITION: To loathe or detest; to feel animosity toward

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Fists that shake

An intense, fevered stare

A clenched jaw and grinding teeth

Rigid and defined forearm muscles

Uttering dark, hurtful words meant to provoke someone

Stiff posture, square shoulders, and a lurching walk

Shoving, pushing, or tripping

Baring the teeth

Fingers retracting, turning claw-like

Shouting, screaming, or swearing

Lunging at an enemy

Spittle flying while one is yelling

A red face and neck

Sweating

A visible vein throb

A corded neck

Leaving an event or situation; refusing to be in the same place if the other person arrives

Switching shifts or altering a schedule to avoid an enemy

Tightness in the face, one's skin stretched into a snarl

An animalistic growl in the throat

Flaring nostrils

A grip that unintentionally crushes or breaks (snapping a pen, etc.)

A tense body, on the verge of springing

Bullying—both online and off

A mouth that curls with dislike; sneering

Spitting at someone or in their direction

Reaching out to throttle, hit, or cause pain
Shoving people aside to reach the enemy
Angry tears
Cursing and swearing
A scathing tone
A shaking voice
Using friends to help ostracize or bring the enemy low
Initiating hateful gossip, setting the enemy up, or starting rumors
Wrenching an enemy's arm to stop them from leaving
Acting on violent urges (throwing a chair, destroying property, etc.)
A heaving chest

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

One's breath sounding loud in one's ears
Pain in the jaw or head from clenching and grinding one's teeth
A pounding heartbeat
Rising body temperature
Strain or soreness from tense muscles
Roaring in the ears (high blood pressure)

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A dark mood that no one can reach through or dispel
Rash decisions and impaired judgment
Irrational thoughts—taking risks to get even
A desire to carry out a vendetta (via vandalism, theft, etc.)
A single-minded focus on how to destroy another
Humiliation fantasies featuring the enemy
A desire to break, crush, or destroy something

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

An inability to enjoy positive things or happiness
Difficulty eating and sleeping

Isolating oneself

Fixating on an enemy—stalking, committing crimes against them, etc.

Gravitating to people who feel the same way about the person or entity

Making plans to sabotage an enemy or reveal their ugliness to others

Deriving pleasure from violent fantasies involving an enemy

Assault or murder

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Clamping the teeth shut to contain hard words

Taking deep breaths to calm oneself

Seeking out a distraction or diversion

Leaving the situation or presence of an enemy

Surrounding oneself with supportive friends

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Paranoia](#), [Rage](#), [Obsessed](#), [Vengeful](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Bitterness](#), [Resentment](#), [Scorn](#), [Jealousy](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Attack, bash, bite, blacken, blaze, burn, consume, despise, fantasize, fuel, glare, harbor, incite, loathe, obsess, rant, ravage, sabotage, scorch, scream, seethe, shatter, shout, simmer, slander, smash, swear, tear, threaten, wreak

WRITER'S TIP: *One way to create emotional intensity is to have the character remember the stakes on the cusp of taking action. Worry over the outcome can add a slice of desperation to any scene and create a compelling emotional pull for the reader.*

HOMESICK

DEFINITION: Grief at being separated from the people or places that represent belonging and comfort

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Lethargy, moping about—movements that lack energy

Sleeping a lot

Aimless wandering

Slouching in one's chair (slumped posture)

Crying easily

Reddened, puffy eyes

A nose red from crying

Dull eyes lacking any sparkle

Facial features being downturned

A dropped-down chin; not holding one's head up proud and high

Sighing often

Rubbing a palm against one's breastbone, massaging a constant ache

Wrapping arms around one's torso (self-hugging for comfort)

A face devoid of emotion

Lying on a couch, watching TV for hours on end

Frequently being startled out of a reverie

An inward, thoughtful expression, as if one is thinking of other things

Comforting oneself with memorabilia (pictures, old videos, keepsakes, etc.)

Reminiscing with anyone who will listen

A voice that wavers or breaks when speaking of home

Calling the people one is missing

Grilling them about what's happening at home

Counting the days to a trip home

Distracting oneself with activities

Reading books, watching movies, or listening to music associated with one's past

Comparing one's new surroundings with the old place and finding them lacking

Stalking loved ones on social media to stay informed about what's going on back home

Overindulging (in food, drink, exercise, shopping, video games, etc.) as a way of coping

Spending a lot of time alone or with other people, depending on how one copes

Desperately trying to fit in within the new environment (to get past the homesickness)

Haunting the mailbox or constantly checking one's phone, hoping for correspondence

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Eyes stinging with tears

A hollow feeling in the chest

A thick lump in the throat that never seems to go away

A sensation of emptiness or sinking

Ribs growing tight, restricting one's breath

An upset stomach, body aches, or a headache

A sharp twinge in the chest upon hearing about activities one is missing back home

An adrenaline jolt when the phone rings or a care package arrives

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Recalling the good about one's old home and forgetting about the bad

Trying not to think about home

Striving to find any positives in one's new environment

Struggling with feelings of disloyalty as one begins to integrate into the new surroundings

The sensation of time passing very slowly
Constantly wondering what loved ones are doing right now
Experiencing longing and sadness when one is missing out on notable events back home (family dinners, a birthday, putting the kids to bed, etc.)
Becoming angry at friends and family who seem to have “moved on”

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Depression
Excessive weight loss or gain
Clinging desperately to the old way of life; being unable to move forward
Spending all of one’s time traveling so one can return home as much as possible
Being unable to integrate into one’s new environment, even after an extended time
Reluctance to attach to anyone in the new situation so one can avoid experiencing the same hurt again

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Feigned happiness
Drinking or overeating in private
Disparaging the old home verbally (despite really loving and missing it)
Speaking to loved ones in an overly bright tone of voice
Mementos being placed in prominent positions or showing signs of overuse and wear

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Nostalgia](#), [Sadness](#), [Depressed](#), [Anxiety](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Indifference](#), [Resignation](#), [Satisfaction](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Ache, complain, covet, crave, cry, grieve, languish, long for, miss, mope, mourn, oversleep, pine away, sigh,

suffer, uproot, weep, yearn

WRITER'S TIP: *Character emotion can be shown to great effect through how they view the world. What attitudes, observations, and judgments can be tied to what they are currently feeling?*

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HOPEFULNESS

DEFINITION: A bright, promising outlook; optimism

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Holding one's breath

Raising the eyebrows and offering a questioning gaze

Leaning in

Clutching at the chest or belly

Muttering *please* repeatedly under the breath

Clasping the hands under the chin (in a prayer gesture)

A face that seems to shine

Gently biting the lip

Covering the mouth with a hand, eyes wide and shining

Taking deep breaths

Wiggling or squirming

Verbalizing the pros, not the cons

Strong eye contact

Smiling

Stiff posture, an air of readiness

Smoothing one's clothing to appear collected or worthy

Nodding along as another speaks

Holding still in expectation

Rapid swallowing and nodding

Chattiness and babbling

The lips parting slightly

Asking others to reaffirm the chances of success

Shifting back and forth

Making promises to convince others of one's worthiness

Offering commitment, to show one's ability to meet expectations

Attentiveness to the tasks or people connected with one's goal

Restlessness

Licking the lips with cautious hope
Exhaling while the eyes look up
A gaze that darts to a symbol of hope (a friend in the know, a table of judges, etc.)

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A flutter in the belly
A lighthearted feeling
Tingling limbs
A jolt through the body (an adrenaline spike)
A floating sensation, like all one's burdens have been removed
Breath that temporarily bottles up in the chest

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A willingness to believe that everything will be all right
A strong awareness of one's surroundings
Thinking positive thoughts
A sense of calm
Focusing on improvement (studying, working extra hard, etc.)
Refusing to consider, speak of, or listen to negatives
Preparing for the best-case scenario

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Hands clasped in prayer, pressed to the lips, eyes closed
Quivering breaths
Shakiness
Tears
A trembling voice
Whimpering

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Locking one's hands together to force them into stillness

Mentally reducing high expectations
Reminding oneself of obstacles or competition
Pressing the palms downward to stave off overconfidence
Keeping one's face blank
Looking down or away

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Eagerness](#), [Excitement](#), [Uncertainty](#),
[Disappointment](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Powerlessness](#), [Discouraged](#), [Doubt](#),
[Anticipation](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Anticipate, aspire, await, babble, beam, beg, build, chatter, cheer, desire, dream, jabber, pledge, quiver, radiate, smile, sparkle, strive, tremble

WRITER'S TIP: *Force your characters to make choices between bad and worse. Readers will empathize with your character, remembering their own past when they faced a similar dilemma.*

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HORROR

DEFINITION: A mixture of repugnance and fear arising from a negative experience beyond one's comprehension or imagining

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

The body freezing mid-movement
One's mouth falling open, the upper lip curling back
Grimacing and wanting to look away but being unable to
The head recoiling from the source, eyes wide and staring
One's words drying up mid-sentence
Opening the mouth to speak but being unable to find words
Trying to make sense of what one is experiencing by reading other people's reactions
Speaking in fragments: *This...He...Why...*
Shaking the head in a slow, back-and-forth sweep of denial
The neck disappearing as shoulders rise and pull forward
Placing trembling fingertips against one's open mouth
Eyebrows folding inward, the nose crinkling
Gripping one's own throat or pressing a hand against the breastbone
Swallowing rapidly
Retreating; putting distance between oneself and the source
A slow intake of uneven breath (shuddery or shaky)
Turning the head to the side with the eyes tightly closed
Shielding the body (turning the torso to the side, crossing one's arms over one's chest, etc.)
Clamping a hand across one's mouth and applying pressure
Stumbling back a step or two
Tripping and falling as one tries to create some distance
Pushing the back of the hand against one's nose and looking away
Holding a shaking hand up between oneself and the source
Eyes that are unable to close

Cringing and rubbing one's palm against the chest (above one's heart)
The body contorting (knees drawing up, the torso twisting, arms pulling in, etc.)

Scraping one's palms against clothing as if to rid them of something

Rubbing or pulling at the ears (if a sound is part of the experience)

Clapping the hands over the sides of one's head to block out a specific noise

Forcing oneself to look down or to the side, breaking eye contact

Taking a deep breath to try and regain control of one's emotions

Trying to verbally diffuse the moment (reasoning, bargaining, or placating) by talking slowly and enunciating one's words

Moving slowly, using no sudden movements

Pulling loved ones close (gathering children, drawing a spouse near) to protect them

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Internal chest pressure from forgetting to breathe

Body tension (e.g., the stomach hardening)

The burn of bile in the back of the throat

An uncontrollable shudder that sweeps through one's entire body

A sudden drop in body temperature

A hard thudding in the chest from an increased heart rate

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Losing track of spatial awareness (fumbling, clumsiness, stumbling, etc.)

Focusing on something small (like breathing) to feel more in control

Sudden revelations (putting together pieces of information that would have foreshadowed the negative experience, if one had only realized their significance)

A hyper-focus on the possible dangers associated with this moment (survival instinct)

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Breaths coming in short bursts once the initial shock passes

A loosening of the bladder

Shutting down and freezing on the spot

Uncontrolled tears sliding down one's cheeks and onto trembling lips

Looking for an escape

Turning and fleeing

A heart attack

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

A hard, visible swallow as one's lips press tight

A slight tremor in the fingertips

A voice that warbles before it steadies

Adopting a strained smile that twitches as it widens, fighting for mind over body

Nervous laughter

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Terror](#), [Powerlessness](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Fear](#), [Disgust](#), [Hatred](#), [Desperation](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Clench, conceal, convulse, cringe, flee, freeze, gag, gasp, grip, nauseate, quiver, recoil, reject, repress, retreat, seize, shake, shrink, shudder, stare

WRITER'S TIP: *Too much self-awareness can hurt emotional descriptions. Rarely do people think about the mechanics of what their bodies are doing (I felt my lungs swell with unspent breath), so weigh description more on showing a character's reactions and behaviors naturally as they happen.*

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HUMBLER

DEFINITION: An awareness of one's lowly or modest status

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

- Ducking one's head
- Dropping the chin to the chest
- Squeezing the eyes shut
- Taking a step back
- Standing behind others
- Covering the eyes with one's hands
- Standing with hands on hips and the head bowed
- Giving a slow nod, as if acknowledging the truth of the situation
- Running the hands through one's hair and turning away
- Steepling the fingers in front of one's mouth
- Speaking in a quieter voice than normal
- Getting choked up
- Tilting the head back and blinking quickly to keep from crying
- Not defending oneself
- Letting others be in the spotlight; not calling attention to oneself
- Shaking the head and exhaling loudly through the nose
- Mashing the lips together in frustration
- Going very still
- Pacing in the background, away from others
- Making one's body small
- Crossing the arms
- Fidgeting and fiddling with things, such as buttons, coins, hair, or earrings
- Wincing
- Not looking other people in the eye
- Tense jaw muscles
- Clenched teeth

Walking in slow, small circles

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Tightness in the chest

A dropping sensation in the belly

The throat squeezing shut

Prickling eyes

Nausea roiling in the pit of the stomach

Tense muscles

MENTAL RESPONSES:

The mind racing as one tries to come to grips with what has happened

The mind going blank as new information changes the perception of oneself and one's path forward

Suspended disbelief

Self-berating thoughts

Wanting to hide

Replaying the humbling moment on a loop in one's mind

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Doubting oneself

Self-isolation (if shame is a factor)

Avoiding the place where the humbling situation occurred

No longer participating in that activity, even if it was one's passion

Letting one's physical appearance go

Risk-aversion

Avoiding the spotlight

Being overly critical of oneself

Perfectionism (to avoid being humbled again)

Hyper-focusing on the humbling activity to prove one's worth in that area

Renewed determination and an evolved outlook

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Denying the truth of what happened
Hatred or rage toward the person doing the humbling
Making excuses for what happened
Laughing off what happened as if it was no big deal
Overcompensating
Striving to prove oneself repeatedly to others
Having a cocky attitude

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Resentment](#), [Defensiveness](#), [Denial](#),
[Humiliation](#), [Devastation](#), [Regret](#), [Shame](#), [Self-Loathing](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Resignation](#), [Gratitude](#), [Determination](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Abase, acknowledge, admit, apologize, astound, aver, awe, blunder, botch, bungle, chasten, concede, confess, congratulate, deflate, fall short, flop, flub, fumble, lapse, misstep, own up, recant, recognize, screw up, slip, stoop, wallow

WRITER'S TIP: *Does your character have a bad habit, mannerism, or tic that occurs when they're trying to hide emotion from others? If so, show this when they're working to hold back their true feelings.*

HUMILIATION

DEFINITION: Feeling degraded or mortified, worthless or cheap

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

The body collapsing in on itself

A bowed head

Shoulders curling over the chest

Angling one's torso away from others

Uncontrollable shuddering or shivering

Hair hanging in the face, hiding the eyes

A downward gaze

A flushed face

A hitching chest

Dull and lifeless eyes

Pulling down a shirt hem (covering gesture)

Body shielding (if one is holding onto an object)

Hands clutching at the stomach

Covering the face with the hands

The bottom lip or chin trembling

Whimpering

A bobbing Adam's apple

Arms falling to the sides, lifeless

Uncontrolled tears

Flinching at noises or from being touched

Huddling or crouching

Trying to cover one's body with one's hands

The neck bending forward

Slow and jerky movements; walking stiffly

Knees that are locked tightly together

A loss of coordination

Cold sweat

Stumbling and staggering
Backing up against a wall, sliding into a corner, or hiding
Visible tremors coursing through the body
Hands gripping the elbows
Pigeon toes (standing with the toes tilted inward)
Sobs trapped in the throat
Drawing the knees up to the body's core
Wrapping one's arms around oneself
A runny nose

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Weakness in the legs
A sluggish heartbeat
Pain in the chest and throat
Rapid swallowing
Dizziness; a sense of vertigo
A squeezing sensation in the ribs
Loose muscles, the body feeling broken
The skin tightening (a "crawling" sensation)
Hot eyes and cheeks
Nausea

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Self-loathing
Shattered thoughts; feeling disillusioned by a lack of human decency
A feeling of nakedness, of being on display
A need to hide or flee that supersedes all else
Thoughts desperately racing for a way to end the experience

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Curling up on the floor
Hiding behind or against something

Crying, blubbing, hitching sobs
Wanting to escape by any means
A desire to die, for the emotional pain to end

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Numbness in the mind and body
Becoming passive and disengaged
Closing off all thoughts of what is happening
Not speaking or making any sound
Sending the mind “somewhere else”

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Depressed](#), [Regret](#), [Shame](#), [Rage](#), [Hatred](#),
[Vengeful](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Apprehension](#), [Nervousness](#), [Confusion](#),
[Embarrassment](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Cower, cringe, dissemble, escape, flee, flinch, hide, lurch, retreat, shake, shrink, stammer, stoop, stumble, stutter, topple, wince, wither

WRITER’S TIP: *Add conflicting emotions for a richer experience. A character might feel excitement and pride at purchasing their first car, yet worry that they might be extending themselves too far financially. This inner conflict helps to humanize a character to the reader.*

HURT

DEFINITION: Suffering mental pain; feeling wounded or aggrieved

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Eyes widening, yet the brows are furrowed

Swallowing hard

Lowering the head, the neck appearing to shrink

A slow, disbelieving headshake

A trembling chin

The mouth falling open

Flinching, starting

Color draining from the face

Saying *How could you?* as an accusation

Verbalizing betrayal in a strangled tone: *Leave me alone!*

Hunching over, as if choking down a sob

Pressing a fist to the lips

Biting down on one's bottom lip

Gripping a fistful of one's shirt at the chest level

Holding a hand up, warding others off

Clutching the stomach

The body crumpling in on itself

A hitching chest

Drooping shoulders

Weakness in the knees

An uneven step

Displaying poor balance and coordination

A hand pressing against the throat or breastbone

Stuttering, choking out words

Letting out a whimper

Eyes that water

The mouth opening but no words forming

Sending someone a long, pained look and then breaking eye contact
A hanging head
Retracting the arms, bringing them close to the torso
Stumbling back a step
Retreating or spinning away
A grimace that lingers
Offering a cutting remark: *Wow. Family doesn't mean much these days, does it?*
Clutching at oneself, elbows pressed to the sides

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Dizziness
The stomach hardening
Nausea
A painful tightness in one's throat
Constricting lungs, making it hard to breathe
One's heartbeat seeming to slow or stop momentarily
Weakening muscles
A trembling in the limbs
Spots flashing in one's vision

MENTAL RESPONSES:

The sense that time has stopped
Thoughts spinning, focusing inward
Shock and disbelief
Dredging up history, trying to understand how it led here
Questioning one's beliefs and relationships (disillusionment)

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

A sense of betrayal that rocks the mind to the very core
A collapse in body posture
Tears, sobbing

Running away

Reacting with anger (screaming, slapping, hitting, hurling insults, etc.)

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Visible swallowing

Unnatural stiffness

Pinching the lips tight to keep them from trembling

Tensing the body to ward off shaking

Lifting the chin

Forcing oneself to maintain eye contact or offer a frozen smile

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Depressed](#), [Anguish](#), [Betrayed](#), [Anger](#), [Rage](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Confusion](#), [Stunned](#), [Insecurity](#), [Self-Pity](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Argue, attack, collapse, crumple, defend, dissolve, fight, flinch, reject, shout, shrink, sob, squabble, tremble, whimper, withdraw, yell

WRITER'S TIP: *A natural way to describe a character's appearance is to show them interacting with their environment. A sense of movement also allows this type of description to flow with the scene as it progresses.*

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HYSTERIA

DEFINITION: An excess of emotion resulting in extreme responses and a loss of control

NOTES: This entry refers to the emotion rather than the hysteria associated with psychological disorders.

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Screaming or yelling

Uncontrollable sobbing

Heavy breathing

Flared nostrils

Flushed skin

Sweat breaking out on the skin

Eyes wide open, with the white showing all around the iris

Closing the eyes and covering the ears to block out all stimuli

Vehement head shaking

Hands clenching into fists

Stamping one's feet

Pounding one's fists against one's thighs

Pulling at one's hair

Muttering or screaming the same words over and over: *It's not true, This isn't happening, He's all right*, etc.

Screaming oneself hoarse

Thrashing about in a way that could cause harm

Veins standing out in the face or neck

Flapping the hands

Falling to the ground

Throwing oneself down (on a couch, bed, the ground, etc.)

A bent posture, as if protecting oneself

Jerking away from nearby people or surfaces

Clinging to or hanging onto people
Passing out
Attacking the bearer of bad news (if bad news triggered the hysteria)
Verbally denying the bad news
Curling into the fetal position
Hugging one's knees and rocking back and forth
Hyperventilating and being unable to speak coherently

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Elevated heart rate and pulse
Muscles going limp
Seeing spots
Feeling like one can't get enough oxygen; shortness of breath
Narrowed senses (decreased range of vision, hearing loss, etc.)
The sensation of being squeezed; feeling physical pressure

MENTAL RESPONSES:

An inability to listen to reason
A complete lack of regard for what others think (loss of inhibition)
Not noticing what's going on in the immediate environment (not hearing people calling one's name or touching one's arm, etc.)
Recognizing the loss of control but not knowing how to rein it in
The mind jumping from one thought immediately to another
Feeling separated from one's body and viewing oneself from an external vantagepoint

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Exhaustion that could lead to a physical collapse
Experiencing a mental break
Losing one's voice
Sleeping for a long period of time
Muscle soreness

Bruising and body aches from having to be physically restrained by others

Burst blood vessels in the eyes

Suffering a heart attack

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

By its definition, hysteria cannot be controlled; therefore, it cannot be suppressed.

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Rage](#), [Denial](#), [Overwhelmed](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Anxiety](#), [Fear](#), [Sadness](#), [Agitation](#), [Unease](#), [Confusion](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Accuse, beat, bruise, claw, cling, clutch, collapse, crack up, crumple, cry, curl, drop, faint, flail, flinch, gasp, go to pieces, grab, grip, huddle, jerk, keel over, lose it, lunge, sag, scream, shout, shriek, sob, spit, startle, thrash, wail, yell

WRITER'S TIP: *Characters in a heightened emotional state have their senses dialed up. Describing an awareness of a sound, smell, taste, etc. they may not otherwise notice is a good way to show this.*

IMPATIENCE

DEFINITION: Feeling restless or short-tempered; having a desire for immediate change, relief, or gratification

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Raising one's eyebrows
Placing the hands on the hips
Scowling
Tilting the head back and looking upward
Crossing the arms
Standing or sitting stiffly
A tapping foot
Folding the hands
Pursing one's lips
Fiddling with cuffs or jewelry
Glancing repeatedly at the clock
Pacing
A hard jaw line (clenched teeth)
A jutting chin
Clicking one's fingernails against a table
Fidgeting instead of sitting or standing still
Narrowing the eyes; having an intense focus
Talking over others
Compressing the lips while someone else speaks
Being unnerved by annoying stimuli, such as loud breathing or the clicking of a pen
Frowning
A sharp tone
Massaging the temples, as if weary
Pinching the bridge of the nose and squeezing the eyes tight
Attention that snaps toward sound or movement

Door-watching (or clock-watching, email-watching, etc.)
Complaining under the breath: *Where is he?* or *This is taking too long!*
Whining, grumbling, or pouting (small children)
Letting out a loud breath
Moving about (sitting and then standing, choosing a different chair,
etc.)
Toying with items (turning a cup, mangling a paperclip, etc.)
Shaking the head and muttering
Pushing sleeves up or down (and repeating)
Tilting the head to the ceiling and letting out a heavy sigh
Uncrossing and re-crossing the legs
Tension in the face, shoulders, and neck
Using the body to nudge, push, or block (line jumpers)
Repeatedly running the hands through the hair
Veiled anger or light sarcasm

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Breathing that grows heavier, louder
Rising body temperature
Feeling exhausted or strained to the limits
Headaches

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Mentally berating a time-waster
Wishing time would speed up
Running through how to do something faster or more efficiently
One's attention straying to other things
Asserting mental restraint to avoid snapping

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Slapping a hand against the table
Yelling or barking orders

Cutting people off
Taking over a project or duty
Telling the speaker to move on and get to the point
Redirecting the focus to allow things to proceed better
Setting a time limit
Making demands
Resorting to the physical (pushing, shoving, etc.)

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

A frozen smile
Going for a walk
Using the time to run an errand or complete a task
Attempting to distract oneself to maintain patience
Rooting in a purse or pocket as a distraction
Checking and rechecking a phone for messages
Fussing with one's appearance (brushing away lint, checking one's fingernails, etc.)

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Irritation](#), [Frustration](#), [Anger](#), [Scorn](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Resignation](#), [Acceptance](#), [Satisfaction](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Bemoan, complain, distract, fiddle, fidget, fret, gripe, grumble, hover, interrupt, jiggle, manipulate, mumble, pace, sigh, start, take over, wince

WRITER'S TIP: *Never let the reader notice the writing. Overusing metaphors, similes, descriptive terms, and repeated body language can pull the reader out of the story.*

INADEQUATE

DEFINITION: A persistent feeling of shame and self-doubt due to the perception that one is inferior to others

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

A lack of eye contact; often looking down or to the side when being spoken to

Hiding one's hands in one's pockets

Avoiding the spotlight (staying on the fringes, supporting rather than leading, etc.)

Not contributing to conversation (out of a fear of revealing one's inferiority)

Hesitating before speaking

Stumbling over one's words

Blushing

A caved-in chest and overall poor posture

Acting to impress others, seeking flattery and validation

Overpreparing (practicing a speech to death, having an answer for all possible questions in advance, always making a back-up plan, studying every angle, over-packing, etc.)

Asking others for advice and opinions because one doesn't trust one's own

Giving in (or giving up) when challenged by another

Fidgeting at the feeling that all one's flaws are on display (shifting position, tugging at one's clothing, crossing and uncrossing the legs)

Apologizing when it is not necessary or expected

Words drying up because one feels inferior to others in the conversation

Folding the arms in front of oneself; forming a barrier

Hands that shake slightly (especially when others are watching)

Standing with a narrow stance and hunched shoulders, taking up less space

Slouching and rubbing the back of the neck

Holding the hands in front of the body in a shielding position

Covering one's lap with the hands

A too-brief or weak handshake

Verbalizing one's stupidity over miniscule mistakes: *I can't believe it—I'm such an idiot!*

Crossing the arms and the legs

Dressing carefully and obsessing over details to mask one's inferiority within the group

Deflecting compliments by pointing out what one should have done better

Procrastinating on things that could determine one's sense of worth

Avoiding confrontation by backing down even if one believes one is in the right

Trying to hide one's flaws (styling one's hair to cover a birthmark, for example)

Hurting oneself as punishment for a perceived failing (hidden pinch marks, fingernail indentations in the skin, scratches, etc.)

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Nausea

A racing heartbeat (anxiety-induced)

Raised body temperature that leads to sweating

A dry mouth

Light-headedness

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Feeling like an impostor

Fleeting thoughts of unhappiness when the inner focus on one's failings kicks in

Mentally running oneself down; having a critical inner voice

Holding oneself to impossibly high standards that one would never place on another

Having a hard time sharing one's ideas (due to the assumption that they're flawed)

Constantly comparing oneself to others (over wealth, success, beauty, talents, the ability to fill a specific role properly, etc.) and feeling shame at coming up short

Never enjoying personal wins, instead focusing on what one should have done better

Not pursuing a meaningful goal by labeling it as out of reach for "someone like me"

Craving praise yet feeling unworthy of it when it happens

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Becoming tongue-tied

Second guessing one's choices, actions, and decisions

Growing upset at even the lightest amount of criticism (sensitivity)

Punishing oneself for a perceived poor performance

Self-isolation

A brain that won't turn off (obsessing about small things), causing insomnia

Ulcers and other stress-caused illnesses

Performance anxiety; avoiding social situations

Setting one's sights low (underachieving at work) to avoid revealing the inadequacy

Accepting mistreatment because one believes it is deserved (toxic relationships)

Wanting to hide or flee and then mentally ridiculing oneself for being weak

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Perfectionistic tendencies (working long hours, trying to excel at everything, etc.)

Pushing oneself to keep up with peers and competition

Collecting accomplishments and accolades but not enjoying them

Judging worth by results rather than effort

Unnecessarily pointing out one's importance or level of prestige to others

False bravado; overcompensating through dominance or loudness

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Worthlessness](#), [Depressed](#), [Self-Pity](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Conflicted](#), [Longing](#), [Determination](#), [Acceptance](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Compare, cower, criticize, crouch, discard, distort, dwell, fail, fixate, judge, lack, limit, mumble, reject, shrug, slump, stumble, subjugate, worry

WRITER'S TIP: *Restraint is something characters shed when their emotions are fired up. Showing a character's progression as they lose control of their behavior and words makes for great reading.*

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INDIFFERENCE

DEFINITION: A state of apathy, casualness, or disinterest

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Shoulders are lowered and loose

A slow, steady gait

Arms hanging limply at the sides

Shrugging half-heartedly

Long pauses before responding

Staring blankly or emotionlessly

Lifting a hand loosely, palm up, in a *Who cares?* gesture

Placing hands in one's pockets

Leaning back or away

Looking sleepy or glazed

Speaking in a flat voice

Smiling politely, not genuinely

The body sagging while seated, lacking tension

A wandering gaze

Picking at lint, scratching at cuticles, etc., to show that interest is lacking

Closing one's eyes to shut everything out

Texting during an event or while someone speaks

Not bothering to answer someone's questions

Being unresponsive during a group discussion or debate

Ignoring something being handed over (a file, business card, etc.)

Turning away

A nonchalant attitude

Speaking only when one is spoken to

Not responding to jokes or personal exchanges

Pointedly ignoring another person or situation that draws others in

Relaxed posture

An unhurried exit

Focusing on one's shoe, scuffing at the ground, etc., rather than giving due attention

Responding with *Whatever* or *So?*

Randomly changing the topic

Yawning

Mimicking boredom (slumping in one's seat, tapping a pencil, etc.)

Half-lidded eyes

Muttering *Uh-huh* or *Yeah* when it seems appropriate

Being easily distracted by other things (TV, a girl walking past, etc.)

Choosing brainless activities to pass the time (TV bingeing, scrolling through memes, etc.)

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A lack of energy

Slow, even breaths

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Zoning or tuning others out to concentrate on other things

Wandering thoughts

A lack of empathy

Thinking about the time or future events

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

A disconnect with one's life or society

A fading sense of empathy

Falling into a routine

Meaningless interaction with others

Finding little day-to-day joy

Ignoring the pain or suffering of others

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Smiling and pretending to pay attention
Nodding along as someone speaks but not actively listening
Asking a few token questions
Making an excuse to leave

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Irritation](#), [Annoyance](#), [Contempt](#), [Resignation](#),
[Curiosity](#), [Concern](#), [Discouraged](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Validated](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Detach, dismiss, disregard, drift, flop, forget, glaze, hunch, ignore, loll, neglect, plod, sag, shrug, slack, slouch, slump, snub, stare, wander

WRITER'S TIP: *To create a fluid, emotional arc in your story, make sure your character's feelings build in intensity and complexity as the novel progresses.*

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INSECURITY

DEFINITION: Feeling unsure of oneself or displaying a lack of confidence

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Smoothing down clothing

A self-deprecating laugh

Breaking eye contact and shrugging

Keeping one's hands in one's pockets

Fidgeting

Checking one's breath

Throat-clearing

Visible blushing

Speaking in a too-quiet voice

Licking or biting the bottom lip

Petting or stroking one's hair (comforting gestures)

Covering up (pulling a jacket tighter, holding one's elbows, etc.)

Holding the knees and legs tightly together

Awkwardly mirroring the behavior of others to try and fit in

Choosing loose clothes over tight, revealing ones

Asking for reassurance from others

Brushing off compliments or putting oneself down (self-deprecation)

Looking down while walking

Staying at the edge of a group or seeking the corner of a busy room

Tucking the hands behind the elbows

Twisting one's wrists

Not smiling, or offering a smile that fades quickly

Visible tension in the muscles

Rubbing one's forearms

Needing advice or instruction on what to say or do

Laughing too loudly, or at odd times

Clutching an item, such as a book, binder, or purse, to the chest
Tapping the leg to settle one's nerves
Hiding behind one's hair
Biting one's nails
Staying at a distance, keeping a wide personal buffer of space
Holding a hand close to the face while speaking
Difficulty speaking or offering opinions
Rubbing at one's lips
Wearing too much makeup
Rushing one's speech or speaking in a stammer
Increased sweat output during uncomfortable moments

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A heartbeat that races when one feels confronted
A roiling stomach
Uncontrollable flushes of heat
An uncomfortable, dry throat

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Difficulty making decisions; overthinking problems
Obsessing over one's flaws and shortcomings
Agreeing only to avoid a confrontation or be accepted
Fixating on the talents and strengths of others
Comparing oneself to others and finding oneself lacking

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Holding onto a comfort item (a special piece of jewelry, a picture, etc.)
A bent spine and hunched shoulders
Blushing when one is noticed or spoken to
Avoiding social situations
Acting skittish around people
Panic symptoms when one is put on the spot

Preferring to do things alone
Wearing plain clothing to reinforce invisibility
Difficulty making friends
Choosing a seat in the back of the room or away from others
Seeking interaction online rather than in person

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Tossing the hair
Thrusting the chest out
Standing taller, squaring one's shoulders
Forcing oneself to maintain eye contact
Deflecting questions or concern
Rushing into decisions to prove one's decisiveness
Taking risks
Lying
Inserting oneself into conversations

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Unease](#), [Wariness](#), [Defensiveness](#), [Worry](#),
[Doubt](#), [Intimidated](#), [Embarrassment](#), [Loneliness](#), [Paranoia](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Uncertainty](#), [Nervousness](#), [Unappreciated](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Blend in, blush, conform, doubt, falter, fidget, fret, fuss, hesitate, overcompensate, second-guess, shuffle, stammer, stumble, stutter, waffle, waver, withdraw, worry

WRITER'S TIP: *Scenes do not happen in a vacuum. Don't forget to include setting, thoughts or verbal cues that allude to the passage of time.*

INSPIRED

DEFINITION: Wanting to do or be better—usually because of an external stimulus, such as another person, a work of art, a saying or mantra, etc.

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

The features suddenly going still as the *aha* moment hits

The mouth hanging open

A brightening of the countenance

Wide-open eyes

An inward gaze as one tries to grasp a fleeting idea

Leaping into motion

Extended periods of frenzied activity

Forgetting to eat or sleep

Being highly productive

Breathing quickly

Talking about one's ideas or the source of inspiration to anyone who will listen

Waving the hands around

Pacing while thinking or talking through ideas

Smiling frequently

Leaning in close when talking to others

Having a serious or intense expression

Not responding when one is addressed

Missing appointments

Expressing frustration or impatience with interruptions

Speaking quickly or louder than usual

Drawing diagrams, illustrations, and plans

Making a mess while working (due to not wanting to stop to clean)

An unkempt appearance (wrinkled clothes, a shirt buttoned wrong, hair sticking up, etc.)

- Disappearing for long stretches of time
- Using stimulants (coffee, energy drinks, etc.) to increase one's productivity
- Bouncing on the soles of the feet
- Running to discuss one's idea with someone else
- Talking to oneself to hash out ideas
- Making excuses to get out of obligations and responsibilities one views as less important
- Quickly becoming impatient with people who can't see one's vision

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

- Feeling highly energized
- Feeling jittery (from stimulants, a lack of sleep, etc.)
- A buoyant sensation; lightness
- The heart speeding up as small epiphanies hit

MENTAL RESPONSES:

- Mental clarity
- Being hyper-focused
- Turning inward (to avoid distraction)
- The mind constantly churning, cycling through ideas
- Frustration at not being able to work fast enough to keep up with one's ideas
- Losing track of time
- Forgetfulness
- Relief when personal obligations are lifted (e.g., when a spouse is asleep, one can work late)

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

- Neglecting one's health
- Neglected personal hygiene taken to an extreme (overgrown fingernails, wearing just underwear because one has no clean clothing, etc.)

Sallow skin from not getting enough sunlight
Reddened eyes from lack of sleep
Weight loss
Being unaware of dramatic events going on in the world

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

An unnaturally still countenance and posture
Animated eyes (a darting gaze, frequent blinking, brightness, etc.)
Jittery extremities
Making excuses so one can get back to work on one's ideas
Being easily distracted (as one's mind keeps going to the source of the inspiration)
The lips twitching as though trying to hide a smile

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Euphoria](#), [Obsessed](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Disappointment](#), [Remorse](#), [Self-Pity](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Achieve, admire, arouse, birth, build, challenge, create, develop, devote, drive, emulate, energize, galvanize, generate, incite, invigorate, kindle, motivate, produce, prompt, push, root, rouse, spark, stimulate, stoke, trigger, wonder

WRITER'S TIP: *Common gestures and expressions such as shrugging or frowning are easy to interpret but can lead to lackluster description if they're written "as-is" too often. Customize responses based on the character's personality and comfort zone to paint a fresh image for readers.*

INTIMIDATED

DEFINITION: Feeling afraid or timid due to a real or perceived threat

NOTES: When someone is feeling intimidated, their responses will vary depending on whether they lean toward a fight-flight-or-freeze-type response to threats. This entry contains some of each of these reactions.

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

The body shrinking in on itself

Shoulders slumping

The posture sagging

Stepping back from the perceived threat

A darting gaze; not looking people in the eye

A brittle laugh

Hands jammed in the pockets

Arms crossed, hands clenching the upper arms

Hiding behind one's hair, a hoodie, another person, etc.

Shuffling one's feet

Crossing and re-crossing the legs

Fidgeting with a pen, one's hair, papers on the desk, etc.

Becoming very still (to avoid attention)

A furrowed brow as one tries to figure out what to do or say

Biting the lips or nails

Standing back from the group

Not engaging in conversation

The skin flushing or sweating

Stuttering or stammering as one tries to respond

The voice dropping to a mutter or murmur

Fast-blinking eyes

Hands up, in a placating or surrendering gesture

Backpedaling: *Oh, I was just kidding, or I didn't mean anything by it.*

Passing a job or responsibility to someone else instead of taking it on oneself

Taking deep breaths to try and settle one's nerves

Making a quick escape; physically leaving the area

Speaking to others privately afterward to get their take on what happened

Getting in the other person's space

Becoming argumentative

Making passive-aggressive comments

Making oneself look larger: squaring the shoulders, standing as tall as possible, etc.

False bravado (getting louder, making empty threats, etc.)

Hands tightening into fists

Flinching but holding one's ground

Publicly blowing off the threat

A muscle tic developing along the jawline

A flinty or hard gaze

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

The mouth going dry

Weakness in the muscles

A tightness in the chest

An increased heartrate

A spike of adrenaline

One's focus narrowing in on the threat

The senses becoming more acute

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A desire to either escape or go on the defensive

Thoughts racing as one tries to make sense of what's happening

The mind cycling through possible responses

Frantically trying to think of something to say to prove one's credibility or capability

Cataloguing possible escape routes or plans

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Sucking up to the threat

Not taking risks; sticking with what's safe

Keeping one's opinions or ideas to oneself

Not speaking when the threat is near

Agreeing with the threat on everything; losing one's sense of self

Self-loathing

Co-dependency

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Becoming defensive when the threat is present or mentioned

Overcompensating

Regaining a sense of power by belittling someone else

Avoiding the threat

Surrounding oneself with "yes" men or people who will provide affirmation

A marked change in behavior when one is around the threat

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Insecurity](#), [Emasculated](#), [Fear](#), [Humiliation](#), [Resignation](#), [Anxiety](#), [Bitterness](#), [Contempt](#), [Defensiveness](#), [Denial](#), [Anger](#), [Paranoia](#), [Powerlessness](#), [Self-Loathing](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Indifference](#), [Hurt](#), [Regret](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Abandon, abase, avoid, backpedal, brownnose, bumble, challenge, cower, doubt, evade, faze, flee, fluster, grovel, hem and haw, hesitate, kowtow, pressure, quail, repress, retreat, shrink, stammer, stumble, surrender, withdraw

WRITER'S TIP: *If you need to show a wide personality divide between clashing characters, try to show them responding with vastly different emotions to the same situation or event.*

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IRRITATION

DEFINITION: Impatience and displeasure; the sense of being bothered

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

The lips pressing together, pursing, or flattening

Features tightening

Narrowing the eyes; squinting or tilting the head down while making eye contact

Rubbing the back of the neck

Watching the source furtively

Frowning

Crossing one's arms

Pulling or plucking at clothing as if it chafes

Fidgety movements (scraping the hair back, curling one's fingers, etc.)

Adopting a challenging tone

A hard smile

Poking a tongue lightly into the cheek and inhaling a long breath

Asking pointed questions

Changing the subject

Forcing a laugh

Raising the voice

Opening the mouth to say something, then thinking better of it

Biting the inside of the cheek

Restless legs (crossing and uncrossing, unable to stand still, etc.)

Going silent; disengaging from conversation

Feigning interest in other things to buy time and regain control

Making small, jittery movements with the fingers

Breathing through the nose (audibly to others)

Curling one's toes

Clasping the hands tightly so the knuckles turn white

Interrupting people

Repeating a mannerism (scratching an eyebrow, adjusting glasses, etc.)

Spots of color entering the cheeks

Clenching one's teeth

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Tightness in the chest

Tense muscles

Sensitive skin

A quickened pulse

A twitchy feeling in the extremities

Raised body temperature

Tightness in the jaw and facial muscles, causing discomfort

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Dismissing the source as unworthy

Trying to put the upsetting information out of one's mind

A desire to talk the situation over with someone else

Wishing someone would stop or shut up

Stubbornly sticking to one's belief, even if it doesn't make sense

Clouded judgment

Judging others and their performance or contribution

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Openly challenging another's logic or standpoint

Swearing

Negative language: *You don't know what you're talking about!*

Sarcasm

Name-calling or side insults: *Can you stop that? It's like working with a two-year-old!*

Facial tics

Rising blood pressure

Snapping and saying something that offends others or damages a relationship

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Avoiding the source

Two-faced behavior

Nitpicking

Passive-aggressive comments

Forcing oneself to not look at or acknowledge the source

Leaving the room or situation to clear one's thoughts

Seeking to discredit the source so one won't have to believe him or her

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Resentment](#), [Frustration](#), [Anger](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Annoyance](#), [Indifference](#), [Relief](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Bark, call out, chafe, clench, exhale, frown, glare, gripe, grit, grumble, huff, judge, mutter, snap, squeeze, squirm, stiffen, swear, tense, twitch

WRITER'S TIP: *Make body language unique to the character. Do they lift themselves up in their shoes as they wait in line? Do they run a finger along the seam of their jeans when they're deep in thought? Creative emotional mannerisms help characters leap off the page.*

JEALOUSY

DEFINITION: Hostility toward a rival or one suspected of enjoying an advantage

NOTES: The advantage can be a person, an object, or an intangible (love, success, etc.)

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

- Adopting a sullen look
- Making a slight growl or noise in the throat
- Bitterness at seeing others respond positively to the rival
- Quick, sharp movements (swiping tears from the cheeks, shoving hair out of the eyes, etc.)
- Pursing or pressing one's lips flat
- Crossing the arms in front of the chest
- Clenching one's teeth
- Muttering unkind things under one's breath
- Starting rumors; acting catty
- Picking on someone weaker to gain a sense of power and control
- Sneering
- Ugly laughter
- Shouting insults and calling names
- Taking a step closer, fists clenched
- A visible flush in the cheeks
- A pinched expression
- Tight muscles
- One's body mimicking that of the rival
- Trying to "one-up" the other person
- Issuing a challenge to the rival that contains an element of risk
- Criticism
- Spitting in the direction of the rival

Swearing
Kicking at nearby objects
Showing off
Pulling stunts or pranks to regain attention
Rudeness; saying something that is a low blow
Reckless behavior
Gloating when the rival falters or shows weakness

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A burning sensation in the chest or stomach
The stomach hardening
Breaths coming coarser, faster
Spots or flashes in one's vision
A pain in the jaw from clenching one's teeth

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A desire to vent and voice the rival's unworthiness to others
Rash decision making (quitting a team, storming out of a party, etc.)
A flash of anger when the rival is mentioned
A desire to discredit the rival or take away their power
Wishing harm or desiring revenge
Turmoil at having negative feelings
Focusing solely on the rival's negative attributes
Imagining how others view oneself in comparison to the rival
Rejecting the advantage (choosing to pursue another girl or guy instead)

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Jeering, running someone down, bullying
Picking fights
An unhealthy obsession with the rival
Indulging in petty crime (keying the rival's car, etc.)

Engaging in self-mutilation as a release
Negativity spilling into other parts of one's life
Self-doubt; a lack of confidence
A relationship categorized by negativity, passive-aggression, and criticism
Feeling fake from wearing two faces for so long
Dishonesty with oneself and others
A pattern of subversively trying to undermine the rival, thereby lowering them in the eyes of others

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Acting normal to the rival's face but talking negatively behind their back
Watching the rival furtively, privately
Striving to also excel at whatever is desired
Grouping with others who also lack whatever is desired
Kissing up to gain approval through association
Trying not to focus on the rival
Telling oneself that it doesn't matter
Attempting to think positive thoughts about the rival

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Envy](#), [Determination](#), [Contempt](#), [Desperation](#), [Anger](#), [Vengeful](#), [Hatred](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Dissatisfaction](#), [Self-Pity](#), [Resignation](#), [Remorse](#), [Shame](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Avoid, burn, conceal, covet, crave, damage, disparage, entrap, fantasize, gloat, hack, insult, leer, lure, mock, obsess, pine, provoke, pursue, resent, sabotage, scorn, seduce, slander, snap, snarl, spoil, subvert, undermine, want, yearn

WRITER'S TIP: *In each scene, think about the lighting. Full sunlight, muddy clouds washing everything in grey, the onset of sunset or even darkness...light and shadow can affect a character's mood, amp their stress level or even work against their goals.*

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LONELINESS

DEFINITION: The feeling of being isolated or cut off

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

A longing gaze

Disinterest in one's appearance (bland clothing, lackluster hair, etc.)

Being meticulous with one's appearance in hopes of attracting interest

Slumped shoulders

Limp posture

A monotone voice

Looking down when walking in public

Watching people furtively

An expressionless, unsmiling face

Sullenness

Being generous in hopes of currying favor

Spying or eavesdropping on others to feel a part of something

Filling one's schedule with work or volunteering to avoid downtime

Using books, the Internet, and TV to escape

An expression that crumples at other people's affection displays

Hugging oneself

A lack of eye contact

False bravado

Tears, sadness

A heavy sigh

Talking to oneself

Feeling a sense of comfort from a full mailbox—even if it's full of junk mail

Stroking oneself (e.g., rubbing an arm absently for contact)

Using bright or eccentric clothing choices to get attention or to stay upbeat

Doting on someone or something (a neighbor, a pet, etc.)

Talking to strangers to feel connected

Asking questions out of a desire to converse rather than because of curiosity

Relishing opportunities to talk or engage (e.g., when the mail is delivered)

Rambling when conversing with others

Trying out dating apps and the like

Adhering to a routine (eating the same meals, visiting the same park, etc.)

Buying oneself gifts or small indulgences to boost one's mood

Living vicariously through an alter ego or avatar (via social networking, gaming, etc.)

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A thickness in the throat, signaling the onset of tears

A longing so intense it manifests itself as an ache or pain

Insomnia

Fatigue

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Avoiding crowds, large events, or social situations

A desire to be included or wanted

Anger and bitterness

Daydreaming about people one would like to have relationships with

A feeling of unworthiness

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Doubting oneself; a lack of confidence

Weight gain

Believing that one is unattractive or has a boring personality

Uncontrollable crying bouts

Despairing of ever being able to change

High blood pressure
Workaholic tendencies
Bingeing to compensate (eating, drinking, shopping, gambling, etc.)
Hoarding pets
Suicidal thoughts

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Committing too quickly to anyone who shows interest
Choosing negative relationships over being alone
Being too friendly and coming across as desperate
Frequently calling family or friends
Solitary activities that show a craving for contact (e.g., people-watching from the porch)

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Resignation](#), [Sadness](#), [Hurt](#), [Depressed](#), [Anger](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Insecurity](#), [Unappreciated](#), [Neglected](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Ache, avoid, binge, cling, cope, cry, deflect, dodge, dote, drag, droop, eavesdrop, emulate, endure, fake, fantasize, hide, indulge, languish, laze, long, mirror, mope, numb, plod, pretend, sidestep, slouch, slump, stoop, weep, wish, yearn

WRITER'S TIP: *Body movements should never be random. Everything a character does should have a specific intent: to achieve an end, reveal emotion, or to characterize.*

LONGING

DEFINITION: Urgently wanting something that one has yet to obtain

NOTES: While the object of a character's longing is often another person, it can also be anything else, even something intangible. For instance, they might long to escape a boring job, mend something broken in society, or learn more about their culture. For detailed information on the longing associated with people, please see the DESIRE entry.

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Closing one's eyes

Taking deep breaths

Staring out the window

Daydreaming

Smiling wistfully

The lips parting

An inward gaze

Absently toying with a necklace, ring, or other comfort item

Running a finger along the edge of a shirt collar

Long periods of stillness and quiet, as one's thoughts turn inward

Speaking in a soft voice about the subject of one's longing

The voice taking on a wistful tone

Rubbing a palm over one's heart

Throwing oneself into hobbies or work to distract oneself

Frequently losing the thread of conversations

Not noticing the things in one's environment

A waning interest in passions and interests one used to enjoy

Spending time alone

Researching the area of longing (e.g., visiting travel sites, looking into educational courses, frequenting forums where like-minded people are discussing a topic, etc.)

Talking to others about how to set a course that will lead to eventual fulfillment

Being in a group but not really engaging; the mind being elsewhere

Insomnia

Loss of appetite (or forgetting to eat)

Facial features brightening when the longed-for subject is broached

Making plans to acquire what one longs for

Talking often about the thing one wants

Looking at pictures, videos, or other mementos that represent what one longs for

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A weight in the chest

Heavy limbs

Heartache

A dulling of the senses

One's nerves firing all at once when the object of one's desire is within grasp

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Tuning out distractions in order to concentrate on one's goals

Frustration with any barriers keeping one from one's desire

Daydreaming or fantasizing about what one wants

Desperation, as if one's dreams will never come true

The sense that time is passing very slowly

Difficulty focusing on other things

Thinking obsessively about the thing one wants

Deliberately cutting off thoughts about one's desire; trying not to think about it

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Isolation

Depression

Excessive weight loss or gain

Making big changes, such as moving or quitting school, so one can pursue the object

Obsessively pursuing the desire regardless of how futile it is

Sacrificing everything in the pursuit (one's savings, job, self-respect, etc.)

Being unable to enjoy one's blessings

Bitterness and resentment

One's longing turning to contempt and disdain

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Denying one's interest

Avoiding the object of one's desire

Feigning interest in something else to throw people off

Ignoring or scorning what one secretly desires

Forced laughter

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Discouraged](#), [Desperation](#), [Bitterness](#), [Anguish](#), [Excitement](#), [Obsessed](#), [Elation](#), [Satisfaction](#), [Resignation](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Indifference](#), [Curiosity](#), [Admiration](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Ache, aspire, calculate, contrive, covet, crave, desire, hunt, need, notice, pine for, plan, plot, pursue, stalk, strive for, want, watch, woo, yearn

WRITER'S TIP: *When characters are distracted, they miss the obvious, creating perfect pathways to conflict and disaster. Think about how overlooked aspects of a setting, the behavior of others, and important bits of dialogue can lead to complications down the road.*

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LOVE

DEFINITION: Deep affection, attachment, or devotion for another

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Moving to get closer or touch the person

Smiling at nothing

A beaming expression, glowing cheeks

Strong eye contact, with very little blinking

Focusing on the other's best attributes

Taking large, deep, savoring breaths

A yearning look

Unconsciously parting the lips

A light, bouncing step

A silly grin

Laughing and talking nonstop

Leaning against one another

Lying in the other's lap

Using pet names or terms of endearment

Mooning over photos or representations of a love interest

Listening to and connecting with love songs

Adopting a silly love-struck tone when communicating

Nervous behaviors (fiddling with the hands, moistening one's lips, etc.)

Getting tongue-tangled

Saying *I love you*

Pointing one's torso and feet toward the loved one

Playful shoving and grabbing

Sharing secrets and desires

Affectionate touches (stroking an arm, holding hands, kissing, hugging, etc.)

Sitting together so the legs touch

Putting an arm around someone's shoulders

Realigning hobbies or interests to match the other person's
Hooking a hand in the other person's belt or pocket
Ignoring or neglecting other friends to be with the significant other
Writing notes or poetry to the other person
Offering gifts of time, value, or thoughtfulness
Talking to friends about the special person, asking for advice
Obsessively checking the phone to see if the love interest has called
Constant texting back and forth
Doodling hearts and names
Trying to improve one's appearance in some way, by coloring one's hair, working out, etc.
Watching romantic movies

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A fluttering in the stomach, a feeling of emptiness
A racing pulse
The heart beating, banging, or hammering
A hyper-awareness of the body
Weak knees or legs
A tingling or electrical jolt at accidental touches

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Euphoria; pleasure at touching and closeness
Appreciating the world and everything in it
Losing track of time when one is with the other person
Mental fuzziness, distraction, and daydreaming
Losing awareness of one's surroundings when the love interest is near
Seeking ways to make a loved one proud
Worrying when too much time has passed without contact
A feeling of possessiveness and jealousy
Feeling safe and whole when one is with the other person

A tendency to notice things the love interest would enjoy, even in their absence

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Exchanging personal effects (clothing, jewelry, keys, etc.)
Embracing the love interest's friends as one's own
Sharing finances and possessions
Enduring hardship to be with the love interest or make them happy
Putting the other's needs and desires first
Intimacy
Sharing hopes and dreams; becoming emotionally vulnerable
Future planning that centers around the love interest
Entering into a committed relationship (living together, getting married, etc.)

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Flushed skin
A high-pitched voice
Nervous laughter or giggling
Standing close, yet not touching
Darting glances
Watching from a safe distance
An increased interest in the other person's personal life
Forcibly declaring that nothing's going on: *We're just friends*
An overall brightening of one's mood when the other person enters the room

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Peacefulness](#), [Satisfaction](#), [Desire](#), [Adoration](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Acceptance](#), [Connectedness](#), [Gratitude](#), [Longing](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Beam, canoodle, caress, confide, embrace, encourage, flirt, gaze, grin, kiss, laugh, nurture, nuzzle, ogle, stare, stroke, tease, tingle, touch, trust

WRITER'S TIP: *Sentence structure is especially important when writing descriptions. Varied sentence length keeps the pace moving and makes the flow of sensory detail feel more natural, avoiding a “dry report” feel.*

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LUST

DEFINITION: An intense sexual craving or longing

NOTES: Some displays of lust may be more masculine or feminine in nature, so choose descriptors that best fit your character's personality and preferred sexual expression.

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Deep and prolonged eye contact

Arching the back

Thrusting out one's chest and exposing the neck

Letting one's long hair slide across the shoulder

Trailing a finger toward one's cleavage or open collar while maintaining eye contact

A gaze that explores and suggests

Self-petting gestures (slowly running a hand down a thigh, caressing a forearm, etc.)

Opening one's legs slightly while seated

Pressing oneself against the other person, or allowing oneself to be pulled close

Touching the other's face with the back of the hand and drawing it downward

Running one's palms over the other's sleeves, squeezing the forearms

Leaning in and tilting one's head

Pushing one's lips against another's in a soft stroke or brush, testing the connection

Deepening the kiss (tasting, pushing, quickening, a gentle stroke of the tongue, etc.)

Firmly pulling closer, conveying one's desire and need

Anchoring one's hand on the other's belt, then slipping a finger beneath the waistline fabric

Reaching past a gap between buttons to touch warm skin
Breathing that grows faster and more audible
Running hands through each other's hair or over the chest, stomach,
and back
Fingers that rub and tweak, stroking and squeezing each curve
One's gaze being drawn to the lips
Entwining limbs
Opening one's mouth, panting, or gasping
Closing the eyes to better focus on the intensifying sensations
A grip that grows possessive and more intense
Lips touching and sampling the neck and shoulders, leaving moist
prints and trails
Heads that tip back
Pulling at restrictive clothing to loosen it
Hands that fumble with buttons and zippers, trembling in urgency
Skin tightening or hardening
Cradling the other person's head while kissing them
Lips visiting sensitive places to tease (nipples, earlobes, forearms, the
stomach, etc.)
Teeth playfully dragging at the lower lip during a kiss
Vocalizing (soft sighs, moans, whispered directions or suggestions, etc.)
Bodies pressing against one another to become one
Instinctively grabbing at one's partner (the shoulders, hips, or waist) as
control is lost, muscles shuddering

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Growing hot or feverish
Fluttery sensations in the chest and stomach
Becoming sensitive to touch and moisture
Tingling and pleasure aches flooding the body
A pounding heartbeat
Shivering from pleasure or desire

Growing wet (women) and more sensitive, desiring pressure and friction

Hands that ache with the need to touch and explore

Sexual throbbing and tingling

A sudden flush of warmth that spreads from the groin outward

Shudders of pleasure, and the need to bear down

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Hypersensitivity to smell and touch

Fantasizing about past sexual encounters or imagining new ones

Concentrating one's focus on pleasure centers of the body

An overwhelming desire to join and become one

Thoughts that disappear in the moment of release

Euphoric satisfaction and completeness

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Sexual aggressiveness

Being unable to concentrate on anything but obtaining sexual release

A need to satisfy one's urgings regardless of who one is with, the timing, or location

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Playing out fantasies in one's head

Squirming in one's seat; feeling antsy

Having difficulty concentrating, staying on task, or sleeping

Finding one's gaze being drawn to attractive attributes of suitable partners

Arguing, getting angry over nothing, and other signs of extreme irritability

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Elation](#), [Love](#), [Frustration](#), [Disappointment](#), [Jealousy](#), [Scorn](#), [Bitterness](#), [Shame](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Satisfaction](#), [Desire](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Arouse, bathe, brush, buck, burn, caress, cradle, curl, drift, erupt, explore, flick, flicker, graze, grip, lick, lunge, massage, need, nibble, nip, please, press, pulse, quiver, rock, rub, seize, shiver, shudder, skim, soothe, spiral, squeeze, stroke, suck, sweep, throb, thrust, tilt, tingle, trail, tremble, twist, warm, whisper

WRITER'S TIP: *Curiosity is perfect for revealing deeper layers. What draws one character in may be different for others, so use this feeling to shed light on their personality, interests, and desires.*

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MOODY

DEFINITION: Experiencing unexpected mood swings; feeling emotionally sensitive or temperamental

NOTES: Moodiness can cause either volatile or reserved behavior, so choose the best fit for your character's personality and temperament.

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Crossing one's arms over the chest

Body tenseness (e.g., tightly gripping a backpack strap or one's car keys)

Rubbing one's temples

Restless movements (shuffling one's feet, biting one's nails, twisting a lock of hair, etc.)

Pacing or walking in circles

Crossed legs, with the foot bouncing up and down

Biting the lip

Being highly negative

Glaring at people or staring them down

Taking things wrong (e.g., misreading something that's said) and snapping at people

Raising one's voice

Interrupting others

Rolling the eyes

Blowing out breath in an exaggerated huff

Making annoyed noises in the back of one's throat

Muttering under the breath

Exploding in an angry outburst (yelling or swearing)

Becoming argumentative or picking a fight

Speaking tactlessly and saying things that hurt others

Storming out of the room

Squeezing one's eyes shut to regain control of one's emotions
Blinking back tears or crying at little provocation
A voice that breaks or cracks
Slack posture and an inward look
Refusing to engage in conversation
Trying to release one's emotions (via going for a run or heading to the beach)
Taking big breaths
Sighing
Distracting oneself (with a cell phone or book, by going for a drive, etc.)
Avoiding the people one expects to be frustrating or infuriating
Withdrawing from others

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Eyes prickling with tears
Tightness in the chest
A squeezing in the throat
An ache in the jaw from clenching one's teeth

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Being easily startled; feeling jumpy or jittery
Expecting people to be annoying before they actually are (predicting what people will say, anticipating an irritating habit or gesture, etc.)
Being impatient; getting upset by small setbacks that normally wouldn't be a problem
Being easily frustrated
Difficulty finding things that one wants to do
Being easily hurt by playful or teasing comments (feeling attacked)
An inability to think clearly or see the situation accurately
Being unable to admit wrongdoing; believing that everyone else is to blame

Feeling out of control and responding poorly but not knowing how to stop

Thinking negative thoughts about oneself: *Why am I such a horrible person?* or *No wonder no one wants to be around me.*

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Headaches or migraines

Stomach pains and ulcers

Insomnia

Driving loved ones away, leading to isolation

Turning to medical aids, drugs, or alcohol as a way of coping

One's school or work performance suffering

Becoming more and more negative in one's thinking

Migrating toward other negative people

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Being passive-aggressive

Putting on a happy face

Exiting a room or situation to avoid becoming angry or bursting into tears

Clamming up

Taking a background role; letting others be in charge

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Irritation](#), [Anger](#), [Self-Pity](#), [Sadness](#), [Hurt](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Agitation](#), [Conflicted](#), [Indifference](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Argue, belittle, confront, cry, disrespect, dissolve, explode, flee, flinch, groan, hide, insult, mutter, provoke, sigh, sulk, tear up, tremble, yell

WRITER'S TIP: *If a character is pretending to feel something to fit in or because it is expected, make sure to show hesitation, initial awkwardness, or internal thoughts to emphasize this forced emotion.*

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Moved

DEFINITION: Being deeply stirred emotionally

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

One's hand covering the heart

Eyes glistening

Smiling broadly

Moving slowly

Covering one's eyes

One's chin dropping to the chest

Turning away or stepping outside to get oneself together

Closing the eyes and pulling in an expansive breath

The bottom lip pressing into the upper one and the chin quivering slightly

Pressing one's fingers to the lips

Laying a hand against the breastbone

Speaking in a trembling voice

A voice that cracks with emotion

Letting out an involuntary moan or cry

Expressing gratitude (via a letter, with a gift of appreciation, verbally, etc.)

Swiping at tears on one's cheeks

Sweeping someone into a hug

Sharing a nod and meaningful eye contact with the person causing the feeling

A brief loosening of the posture as muscles give out and then "catch"

Grabbing onto someone for support

Collapsing into a chair

Shaking the head in disbelief

Steepling the fingers in front of one's mouth

Sniffing

Wiping one's nose or eyes with a tissue
Difficulty speaking
Hands that tremble slightly
Pressing the lips together, as if trying to contain one's emotion
Rising shakily to one's feet
The skin reddening or turning blotchy
Reaching out to touch someone who is part of the experience
Becoming verbose while expressing gratitude

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A prickle in the nose or behind the eyes
A thickness in the throat
A lightening sensation; feeling as if a load has been lifted
The extremities going numb
Warmth expanding through one's chest
Feeling "jumbled" in the midsection

MENTAL RESPONSES:

An overwhelming sense of relief
Scattered thoughts or an overall foggy mental state
Tunnel vision; not noticing the peripheral things
Being hyper-focused on the person or circumstance responsible for one's emotion
Not caring what other people think about one's emotional response
Experiencing a mixture of emotions (joy, relief, gratitude, surprise, etc.)
and not knowing how to express them

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Passing out
Hyperventilating
Getting hiccups from prolonged crying
Being so energized that one can't sleep

Being so determined to show appreciation that one neglects one's basic needs

Becoming clingy or needy; smothering the recipient of one's gratitude

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

The body going very still

The eyes furiously blinking

Turning away

Biting on the lips

Expressing thanks in a gruff tone of voice

Clearing the throat

Speaking as few words as possible to avoid revealing one's true feelings

Putting space between oneself and the person responsible

Giving a curt nod

One's expression growing stony and hard to read

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Happiness](#), [Gratitude](#), [Overwhelmed](#), [Elation](#), [Euphoria](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Disbelief](#), [Stunned](#), [Relief](#), [Pleased](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Bawl, clasp, collapse, cry, drop, fall, gasp, give out, grasp, hold, hug, ignite, nod, press, quiver, reach, shake, sob, stir, touch, tremble, weep

WRITER'S TIP: *Is your character more introverted or extroverted? Knowing where they are on the spectrum can help indicate how expressive they will be, especially when they're with other characters.*

NEGLECTED

DEFINITION: Feeling ignored, overlooked, or unloved

NOTES: This entry will focus on the effects of emotional neglect, such as being ignored, marginalized, devalued, and sidelined by the important people in one's life.

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

An expression that indicates hurt or confusion

A furrowed brow

Frowning

Wincing

Flinching away from the offending party

An inward gaze

A downcast countenance

Rounded shoulders

Making oneself small (curling up in a chair, standing with the legs tightly together and one's hands clasped in front of the body, etc.)

Leaning away from the person; keeping one's distance

Not speaking up for oneself

Withdrawing from others

Crying

Standing behind others; keeping to the background

Sniffing

Turning away to hide one's hurt

Hugging oneself

Seeking comfort (with another person, with food, by retreating to a safe place, etc.)

Voicing one's dissatisfaction to the one withholding affection or attention

The voice rising or breaking

Nagging, cajoling, or wheedling to get the other person to do what one wants

Placating the other person to win them over

Casting darting glances at the person

Jumping at the first sign of attention

Gazing with longing at people who are receiving what one is missing

Looking askance at the person withholding affection; wanting attention but fearing further rejection

Treading carefully with the other person; not wanting to rock the boat

Speaking loudly or more excitedly (even subconsciously) as a way to gain attention

Doing anything to gain attention or favor from the person

Making excuses for the other party

Being highly attentive to others to avoid causing anyone else the same pain

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A dropping sensation in the midsection

A strong yearning for what is being withheld

The heart fluttering hollowly

A void opening up internally

A surge of adrenaline when the person shows attention

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Confusion

Believing that one is responsible for the neglect

Mentally searching for what one did wrong to cause the problem

Practicing what one will say or do next time an opportunity arises

Wanting to avoid the person but being pushed by one's unmet need to fill the void

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Fawning over the neglectful party

Becoming clingy

Acting out in unusual or negative ways to get what one wants (pursuing someone else to get the person's attention, engaging in harmful behaviors, etc.)

Entering into toxic or dangerous relationships as a way of meeting one's need

Rejecting others before they can do the rejecting

Consistently initiating drama

Being fiercely independent and determined to care for oneself

One's affection turning to scorn, bitterness, or anger

Hardening oneself against the other person

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Holding one's chin high

Maintaining a steady voice

Acting as if the neglect is no big deal

Withdrawing from the person but still pursuing them in subtle ways (asking friends about the person, stalking them on social media, etc.)

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Unappreciated](#), [Intimidated](#), [Longing](#), [Anger](#), [Confusion](#), [Discouraged](#), [Anxiety](#), [Defiant](#), [Depressed](#), [Hurt](#), [Resentment](#), [Scorn](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Indifference](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Blanch, cling, contract, cringe, crumple, cry, doubt, flinch, hesitate, manipulate, nag, quail, rebel, recoil, shrink, shrivel, tremble, wince, wither, wonder

WRITER'S TIP: *Do you know your character's emotional wound? Whatever difficult trauma is in their past, the emotion surrounding it will act as a trigger, awakening their pain and causing them to overreact.*

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NERVOUSNESS

DEFINITION: Feeling unsettled and being easily agitated

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Short, jerky movements

Pacing

Rapid blinking; a tightness around the eyes

Rubbing the back of the neck

Unfastening the top button of a shirt

Scratching or rubbing one's skin

Biting at the lips

Jumpiness

Flighty hand movements

Clumsiness

Rubbing one's hands down one's pant legs

A lack of eye contact

Scraping a hand through the hair

Quick breaths

Crossing and uncrossing one's arms or legs

Eyeing the exits

Bouncing a knee (while sitting)

Repeated gestures (straightening one's tie, touching an ear, etc.)

Increased sweat, particularly on the hands

Tingling fingers and toes

Pupils that appear dilated

Biting or picking at one's fingernails

Shaking out the hands

Clearing the throat

Facial tics

Stuttering and stumbling over one's words

Quick, high-pitched laughter

Restlessness (e.g., sitting, then standing)
Laughter that goes on for longer than normal
Closing the eyes and taking a calming breath
Rapid speaking, babbling, revealing things one didn't intend to, etc.
A change in the pitch, tone, or volume of the voice
Tackling a task (cleaning, waxing the car, etc.) to distract oneself

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Sensitive skin
Faintness
An empty feeling in the pit of the stomach
Quivery, twitchy muscles
Nausea, or a fluttery feeling in the stomach
Loss of appetite
Dry mouth
Heart palpitations
Headache

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Acute senses (especially regarding sound and movement)
The desire to flee
Erratic thought processes and irrational fears
Second-guessing oneself
The mind going to the worst-case scenario
Wishing time would speed up

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Vomiting
Fatigue or insomnia
Panic attacks
Withdrawal
Irritability

Ulcers and other digestive disorders

Weight loss or gain

Negative thought patterns

Indulging in alcohol, drugs, or chain smoking to take the edge off

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

A pasted-on smile

Clasping one's hands together

An unnatural stillness

Eyes that blink too much or don't blink enough

Not meeting anyone's gaze

Changing the topic

Avoiding conversation

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Flustered](#), [Insecurity](#), [Anxiety](#), [Fear](#), [Dread](#),
[Doubt](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Uncertainty](#), [Apprehension](#), [Relief](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Babble, chafe, chatter, dart, fiddle, fidget, fool with, giggle, interrupt, jerk, jump, overreact, panic, startle, stifle, swallow, tap, twitch, worry

WRITER'S TIP: *Body movement and external reactions alone will not create an emotional experience for the reader. Pairing action with a light use of internal sensations and/or thoughts creates a deeper emotional pull.*

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NOSTALGIA

DEFINITION: Fondly recalling a past period or situation one would like to revisit

NOTES: While nostalgia and homesickness are often seen as the same thing, there are subtle differences between the two. The former is typically a fond remembering, while the latter is a deeper feeling that's often coupled with a strong sense of sadness or even grief. If your character is feeling HOMESICK, see that entry for ideas on how it might be expressed.

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

An unfocused gaze

A slight smile

Slowly flipping through old pictures, stroking the pages

A relaxed posture

Eyes that fill with happy tears

Using a quiet voice

Cocking one's head to the side while remembering

Subdued laughter

A shallow sigh

An unhurried walk

Slouching on a sofa, watching old movies from the time period one fondly remembers

Slow, languid movements

Growing animated when memory is triggered (an old song playing on the radio, etc.)

Eyes brightening as memories are recalled

Keeping mementos from the happy time

Telling and retelling stories about the past

Seeking out those who share one's memories

Gently touching memorable items (a baby blanket, wedding invitations, etc.)

Closing one's eyes to more clearly recall the memories

Trying to recreate a past event (burning the same scented candle, wearing the old clothes, etc.)

Walking through one's house and remembering how things used to look before one's children moved on

Seeing similarities in the present: *You look just like him*, or *This is the same color as our first car*.

Increased tenderness (sitting close, a quick kiss, etc.) for those who shared in the event

Talking frequently about the past

Baking an old dessert that was a favorite of the person one is remembering

Visiting special places (the kids' favorite playground, a favorite restaurant, etc.)

Using social networks to find old friends and family

Remembering only the good about the time or person; forgetting the negative associations

Seeking to reconnect (phoning out of the blue, arranging a visit, etc.)

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Eyes prickling with tears

An excited flutter in the belly

An overall relaxation of the body

The breaths slowing as a memory takes over

Thickness in the throat

Dulled awareness—e.g., sitting in an uncomfortable position without feeling it

Experiencing (to a lesser degree) the same physical sensations felt during the past event

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Losing track of the time while remembering

A desire to go back and visit the past

Mentally replaying past events

Pushing oneself to recall small details (the color of a friend's jacket, the name of a child's best friend who often stayed for dinner, etc.) to make the memory more vivid

Regrets resurfacing (things one didn't say or do, or how one held back, etc.) that one must process and let go of to regain the happy state of remembering

Satisfaction at having experienced the event despite any pain or loss resulting from it

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Discontentment with the way things presently are

Choosing to reconnect with someone, even if it means working past a challenge (e.g., a past falling-out, dealing with problematic family members, a fear of flying, etc.)

Reconnecting with a past joy (volunteering, teaching dance lessons again, rejoining a choir to sing, etc.)

Expressing more emotion about the past than the present

Spending large periods of time in the past

Hoarding tendencies

Neglecting current duties or relationships

An inability to move on

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

An austere lack of mementos from the past

Sniffing back tears

Rejecting opportunities to revisit the past (reunions, trips to the old hometown, etc.)

Not engaging in conversations about the past

Refusing to speak about someone, or changing the topic when their name comes up

Masking nostalgia with practicality: *I kept his toys so he could give them to his kids.*

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Longing](#), [Dissatisfaction](#), [Sadness](#), [Happiness](#), [Sappy](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Wistful](#), [Gratitude](#), [Satisfaction](#), [Connectedness](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Call, caress, celebrate, cradle, cry, grasp, graze, grieve, grin, hold, honor, hug, joke, kiss, laugh, meditate, memorialize, peruse, ponder, pore over, recall, reflect, relive, remember, reminisce, retell, share, sigh, smooth, stroke, voice

WRITER'S TIP: *When introducing and describing characters, parcel out personal details in small bits. Anything that isn't pivotal to plot or characterization can be left to the reader's imagination.*

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OBSESSED

DEFINITION: Being excessively concerned about or interested in someone or something

NOTES: The character's obsession could be a person or group of people (a love interest or sports team), a goal (being elected class president, escaping from a captor), a hobby (a specific exercise regime, scrapbooking), or anything else that holds their attention for an extended period of time.

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Listening with rapt attention (leaning forward, eyes wide, vigorously nodding the head, etc.)

The pitch of one's voice rising

An over-bright, fanatic shine in the eyes

A laser-focused gaze

An unkempt appearance (uncombed hair, wrinkled clothing, bags under the eyes, etc.)

One's words running together as one talks about the obsession

Speaking animatedly (flapping the hands, bouncing on the heels, fingers jittering, etc.)

Monopolizing conversations; talking over other people to voice one's opinions

Staring longingly at the focus of one's obsession

Quickening breaths

Moving closer or rising up on one's toes to see the person through a crowd

Wearing clothing, accessories, jewelry, etc. that are associated with one's obsession

Moving to a location that makes it easier to pursue the focus of one's interest

Choosing clothing and hairstyles to emulate the person one is focused on or to specifically draw their attention

Talking about the obsession with anyone who will listen

Collecting the object in its many forms—buttons, bobbleheads, cards, whatever applies

Joining a fan club

Attending events (conferences, book signings, etc.) where the subject is being honored

Seeking out others who share this same obsession

Growing angry when the subject is belittled

Allowing one's conversation and focus to be distracted

Stalking the subject

Learning everything one can about one's obsession

Blowing off friends and family in favor of the obsession

Crossing moral boundaries in one's pursuit

Pursuing the person or goal despite rejection or failure

Spending excessive time, money, or energy on activities tied to the obsession

Turning conversations back to the object of one's obsession

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A rush of adrenaline when the subject appears or is mentioned

A taut feeling in the midsection when one is unable to pursue the obsession

The heart beating frantically when the subject appears

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Having a single-minded focus

A compulsive need to pursue or own the object of desire

The mind constantly turning back to the obsession

The mind replaying the same events over and over

Fantasizing about one's obsession

Believing that life is less fulfilling without the object of one's desire
Mood swings that are driven by one's perceived success or failure

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Fatigue

High blood pressure

An inability to fully function when one isn't near or pursuing the
subject

Muscle tics

Lack of hygiene and self-care

Going long stretches without engaging with others; becoming isolated

Obsessive-compulsive behaviors

A loss of self as the preoccupation with the obsession takes priority
over other needs

Losing touch with one's emotions; becoming numb to them

Becoming angry and defensive when confronted about having an
unhealthy obsession

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Attempting to play it cool around others

Avoiding mention of the subject in an attempt to throw others off

Denying any interest at all in the object of one's desire

Inattentiveness; trying to pay attention but not always being able to do
so

Joining groups or going out with friends but not truly engaging

Escalating worry over what people would think if they found out

Trying to hide one's displeasure if the subject is disparaged (mashing
the lips together, crossing the arms, turning away, etc.)

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Betrayed](#), [Despair](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Indifference](#), [Adoration](#), [Awe](#), [Desire](#), [Eagerness](#), [Excitement](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Consume, engross, enthrall, fixate, focus, grip, haunt, preoccupy, pursue, stalk, strive, target, torment

WRITER'S TIP: *When it comes to emotion, humor can have many uses. For some, it is a way to work past a situation with optimism intact. Others use it to deflect or distract. What purpose does humor serve your character's state of mind?*

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OVERWHELMED

DEFINITION: To be overpowered or overcome by feelings or circumstances

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Bringing a shaky hand to the forehead
Holding a palm up to stop someone from dumping on more worry
Waving people away
Shoulders that drop or curl
A chest that caves in
Clutching at one's arms or stomach
Touching a temple while closing the eyes
A voice choked with tears
A chest that hitches
A quaking voice
Poor balance
Mumbling, muttering
Letting out an uncontrollable cry, sob, or whimper
Uncertain (almost drunken) steps
Sagging into a chair or leaning against a doorframe or wall
Pulling the knees up to the chest and circling them with the arms
Falling against another person
Shaking all over
Teary eyes
Difficulty forming responses
Holing up in a corner and placing one's back against the wall
Dropping or spilling things
Shaking the head repeatedly
A glassy stare; a glazed look
Staring down at one's empty palms
Crumpling to the floor

Putting one's hands over one's ears
Rocking back and forth
Closing the eyes
Inappropriate responses (laughing, screaming, etc.)
Leaning over with the hands on the knees
Hyperventilating
Loosening a belt, collar, or other confining article of clothing
Touching one's fingertips to the lips

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Weakness in the legs; a sudden need to sit down
A wave of heat or cold
Light-headedness
Difficulty breathing
Stomach discomfort (pain or nausea) and being unable to eat
Ringing ears
Tunnel vision

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Noise sensitivity
Mental numbness and an inability to focus
Becoming unresponsive to others, almost catatonic
Wishing for comfort
Irritability; desiring to be alone
Indecisiveness
Negative self-talk; feeling like one is dropping the ball, inept, or incapable

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Flight
Snapping under pressure (screaming, yelling, hitting others, etc.)
Fainting or swooning

Weeping
Hysteria
Headaches or hypertension
Muscle fatigue and soreness
Seeking comfort in unhealthy ways
Heart attack or stroke
Chronic fatigue
Insomnia
Decaying physical health
Hospitalization

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Verbal denial: *I'm fine, really.*
False smiles and confidence
Agreeability or false enthusiasm
Masking weakness with excuses: *Sorry, I stood up too fast.*
Feigning a headache or other malady rather than admitting one's limits

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Anxiety](#), [Hysteria](#), [Depressed](#), [Powerlessness](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Determination](#), [Gratitude](#), [Relief](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Collapse, crumple, hyperventilate, mumble, overreact, panic, paralyze, quit, retreat, shake, shut down, snap, stare, stumble, sweat, tremble, withdraw, yell

WRITER'S TIP: When delivering emotional description, it's easy to rely too much on facial expressions. Instead, look down and describe what the arms, hands, legs, and feet are doing.

PANIC

DEFINITION: A sudden and incapacitating fear that produces neurotic or illogical behavior

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Quick, shallow breathing

Eyes that are wide, with white showing around the whole iris

Hyperventilating

Squeezing the eyes shut

Clenching and unclenching the fists

Folding the body over and making oneself small

Veins standing out in one's neck

Involuntary moans or whimpers

Being on edge (jumping at sounds, difficulty concentrating, etc.)

Sitting upright

Grasping the sides of one's head to try and regain control

Hands that shake and flutter

Muscles that look tight and clenched

Body tremors

Sweating

Flushed skin

Gasping to control one's breath

Pressing a palm against one's chest to the point of pain

A voice that elevates in pitch and volume

Speaking quickly; using choppy sentences

Backing against a wall or corner

Crying

Holding one's own shoulders tight to try and still one's quaking

Repeating the same thing over and over: *No, no, no, this isn't happening!*

Calling for help

Being unable to stay still (jerky movements, pacing and then changing direction, sitting and then getting up again, rushing people for news, etc.)

Desperately holding onto a source of stability, such as a person or comfort item

A darting gaze that attempts to absorb everything in one's environment

Passing out

Fleeing

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Adrenaline shooting through one's system

Heart palpitations and tingling in the chest

Elevated blood pressure

Feeling as if one is choking or smothering

The sensation of not being able to get enough oxygen (chest tightness)

Tingling in the extremities, the fingers and toes going numb

Nausea

Vertigo

Seeing spots in one's vision

Feeling faint or dizzy

A temperature increase (profuse sweating) or decrease (uncontrollable shivering)

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A sudden and overwhelming sensation of dread

The fear that one is going to die

Believing that one is going crazy

Trying to make sense of one's situation but being unable to think coherently

Focusing on subduing the symptoms (calming down)

Repeating to oneself that everything is going to be okay

Searching for a trigger or cause for one's panic

Becoming disoriented

Frantically wanting to fix things but being too wound up to do anything useful

Fixating on worst-case scenarios

Becoming hyper-reactive to sounds, movement, touch, etc.

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Developing a panic or anxiety disorder

Depression

Reliance upon prescription medications

Drug or alcohol abuse

Phobias

Becoming homebound

Avoiding situations that trigger one's panic

Avoiding places where one can't escape if a panic attack comes on

Constantly worrying about when the next attack will hit

Sleeping more than usual

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Closing the eyes

Taking deep, controlled breaths

Leaving the room or turning aside to regain control

Practicing relaxation techniques

Avoiding eye contact with others

Talking oneself down using logic and reasoning

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Hysteria](#), [Paranoia](#), [Terror](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Anxiety](#), [Dread](#), [Fear](#), [Sadness](#), [Unease](#), [Worry](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Choke, cling, collapse, faint, flee, flinch, freak out, gasp, grab, hide, hyperventilate, jerk, scrape, shake,

shudder, sob, sweat, tremble, whimper

WRITER'S TIP: *To dig deeper into a character, think about shame. What makes them feel this painful emotion? Drill down to important backstory to understand what happened, and then make them face their shame on the page.*

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PARANOIA

DEFINITION: Excessive or illogical suspicion and/or distrust of others

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Flinching and startling easily
Clenching the jaw
Darting eye movements; a wide-eyed look
Adopting excessive safety precautions (extra locks, guard dogs, video surveillance, etc.)
Fidgety hands that won't settle
Restless sleep or insomnia
Backing away with raised hands
Eyes that don't seem to blink often enough
Crossing the arms tightly over the chest
Muttering under one's breath; talking to oneself
Scratching compulsively
Sweating
Bloodshot eyes
Scouting for exits when entering a room
A heightened need for personal distance
Dependency on caffeinated beverages or drugs to stay alert
Pallid skin from lack of sunlight
A rumpled appearance
Accusing innocent people of planning or carrying out mischief
Facial tics; muscles that jump
A quick, erratic pace
Always looking over the shoulder or around the next corner
Plucking at clothing as if it chafes
Aligning with fringe groups and conspiracy theorists
Espousing far-out beliefs and opinions

Becoming easily offended; jumping to the defensive
Verbally attacking any perceived opponents
Spouting inane or irrational arguments
Citing unreliable sources
Stubbornly adhering to one's beliefs no matter how outlandish they are
Perfectionist tendencies
Compulsive behaviors
Refusing food or drink prepared by others

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Fatigue
Muscles that are always tense, ready to fight or run
Sensitivity to touch and sound
A racing heartbeat
Raw nerves and skin
A high adrenaline level; jumpiness

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Seeing danger symbols in everything
Judging too quickly
Believing that others always have a hidden agenda or motive
A heightened sense of self-importance
Irrational responses; jumping to illogical conclusions
Mental fatigue from not getting enough sleep
An inability to connect with others due to a lack of trust
Always seeing the worst-case scenario
Negative thought patterns
Feeling watched or followed
The belief that everyone else is deluded
Adhering to superstitious beliefs to stay safe

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Contacting the authorities for help against suspected assailants
An inability to maintain long-term relationships
Isolation
Living off the grid
The belief that one is no longer required to live by the laws of society
A complete break with reality
Hallucinations and delusions
Rage
Anxiety attacks, phobias, and/or psychosis

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Avoidance of social situations
Attempting to engage socially but with wary and darting eyes
Agreeing with everything to seem part of the group
Watching others and mimicking them as a way of appearing normal
A smile that is frozen or manic
A high voice or odd laugh
Using medicine or seeking therapy

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Fear](#), [Obsessed](#), [Anger](#), [Rage](#), [Hatred](#),
[Desperation](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Skepticism](#), [Scorn](#), [Unease](#), [Wariness](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Analyze, argue, bolt, challenge, contradict, dart, fixate, flinch, jerk, jump, obsess, peer, pry, race, scuttle, shudder, snap, snoop, sprint, start, twitch

WRITER'S TIP: *In dialogue, it's not always what a character says that's important, it's how they say it. (And sometimes it's what they are trying hard not to say!)*

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PEACEFULNESS

DEFINITION: A state of calm that is devoid of strife, agitation, or commotion

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

A relaxed posture (slack muscles, loose limbs, etc.)

Smiling or grinning

Fingers loosely clasped in one's lap

Closed eyes, with the head tipped back

Softened features that imply calm

Nodding to others in greeting

Leaning back, an arm hooked over the back of a chair

Taking a deep, satisfied breath

Using a friend's shoulder as a shelf to rest one's elbow

An unforced laugh

Whistling or humming

Being honest and transparent—doing what feels right in the moment

Sparkling eyes and a weightless gaze

Enjoying an event (a movie, a concert in the park, a picnic, etc.)

Lying on the grass to soak up the sun

Catlike stretches

A warm voice with a caring tone

Taking slow, easy breaths

Half-closed eyes; a lidded look of satisfaction

Lacing the fingers behind the head

A wide stance and open demeanor

Languid movements

Rolling the neck back and forth

Looping the thumbs in the front pockets while standing

An easy, unhurried walk

A wandering gaze, taking in random things

Noticing and enjoying the small things (stopping to smell the roses)

A satisfied sigh

Unhurried speech

Contentedly taking more time to complete tasks

Helping others out of a desire to lift some of their burdens also

Expressing a greater interest in the happiness of others

Engaging in meaningful conversations

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Drowsiness

A lack of tension and stress that almost equates to a feeling of nothingness

A steady, calm pulse and heartbeat

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Being with others with no need to fill the silence

Satisfaction with the world at large

A feeling of connection to life

Appreciating beauty more, in all forms

Having no desire to be anywhere else

Enjoying listening to others

Living in the moment, not acknowledging the past or future

Avoiding topics of conversation that will kill the mood

Delighting in even mundane, everyday tasks

A desire for everyone to experience such peace

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

A lessened need for worldly goods

Choosing to spend time with positive or like-minded people

A growing interest in spiritual or religious philosophy

A desire to maintain a positive status quo

Changing one's lifestyle to accommodate new beliefs, such as recycling or moving to the country

Impatience with corporate greed and capitalism

A desire for more natural living

An increased awareness of one's body and what goes into it

Engaging in new and satisfying hobbies and interests

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Claiming that one's calm demeanor is simply tiredness

Forcing oneself to maintain a slight stiffness in posture

Pretending to disengage because of boredom

Asking expected questions so others assume one is of the same mindset

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Happiness](#), [Satisfaction](#), [Connectedness](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Curiosity](#), [Wistful](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Amble, appreciate, chat, discuss, enfold, experience, hum, lean, linger, loiter, lounge, meander, relax, rest, share, smile, stretch, stroll, whistle

WRITER'S TIP: *Choose verbs carefully. The meaning of a sentence can be altered through the words used to describe action. Readers will see a character who trudges up the stairs as being in a different emotional state than one that bounds up them, two at a time.*

PITY

DEFINITION: Feeling discomfort at the distress of others while being grateful one doesn't have to experience it oneself

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Giving a clenched half-smile

Sighing

A sagging body posture

Head tilted slightly to the side

Looking at the person sideways rather than straight on

Sharing a pained glance (the eyebrows drawing in, an empathetic frown, etc.) with someone else

Facial cues that show disdain (a curling lip, covering the nose against an unpleasant odor, the nose wrinkling, etc.)

Laying a hand over one's heart before quickly lowering it

Looking at the person as they talk but being unable to meet their eyes

Carefully weighing one's words before speaking

Leaning back and shaking the head at the person's misfortune

Wincing

Making a *tsk* sound

The face wrinkling up

One's gaze dropping to the ground

Narrowing one's eyes as one tries to listen without judgment

Wringing one's hands

Holding a fist to one's mouth

Shuffling backward

Turning away, unable to look any more

Overall awkwardness, such as not knowing what to do with one's hands (shoving them in pockets, hiding them in one's armpits, etc.)

Looking around, as if for someone to do something

Reaching out to the person but not touching them

Stepping closer while providing the person adequate personal space
Offering clichéd platitudes: *You'll get through this, or It's always darkest before the storm.*

Clearing the throat

Offering to say a prayer for the person

Fidgeting (with a button, cell phone, jewelry, etc.)

Asking questions about what happened instead of simply listening and offering comfort

Making comments hinting that the person is somehow to blame for their misfortune

Speaking in a falsely sympathetic tone

Talking it over with others later, in private

Offering false hope: *Maybe this will lead to something better, or I'm sure he'll forgive you in time.*

Offering superficial comforting gestures (such as clapping the person on the back) but not doing anything that would really help

Clutching whatever one is holding, such as a set of keys or a binder

Blocking a child's view of the sight

Making excuses to others as to why one didn't get involved: *If I'd given him money, he would have just spent it all on booze.*

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

An uncomfortable sensation in the belly

A flutter of guilt, as if one should do something to help

A squeezing in the chest

An uncomfortable lump in the throat

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Wanting to help but not knowing what to say or do

Fearing that one might suffer the same hardship

Subconsciously making plans to keep the hardship from befalling oneself

Seeking a way to exit graciously

Thoughts turning to loved ones (if the misfortune involves the person's family)

Guilt, because the situation requires more aid than one is willing to offer

Being grateful one has never had to suffer in the same way

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Distancing oneself from the party because the situation is just too awkward

Blaming the person for their misfortune so one doesn't have to feel sorry for them

One's pity turning to contempt or scorn

Helping in ways that doesn't require emotional involvement, such as giving financial gifts

Becoming two-faced (e.g., offering help to the aggrieved party while gossiping about the situation with others)

Realizing one can help in a tangible way and choosing to step up and do it

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

No one likes to be pitied, since there's often an element of condescension or patronization involved. Because of this, people feeling pity will try to make it look like true EMPATHY or CONCERN. For ideas on what suppressed pity might look like, please see those entries.

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Contempt](#), [Smugness](#), [Guilt](#), [Empathy](#), [Determination](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Indifference](#), [Concern](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Ache, act, agonize, comfort, commiserate, consider, console, cry, deplore, empathize, enable, encourage, feel, give, gossip, grieve, help, hurt, judge, lament, mourn, nod, offer, pat, pray, soothe, suffer, sympathize, warn, weep

WRITER'S TIP: *No matter how resilient your character is, some things will get under their skin. Look for emotions that force them to be vulnerable so they'll seem more realistic to readers.*

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PLEASED

DEFINITION: Experiencing a pleasurable sense of satisfaction

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

A relaxed smile crossing the face

An overall lifting of the facial countenance

The head tilting slightly to the side

The cheeks going lightly pink with pleasure

Rubbing a hand self-consciously through one's hair

Lifting the chin

The chest puffing out

Leaning back in one's seat

Maintaining an open body posture (not tense or defended)

Sighing in satisfaction

Placing the palm of a hand over one's heart

One's voice going soft and gentle

Giving a thumbs up

Covering one's smile with a hand

Offering a conspiratorial gesture to someone involved (winking, giving a high five, shaking hands, etc.)

Nodding the head

Shaking the head slightly while smiling in happy disbelief

Laughing to oneself

Clapping the hands

Making strong eye contact with others

The body going into motion (moving from a sitting to standing position, standing to walking, etc.)

Making physical contact with those nearby—hugging, squeezing a shoulder, etc.

Sharing a happy glance with someone

Strong eye contact

Bouncing lightly in place (trying to contain a sudden boost in energy)
Verbalizing one's pleasure: *I couldn't be more proud*, or *Isn't this great?*
Offering encouragement or kind words to others; passing the feeling along
Eagerly discussing the event that has caused one's pleasure
Celebrating in some way—indulging in a special treat or going out with friends, for example

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Warmth spreading throughout the chest
One's face feeling stretched from so much smiling
Relaxed muscles
Warmth in the cheeks
The chest-swelling sensation that accompanies pride in a job well done

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A sense of contentment; a lack of stress or worry
Wanting the feeling to last
Being more tolerant and patient with others
Capitalizing on the situation by continuing whatever brought on the pleased feeling (making the most of the opportunity)
Looking more fondly on others and wishing to pass on the feelings of goodwill (giving those involved their due for helping out, complimenting others, etc.)

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

An increased sense of pride and self-confidence (if the pleasure was caused by one's actions)
Improved productivity
Improved relationships due to one's expansive feeling and a desire to keep it going

A positive shift in priorities; realizing that certain “problems” aren’t as important as one once thought

Lost productivity in other areas due to one’s attention being fractured

People in one’s life feeling marginalized (if the pleasure is associated with another person)

Ignoring one’s problems out of a desire to hold onto the pleased feeling

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

The corners of the lips twitching

The lips pursing or mashing together

Covering the mouth with one’s hand

The eyes becoming more animated

Drawing in a big, settling breath

Turning one’s attention away from the cause of one’s pleasure

Holding unnaturally still

Maintaining a tall, stiff posture

Leaning back or turning one’s body away, as if to show a lack of interest

Acting unconcerned while one’s eyes dart to the cause of the pleasure

Not talking about the cause but keeping a memento nearby to remind one of it

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Satisfaction](#), [Confidence](#), [Happiness](#), [Validated](#), [Pride](#), [Inspired](#), [Elation](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Amusement](#), [Surprise](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Beam, chuckle, grin, high-five, hug, laugh, nod, relax, smile, tease, wink

WRITER'S TIP: *Gratitude is a powerful emotion for self-protective characters, since it lowers their emotional shield. Think about including an event that causes them to experience gratitude so they can see that not everyone is an enemy. This will help them grow and move past their own fears.*

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POWERLESSNESS

DEFINITION: Feeling that that one lacks the authority, skills, or resources to act

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Making oneself small (legs close together, slouching, a caved-in chest, etc.)

Dressing in a way that doesn't attract attention

Maintaining a vacant look while staring off into space

Hiding one's hands in pockets or behind the back

A lack of coordination (bumping into things, fumbling or dropping objects, etc.)

Movements that lack energy

Poor posture

A bent neck

Avoiding eye contact

Starting sentences but not finishing them

Giving one-word answers

Speaking in a monotone voice that lacks emotion or interest

Verbalizing self-blame: *I should have stopped her, or I deserve this.*

Giving a single nod rather than speaking an affirmation

Sagging back in a chair as if needing support

Arms that hang at one's sides

Asking for instructions or seeking approval before acting

A weak handshake or grasp

Avoiding people or bodily contact

Slack facial features

Shaking one's head while looking at the floor

Shrugging weakly

Pressing one's fist to the lips and closing the eyes

Rubbing one's legs or squeezing the knees while sitting

Placing one's hand against the forehead to support the head
Feet that point away from the person one is talking to (and toward an exit or source of safety)
Looking down at one's hands
Not asking for what one needs or wants
Difficulty making independent choices
Avoiding conflict and risk; choosing what is safe or known
Self-deprecation: *I'm useless*, or *You need someone better to do this job*.
Not asking questions
Following instructions blindly
Erratic pacing (when frustrated)
Twisting one's hands
A voice that cracks with emotion when one is pressured

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A heavy stomach
Ribs that seem too tight
Body fatigue
Feeling hollowed out

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Time seeming to slow down
A desire to be alone
Escaping into one's thoughts rather than engaging with the real world
Frustration with oneself
Thoughts of self-loathing and inadequacy

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Desiring guidance even with the smallest things
Blindly doing what one is told
Increased self-loathing, which may progress to self-harming

Being taken advantage of by those who notice one's weakness
Not attending to personal needs or pursuing meaningful personal goals

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Putting on a happy face
Referencing times when one was strong or victorious
Making empty threats: *He'd never say that to my face!*
Fighting back in small, though unsuccessful, ways
Fantasizing about sabotage or giving someone their comeuppance

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Defeat](#), [Resignation](#), [Shame](#), [Self-Loathing](#),
[Inadequate](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Uncertainty](#), [Hopefulness](#), [Determination](#),
[Satisfaction](#), [Peacefulness](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Avoid, bend, bow, break, cave, cower, cringe, defer, deflate, drain, drift, droop, drop, fetch, follow, grovel, hide, mumble, obey, paralyze, report, resign, sag, scuff, serve, shrink, shrug, shuffle, slump, submit, surrender, weaken, yield

WRITER'S TIP: *If you want readers to connect with a point-of-view character's emotions, make him or her likeable, relatable, or vulnerable. This allows for empathy bonds to form.*

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PRIDE

DEFINITION: Proper self-respect arising from a significant achievement, possession of an item, or involvement in a relationship

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

A high chin

Shoulders held back

The chest thrust out

Standing tall with good posture, the legs spread wide

A gleam in one's eye

A knowing grin

Perfectionism

Watching others to see their reactions

Verbalizing the ups and downs that led to this point

Calling friends and loved ones to tell them about an accomplishment

Direct or intense eye contact

A booming laugh

A huge smile that shows a lot of teeth

Becoming talkative

Being generous with compliments

Using one's success to encourage others: *If I can do it, so can you.*

Lifting the heels and rising slightly to emphasize one's words

Steering or dominating the conversation

Becoming more animated when there's an audience

A grin that conveys secret knowledge

Thrusting oneself into the middle of an event or debate

A satisfied smile

Expansive movements

Hooking the thumbs into one's belt loops and thrusting the pelvis forward

Pulling in a deep breath

Ignoring or overlooking any flaws associated with the pride item
A preoccupation with one's appearance
Standing with the hands tucked into one's armpits, thumbs visible and pointing up
Flipping the hair back
Assuming a pose that's sexy or draws attention to one's best attributes
Appearing unaffected by what others think
Speaking first and thinking second (if at all)

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

The feeling of being taller, bigger, and stronger
The lungs expanding to their fullest through deep, satisfied breaths

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Positive self-thoughts
Preoccupation with one's achievements or successes
A feeling of being able to conquer the world
Wanting to be surrounded by supportive loved ones
A desire to share achievements with others
A tendency to judge people according to one's personal measuring stick
Overestimating one's capabilities
Underestimating others
A sense of entitlement
Planning and seeking advantages
Being terrified of failure (if one is used to succeeding)
Thinking about how to exceed the expectations of others

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Enjoyment at proving others wrong
Bragging; obsessively talking about an achievement or material object
Praising group accomplishments to remind people of one's involvement
Reacting with anger or jealousy if one's reputation is impugned

Making radical statements or promises about future goals
Revisiting the source or place of accomplishment to feel empowered

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Waving off a compliment
Passing the credit to someone else
Turning attention away from oneself
Seeking others' opinions as a form of validation
False modesty

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Smugness](#), [Contempt](#), [Confidence](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Pleased](#), [Uncertainty](#), [Insecurity](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Bask, boast, brag, confide, confront, defend, deliver, disdain, dismiss, flaunt, laugh, preen, puff up, regale, smirk, sneer, strut, swagger, swell

WRITER'S TIP: *How comfortable is your character with the full range of emotions? Are there certain feelings they're afraid to show? Explore this possibility to add nuance to your character's emotional responses.*

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RAGE

DEFINITION: Violent and uncontrolled anger

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Flushed or mottled skin

Shaking extremities

Hands that clench and unclench

Wide eyes, showing the whites

Spittle building up in the corners of the mouth

Biting criticism and belittlement

Jabbing a finger in someone's face

A corded neck

Nostrils flaring

Lips pulling back, baring the teeth

Cracking the neck from side to side

Muscles and veins straining against the skin

A guttural roar

Planting the feet wide apart

Sudden explosions over seemingly little things

Pushing and shoving

Limbering up the shoulders and neck as if readying to fight

Squeezing someone's arm to the point of bruising

Using insults to pick a fight

Cracking one's knuckles to intimidate

Pulling out a weapon, or finding something nearby to use as one

Moving slowly and deliberately toward another person

Barreling toward someone and uttering a scream or war cry

Fighting with no thought for one's safety

Throwing or kicking things, causing damage

Screaming

Threatening violence

Uttering death threats: *I'll kill you!*
Staring someone down to frighten them
Getting into someone's personal space
Manipulation

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A pounding in the ears
Increased blood flow to the extremities
Elevated pulse
A dry throat from rushed breathing
Pain that is suspended until later
Adrenaline rushing through the body
A sensation of increased strength
An edgy, twitchy feeling
Tunnel vision or flashes in one's vision

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Being driven by the belief that one has been mistreated or done wrong
A desire for vengeance
Looking for a fight
Wanting to hurt someone, to see blood
A sense of release when violence is expressed
Not thinking or caring about consequences
A need to dominate or control
Difficulty focusing or concentrating

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Beating someone senseless
Committing assault or murder
Seeking out opportunities to react violently
Self-destructive addictions
Depression

Heart disease and stroke

Ulcers

An inability to cope with smaller problems over time

Insomnia

Fatigue

Destroying property

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Unnatural silence

Uncontrollable body tremors

Punching a wall or object instead of a person

Clenched, grinding teeth

Pain in the jaw from clenched teeth

A tight smile that doesn't reach the eyes

Grabbing onto something secure (like a steering wheel) and shaking it violently

Punching or ripping apart something soft

Aggressive workouts

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Vengeful](#), [Paranoia](#), [Regret](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Anger](#), [Guilt](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Attack, bellow, break, charge, clench, clutch, explode, flush, glare, grab, hit, hurl, hurt, jeer, kick, roar, scream, seize, smash, swear, taunt, tense, threaten, throw

WRITER'S TIP: *As your character reacts emotionally to circumstances within the environment, don't underestimate the importance of sensory details. Do textures bother them because of a heightened state? What sounds do they pick up on that they might not otherwise notice?*

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REGRET

DEFINITION: Sorrow aroused by circumstances beyond one's ability to control or repair

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Scrubbing a hand over the face

Laying a hand against the breastbone

A heavy sigh

A downturned mouth

Bent posture

Crossing the arms over the stomach

Heavy arms, the shoulders pulled low

Apologizing

Trying to reason or explain

Eyebrows gathering in

A pained expression

Hands falling to the sides

Staring down at one's feet

Covering the face with the hands

Squeezing one's eyes shut

Lifting the hands up and then letting them fall

Pinching the bridge of the nose, eyes closed

Wincing or grimacing

Rubbing the chest, as if one is feeling pained

Avoiding the victims

Seeking reconciliation; determination to set things right

Berating oneself for one's actions or choices

Losing the thread of conversations

Hiding behind one's hair

Shaking the head

A voice that loses its power

Using broken sentences or trailing off while speaking
Making a *tsking* noise or murmuring regret: *What a shame.*
Asking questions about the fallout: *How did she take the news?*
Scrambling to reverse what was said or done
Increasing one's distance from others
Trying to fade into the background at social events
Putting oneself down

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A knotted belly
Insomnia
An inability to fill the lungs completely
A nervous stomach
Loss of appetite
Dullness in the chest
A feeling of heaviness

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Feelings of inadequacy
Self-loathing
The feeling that one deserves pain or judgment
Obsession with the person or event associated with the regret
Reliving past events
Thoughts that turn inward
Trying to forget the event
A desire to go unnoticed
Distractedness
Wishing it hadn't happened

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Not taking physical care of oneself
Weight loss

Withdrawing from society
Dropping out of clubs and groups
No longer finding joy in hobbies or favorite pastimes
Overcompensation in other relationships
Crying, sobbing
Self-destructive behaviors
Drug and alcohol abuse
Unsafe sexual practices
Abusive relationships
A string of broken relationships
Ulcers
A lack of intimacy with others
An inability to forgive oneself

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Desperately seeking out new relationships
Talking about one's accomplishments as a way of winning people over
Making life-altering decisions (a career change, a move, etc.) as a way of starting over
Acting like the life of the party
Putting on a happy face

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Shame](#), [Frustration](#), [Depressed](#), [Self-Pity](#), [Self-Loathing](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Sadness](#), [Embarrassment](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Avert, cry, deny, downplay, elude, evade, flinch, hide, isolate, minimize, murmur, stray, wallow, wander, wince

WRITER'S TIP: Watch for possible description crutches. Is the color green used too much? Does a sensory sound (like wind rustling through the trees) happen in multiple scenes? Keep track of these details to avoid overuse.

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RELIEF

DEFINITION: The alleviation or lightening of oppressive stressors

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Covering the mouth with a hand

Shaking the head and closing the eyes

Gasping

Trembling hands

Reaching out to another for comfort

Slumping posture

A slow smile

Using humor to lighten the moment

Shaky laughter

Sagging against a wall or person

Pressing the palms to the eyes

Asking for the good news to be repeated

Wobbly legs

Buckling knees

Stumbling back a step

Flopping back in a chair

A gaping mouth

Struggling to speak, to find the right words

An unsteady walk

Crying or calling out in release

Asking redundant questions to assure that the moment is real

Eyes going up, looking heavenward

Letting out a huge breath

Rocking back and forth

Eyes shining, locked on the source of relief

A slight moan

Lips parting

Showing kinship with the people involved (hugging, reaching for their hands, etc.)

Pressing one's hands to the stomach

A palm pressed to the heart

A bowed head

Starting to fall, then catching oneself

Closed eyes and compulsive nodding

Letting the head fall back

Uttering a soft curse or thanking God

Making the sign of the cross (if one is religious)

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Dry mouth

Weak muscles

An unexpected release of all tension

Tears welling up behind the eyelids

A sudden lightness or giddiness

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Wanting to be held

A desire to be still and let the relief sink in

Gratitude

Jumbled thoughts

An inability to formulate an appropriate verbal response

Postponement of residual loss or pain until a later time

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Breaking down and crying

Exuberant responses (jumping up and down, shouting, running, hysterical crying, etc.)

Collapsing

An expanding feeling in the chest

Light-headedness

A thick throat

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

A deliberately quiet exhale

Briefly closing the eyes

Drawing a deep breath through the nose

Biting the lips to keep from smiling

Swallowing and nodding

Narrowed eyes (when it's necessary to focus on something besides the source of relief)

Not thinking about it; putting it off to savor later

Inattentiveness

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Happiness](#), [Excitement](#), [Gratitude](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Uncertainty](#), [Confusion](#), [Worry](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Beam, cave, clutch, collapse, crumble, crumple, droop, exhale, faint, fall, laugh, shake, sink, slump, smile, sob, squeal, thank, tremble, weaken

WRITER'S TIP: *When a character is hiding an emotion, the cues are not as noticeable. In this circumstance, it's often more effective to show the emotion through change—altering a speech pattern, falling back on habits, posture shifts, etc.*

RELUCTANCE

DEFINITION: Unwillingness; aversion

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Stalling gestures, such as taking time to think or turning away

A hard, obvious swallow

Wetting the lips

Tense arms, shoulders, or face

Hesitant steps

The head pulling back as the shoulders push forward

Responding slowly

Pressing the lips together

Glancing around uneasily

Hands that shake; nervous twitching

The hands almost curling into fists and then straightening

A grimace or pained look

Eyebrows squeezing together

Stuttering and stammering

Making excuses

Lying

Tentatively reaching out or touching someone

Holding a hand up, warding someone or something off

Suggesting someone else to help or act instead

Shaking the head

A hand fluttering to the lips or neck

Nervous habits (running hands through the hair, pacing, repetitive gestures, etc.)

A too-quick smile

Glancing at one's watch

Jumpiness

Taking a steeling breath before responding or acting

Moving toward an exit
Putting distance between oneself and the requester
Biting the lip or nails
Pinching the bridge of the nose and tightly squeezing the eyes
Changing the topic or diverting attention
Closed body language (hands up, crossed arms, etc.)
Leaning or turning away from the person making the request
Asking for time to make the decision
Expressing skepticism
Asking questions for clarification
Not meeting the requester's eyes
Not engaging in further conversation
Making suggestions for a better option: *Tim's so good with clients, though. Why not ask him?*
Answering with a *Maybe* response
Muttering negatives: *No*, or *I don't want to*.
Downplaying abilities: *I am so disorganized. Trust me, you want someone else handling this.*

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A tightening chest
Slight tenseness in the muscles
A heaviness in the stomach

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A desire to get away from the person making the request
Indecision
A mind that is clearly distracted
Guilt
Searching for ways to get out of whatever is requested
An inability to focus on anything but the decision to be made
A need to justify one's reluctance

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Resentment

A tight or roiling stomach

Avoidance of the source

A strained relationship

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Agreeing, then not following through

Hints about being busy or overly stressed

A rising antipathy toward the person responsible for the situation

Passive-aggressive comments

Deflecting (e.g., making jokes)

Acting as if the request is absurd

Revealing one's true feelings to a third party, hoping they'll pass the information along

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Skepticism](#), [Defensiveness](#), [Anger](#), [Fear](#), [Disgust](#), [Resentment](#), [Dread](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Resignation](#), [Satisfaction](#), [Relief](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Avoid, balk, dawdle, defer, divert, feign, gulp, hedge, procrastinate, protest, put off, refuse, resist, second-guess, shuffle, squirm, stall, stammer

WRITER'S TIP: *Avoid brand-dropping to characterize. Brand names come and go and can date your writing. Instead, use other clues to convey your character's personality, strengths or shortcomings.*

REMORSE

DEFINITION: Distress resulting from guilt over wrongdoing; a desire to undo or fix

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Heartfelt apologies

Asking to talk

Following the aggrieved party

Repeatedly returning to the scene where a past event took place

Keeping the head down as the eyes look up

Watering eyes

A hand that cups the mouth

Holding one's head in one's hands

Tears that one does not try to hide or control

Silence

Offering restitution or making promises

Using the victim's name in dialogue when they are present

Telling the unvarnished truth

Speaking without hesitation when answering

A quivering chin

Holding the stomach

Shoulders that curl over the chest

Not defending oneself against attack (verbal or physical)

A crumpled body posture

Staring down at the floor

Clasping the hands together in the lap

Shaking

Begging for forgiveness

Shoulders that quake with repressed sobs

A pleading tone

A pale or unhealthy complexion

Dark circles under the eyes
Hollowed cheeks
Reaching out to touch and then pulling back, as if one isn't worthy
Readily agreeing to a punishment or pronouncement
A voice that cracks
Verbalizing responsibility for what happened
Giving quiet answers to questions
Arms hanging at the sides
Still hands and feet
Obedience
Breaking into sobs
Asking others for advice on how to make up for what happened

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A stomach that feels hard
A runny nose
Nausea
Gritty or dry eyes from lack of sleep
A lump in the throat

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Mentally berating oneself over an action or poor decision
Wanting to face the consequences
Obsessing over finding a way to repay the debt
Empathy for the other party and what they are going through
Being honest about one's role in the situation
Relief for owning up to wrongdoing

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Weight loss
Headaches
Heart problems

Self-destructive behaviors out of the belief that one does not deserve happiness

Desperation to balance the scales or resolve the situation

A complete life change (taking up charity work, finding God, etc.)

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Avoiding friends who are also culpable (if it was a group act)

Lying about one's feelings

Claiming that the victim was partly responsible

Making an excuse to leave

Dropping out of activities, school, or work on false pretenses

Moving away

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Shame](#), [Regret](#), [Desperation](#), [Determination](#), [Devastation](#), [Worthlessness](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Guilt](#), [Insecurity](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Apologize, beg, confess, cower, cringe, cry, grieve, grovel, implore, languish, muddle, pester, plead, seek, shrink, sob, surrender, voice, wish

WRITER'S TIP: *Description is clearest when a writer adheres to the real order of events in a scene. Show the action (stimulus), then the reaction (response), and a reader will clearly see how A leads to B.*

RESENTMENT

DEFINITION: Moral-centered anger arising from disrespect, unjust treatment, or unfairness

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

A pinched mouth

Arms crossed over the chest

A flat look, the eyes narrowed

Scowling

Increasing one's personal distance from others

Complaining

Rudeness and sarcasm

Pouting

Catty behavior

Name-calling

A voice that rises in volume or intensity

Arguing

Looking past someone rather than at them

A hard expression

Arms straight, hands locked into fists

Refusing to be bought off through kindness or thoughtfulness

Shunning the source

A stiff stance

Purposely ignoring someone's conciliatory efforts

Muttering or cursing under the breath

Twisting the mouth; a soured expression

Belittling another's status or accomplishment

Tension in the neck and shoulders

Pointing and jabbing the air for emphasis

A curling lip, showing the teeth

A sharp, defined jaw line

The voice taking on a tart tone
Snapping at others
Sabotaging another's projects or actions out of a sense of being wronged
Talking behind someone's back; gossiping
An unkind smile
Shaking the head in disapproval but not saying anything
Balling the hands into fists
Walking out of the room
Spinning away in a huff and stomping up the stairs
Shutting a door with more force than is necessary

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Tension headaches
Pain in the jaw
A tight chest
Constricting the throat
High blood pressure
Stomach troubles or ulcers

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Unkind thoughts toward the target
Frustration at unfairness or a lack of justice
Fantasizing harm or the downfall of another
Moodiness
Wanting to be alone
Fixating on a person or situation to the detriment of other relationships
A desire to bring others in and create a mob mentality of resentment
Becoming obsessed with fairness (noticing imbalances, always treating others equally, etc.)

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Weight gain
Illness
Insomnia
Arriving late, calling in sick, or refusing work shifts to avoid the source of resentment
High blood pressure
Seeking revenge

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Walking away
Keeping silent
Changing the topic to something safe
Putting on a smile
Pretending to move on while making plans to bring about justice

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Bitterness](#), [Contempt](#), [Anger](#), [Hatred](#), [Jealousy](#), [Defiant](#), [Vengeful](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Acceptance](#), [Hurt](#), [Determination](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Accuse, attack, defend, fester, frown, fume, gossip, gripe, harbor, insult, pout, sabotage, scowl, seethe, snap, stew, sulk, undermine, vent

WRITER'S TIP: *When you're exposing the reader to a new scene, person, or object, it can be useful to have some description or opinion delivered through a secondary character's dialogue. What they notice and how they respond provides an opportunity to characterize.*

RESIGNATION

DEFINITION: The state of surrendering, often with little or no resistance

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

- Sighing dejectedly
- Slumped shoulders
- Blank features
- Stooped posture
- Shuffling footsteps
- Taking small steps
- Tears
- A monotone voice
- Becoming less verbal over time
- Dull eyes
- A chin that trembles
- Answering with a small nod
- Sagging facial features
- Limp hands and arms
- Unwashed hair
- Wrinkled and disheveled clothes
- A loss of appetite
- Disinterest in former hobbies or passions
- Making oneself small (hugging oneself, squatting down, curling into the fetal position, etc.)
- Avoiding eye contact
- Being at a loss for words
- Lethargically giving comfort to someone (rubbing their back, patting their shoulder, etc.)
- A shake of the head
- Tipping one's head back on the neck to look skyward

Agreeing, but without emotion
Clasping the hands together
Leaning forward, elbows on the knees
Staring off at nothing
A hanging head
A loose jaw
A half-hearted shrug
A long exhale
Muttering and mumbling
Holding the head in the hands
Propping a cheek on a fist
Slowed reactions to stimuli
Grunting; giving one-word answers
Purposely closing the eyes, as if to process
Excessive sleeping

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A falling or dropping sensation
A sensation of emptiness
Feeling numb and heavy
A lack of emotion
Weakness in the muscles
Pain in the throat (because it's constricted)

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A determination to make the best of the situation (glass half full)
An inability to focus or concentrate
Feeling directionless
Confusion: *How did this happen?* or *What will happen to me now?*
The sense that nothing will ever be the same
Feeling powerless over the present or future
Believing that one has failed

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Depression

Retreating inward

Disconnecting from others

Doubting oneself; a decrease in confidence

Apathy

Becoming submissive; giving up control

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Whining and questioning

Offering token weak arguments

Squaring the shoulders but without any real force or strength

Offering a small display of anger

Acting like giving in was a choice, not the only option

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Sadness](#), [Disappointment](#), [Defeat](#), [Self-Pity](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Acceptance](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Abandon, capitulate, cave, defer, deliver, droop, drop, end, evacuate, fade, forfeit, give up, mumble, murmur, nod, quit, recant, relinquish, sag, shuffle, sigh, slouch, slump, stare, submit, surrender, waste away, whisper, wither, yield

WRITER'S TIP: *Too many emotional internalizations in a scene can slow the pace considerably. If the character's reflections are key to readers understanding what is being felt, try shifting some of these inner thoughts to active, realistic dialogue. It will increase the pace and still reveal the character's feelings.*

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SADNESS

DEFINITION: Characterized by unhappiness

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

A puffy face or eyes that appear red

Smudged makeup

Splotchy skin

Sniffing and wiping at the nose

Wincing

Sighing

Speaking less; seeming too-quiet

A tearful or breaking voice

Staring down at one's hands

Stooped posture—a caved chest, lowered shoulders, etc.

A distant, dull, or empty stare

A flat, monotone voice

Difficulty participating in conversation, as if responding takes a great effort

Downturned facial features

Covering the face with the hands briefly before pulling them away

Arms hanging at the sides, slack

Crossing one's arms and holding onto the shoulders (self-comforting)

Slumping rather than sitting up straight

A heavy-footed walk

A slack expression

Wet, dull eyes

Bending forward, laying the head on the arms

Movements that lack energy

A trembling chin

Digging for tissues

Drawing the limbs close to the body

Staring down at one's empty hands

Making excuses for one's despondency: *I'm just tired*, or *Everything's fine, really*.

Decreased interaction with the world at large

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Hot or gummy eyelids

A scratchy throat

A runny nose

Soreness in the throat and lungs

Heaviness or tightness in the chest and limbs

Blurred vision

Lack of energy

The body feeling cold

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Feeling like time is slowing down

Difficulty responding to questions

An inability to see where the future might go

Turning inward; withdrawing

A desire to escape the sadness (through sleep, drink, companionship, etc.)

A need to be alone

Desiring comfort from others but not knowing how to communicate it

Avoiding the painful subject

Denial

Focusing on distractions (work, the problems of others, etc.) to avoid one's pain

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Crying

A loss of appetite

Losing all hope that something positive might come
Despondency
Struggling with motivation
Avoiding friends, since their positivity or happiness makes one feel worse

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Turning away
Halting one's speech to gain control
Biting the lip
Blinking
Clearing one's throat
Changing the subject
Sipping a drink or taking a bite to eat (to prove to others that one is stable)
Quivery smiles
A voice that sounds falsely bright
Focusing on alleviating another's pain rather than one's own
Excusing oneself to use the restroom or get a drink so one can be alone

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Nostalgia](#), [Depressed](#), [Loneliness](#), [Frustration](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Somberness](#), [Wistful](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Collapse, contract, cry, deflate, double over, drag, fall, internalize, loll, moan, obsess, quiver, recoil, rock, shake, shamble, shuffle, sniffle, stare

WRITER'S TIP: *In dialogue, be on the lookout for where your character "thinks" instead of responding verbally. This leads to unnatural, one-sided conversations.*

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SAPPY

DEFINITION: Overly sentimental; feeling an exaggerated sense of happiness, connectedness, or romance

NOTES: Sappiness is similar to nostalgia in the way it manifests. But while the former is typically a result of happier emotions, the latter is more often associated with wistfulness and sadness. If that's the response you're seeking, please see the NOSTALGIA entry.

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Languid, contented movements

Showing more patience and tolerance; being more easygoing

Cocking the head to the side

The gaze going distant as one recalls a happy memory

Smiling broadly at the person or thing evoking one's feelings

Clasping the hands against one's chin

Being very touchy-feely

A blush in the cheeks (as one realizes how silly one is being)

Hugging someone often

Trailing one's fingers along favorite mementos

Snuggling or cuddling with someone

Nuzzling someone with one's head or chin

Running a hand up and down the person's arm or back

Tousling the person's hair

Walking with one's head on the other person's shoulder

Watching old videos or playing sentimental music

Sighing happily

Sending someone a letter or text message "just because"

Buying gifts for the person

Creating a personalized gift, such as a poem or playlist of meaningful songs

Cooking foods associated with the happy memory or person
Telling happy stories about the good old days
Verbalizing one's feelings: *Everything is perfect right now*, or *I'm so glad you're here*.
Wearing a silly grin
Eyes sparkling with unshed tears
The face turning rosy
A smile that quavers
A quivering chin, eyes shining with happy tears
Buying a certain kind of cologne, shampoo, or fabric softener because it reminds one of the other person's smell
Complimenting the other person
Having difficulty restraining oneself, even when the other person is not as responsive

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

An effusion of warmth
An expanding feeling in the chest
Eyes prickling (tearing up)
Feeling energized or twitchy
The heart rate increasing when the person approaches
One's heart feeling as if it's swelling or growing
Restlessness when one is distanced from the other person or thing

MENTAL RESPONSES:

The mind playing a loop of happy memories involving the person or thing
Being in a good mood
A sense of calm and contentment
Being highly focused on that person or thing
Exaggerating one's memories so they're wholly positive

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Being clingy or smothering

Going over-the-top for the person (giving hard-to-acquire gifts, throwing elaborate themed dinners, etc.)

Driving the person away with one's ongoing sappiness

Annoying others with one's constant reminiscing

One's feelings turning to sadness, frustration, or anger if one can't be with the other person

One's sappy feeling naturally returning to a more even-keeled emotion over time

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Not touching the other person, despite wanting to do so

Quickly glancing at or touching the thing that reminds one of the happy memory

One's attention drifting frequently; having to be pulled back on task

Always being near the other person

One's true feeling slipping through if the other person offers encouragement

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Adoration](#), [Longing](#), [Euphoria](#), [Confusion](#), [Frustration](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Despair](#), [Satisfaction](#), [Happiness](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Affirm, beam, clasp, cuddle, grasp, hold, hug, kiss, laugh, massage, smile, snuggle, spoil, spoon, squeeze, stroke, swoon, touch, tousle, twine

WRITER'S TIP: *One emotion to include in every story is hope. Without it, even the most carefully crafted fiction will contain a void that readers will notice and cause them to disengage.*

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SATISFACTION

DEFINITION: The state of being content or fulfilled

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

A high chin and exposed neck

A crisp nod

Smoothing the front of a shirt or tugging down the sleeves

Offering a thumbs-up

Giving a toast or praise

Clapping someone on the back

A wide stance—fists on hips, elbows wide, etc.

Surveying the finished product with a pleased expression

A raised eyebrow and a *See?* look

A sleek walk that draws the eye (catlike and deliberate)

A shy, confident, radiant, or cocky smile

Apt dialogue that sums up the situation perfectly

Saying *I told you so!*

A puffed-out chest

Shoulders back, straight posture

A fist pump

Clapping

Loud cheering or whooping

Fingers forming a steeple

Including others in the moment

Bragging

A hand casually anchored on the hip

Stretching the arms out wide

Leaning back, at ease and in control

A deep, gratifying sigh

Whistling or humming

A distant, unfocused smile

Taking deep breaths, savoring the moment
Unhurried, relaxed movements
A direct manner (eye contact, strength in the voice, etc.)
Offering congratulations where they are due
Rewarding oneself
Lingering near one's accomplishment (a person, place, event, or object)
to bask in the feeling of a job well done

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A hyper-awareness of others and their reactions
A lightness in the chest
Warmth spreading through the body
A tiredness that is fulfilling rather than exhausting

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Happiness over a job well done
Euphoria and exhilaration
Contentment
Gratification
Increased confidence
Looking forward to a well-earned rest
Mentally fixating on the recent success
Not paying attention to one's surroundings
Self-congratulations
Generosity to others as a result of feeling gratified
A desire to tell everyone about the success

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Justified possessiveness
An expression of supreme confidence
A glowing countenance
Cockiness

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Twitching lips

Hiding a smile behind a hand

Bouncing lightly on the toes

Getting away at the first opportunity to tell someone the good news

Settling back in a chair in release

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Happiness](#), [Smugness](#), [Pride](#), [Gratitude](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Unease](#), [Indifference](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Applaud, bask, brag, cherish, clap, congratulate, delight, grin, linger, polish, relish, savor, smile, smirk, smooth, strut, swell, swing, toast

WRITER'S TIP: *Loners and their lack of social interaction present specific writing challenges. To break up long stretches of introspection, maintain some character relationships. Remember that a person can be lonely even when surrounded by people; use the dialogue, dysfunction, and drama that go along with those relationships to keep the pace moving forward.*

SCHADENFREUDE

DEFINITION: Malicious enjoyment from the suffering or unhappiness of others

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

A sneer, followed by a bark of laughter

Squinting (from the force of one's grin)

Fingers that alternately flex and curl into fists

The face and neck flushing with pleasure

Having a wild-eyed look

Tipping the head back

An unkind smile spreading slowly over the face

Pumping one's fist at the sky

Chuckling unpleasantly

One's chest rising and falling as breaths come quicker and faster

Rubbing the hands together

Drawing out one's words: *Would you look...at...that!*

Verbally kicking someone when they're down: *You'll never fit in here.*

Nodding one's head rapidly

Wetting the lips

Bouncing in place or shifting from one foot to the other

Seeking to benefit from the situation—e.g., making a bet against the victim

Looking the person up and down with a disgusted expression

Standing back and watching with an intense gaze

Egging on whoever is doing the hurting

Joining in the attack on the victim

Slapping one's hands against the cheeks while the mouth hangs open in mock horror, then pointing at one's rival and grinning

Savoring the moment with one's friends (shaking heads scornfully, giving high fives, etc.)

Muscles that quiver and shake

A muscle tic jumping in the cheek, jaw, or neck

Clapping and jeering

Asking questions designed to make the person squirm: *You did prepare for this, right?*

Mumbling or muttering under the breath: *Yeah, do it, or Couldn't happen to a nicer guy.*

Crossing the arms so firmly the fingers dig into the biceps

Squatting down to get on the same level with the victim

Watching raptly but silently, the fingers steepled in front of one's mouth

Relishing a secret's reveal: *Mom, did you know it was Jess who backed into your car last week?*

Not responding to requests for help

Toying with the victim—e.g., reaching out a hand as if to help, then jerking it back

Catching the victim's eye and making a fake "pouty" face

Talking about the experience later with friends

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A flush of warmth through the body

Feeling light-headed with adrenaline

An expansive feeling in the chest

A heady rush of power; feeling invincible

A buzzing sensation in the extremities

Twitchy muscles

Weakness in the knees as the adrenaline wears off

MENTAL RESPONSES:

One's focus narrowing on the victim; everything else fading away

Fantasizing about participating in the victim's misfortune

Feeling vindicated (if one had been mistreated by the victim in the past)

Wanting to continue the feeling of satisfaction by engaging in other harmful activities (trashing a hotel room, vandalizing someone's car, brawling, etc.)

Justifying one's feelings by blaming the victim or recalling their faults

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Yelling oneself hoarse

Profuse sweating

Decreased empathy for people in general

Wanting more (and more extreme) pain for the victim

Becoming sexually aroused (sadism)

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

A smile that one tries (and fails) to restrain

Making eye contact with the victim and shrugging with a smile

Looking away (breaking eye contact)

Darting glances at others to see their emotional states before reacting

Positioning oneself so one can witness the mistreatment without being seen

Claiming to have no knowledge of the situation

Making passive-aggressive or ambiguous comments: *Oh, you poor thing.*

Watching with a stony face that seems to be devoid of emotion

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Elation](#), [Hysteria](#), [Vengeful](#), [Vindicated](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Conflicted](#), [Doubt](#), [Guilt](#), [Shame](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Bash, bask, belittle, cackle, castigate, cheer, clap, crow, crucify, declare, delight, enjoy, flaunt, gloat, humiliate, jeer, lambaste, lord, mock, preen, pretend, relish, savor, scoff, shout, simper, smirk, sneer, snicker, taunt, titter, torment

WRITER'S TIP: *When you're trying to write a specific character's emotional reaction to a situation, remember that their core personality traits, past experiences, and deepest fears will steer their actions.*

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SCORN

DEFINITION: Extreme contempt or derision; regarding as inferior

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

A biting remark

Belittling comments that remind the target who has the upper hand

A smirk

A quick, disgusted snort

Looming over the target

Crossed arms and a wide stance

Sarcasm

A tight jaw

A harsh squint

A deliberate eyebrow raise and head tilt

Pulling down one's glasses and looking over the rims with a flat gaze

Flapping a hand in dismissal

Bullying tactics

An exaggerated eye roll or upward glance

Blowing out a breath that rattles the lips

Insulting the target in front of others

A thrust-out chest

An ugly twist to the mouth

Encouraging others to speak up against the target

Limited verbal responses, as if the target isn't even worth talking to

Laughter at the person's expense

A wrinkled nose

Flicking a hand in front of one's nose as if to get rid of a bad smell

A tight mouth, as if tasting something bad

Narrowed eyes

Staring the target down

Applauding in a deliberately false fashion

Projecting hurtful observations: *I'd be embarrassed if I were you!*

Ridiculing the person's beliefs

Anger at being touched or addressed by the target

Calling attention to the person's weaknesses

Ignoring the target

Speaking slowly to emphasize hurtful words

Leaving to show that the target is not worth one's time

Apologizing to others for having their time wasted by the target

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A puffed-up feeling

The rush of adrenaline at taking away another's power

Elevated body temperature

Increased heart rate

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Elation at delivering a blow to an opponent through dialogue or action

Anger

A desire to put the person in their place

Superiority

Arrogance

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Asking questions to further incriminate the target

Egging the target on

Picking fights

Forcing the target into circumstances where they're sure to fail

Gathering other like-minded people and encouraging their scorn

Seeking to hurt through a low blow comment

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

A blank, emotionless face

Becoming unresponsive to questions or actions

Turning away

Shaking the head

A slight muscle jump in the cheek

A tightened jaw

Clamping one's lips tight to keep from saying anything

Making an excuse to leave

If pressed, stating that one's opinions will not be popular and it's better to stay silent

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Anger](#), [Hatred](#), [Elation](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Resentment](#), [Pity](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Bark, belittle, bully, corner, demean, dismiss, disparage, expose, glare, goad, humiliate, insinuate, insult, interrupt, mistreat, mock, narrow, offend, pin, press, ridicule, scoff, shame, smirk, snap, sneer, snicker, snort, squint, taunt, trap

WRITER'S TIP: *When describing a character's emotional state, pay attention to their voice. Does it rise or drop in pitch? Get louder or softer? Grow rough or silky smooth? Changes in pitch and tone are great indicators for when a character is trying to hide their feelings from others.*

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SELF-LOATHING

DEFINITION: Intense dislike or even hatred for oneself

NOTES: Self-loathing can manifest through seemingly contrasting behaviors. Some characters may seem guilt-ridden and deserving of pain, while others act aggressively to mask their feelings of self-hatred and low worth.

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Crying or often being on the verge of tears

Apologizing for failures and mistakes

Trying too hard to please

Looking to others for reassurance: *Is this right?* or *Should I do this?*

Having impossible expectations for oneself

Accepting punishments without question

Scrutinizing flaws (grabbing at a non-existent roll of fat, obsessing over pimples, etc.)

Believing the cruel words of others

Feeling guilt at experiencing pleasure or a happy moment

Walking with one's head down

Doing small things that hurt (scratching one's arm, pinching, digging a nail into one's flesh, etc.)

Self-sabotage (talking too much but being unable to stop, telling lies no one believes, etc.)

Slumped posture

Keeping one's arms tight to the sides, not taking up space

Avoiding social situations

Keeping a wide personal space barrier

Adhering to a routine

Dismissing compliments: *Someone else would have done a better job,* or *Are you kidding? My project looks terrible!*

Seeking out negative attention (e.g., drinking too much)

Being unresponsive or speaking very little

Wearing clothing that is unflattering or attracts the wrong sort of attention

Gesturing without energy (e.g., nodding toward something rather than pointing at it)

Verbalizing one's flaws: *I break anything I touch, or If I try and fix your hair I'll just ruin it.*

An absence of smiles and facial expressions

Taking stupid risks in the hopes of being caught and punished

Adopting destructive habits such as pill popping, smoking, or drinking

Choosing friendships with negative people (who engage in mean gossip, bullying, etc.)

Being argumentative

Avoiding being touched

Using sarcasm to hurt others and keep them away

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Body aches and a feeling of heaviness

Fatigue

An upset stomach

Normal pains that one ignores (believing that the pain is deserved)

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Negative thoughts: *I'm so stupid, or I mess everything up.*

Envy others, then feeling guilt for wanting what they have

Constant self-critical assessments: *I can't wear this shirt. Look at my scrawny arms!*

Desiring connection but feeling unworthy: *Who am I kidding? She wouldn't look twice at me.*

Having little motivation to make one's life better

Focusing intensely on one's emotional or physical pain

A desire to escape or disappear

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Developing an eating disorder

Self-mutilation, such as cutting

Thoughts of suicide

Suicide attempts

Overmedicating with drugs or alcohol

Being trapped in a lifestyle where one is devalued (in the sex industry, with an abusive partner, etc.)

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Overachieving (setting high goals but taking no pleasure in meeting them)

Pushing oneself past reasonable limits as a form of punishment

Avoiding people and relationships

Hoarding behaviors

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Depressed](#), [Despair](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Worthlessness](#), [Insecurity](#), [Conflicted](#), [Hopefulness](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Abuse, belittle, blame, bully, curse, degrade, despise, discredit, hate, humiliate, mock, punish, ridicule, sabotage, scoff, shame, taunt

WRITER'S TIP: *Regret is a difficult emotion, one that is felt both in the moment and in the long-term. What old regrets have power over your character, steering their actions and decisions? Think about how these can become part of the story so your character can learn to let go of them.*

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SELF-PITY

DEFINITION: A self-indulgent preoccupation with one's problems or complaints; feeling sorry for oneself

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

An overall downcast countenance

Frowning

Flaccid or sagging muscles

Rounded shoulders

Slumped posture

Shuffling footsteps

Plodding or trudging along

Eyes that lack sparkle or shine

Deep sighs

A flat, emotionless voice

Sitting slouched in a chair, the head propped on one's hand

Sleeping too much or not enough

Doodling on paper or sketching shapes with one's finger on a desk

Complaining about one's circumstances

Dissolving into tears over one's situation

Becoming more animated when one is discussing one's problems

Being unable to laugh at oneself; taking oneself too seriously

One-upping others: *Oh, you think that's bad? I'd trade places with you any day.*

Fishing for compliments

Posting cryptic social media messages to encourage sympathy and attention

Not fussing with one's appearance

Withdrawing from others

Seeking comfort from others; needing validation

Melodramatic responses to circumstances

Apathy toward other people and their problems
Trying to pull others into one's drama
Frequently calling friends to "help" one through a difficult situation
Blaming others for one's misfortunes; not taking responsibility for one's own actions
Always turning the conversation back to oneself
Constantly talking about past glory days (before everything went sideways) instead of focusing on the way ahead and improving one's situation
Railing against perceived enemies (a certain person, a group of people, God, etc.)
Self-destructive behaviors, such as drinking excessively or abusing medication
A tendency to overreact and personalize things (e.g., viewing an innocent slight as an attack)
Overindulging to boost one's mood (shopping for a pick-me-up gift, eating treats, etc.)

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A feeling of heaviness that won't lift (the physical manifestations of emotional pain)
Feeling energized when discussing one's misfortunes (adrenaline spikes)
Pain in the throat when one is crying or trying not to cry

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Difficulty empathizing with others
Comparing one's situation with other people's
Believing that one is being persecuted or targeted in some way
A sense of despair; believing that things will never get better
Always seeing the bad in situations
Believing that the worst-case scenario will come to be

Not seeing one's reality clearly; being prone to exaggeration
Believing untruths about oneself (that one is incapable, a victim, stupid, etc.)
Craving a happier path but being afraid to pursue it (fear of failure and hurt)

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Becoming isolated
Becoming codependent on those who offer sympathy and support
Purposely or subconsciously making choices that ensure a negative outcome (so one can continue to feel sorry for oneself and receive sympathy from others)
Becoming depressed
Losing friends who are drained by one's constant negativity
Giving up on long-term goals or dreams because one believes they're out of reach
Bitterness and resentment
Self-loathing (if one recognizes the unhealthy need for other peoples' validation but feels unable to change)
An inability to move forward because one is so focused on past slights and unfairnesses

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Inquiring about other people's problems and feigning interest in them
Forcing oneself to socialize with others
Not talking (to avoid calling attention to one's problem)
Smiling and laughing a lot
Speaking in a bright and happy voice
Being purposely animated in one's movements and gestures
Not mentioning one's problems but being negative about other things

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Worthlessness](#), [Defeat](#), [Depressed](#), [Self-Loathing](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Insecurity](#), [Powerlessness](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Blame, brood, cling, complain, drown, excuse, falter, forfeit, grieve, gripe, grouse, justify, lament, mope, mourn, pout, stew, sulk, wallow, whine

WRITER'S TIP: *When working to evoke an emotional response from readers, choose words with care. Language choices will color the mood and influence what readers feel as they read.*

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SHAME

DEFINITION: The feeling that arises from a dishonorable or improper act; disgrace

NOTES: Not all shame is deserved; many victims of violence and abuse feel shame when they are, in fact, blameless. Even when a feeling of shame is unfounded, it will present the same way.

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

- Cheeks that burn
- Crumpling onto a chair or sofa
- Pulling one's arms and legs in toward the core
- Muttering *What have I done?* or *How could I let this happen?*
- Using the hair to hide the face
- Pulling a ball cap low
- Pressing one's hands against the cheeks
- Dropping the chin to the chest
- Eyes that are wet with tears
- An inability to meet another's gaze
- Crumpling under scrutiny
- Shaking, trembling, and shivering
- Hunched shoulders
- A perpetual slouch
- A closed-off stance (crossing the arms, making oneself small, averting the head, etc.)
- Pressing a palm over the lips to hold back a cry
- Shaking the head
- Letting out an uncontrolled moan
- Punching one's fists against one's thighs to release frustration
- Lashing out at others to transfer anger or blame
- Arms hanging at the sides

Hitching breaths
A trembling chin
Shielding the body
Angling away from those bearing witness to the shame
Pulling and tugging at one's clothes to make one less visible
Vandalism of one's own things (self-punishment)
Loss of interest in one's personal appearance
Seeking out second chances (fawning, begging, following others, etc.)
to regain self-worth
Lying or doing whatever it takes to keep a shameful secret

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Hypersensitivity to noise, crowds, and activity
Flu-like symptoms (nausea, sweats, tingling in the chest, etc.)
Weak knees
Thickness in the throat
Heat and tingling in the face
Body tremors

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Flight reactions
Pulling away from friends and loved ones
Avoiding familiar places and activities
Self-loathing, berating oneself, anger, and disgust
Risk-taking behaviors; hoping something will happen to balance the scale
An utter lack of self-confidence
A desire to fade into the background and avoid notice
Believing that people are watching and judging (if the shameful event is a close-kept secret)

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Self-violence (scratching, cutting, pulling hair, etc.)
Depression
Substance abuse
Eating disorders
Increased sexual activity
Panic attacks
Anxiety disorders
Perfectionistic tendencies to balance the source of shame
Seeking power as a means of self-validation
Denial
Diverting blame to others
Suicide
Abusive relationships
Attempting to change one's appearance
The belief that one deserves pain
Rejecting help out of a desire to do penance

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Engaging with others, yet showing discomfort (avoiding eye contact, fidgeting, etc.)
Holding oneself rigidly tall and upright
Taking deep, steady breaths
An overly bright smile
Being unreasonably aggressive or confrontational
Overcompensating

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Depressed](#), [Humiliation](#), [Remorse](#), [Self-Loathing](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Appalled](#), [Defensiveness](#), [Guilt](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Avert, clutch, cower, cringe, disguise, duck, flinch, hide, mask, quiver, retreat, self-harm, shake, shrink, sob, tremble, withdraw

WRITER'S TIP: *There are dozens of physical, internal, and mental responses to use when conveying a given emotion. Filter possible cues through what you know about your character. "Would my character react this way?" is a great question to ask to stay on the right track.*

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SHOCK

DEFINITION: Lingering upset after experiencing a traumatic or fear-inducing event

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

- Taking a step or two back
- Eyes widening or bulging
- Body movements that freeze momentarily
- Becoming speechless
- Rapid blinking as one tries to process what one has seen or heard
- The mouth falling open
- Raising the eyebrows
- One's head drawing back quickly
- Covering one's mouth with the palm
- A shaky or disbelieving voice
- Not knowing where to look; a wandering gaze that doesn't settle
- Pressing a fist to the mouth or pinching the lips between the thumb and index finger
- Needing to sit down or lean against something for support
- Rubbing one's forehead and shaking the head
- Asking questions to better understand or cope with the news
- Tears welling up at bad news
- Turning away and shielding the face
- Rubbing at one's eyes as if to reaffirm what one is seeing
- Taking shaky breaths
- Lightly holding or stroking one's throat in a self-soothing gesture
- Rubbing or pressing down on the breastbone
- Posture that crumples (shoulders falling and the chest caving in)
- Stepping back from others to create space; needing a moment to process the information
- Stuttering; struggling to find the right words

Pressing one's hands against one's ears
Shaking the head in denial
Stumbling or shambling
Forgetting what one was doing
Swaying slightly
Folding an arm against one's stomach
One's voice cracking or warbling with emotion
Voicing denial
Squeezing the eyes shut

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A sudden feeling of cold or a heaviness that expands in one's core
Muscles that go weak or numb
Feeling dizzy
Skin that tingles with discomfort
Light chest pain or a tightness in the chest
A heavy feeling in the stomach

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Refusing to believe the truth of what one has seen
Tuning out everything other than what has caused the shock
Replaying what one has seen (or imagining what one has heard)
Time seeming to slow down
Wishing something was not true or real
Wishing one could go back to a state of ignorance
Wanting to have a reason for what happened to better understand it

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Shutting down; emotional numbness
Fleeing the situation
Collapsing; one's body being unable to bear its own weight
Denial

Sobbing
Rapid swallowing to try and dispel a thick ache in the throat
Seeking comfort or closeness with others who are sharing the experience

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Eyes bulging before one can control one's expression
Muscles that stiffen involuntarily before one forcibly relaxes them
Busying oneself to appear indifferent about what has happened
Seeking a quick exit to avoid the scrutiny of others
Hands that tremble slightly
A sudden onset of clumsiness

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Disbelief](#), [Disgust](#), [Anger](#), [Humiliation](#),
[Anguish](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Regret](#), [Sadness](#), [Resignation](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Ache, appall, back away, collapse, comfort, disbelieve, dread, drop, flinch, gape, grasp, hold, horrify, jerk, lean, numb, question, reach out, regress, regret, retreat, shake, shout, stroke, stumble, stutter, traumatize, tremble, weaken, weave

WRITER'S TIP: Sometimes an unexpected emotion creates a gateway to a revelation, showing the character a deeper truth about a past event or offering them clarity in a current one. Spend time describing these moments because they often lead to growth and transformation.

SKEPTICISM

DEFINITION: Feeling doubtful or incredulous

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Pursing the lips in thought

Tilting the head and pausing

Shaking the head

Pressing the lips into a fine line

Raising the eyebrows

Clearing the throat

Fiddling with jewelry or other items

Shrugging

Nodding, but with a tight expression to show one is not fully committed

A confrontational stance

A smirk or eye roll

A hand flap that dismisses the person or their idea

Demanding proof or evidence

Listing the possible consequences

Polite verbal opposition

A condescending smile

Muttering negatives: *I don't think so*, or *No way that would work*.

Restlessness (pacing, tapping fingers, clock-watching, etc.)

A tightness in the face

Rigid body posture

Rubbing the back of the neck without making eye contact

Narrowed eyes

Biting or chewing on one's lip

Gossiping with others; running a person down for their choices or ideas

Sniping remarks

Licking one's lips

Hemming and hawing

Referencing similar events from the past that did not pan out
Bringing up everything that could go wrong
A purposeful shiver or shudder
Biting the fingernails
A heavy sigh
Walking away
Tapping a finger against the tabletop to drive a point home
Asking *Are you sure?* or *What if?* questions
A jutting chin
A silent look while crossing the arms
Wrinkling the nose like there's a bad smell
A quick exhale through the nose (a snort)

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Tightness in the chest
Increased heartbeat and pulse
Tense muscles
A flare of adrenaline, firing the brain to act

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Negative thoughts
Uncertainty
Homing in on flaws, either of logic or of a personal nature
A desire to change the speaker's mind or standpoint
Wanting to be around people with the same opinions

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Anger
Frustration and a loss of patience
Passive skepticism becoming more overt: *You're making a mistake.*
Looking for ways to discredit the speaker
A desire to shut the speaker up

The mind racing through possible arguments
Disbelief (that others can't see the truth)
Actively seeking to bring people over to one's way of thinking
Becoming argumentative

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Attempting to keep a neutral facial expression
Footsteps that drag
A quick widening of the eyes before schooling one's expression
Apologizing for not showing immediate support
Sitting still, hands clasped, mimicking interest and attention
Acting noncommittal: *Interesting idea*, or *That's something to think about*.
Asking for a person to review the pros and cons again for clarity
Suggesting a trial basis as a solution
Requesting more time to reflect
Suggesting that perhaps more thought or study is needed

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Suspicion](#), [Resignation](#), [Fear](#), [Scorn](#), [Paranoia](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Uncertainty](#), [Confusion](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Argue, attack, challenge, deny, discredit, disprove, dispute, distrust, doubt, oppose, question, refute, smirk, sneer, snort, suspect, wrestle

WRITER'S TIP: *Don't make it easy for your heroes. Pile on the difficulties. Overwhelm them. Make it seemingly impossible for them to succeed so that when they do overcome, the reader will be properly impressed.*

SMUGNESS

DEFINITION: Supreme confidence in and satisfaction with oneself

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

A jutting chin

Crossed arms

A thrust-out chest

Deliberately raised eyebrows

Cocking or tilting the head

A smirk or sneer

Direct, probing eye contact

Squinting and a hard smile

A dismissive nod or glance

Rolling the eyes

Aggressive teasing intended to put another in their place

A sigh conveying annoyance (a huff)

Waving a hand in dismissal

Leaning in aggressively, as if to challenge the other party

Rocking back on one's heels

Mean-spirited talk behind another's back

Projecting the voice to reinforce who has the upper hand

Sarcasm: *Whatever*, or *Sure you are*, or *If you say so!*

A look that radiates superiority

Perfect posture, shoulders back, an exposed neck

A determined walk, strut, or swagger

A loud voice, bragging, full of bluster

Using boisterous movements to draw attention to oneself

A wide stance

Criticism and belittlement

Talking over people and controlling conversations

Looking down one's nose at others

Dominant behavior (invading another's personal space, standing while others sit, etc.)

Lavishing praise on favored ones (children, friends, people in power, etc.)

An arrogant laugh

Preening (fussing with clothing, checking oneself in the mirror, etc.)

Wearing flashy or dramatic clothing

Tossing one's hair back

A shake of the head

Adopting a pondering pose (e.g., clasping the chin and tapping the lips with a finger)

Settling back in a chair with exaggerated casualness

Movements that draw attention (waving a cigar, gesturing with a glass of wine, etc.)

A deliberate crossing of the legs or clasping of the hands

Fidgeting with jewelry to draw attention to it

Clapping someone on the back, overplaying closeness or friendship

Name-dropping

Rubbing it in with an *I told you so*.

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Warmth radiating throughout the body

A puffed-up feeling

Tingling in the chest

The heart rate rising due to an adrenaline rush

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A firm belief in one's own rightness and superiority

Disdain for those who are unworthy

Overconfidence

A desire to belittle the unworthy and exalt one's own accomplishments

Gratitude at having risen above the rest

The belief that those who have not succeeded are to blame for their failure

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Extreme pride in appearance and possessions

Careful consideration of friendships, purchases, places where one is seen, etc.

Reminding someone of a past mistake to rub it in

Choosing to spend time in environments that are a reminder of success

Generosity that displays power (e.g., hosting charity functions)

Acting as if rules do not apply or one is above the law

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Making token acknowledgements to those who played a part in an outcome

Citing that luck was involved but not meaning it

Preachy advice: *Do what I did, and you'll succeed too.*

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Contempt](#), [Scorn](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Disappointment](#), [Doubt](#), [Insecurity](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Bask, belittle, boast, brag, condescend, deign, demean, dismiss, display, dominate, flaunt, gloat, ignore, insist, jeer, loom, lord, patronize, preen, revel, show off, shun, simper, smirk, sneer, splurge, strut, swagger, taunt, tease, tower

WRITER'S TIP: *When describing a character's feelings, the word "felt" is often a cue for telling emotion, not showing. Run a search for this word and challenge yourself on its use.*

SOMBERNESS

DEFINITION: A feeling of melancholy or gloom

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

An unmoving stance

A voice devoid of emotion; deadpan

A grave expression (an inward gaze, lips pressed slightly, eyebrows close together, etc.)

A sad or serious demeanor

Hands folded in one's lap

Sitting quietly

Letting out a heavy sigh

Responding with a slow nod rather than speaking

Flaccid yet unwelcoming (closed) body language

A tendency to look down

Hesitating before speaking, as if weighing one's words

Dark or heavy observations

A bleak mood that affects others, lessens energy, or brings people down

Loose posture, the shoulders dropping

Speaking at the air rather than making eye contact with others

Gazing downward with the hands clasped loosely behind the back

A slow walk

Smooth, expressionless features

Keeping one's arms and legs in close to the body

Functional and precise movements

Unsmiling; humorless

Choosing one's words deliberately

Not reacting to stimuli (laughter, excitement, activities, etc.)

Drab, colorless clothing choices

A grim twist to the mouth

Sedate mannerisms; minimal or economical movement

Eyes that look dark or serious
Opening the mouth to speak and then closing it and shaking one's head
An unnatural stillness
Not responding when someone calls one's name
Using an arm to prop up one's chin, the fingers covering one's mouth
Being less enthusiastic about former enjoyments (food, favorite sports teams, etc.)

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Fatigue; lacking energy
Heaviness in the limbs or muscles
A weighed-down feeling
Slow and even breathing

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A subdued personality
A negative outlook
A desire to be alone
Difficulty engaging in conversation
Searching internally for answers rather than asking others
Losing track of time
Finding it hard to pay attention; getting lost in one's thoughts

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Accepting a negative outcome or realization
Becoming uninterested in hobbies or entertainments
Melancholy; gloominess
Shunning other people who are not of like mind
Inability to focus on the needs of others (children, family, etc.)
Being apathetic toward goals, desires, or upcoming events

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Forced laughter
A too-frequent smile
Smiles that quickly fade
Agreeing to attend happy social events, then not showing
Smiles that don't reach the eyes
Light words delivered in a serious tone
Adding an adornment (a pin, fancy hat, a bright scarf, etc.) solely for appearances

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Depressed](#), [Despair](#), [Resignation](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Indifference](#), [Moody](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Avoid, brood, commiserate, complain, darken, defeat, deflate, despair, dim, dismiss, dwell, ebb, mope, mumble, mute, shrug, sigh, slack, worry

WRITER'S TIP: *If your scene includes a small dip into the past to retrieve information that has direct bearing on the current action, make sure there is an emotional component. Emotions are triggers to memory and help tie the present to the past.*

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STUNNED

DEFINITION: Feeling mentally numbed or paralyzed, usually as a result of a shocking revelation or blow

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Going completely still

Standing with slumped shoulders

Arms hanging loosely at one's sides

Leaning on someone else

The mouth falling open

Absently licking the lips or wiping at one's mouth

Dull eyes

A flat gaze

One's facial muscles going slack

Glancing around without really seeing anything

Moving one's eyes (to take in the surroundings) while the rest of the body is still

One's head slowly swiveling as one glances around

Blinking slowly

Being physically led by others, as if one has lost the ability to move

Shuffling footsteps

Randomly picking up items and putting them back down

Sitting limply

Clutching an object (a purse, stuffed animal, a comfort item, etc.) firmly to the chest

Curling up in the fetal position

Not responding when one's name is called

Delayed reactions to a phone ringing, someone's touch, or other stimuli

Lying down with one's face to the wall

Sitting with elbows on the knees, hands covering one's face

Rubbing one's eyes

Stuttering or stammering
Voicing confusion: *It can't be possible. I don't understand.*
Forgetting what one was doing, mid-action
The eyebrows furrowing as one tries to understand what has happened
Small responses that don't make sense, such as smiling at nothing or
answering a question that was asked much earlier

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A ringing in the ears
Muffled sounds, as if one is wearing earplugs
Dry eyes
A sense of paralysis; one's muscles feeling frozen
A heaviness in the limbs
A knot in the stomach
Nausea
Light-headedness
Seeing spots

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Blank thoughts, as if one's brain has stopped working
Thoughts swirling so quickly it's hard to follow them
Difficulty focusing
Emotional numbness
A sense of vertigo
Questioning what one has just learned or witnessed; feeling disbelief

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Falling into a catatonic state
Forgetting appointments, birthdays, and other notable events
Poor hygiene (wearing dirty or rumpled clothes, not bathing, etc.)
Not leaving home for long periods of time
Feeling out of it, as if one never quite knows what's going on

A loss of interest in anything and anyone

Missing work or school

An inability to focus on anything

Apathy about the future

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Fierce and deliberate blinking

Looking around (as if surveying the area) but not actually looking at anything

Breathing deeply through the nose

Fidgety hands and feet

Leaning against a wall or table (instead of collapsing to a sitting position)

Turning away from the source

Biting one's lip

Pressing the lips together

Asking a question completely unrelated to the cause of the emotion

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Denial](#), [Despair](#), [Anguish](#), [Panic](#), [Hysteria](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Disillusionment](#), [Disbelief](#), [Resignation](#), [Sadness](#), [Grief](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Blank, blink, collapse, crumple, drop, falter, forget, freeze, gape, hesitate, hunch, slacken, stammer, stare, stiffen, stumble, stutter, tense, topple

WRITER'S TIP: *To make a villain relatable and layered, have them experience an emotion that shakes apart their hard exterior and briefly causes them to see life through an unbiased filter of hope.*

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SURPRISE

DEFINITION: Unexpectedly struck with a feeling of wonder, joy, or fear

NOTES: Surprise can be negative or positive.

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

The mouth falling open

Fingers touching parted lips

An incredulous stare or dazed look

Jerking the head back

Slapping the hands against the cheeks

A playful swat at a friend for causing the surprise

Shuffling back a step or two

A yelp, gasp, or squeal

Flinching and clutching one's fists to the chest

A sudden stiffening posture; rigid muscles

Stopping mid-stride or stumbling

Giddiness

Widening or bulging eyes

Doing a double take

A rise in vocal pitch

Grabbing a friend's arm

Hiding the face

Gripping the sides of the head as if to cover the ears

Spreading the fingers out in a fan against the breastbone

Touching the throat

A flush of red in the cheeks and neck

Turning away (negative surprise)

Pulling books or packages tightly against one's chest

Raising a hand to ward off others from approaching or speaking

A shaky, soft, halting, or disbelieving voice
A tentative smile that builds as surprise sinks in
A bark of laughter
Breaths that catch or hitch
Tipping or turning the head to the side

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Tingling skin
A racing heartbeat
A sudden coldness that hits at the core (if the surprise is negative)
Disorientation, dizziness, or euphoria
A fluttery feeling in the belly
A flush of adrenaline tingling through the body

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Wanting to hide
Fuzzy thoughts; an inability to think
Embarrassment; feeling exposed and on display

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Ducking; covering one's head with the arms
Collapsing from a perceived fright
Tears or shakiness
Ducking the chin to hide the neck
Jerking in the legs
Leaping back
Hands rushing toward the mouth to cover it
Letting out a sharp scream
Muscles tightening
Flight reactions (running away, hiding, etc.)
Fight reactions (shoving the initiator, delivering a punch to release anxiety, etc.)

Arms drawing back to the body core in a protective flinch
Stuttering or speechlessness
Swearing or shouting

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

One's smile going stiff in an effort not to lose it (negative)
Rapid blinking
Widening eyes
Lifting the eyebrows
A closed-lipped smile
Nodding the head, as if one is not surprised at all
A quick tensing of the body
A split second where breathing is suspended
Tightening the grip on whatever is being held
Shaking out the hands once the initial shock has passed

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Amazement](#), [Happiness](#), [Fear](#), [Anger](#), [Relief](#),
[Disappointment](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Acceptance](#), [Satisfaction](#), [Confusion](#),
[Resentment](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Beam, catch, exclaim, flinch, flounder, gape, gasp, gawp, grab, grasp, jerk, jump, laugh, retreat, smile, squeal, startle, stumble, swear, yelp

WRITER'S TIP: *With emotion, never be afraid to try something new. Individual expressions should be genuine but unique.*

SUSPICION

DEFINITION: Intuitively suspecting that something is wrong

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Narrowing the eyes; squinting

The body angling away from the source

A wrinkled brow

Flushed skin

A deliberate lowering of the head to study or stare

Arms tight to the body

Shooting glances at the suspect or source

Avoiding direct eye contact

A fake smile

Sneaking or spying

Eavesdropping

Following the suspect

Retreating or keeping at a safe distance

Evaluating the subject's manner and appearance

Forced nonchalance to avoid the subject's notice (hands in pockets, etc.)

Crouching or leaning forward to get closer without being seen

Lips that are pressed flat

Recording the suspect's activity and movement (taking notes, pictures, etc.)

A set jaw

Tilting the head while mentally weighing the evidence

Being confrontational: *What are you doing here?* or *What do you want?*

Pointing a finger while confronting someone

Openly expressing distrust

Crossing the arms

Legs that are wide apart

A raised voice
Trying to convince others of the suspect's guilt
Big movements (waving the arms while talking, counting arguments on one's fingers, etc.)
Swaying from side to side
Arguing with the suspect
Pacing
Biting the inside of the lip
Asking questions one already knows the answers to
Sarcasm: *So, you just happened to be there when my car's tires were slashed, huh?*
Questioning others as a way of gathering information
Googling the suspect
Avoiding a particular area or choosing a new route

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Quickened breaths
An adrenaline rush
A thumping heartbeat
The fight-flight-or-freeze reflex kicking in
A knot in the belly

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Listening intently to catch the suspect in their lie
Mentally running through everything known about the situation
Wanting to shield oneself and others from the person
Second-guessing oneself, fearing others will think one's concerns are irrational
Carefully preparing an argument or plan of attack
Weighing the danger level of the situation

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Obsession with the suspect or source
Stalking
Setting up the suspect in the hopes he will reveal his true self
Attempting to openly discredit or blackball the suspect
Contacting the appropriate authorities to express concern
Fantasizing about the day the suspect is finally exposed
Looking for changes to a location that will confirm one's beliefs about possible danger

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

A slight nod
Hmms, as opposed to overt agreement
A flat tone of voice
Noncommittal answers
Avoiding the suspected person
Agreeing too quickly, too loudly
Over-the-top support: *I'm with you 100%*, or *I absolutely agree*.
Nervous movements (biting fingernails, twisting a shirt button, rubbing the neck, etc.)
Standing back from the suspect; not stepping into his circle of friends
Spending minimum time with the suspect before finding a reason to leave

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Unease](#), [Fear](#), [Agitation](#), [Anger](#), [Paranoia](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Acceptance](#), [Uncertainty](#), [Doubt](#), [Wariness](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Argue, bait, catch, confront, creep, criticize, disprove, eavesdrop, examine, follow, furrow, lurk, narrow, peer, plant, pose, pretend, question, scrutinize, sneak, snoop, spy, squint, stalk, study, trail, trap, trick, undermine, watch

WRITER'S TIP: While it's tempting to let a character speak openly about their emotions in dialogue, it will raise a red flag for the reader. If you wouldn't say it in real life, don't let your character.

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SYMPATHY

DEFINITION: A sensitivity to the circumstances of others that results in a desire to offer support

NOTES: Sympathy and empathy are close in nature but aren't the same. Sympathy is felt more at a surface level, meaning a person can provide support without feeling personally invested. On the other hand, empathy is a deeper manifestation where a shared emotional experience makes the moment highly personal and meaningful. For ideas on the latter, please view the EMPATHY entry.

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Kind words

A soothing tone of voice

Telling someone that it will be okay

Patting someone's back

Swallowing before speaking

Moving closer; entering another's personal space (if they are open to it)

Squeezing a hand and then letting go

Offering a deep sigh and thoughtful expression

A parting hug that lasts longer than normal

An understanding nod

Eyes narrowing, the eyebrows pulling down in concentration

Asking what the person needs and how one can help

Offering the bright side: *At least now we know*, or *It could have been worse*.

Pulling someone against your shoulder (if the relationship is close)

Stroking or smoothing someone's hair

Clumsy attempts to comfort (a weak smile, an awkward hug, etc.)

Fumbling for words

Patting a leg in comfort

Leaning in or scooting closer
Offering a listening ear
Sitting in silence together because one doesn't know what to say
Phrasing questions in a positive way to make the other person feel better

Bringing up something that will comfort: *Your son is coming this weekend, right?*

Sitting with one's knees touching the other person's
Bringing a box of tissue or a cup of tea, unasked
Floundering hand movements
Handling distractions (answering the phone, etc.) so the other person won't have to

Apologizing—not out of accountability but to voice the unfairness of the situation

Offering the advice of a relative or friend: *As my uncle used to say...*
Fussing over the person's appearance while speaking in encouraging tones

Listening intently while ignoring discomforts (cold, rain, heat, etc.)
Listening with one's arms crossed over the chest
Leaning in awkwardly with the hands in the pockets, asking if things are okay

Looking elsewhere while listening, so as not to make the other person unduly uncomfortable

Offering to take the other person somewhere—a walk, a car ride, to hang out—as a distraction

Running defense for the person (making excuses on their behalf, telling people that their concerns can wait since the person needs a few moments, etc.)

Agreeing, even if the person is being irrational

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Feeling emotionally drained

An overall weighted feeling

A slower heartbeat

An ache in the throat

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Wishing one could alleviate the emotional pain

Uncertainty about what to say

Putting diplomacy above honesty

Forcing oneself to listen without judgment

Worrying that this event could happen again, particularly to oneself or loved ones

Seeing the contrast and having a sudden appreciation for one's good fortune

Offering up prayers on their behalf

A narrowed focus that allows one to solely concentrate on the other person

Relief that one is not experiencing the same challenges

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Obsessive thoughts on how to fix the situation

The mind turning often to the person

Employing clichés: *This too will pass*, *Keep your chin up*, etc.

Giving comfort through gifts or plying the person with food or attention

Devoting time, money, or energy into helping the person navigate this situation

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

A hand that lifts towards the person, then lowers

Speaking often of the person or situation

Saying nothing overtly but privately praying for the person

Smiling or sharing a look but not offering verbal support

Watching at a distance, hoping for change

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Empathy](#), [Sadness](#), [Love](#), [Gratitude](#), [Worry](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Indifference](#), [Denial](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Advise, cheer up, comfort, commiserate, counsel, dote, encourage, fuss, hug, listen, motivate, observe, pat, protect, smile, soothe, squeeze

WRITER'S TIP: *Emotions usually don't jump from mild to extreme in a short period of time. To gain the reader's trust, lay the proper foundation and show how stressors can lead to a greater intensity.*

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TERROR

DEFINITION: A state of extreme fear

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Rasping breaths

Bulging eyes; an inability to blink

Full body tremors

Bolting out of hiding and rushing away from the threat

Screaming, crying, or blubbering

Speechlessness or incoherence

Holding oneself tightly (clutching the arms or wrapping the arms around the belly)

Squeezing one's eyes shut

Moaning and whimpering

Trembling chin and lips

Running away with no destination in mind

Shaking one's head, as if in denial

Clapping the hands over the ears

Pressing one's fists to the sides of the head

Crumpling to the ground

Retreating into the fetal position or curling up on the knees

Covering the face

Cringing, flinching, or jumping at sounds

Tense muscles and a rigid posture

A primal scream

Flaring nostrils

Grabbing another person, refusing to let go or leave them

Clumsiness (bumping into things, knocking things over, etc.)

Clutching the throat or chest

Gasping for air

Clammy skin

A harried, wild appearance
Clawing at the cheeks, dragging the fingers down
Tremors in the hands and fingers
Copious sweating
Risking a lesser danger in order to escape
Causing self-harm (cuts, bruises, etc.) while trying to escape, and not noticing
Spinning around, trying to spot any and all danger
Backing away in quick, jerky steps from something or someone
Fight responses (a rush attack, using anything at hand to hit or destroy, etc.)

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Hyperventilation
A racing pulse
The sound of the heartbeat thrashing in the ears
A clenched jaw
High pain tolerance—not feeling or noticing injuries
Increased strength or stamina
Claustrophobia (even if one is not usually claustrophobic)
Pain in the chest, lungs, or throat
Weak legs
Increased sensitivity to every sound, touch, or change in the environment
Dizziness; seeing black spots

MENTAL RESPONSES:

A compulsion to look back (when fleeing)
Impaired decision making
A single-minded focus: to save oneself or someone else
Risk-taking
Surrender (if a breaking point is reached)

Hyper-vigilance

Thoughts that keep coming back to the worst possible outcome

Sensitivity to noise and movement

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Passing out from a stress overload, lack of oxygen, or both

A mental break (humming, rocking, hands over the ears or eyes, etc.)

Heart attack

Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder

Insomnia

Hallucinations

Anxiety attacks

Nightmares

Depression

Substance abuse

Difficulties relating to others

Isolation

Phobias

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Terror, by nature, is almost impossible to suppress or hide. Any attempt to hide terror would simply display itself as FEAR.

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Panic](#), [Paranoia](#), [Anger](#), [Rage](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Fear](#), [Wariness](#), [Resignation](#), [Satisfaction](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Blubber, bolt, clench, clutch, collapse, crumple, faint, freeze, gasp, hyperventilate, moan, quiver, run, scream, shake, shriek, stammer, startle

WRITER'S TIP: When conveying high emotion, keep the metaphors to a minimum. No matter how flowery or creative a character might be, in the midst of strong emotion, most people don't think in those terms. Keep it simple to maintain believability.

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TORMENTED

DEFINITION: Experiencing extreme mental distress because of one's closeness to a possible crisis or disaster

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Eyes going wide, being unable to blink, appearing haunted

Eyebrows pulled together, the crease deep and evident

A quivering chin

Dragging one's fingers down the cheeks

Covering the ears and rocking

Pressing the palms hard against the cheeks

The body quaking

Being unable to sit still

A strangled cry of frustration

A voice that breaks and sounds high pitched

Needing to move, pace, or destroy something

Clock-watching (or door-watching, text-watching, etc.)

Taking shallow, rapid breaths or gulping at the air

Rubbing the arms repetitively as if one is cold (a self-soothing gesture)

Gripping one wrist with the other hand and squeezing, using pain to focus

The posture collapsing, being unable to support one's weight

Clasping hands over one's head and bringing the elbows in tight

Pressing a fist against trembling lips

Slamming a hand into a wall; kicking, hitting, or destroying something for release

Wringing or dry washing one's hands

Gripping a symbol for comfort (holding a son's bear while waiting for news about the child's surgery outcome)

Running one's hands through the hair repeatedly

Needing to vocalize one's torment: *Waiting like this is destroying me!*

Grabbing fistfuls of hair and pulling (using physical pain to push back emotional pain)

Holding the stomach and doubling over

Massaging the throat to try and make swallowing and talking easier

Sensitivity to noise and touch (jumping, flinching, etc.)

Hands that shake and fumble

Pressing a fist against the chest and rubbing it as if to dislodge the pain

Lashing out, yelling, or screaming

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

An upset stomach

Nausea

A restricted throat

Pain in the chest

Feeling cold all over

An inability to draw deep breaths because one is reflexively pushing down on the diaphragm

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Praying, even if one doesn't normally do so

Making mental bargains: *I'll give up whatever I need to for this to be all right.*

Feeling shame and unworthiness for not avoiding this situation or doing something to prevent the terrible outcome that may result

Feeling paralyzed by hopelessness, guilt, and dread

The sensation that time has slowed or stopped

One's mind embracing the worst-case scenario and playing it out

Feeling as if one will never move on from this moment and the pain will be eternal

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Being unable to eat or drink

Being unable to form words
Tears that won't stop
An anxiety attack
Arms tense and hands open as if holding a ball, shaking with extreme force
Mentally shutting down; being unable to cope

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Turning away from other people to hide one's emotions
The body quaking with the force of held-in sobs
Being unable to speak
Fingernails biting into the palms so one can focus on the pain
Finding a way to escape the situation so one can be alone to process it (flight)

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Terror](#), [Hysteria](#), [Vulnerability](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Stunned](#), [Skepticism](#), [Relief](#), [Gratitude](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Beat, burn, clench, crush, cry, curse, grapple, grieve groan, hit, pummel, punish, quake, seethe, shake, shout, suffer, weep, worry, wring

WRITER'S TIP: *If you want readers to connect with a point-of-view character's emotions, consider how to make them likeable or sympathetic. This allows for empathy bonds to form.*

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UNAPPRECIATED

DEFINITION: Feeling undervalued, as if others don't see or acknowledge one's worth or contribution

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Sticking to the background

Standing in corners or against the wall

Staying behind the rest of the people in one's group

An expectant look upon being addressed that fades when no acknowledgement is forthcoming

Not sharing one's ideas or opinions

Only speaking if one is directly addressed

Standing with rounded shoulders

Fingers nervously or absently fiddling—with one's hair, a cuff, a zipper fob, etc.

Taking quiet steps

Keeping one's arms and legs close to one's side

Making oneself small when sitting (crossing one's legs, placing hands in one's lap, etc.)

Responding eagerly when one is given attention or shown gratitude

Speaking in a soft tone

Becoming uncomfortable when others pay one attention

Struggling with compliments

Walking with downcast eyes and a low chin

Working extra hard to try and win the approval of others (people-pleasing)

Pointedly reiterating how hard one has worked or what one has contributed

Taking pains with one's appearance so one can garner attention

Taking on difficult jobs as a way of showing one's capability

Refusing to cooperate (living up to the expectation)

Sabotaging oneself; deliberately doing a job poorly
Seeking quiet vengeance on those who fail to appreciate one's work
Becoming subservient; losing one's sense of self
When slighted, talking about the offender behind his back to others
Developing a martyr complex
Muttering under one's breath
Pouting and sulking
Snapping at someone in anger and then regretting it
Lips pressing tight, the chin trembling in anger
Fishing for compliments or appreciation
Laying guilt trips: *I'm always picking up after everyone and you sit there like it's expected.*
Hitting one's breaking point and refusing to help when it's needed
Hanging around, waiting for someone to express gratitude
Being extra careful to show gratitude to others

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A sinking sensation in one's midsection
Shriveling up inside each time one is dismissed
A fluttering in the stomach in the presence of those who make one feel marginalized
Twitchy fingers
Nausea

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Believing that one's actions aren't worth validating
Feeling badly about oneself (negative self-talk)
Placing oneself lower than others on a hierarchy of worth
Thinking like a martyr

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Becoming angry and bitter

Being uncooperative at work, home, or school
Becoming a natural target for bullies
Not volunteering oneself for jobs or projects
Getting used to being unappreciated and unnoticed
Keeping secrets from the offender (a boss, a spouse, etc.) and feeling justified about it
Taking the jobs no one else wants to do, since it will allow one to maintain anonymity
Underachieving
Subjugating oneself to the will of others
Becoming a wallflower
Desperately trying to be noticed by others (through one's actions, clothing choices, etc.)
Not expressing appreciation to others

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Shrugging off the lack of gratitude as if one doesn't care
Not doing anything for anyone so one doesn't have to face the lack of appreciation
Clinging to the people who are appreciative
Suppressed signs of bitterness or hurt around those who don't show appreciation (pressing the lips together, exhaling noisily through the nose, rolling the eyes, etc.)

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Betrayed](#), [Anger](#), [Bitterness](#), [Defiant](#), [Insecurity](#), [Worthlessness](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Uncertainty](#), [Gratitude](#), [Relief](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Avenge, avert, begrudge, fiddle, fidget, gossip, grumble, hide, lash out, mope, mumble, mutter, pout, resent, retreat, scowl, stutter, sulk

WRITER'S TIP: *With emotions, a natural reflex is to try and maintain control. See how far you can nudge a character to the edge of restraint. When it's important, shove them beyond it.*

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UNCERTAINTY

DEFINITION: The state of being unsure; unable to commit to a course of action

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Biting the lip or inside of the cheek

Frowning

Glancing at others to see what they think

Looking down

Asking others for advice or opinions

Hands that fidget (twisting together, rubbing down the front of one's pants, etc.)

A downcast expression

The forehead wrinkling

Squinting as one looks inward

Pinching or tugging on the bottom lip

Tilting the head from side to side, weighing one's choices

Rubbing the jaw or back of the neck

Pushing the hair out of the face

An impatient huff

Shuffling one's feet

Hesitating mid-action (while reaching for something or pulling out a wallet, etc.)

Starting a sentence with *Well...*; beating around the bush

Pulling back slightly

A grimace and a slight shake of the head

Asking questions to elicit more information

Making a *Hmmm* noise

Clearing one's throat

Swallowing

Stalling gestures, such as cracking the knuckles or sitting back in one's seat

Doodling on paper

Swaying or rocking on one's feet

Rubbing the lips or chin

Biting the inside of the cheek or bottom lip

Sighing

Rolling the neck

Tapping a pencil against a notepad or table

Jotting down notes to delay answering

A slumped posture—rounded shoulders, the head bowed, etc.

Staring at nothing for an overlong moment

Talking through the options aloud

Asking for reassurance

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Breaths that catch in the chest

Tenseness in one's stomach

Increased thirst

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Feeling trapped

Unease at one's options or choices

The mind racing through possibilities

A desperate need to find answers

Feeling flustered by a less-than-ideal situation

Making decisions, then second-guessing oneself

Shutting down; refusing to make a decision

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Self-doubt

Uncertainty that bleeds into other decisions and situations

Anger and frustration

Dismissing the situation without making a decision

Inability to make any decision on one's own

Researching (searching the web, speaking with professionals, etc.) to find answers

Going for a walk or leaving the situation in hopes of gaining a clear head

Repeatedly postponing or rescheduling events

An increased sense of desperation as time goes by and the situation is unresolved

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

A delayed response

A noncommittal answer: *Maybe*, or *We'll see*.

Changing the topic to avoid hurt feelings or an argument

Diversion rather than open support

A hesitant nod

Stalling for time (e.g., pouring a glass of water and drinking it)

Refusing to answer; letting the silence do the talking

Opening one's mouth to argue, then stopping

Acting noncommittal: *Let's put that in our back pocket for now, okay?*

Suggesting a vote of majority

Offering weak agreement or half-hearted support

Requesting more time before committing

Passive-aggressiveness

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Denial](#), [Doubt](#), [Frustration](#), [Unease](#), [Wariness](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Relief](#), [Acceptance](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Deflect, dither, drag, fiddle, fidget, frown, pause, procrastinate, reflect, research, second-guess, shuffle, stall,

suspend, vacillate, waver

WRITER'S TIP: *Maintain an overall perspective of emotional range as the story progresses from scene to scene. A strong manuscript will always expose the reader to contrasting emotional experiences that fit within the context of the POV character's growth.*

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UNEASE

DEFINITION: A restlessness of the body or mind

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Shaking one's head

Crossing and uncrossing the arms or legs

Shifting in one's chair

Twisting or pulling at clothing

Slipping one's hands into one's pockets

Sidelong glances while keeping the head still

Tsking or making a noise in the throat

Leaning away from the source

Drawing back

Making oneself smaller

Stopping to listen intently

Glancing quickly at the source of unease, then looking away

Chewing on a fingernail or picking at one's cuticles

Drawing the mouth into a straight line and biting the lip

Excessive swallowing

A shaky voice

Tugging clothes more firmly into place

Flipping the hair or combing one's fingers through it

Hiding behind one's bangs

Being unnaturally quiet

Throat-clearing

Frowning

Pushing food around on a plate

Gulping food down in order to escape more quickly

Trying to evade notice (slumping in a chair, withdrawing from conversation, etc.)

Turning slowly, unwillingly

Clutching an item tightly or holding it as a shield
Reluctantly speaking or approaching someone
Stilted, halting dialogue
A tapping heel
Checking a cell for messages or to see the time
Fiddling with jewelry or props
A swinging foot that suddenly goes still
Scrunching oneself up on a chair or sofa
Choosing a safe spot to wait
Flicking through a magazine without reading it
Lifting the chin in an attempt to look confident
Consciously forcing one's limbs to relax
Licking the lips
Hands that won't settle
Crossing and re-crossing one's legs
Tightening the hands into fists, then loosening them
Rigid posture
Nervous habits (picking off nail polish, humming under the breath, etc.)
Rubbing sweaty hands down the front of one's jeans
Constant motion (applying lip gloss, texting people, rooting in one's purse, etc.)

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A slight chill or shiver
Hair lifting on the back of the neck
A prickling of the scalp
A quiver in the stomach

MENTAL RESPONSES:

The feeling of being watched
Denial: *There's nothing wrong*, or *Stop overreacting*.
Impatience

Time feeling like it's slowing down
Heightened watchfulness

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Shifting from foot to foot as one struggles to remain still
Pacing
An unshakeable sense of something being wrong
Needing to leave but not understanding why
Feeling physically ill

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Trying to slow one's breathing
Attempting to loosen up by rolling the shoulders
An unfocused gaze as one strives for mental calm
Walking away to gain composure
Wide eyes
A quick, false smile
Studiously not looking at the source
Keeping at a distance
Talking too fast
Pretending to be unaware of a loud argument or uncomfortable situation

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Nervousness](#), [Worry](#), [Fear](#), [Anxiety](#), [Dread](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Resignation](#), [Acceptance](#), [Relief](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Chafe, fidget, hesitate, pace, placate, quell, question, rub, scratch, sense, shift, squirm, stir, stutter, tap, touch, twist, voice, worry, wriggle

WRITER'S TIP: *To create a stronger reader reaction to emotion, remember to focus on showing what triggers the feeling, rather than only showing the character's response to it.*

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VALIDATED

DEFINITION: Feeling that one's thoughts or opinions have been accepted or recognized as worthy

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

A smile taking over one's face

One's breaths becoming more steady and deep

A brightening countenance

Expounding on the idea that was accepted; going into further detail

Nodding the head vigorously

Listening eagerly to others

Sharing one's ideas more readily

A lifting of the chin and shoulders

The chest puffing out

Standing taller

Looking people in the eye

Facing people squarely when speaking to them

Eyes narrowing as one tries to block out other noises and pay attention to the speaker

Leaning in when talking to others

Relaxing enough to sit or lean back while others are talking

Gesturing more animatedly with one's hands

Leaning on one's elbows while sitting at a table, hands clasped

Becoming still, as if not wanting to draw attention now that one has established oneself; playing it safe

A cessation of nervous gestures

Speaking in a steady, confident voice

Speaking quickly

Becoming more generous (thanking people, gesturing kindly, showing helpfulness, etc.)

An excited or enthusiastic tone

The glance darting upward as one recalls information
Eyes that are focused intently on others
Being honest and earnest when supplying answers
Joining groups as an equal (rather than standing behind or fading into the background)
Being more willing to argue or disagree with others
Hands gripping each other or being held behind the back, as if to keep them still
Replaying the moment of validation to others, or repeating one's words in other conversations
Jumping into conversation when one sees a chance to add something else
Trying to hide signs of excitement and act cool
Being at ease enough to take a sip or bite of something

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A jittery feeling of excitement
Adrenaline shooting through one's body
One's senses becoming highly sensitive
A rush of relief at finally having been validated
An expanding feeling in one's chest

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Looking for opportunities to insert one's knowledge into a conversation
Replaying the moment of validation in one's mind
Thinking of other things one could have said
Considering possibilities for pressing one's advantage (instigating more conversations with the same people, researching certain topics to become more knowledgeable, etc.)
Being seemingly focused on others while thinking of what one can say next

Feeling kinship and loyalty toward the one(s) who recognized one's worth

Thinking negatively about the people who have been dismissive in the past

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Becoming overly confident

Speaking without thinking and undermining one's credibility

Not pursuing further knowledge (because one has "arrived")

Feeling superior to those whose opinions or ideas don't measure up to one's own

Being motivated to learn and grow so one can repeat the experience

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Putting the hands in the pockets to look more relaxed than one feels

Being distracted due to one secretly going over the moment in one's mind

Disengaging (to avoid saying anything stupid and negating the previous success)

Asking questions (to stay involved while keeping the attention on others)

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Relief](#), [Satisfaction](#), [Valued](#), [Pride](#), [Smugness](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Uncertainty](#), [Nervousness](#), [Insecurity](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Add, argue, assert, brag, chat, discuss, engage, gesticulate, gesture, help, hobnob, mingle, offer, preen, pursue, strut, talk, wave

WRITER'S TIP: *If a tense situation occurs and your character remains unmoved, you risk causing readers to disengage because it won't feel realistic. Make sure characters always respond—even in a surprising way—to show they feel something. If they don't react, be prepared to adequately show why.*

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VALUED

DEFINITION: Feeling worthy and cherished

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Standing strong, with the head held high

A purposeful stride

Taking a deep breath to center oneself and enjoy the moment

Smiling frequently and genuinely

Trying new things (not letting fear or doubt hold one back)

Politeness (saying *thank you* without hesitation, never interrupting others, etc.)

Becoming more talkative with others

Leaning in when others are talking

Initiating conversations

Maintaining strong eye contact

Making time for people

Laughter

Being positive and upbeat

Taking up more space (the legs firmly planted, a relaxed pose with a hand on one's hip, gesturing while speaking, etc.)

An easygoing, relaxed manner

Transparency (not keeping secrets or holding back)

Not engaging in gossip

Nodding and smiling as people speak

Cheering others on

Touching people to make interactions more personal (hugging, bumping shoulders, holding hands, etc.)

Friendliness

Never asking others for more than one is willing to give

Thoughtfulness (offering compliments, giving gifts, volunteering one's time, etc.)

Being a good listener
Staying on task and being motivated; not procrastinating
Focusing on one's work and family with dedication and vigor (staying late or making good use of one's time)
Following rules without hesitation
Listening intently when others speak
Smiling in response to someone calling out one's name
Being comfortable giving or receiving friendly touches (e.g., a shoulder tap)
Taking pride in one's appearance (dressing neatly, having good hygiene, etc.)
Offering to help often (taking on extra work, running errands, vouching for someone, etc.)
Doing favors with no ulterior motives
Generosity
Standing up for oneself

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Relaxed muscles
Easy breathing
A swelling feeling in the chest (lightness, tingling, etc.)

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Thinking about one's company, group, or country (whichever applies) and the good associated with it
Feeling blessed that one's path led to this place in life and the people in it
Wanting to give back and prove that the value is well placed
Feeling that one has found one's tribe
Longing to learn and gain new skills to better oneself
Wanting to give people what they want when they are deserving
A willingness to take more risks since others have one's back

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Working hard at a task; going the extra mile

Loyalty to those one serves

Feelings of well-being and satisfaction

Being open with one's ideas and opinions

A desire to get closer to people and build personal relationships

Wanting to pass the feeling on (letting others know they are appreciated and have worth)

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Needing reassurance or reinforcement before feeling secure: *Are you happy with my work?*

Creating situations where one will be praised if one is valued

Asking for feedback to better oneself: *What can I do better next time?*
or *How can I help you more?*

Striving for recognition

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Satisfaction](#), [Pride](#), [Confidence](#), [Happiness](#),
[Smugness](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Uncertainty](#), [Insecurity](#), [Hurt](#), [Scorn](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Advise, beam, build, care, cherish, collaborate, congratulate, dedicate, empower, exchange, express, gather, help, improve, include, joke, laugh, listen, mentor, open, pat, please, share, smile, socialize, support, touch, trust, validate

WRITER'S TIP: *To engage a reader's emotions, put characters in real-world scenarios they may identify with: sibling rivalries, telling the truth but not being believed, unreturned affections, etc.*

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VENGEFUL

DEFINITION: Vindictiveness; wanting to make someone pay for a past wrong

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Stiff posture and visible tension in one's muscles

An intense gaze; an unblinking stare

Tension in the jaw

Holding the chin up

Expanding the chest with a full breath, then holding it in

Flexing one's fingers or creating fists

Observing the target and biding one's time

Constantly venting to one's trusted circle about how one was wronged

Faking friendliness to get close to others and find weak points to exploit

Eavesdropping in the hopes of hearing something to use against the target

Discussing the target and possible revenge scenarios with one's supporters

Noting who and what the target cares about most

Creating connections with people around the target to find out information

Verbally criticizing the target when he or she is not around

Being two-faced

Lying easily and convincingly

Reading into what people say and do

Smirking

Rarely (if ever) apologizing for one's actions; viewing them as justified

Answering questions indirectly: *I might show up*, or *Good question. I'll let you know*.

Holding back information when it suits; enjoying the high of control

Taking purposeful strides toward the target
Invading the personal space of the target
Facing one's target directly and attempting to intimidate them (taking a wide stance, hands on the hips, strong gesturing, etc.)
Baring one's teeth slightly when interacting with the target
Offering false smiles and a forced tone
Stalking one's target (either physically or online)
Saying things to encourage self-doubt: *Worried about the meeting tomorrow? I would be.*
Verbally attacking one's target
Sowing dissent among the target's supporters: *She didn't tell you about the party? How odd.*
Making threats
Starting rumors about the target
Eyes that narrow or seem to flash with emotion when one is angered

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A rise in body temperature when the target is sighted
Blood rushing in one's ears
A heartbeat that quickens when one is near the target
Tightness or tingling in the chest
Muscles that tense up
Pressure in the jaw from clamping down
A rush of adrenaline when revenge is attained

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Obsessing about the target
Reliving the events that led to being wronged
Fantasizing about how to get even
Imagining the moment when one's target is brought low

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Violence

Stalking or following the person to intimidate or terrorize them

Destroying the target's property and cherished possessions

Involving the police (pressing false charges, making accusations—true or false—that will ruin them, etc.)

Taking revenge on innocents close to the target

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

False friendliness (smiling, giving compliments, appearing to forgive any slights, etc.)

Adhering to one's normal routine as if nothing is amiss

Continuing to engage with the target as one historically has—spending time together, texting, hanging out, etc.

Strategically laying revenge plans so they can't be traced back to oneself

Patience in waiting for the right moment

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Hatred](#), [Rage](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Doubt](#), [Uncertainty](#), [Defensiveness](#), [Embarrassment](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Creep, damage, destroy, eavesdrop, envy, follow, gather, heave, hurt, infest, infiltrate, malign, plan, plot, prep, prepare, push, rage, retaliate, sabotage, scratch, slap, smash, sneak, squeeze, stage, stalk, terrorize, twist, wait, want

WRITER'S TIP: *To put readers on edge, key into their own fears. A loved one not checking in when they should, finding the front door open and unlocked, an airplane crash on the news when one has to travel...these types of shared fears can impact a reader more deeply.*

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VINDICATED

DEFINITION: Being proven right, absolved of guilt, or set free

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Standing tall

Holding one's head high

The chest being thrust out proudly

Drawing big, chest-expanding breaths

Throwing one's head back with the eyes closed, relishing the moment

Smiling easily and broadly

Laying a fist over one's heart and keeping it there for a moment

Using the hands to cover one's smile, as if afraid to let it out

Shedding happy tears

Dancing or jumping in place

Nodding or closing the eyes while pressing together one's trembling lips

Celebrating with loved ones (hugging, grabbing them, spinning them around, etc.)

Whooping and yelling

Clapping one's hands

The posture sagging (tension letting go) before stiffening again to support the body

Speaking in a louder, brighter tone

Having an open body posture (arms flung out wide, legs apart, head thrown back, etc.)

Taunting one's enemies; rubbing the victory in their faces

Bowing one's head in a silent prayer of thanks

Feeling jittery in one's extremities

Pumping the fists

Taking a victory lap

Squatting down and hugging oneself

Expressing cautious hope (if one is skeptical and has been disappointed before)

Constant smiling

The voice rising in pitch

Pursuing goals or dreams one was previously afraid to go after

Speaking out in circumstances where one wasn't previously comfortable doing so

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A rush of adrenaline

Heart flutters

Feeling highly energetic; needing to move

A lack of sleepiness

A sense of exhaustion as the realization hits that one can finally rest in safety and peace

Euphoria

Being washed with a wave of peace and contentment

The face feeling stretched from nonstop smiling

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Having an optimistic outlook

The world looking suddenly brighter and more beautiful

Noticing details one missed before

Scattered thoughts

Difficulty focusing on any one thing

A renewed sense of faith in God, humanity, the system, etc.

A cessation of fear at the realization that the future is brighter for oneself and one's children

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Becoming braver; taking on opposition or challenges one wouldn't have before

Attempting to help others who might need vindicating
Seeking further reparations
Increased self-confidence
Positive personal changes (eating healthier, taking time for oneself,
etc.)
Getting cocky
Becoming an inspiration for others
Thinking about the future when one was previously unable to do so

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

A hidden smile that keeps trying to break through
Forcing one's body to be still
Clasping one's hands to keep them from twitching
Keeping the head down to hide any telltale signs
Taking calming breaths
Turning away or making a quick exit
Biting one's lip to keep from speaking
Lessened productivity due to the distraction of this meaningful victory
Sharing darting glances with the people who are on one's side

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Confidence](#), [Euphoria](#), [Satisfaction](#),
[Fearlessness](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Anger](#), [Defeat](#), [Despair](#), [Determination](#),
[Disappointment](#), [Discouraged](#), [Disillusionment](#), [Emasculated](#), [Frustration](#),
[Hopefulness](#), [Powerlessness](#), [Resentment](#), [Resignation](#), [Skepticism](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Beam, celebrate, clasp,
congratulate, dance, expand, flourish, give thanks, hug, jump, party, revel,
sag, shout, sigh, swell, whirl, whoop

WRITER'S TIP: *Some emotions, like confusion, should be shorter-lived or paired with another feeling. If the POV character is disoriented for too long, readers may struggle to follow what's happening in the scene.*

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VULNERABILITY

DEFINITION: Having one's guard lowered; feeling emotionally exposed

NOTES: Vulnerability can be a positive, negative, or mixed experience. A vulnerable person who feels fear may display protective gestures while a hopeful person purposefully making himself vulnerable may express more optimistic or open actions. It is also common for a character to progress from protective to open movements if he feels safe.

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Ducking one's chin to hide the neck

Avoiding eye contact or struggling to maintain it

Clasping one's arms in a self-soothing gesture

Shallow breaths

A quiet voice

Hesitations in speech

Holding the elbows tightly at one's sides

Using small movements

Eyes that widen slightly

Rubbing one's hands against one's clothing to dry them

Toying with one's necklace, watch, etc. to release nervous tension

Avoiding answering certain questions, or answering indirectly

Changing the subject

Visible swallowing

Wetting one's lips

Taking a hesitant step forward

A nervous smile

Tentatively placing a hand on someone's arm or shoulder to test the connection

Making self-deprecating comments in jest to lighten the mood

Increasing one's personal distance by taking a step back

Covering one's wrists

Taking a deep breath before doing or saying something that reveals one's vulnerability

Closing one's eyes for a moment before putting one's shoulders back and engaging

Taking extra care with one's appearance

Hesitating before moving closer; reaching out tentatively

Over-preparing for an event—excessive rehearsing of a speech, for example

Asking a personal question that allows someone an opportunity to be vulnerable in return

Hunching one's shoulders or curling up to take up less space

Clasping the hands in front of the groin or other sensitive area

Slightly turning one's body rather than facing others directly

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A tingling in the chest

A fluttering stomach

A dry mouth

The chest tightening

Bodily heaviness

Muscle tension

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Thoughts that flit between trust and worry, creating debate over the best course of action

A desire to trust or give in

Wanting to close the distance or touch another to feel safe or connect on a personal level

A desire to flee

Being open to suggestions

A desire to be honest and transparent but fearing what it will bring

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Forming deep, authentic relationships

A deep sense of self-acceptance

Not letting fear limit one's life choices

An ability to be intimate with others

Sharing secrets, ideas, and fears with the people one trusts

Achieving self-acceptance and viewing the ability to be vulnerable as a strength

Opening up too much and putting oneself in emotional danger

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Acting tough (false bravado, bragging, etc.)

Pretending not to care (having a closed body posture, a tight jaw, breaking eye contact, etc.)

Lashing out with insults, picking fights, or hurting others before they can hurt oneself

Verbal denial: *Oh, I'm fine, really. Everything's good.*

Changing the subject to something safer and less personal

Fleeing the situation

Lying and deception

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Happiness](#), [Satisfaction](#), [Powerlessness](#), [Defeat](#), [Insecurity](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Relief](#), [Surprise](#), [Disappointment](#), [Embarrassment](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Accept, acknowledge, admit, allow, care, choose, communicate, confess, connect, contribute, encircle, forgive,

foster, gift, give, hesitate, invite, join, lean, link, offer, open, press, reach, reveal, share, touch, trust, welcome

WRITER'S TIP: *If your character holds in emotion, at some point, these pent-up feelings will take a toll. Make sure that you follow-through with an explosive reaction or show the detrimental fallout in other ways (damaged relationships, a health crisis, a mental break, or whatever applies).*

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WANDERLUST

DEFINITION: A desire to explore, travel, and experience the unknown

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Eyes that are bright and engaged

The head moving frequently to take in one's surroundings

Good posture (shoulders back, the chest out, etc.)

Having a light step

An upbeat expression and genuine smile

Holding the head high

Taking one's time (stopping to smell the roses)

Struggling with rules and guidelines

Wanting to be outside rather than inside

Spontaneity

Friendliness

Having an easygoing nature

Introducing oneself first

Being resourceful with one's money (frugality)

A willingness to take risks

Being able to prioritize well

Open-mindedness to almost everything

Taking road trips or excursions whenever the chance presents itself

Avoiding too much planning

Having no patience for fussy people

Trying new things without feeling self-conscious

Being always on the move rather than sitting or standing in place

Spending time in nature (hiking, exploring, practicing photography, etc.)

Revealing interest through questions: *What is this? Where does that path go?*

Reading about other cultures, locations, ways of life, and self-development

Being highly curious: *I wonder what plants would grow at the top of a mountain?*

Frequently bringing travel into one's conversations

Becoming more animated when discussing adventures (moving one's hands, smiling, etc.)

Asking other people about where they've been and what they've experienced

Being unmaterialistic and happily getting by with less

Prizing experiences instead of things

Seeking out like-minded people

Being the first to try things

Having an ever-expanding comfort zone

Volunteering to be a guinea pig if doing so will provide a new experience

Downplaying travel-related dangers to loved ones so they won't worry

Being independent (solving one's problems, not worrying about what others think, etc.)

Never second-guessing (because there are no wrong decisions, only experiences)

Building deep and lasting relationships on the road

Being forthright rather than secretive

Encouraging loved ones to take a leap into the unknown

Telling others about one's travel experiences (and sometimes dominating the conversation)

Living for today rather than planning for tomorrow

Enjoying a place but not feeling possessive about it (being able to move on)

Enjoying trying new foods

Being sexually adventurous

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

An expansive feeling in the chest (deep breathing)

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Always thinking about the next trip or experience

An unquenchable desire to learn and grow

Feeling antsy when one is stationary for too long (at work, where one lives, etc.)

Heightened senses

Having a strong imagination

Creative problem solving

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Becoming highly empathetic

Caring about the planet and becoming involved in advocacy

Confidence that increases with every experience

Feeling part of the world and something larger than oneself

Obtaining wisdom through cultural exposure and experiences

Becoming a globetrotter

Knowing more than one language

Blending the practices and traditions of other cultures into one's own

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Surfing travel blogs and websites

Collecting pictures of the places one wishes to visit in the future

Studying other countries and cultures and sharing one's learning with others

Writing about adventure and discovery to have an outlet

Buying a travel backpack just to have it close

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Anticipation](#), [Elation](#), [Satisfaction](#), [Awe](#), [Gratitude](#), [Connectedness](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Disappointment](#), [Dissatisfaction](#),
[Homesick](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Admire, anticipate, appreciate, behold, celebrate, crave, dare, delight, discover, dream, embark, excite, explore, fascinate, grow, indulge, join, launch, long, love, marvel, plunge, shine, stir, stun, taste, thrill, trek, uncover, unfold, wander

WRITER'S TIP: *With more subtle emotions, a “tell” can be an effective way to show that your character is uncomfortable or out of their element. Set it up early with a bit more detail so readers will recognize its importance.*

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WARINESS

DEFINITION: Mistrust marked by caution and watchfulness; being alert to possible danger

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Cocking the head to the side

Eyes narrowing, as if in confusion

Pursing the lips

Lowering the brows

Cutting the eyes toward the source

Holding up the hands in a defensive stance

Speaking in a soothing, placating voice

Backing away

The posture perking up as awareness increases

Sidestepping while keeping one's gaze on the source

Actively listening for something

Lifting the chin

Keeping one's hands free

Taking note of possible exits

Being aware of what lies behind

Asking questions

Circling; approaching someone or something in a roundabout fashion

Slow, cautious movements

Speaking rapidly, with the intent of maintaining the status quo

Standing back and observing before jumping in

Stiffening and going still

A strained or tense voice

Flinching when touched

Hesitation

Biting one's lip or pressing the lips together

A probing gaze

Careful words
A furrowed brow
An inability to relax or smile
Rubbing at the forehead or temples
Gritting the teeth
A stern or serious expression
A jutting jaw
Saying something (*I should go*) or doing something (stepping toward an exit) as a test
Being alert to sudden movements

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Increased adrenaline
Rapid heartbeat and pulse
Tense muscles
Tightness in the gut
One's breath catching or stopping briefly
An intuitive feeling that something isn't right (hairs standing up, the skin prickling, etc.)

MENTAL RESPONSES:

The mind trying to discern possible danger
Trusting one's gut feelings
Heightened senses
Defensiveness
Thoughts that race while one tries to make sense of the situation
Confusion
Difficulty committing fully to any action
A finely tuned sense of observation
Weighing the information one should share and/or choosing to hold back
Trying to see and hear everything at once

Thinking ahead to what might happen

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Increasing one's personal space

Positioning oneself to create a barrier (moving behind a table, etc.)

Arguing without aggression, only to provide insight

Scanning for potential weapons

Paying closer attention to other people's body language and tone of voice

Asking questions one knows the answers to in an effort to discern another's intent

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Standoffishness

Looking from lowered lids

Attempting to lighten the mood with a joke

A posture that suggests discomfort (standing by oneself, clamping the hands around the waist, etc.)

Leaning away

Hesitation

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Anxiety](#), [Fear](#), [Unease](#), [Suspicion](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Relief](#), [Resignation](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Analyze, evade, falter, flinch, hesitate, hold back, inhale, interrogate, pause, prompt, recoil, sidle, stiffen, tense, test, tilt, watch, waver

WRITER'S TIP: When writing emotion, pull from your own past. Even if you haven't experienced what the POV character is going through, chances are you've felt the same emotion about something else. Draw on your personal experience and bring life to the story.

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WISTFUL

DEFINITION: A yearning (tinged with sadness or regret) for change that one believes is likely out of reach

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

A weak, pensive smile

Pressing the lips and glancing down

A far-off look

Growing quiet

Breaths that slow and deepen

The chin dipping slightly

A visible swallow

Letting out a sigh that is a mixture of hope and sadness

Voicing a thoughtful sentiment or yearning: *I wish it could be different, don't you?*

Holding oneself, arms crossed, and rubbing the forearms with one's thumbs

A slow nod while frowning slightly

Reaching out to another in solidarity (clasping their shoulder, taking their hand, etc.)

A voice thickening with emotion

Sharing a sad smile with someone who understands (and has the same yearning)

Laying one hand on top of the other

Talking to oneself (to process complicated feelings or draw comfort from words that one would not feel comfortable voicing around others)

Lightly clasping one's hands together

Light and happiness entering one's expression when remembering a past memory

Closing one's eyes and taking a deep, cleansing breath

Body posture softening, the spine curling slightly

Shoulders that lower or fall slightly
Leaving a task and sitting quietly for a moment
Gently crossing the ankles (while sitting)
Laying a hand on one's breastbone
Discussing what the alternate reality would look like with another
Verbalizing confusion at God's plan but having faith in it (if one is religious)
Lightly stroking the throat while one is lost in thought
Leaning back in a chair, the body relaxing during reflection
Briefly letting go of day-to-day concerns to stop, notice the world, and reflect on something deeper
Sharing a memory of a happier time when it seemed like an option or path was possible
Comforting oneself by applying optimism to the situation: *I would have chosen someone else to lead, but maybe he'll be good for the city.*

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A slight heaviness in the chest
Feeling a slight lump in the throat
A tingling sensation on the arms and nape of the neck
An increased sensitivity to temperature

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Briefly becoming lost in the past
Being triggered by symbols, sensory stimuli, etc. that remind one of the yearning
Wishing things were different
Daydreaming about an alternative reality
Feeling that one has settled; experiencing melancholy about the way things turned out
Remembering past difficulties and how things did eventually get easier (staying hopeful)

Thinking about life and one's place in a bigger, more meaningful way
Experiencing regret that one can't change the past

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Tears that come, unrestrained
A thickening in the throat that feels painful
Having difficulty reengaging with one's reality after periods of wistful thinking
Increased fantasizing about a life where things are different
A life marked by sadness and unfulfillment
Moving elsewhere to separate oneself from reminders of what could have been
Resolving to live a life unmarked by regret

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Voicing the good in one's life; focusing on what one has rather than what is missing
Clearing the throat to disrupt one's thoughts and return to the real world
Changing the topic or asking an unrelated question
Chastising oneself (or others) for daydreaming
Turning to a task and redoubling one's efforts (to keep the mind from wandering)

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Longing](#), [Dissatisfaction](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Acceptance](#), [Sadness](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Ache, bear, cherish, covet, crave, desire, dream, envision, envy, fade, fantasize, grow, imagine, itch, long, mourn, muse, need, pine, regret, remember, seek, speak, stare, struggle, subdue, thirst, wish, withdraw, wonder, yearn

WRITER'S TIP: *Does your character have a trait they take pride in? If so, create an emotional situation that causes them to doubt that trait or skill, leading to internal conflict.*

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WORRY

DEFINITION: Mental distress that arises from disturbing thoughts, usually regarding some anticipated event

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

Wrinkling the brow
Biting one's lip
Pinching the skin at the throat
Feet that bounce or tap
Pulling or twisting one's hair
Going quiet; turning inward
Drinking too much coffee or smoking excessively
Circles under the eyes
One's eyebrows drawing together
Tossing and turning in bed; an inability to sleep
Asking too many questions
Stroking or rubbing an eyebrow
Wearing rumpled, unwashed clothes
Rubbing one's hands on a pant leg
Lank or unwashed hair
Poor communication with others
Repeatedly rubbing the face
A gaze that flits around the room, never settling on a person or object for long
Clinging to loved ones
Taking deep breaths in an effort to calm oneself
Engaging in pointless activities to stay busy
Calling in sick
A stooped posture
Clutching at a sweater, purse, or necklace for comfort
Biting the nails or chewing on a knuckle

Running a jerky hand through the hair
Smoothing and re-smoothing one's clothing
Clasping one's hands together
A stiff neck
Strained muscles
A pained or watery gaze
Clearing the throat
Blinking less (as if worried one might miss something)
Fidgeting—having a hard time sitting still, needing to pace, etc.
Sitting, then standing, then sitting again

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

A loss of appetite
A sensitive stomach
Heartburn or other digestive issues
Dry mouth
A constricted throat

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Uncertainty over choices made
An unwillingness to leave a place of safety
An inability to focus
A need to control
Regret for a past action
Distancing oneself from others
Reading into things; overanalyzing
Assuming the worst-case scenario
Overprotectiveness
Irritability

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Weight loss

Premature gray
New wrinkles
Slipping grades at school or poor performance at work
Ulcers
Anxiety attacks
Panic disorders
High blood pressure
Heart disease
Increased sickness due to a compromised immune system
Insomnia and fatigue
Hypochondria

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Furtively watching the clock or door
Jumpiness
A strained or faked smile
Adopting new hobbies to distract oneself
Putting up a false front as if everything is okay
A shortened attention span
Humming that feels forced or fades quickly after it starts
Going about one's daily activities with the mind somewhere else

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Wariness](#), [Fear](#), [Anxiety](#), [Paranoia](#), [Dread](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Uncertainty](#), [Unease](#), [Relief](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Agitate, ask, clutch, complain, criticize, demand, droop, fiddle, fret, fuss, hover, investigate, mutter, nag, obsess, pace, pull, repeat, stew, twirl, twist

WRITER'S TIP: *Weather details can add texture and meaning to a scene. Consider how a character's mood can shift because of the weather. It can also stand in the way of their goals, providing tension.*

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WORTHLESSNESS

DEFINITION: Feeling devalued, unimportant, and insignificant

PHYSICAL SIGNALS AND BEHAVIORS:

An inward, pained look (eyes drawing closer, brow creased, slackness in the face, etc.)

Avoiding eye contact, looking down

Keeping one's hands hidden (in pockets, jammed into armpits, etc.)

Hesitating when speaking; having difficulty getting words out

Mumbling or talking in a soft-spoken voice

Low energy

Taking up as little space as possible

Collapsed body posture (shoulders that curl forward, the arms hanging limply, etc.)

Being non-reactive (expressing little emotion)

Shielding one's body (half-turning away, talking to the side rather than facing someone head on, crossing the arms or gripping the opposite elbow with a hand, etc.)

Moving slowly (shuffling, dragging one's feet, etc.)

Self-soothing gestures (rubbing the arms, stroking a sleeve, etc.)

Showing surprise when someone engages and responding awkwardly, unsure of how to act

Craving connection yet avoiding social situations and events

Taking insults and bullying rather than challenge them

Flinching at criticisms and needing to escape

Withdrawing; wanting to be alone

Avoiding situations where comparisons are likely (feeling inferior)

Not expressing one's opinions due to the belief that they're invalid

Refusing to speak up or advocate for oneself

Underachieving or avoiding setting any goals

Refusing to ask for help due to the belief that one doesn't deserve it

Not taking care of one's health, hygiene, etc.
Frequently breaking down into tears
Watching oneself cry in the mirror to feel "seen"
Deflecting compliments by citing one's faults or failings instead
Self-deprecation
Feeling alone, even with other people
Giving up easily (expecting failure)
Saying yes to whatever is asked, even if it is unfair or causes hardship

INTERNAL SENSATIONS:

Eyes that grow hot
Heavy, dull pain throughout the body
Experiencing physical pain in the chest or stomach when imagining the future
An almost constant ache in the throat
Difficulty pulling in deeper breaths (tightness in the chest)

MENTAL RESPONSES:

Mental fuzziness and detachment
Thoughts that circle failure, creating a self-fulfilling prophecy
Demoralizing self-talk: *Just shut up. No one cares about your ideas anyway.*
Consistently doubting one's abilities
Feeling inadequate in every way; yearning to be someone else
Being prone to envy and jealousy
Viewing any mistake (big or small) as confirmation of one's worthlessness
Feeling that others are judging one negatively (inferiority complex)
Becoming overwhelmed—even moved to tears—by beauty

ACUTE OR LONG-TERM RESPONSES FOR THIS EMOTION:

Constant fatigue

Poor performance at work or school
Seeking out anyone (even toxic people) who provide one with a sense of value
Cutting and other self-harming behaviors
Taking risks with one's life and leaving the outcome up to chance
Engaging in bad habits (drugs, unprotected sex, etc.) to cope and not caring about the effects
Depression
Suicidal thoughts or attempts

SIGNS THAT THIS EMOTION IS BEING SUPPRESSED:

Forming and sustaining dysfunctional or toxic relationships
Lowering one's standards and expectations
Pasting on a fake smile
Lying about one's life, activities, success, etc. to pretend one is someone "better"
Making excuses for the mean or abusive people in one's life
Pretending that one's kindnesses toward others are due to altruism rather than one's low self-worth

MAY ESCALATE TO: [Shame](#), [Depressed](#), [Self-Loathing](#)

MAY DE-ESCALATE TO: [Stunned](#), [Neglected](#), [Hopefulness](#), [Insecurity](#)

ASSOCIATED POWER VERBS: Avoid, belittle, blame, cope, cringe, cry, detach, dismiss, disregard, expose, flinch, hate, hide, hunch, hurt, loathe, neglect, recoil, reject, reveal, shield, shrug, slump, sob, stoop, stress, struggle, suffer, undercut, weaken, weep

WRITER'S TIP: *If you aren't happy with an emotional response, change the setting. If the character is alone, put them around people. If they are with others, isolate them or take away their comfort zone.*

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RECOMMENDED READING

To read further on character emotion and how to convey it well, try these excellent resources.

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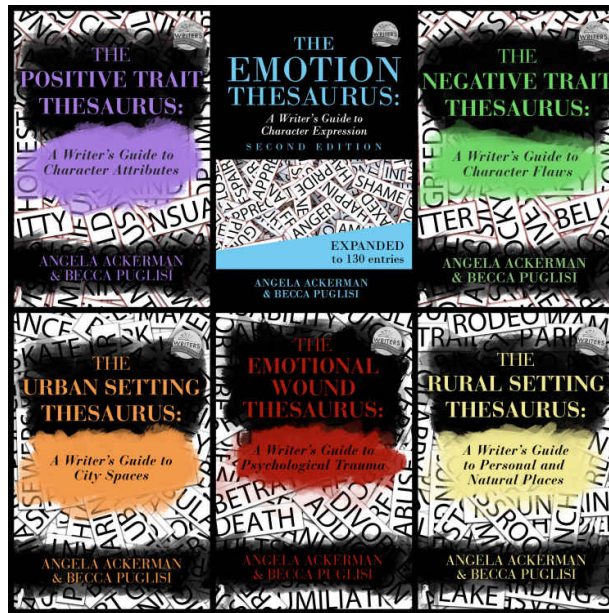
[*The Definitive Book of Body Language*](#) is meant to help you personally read other people and enrich your communication—necessary information for any author wanting to effectively write body language, attitude, and emotions for readers. (Allan & Barbara Pease)

[*Characters, Emotion & Viewpoint*](#) provides you with the techniques you need to create characters and stories sure to linger in the hearts and minds of agents, editors, and readers long after they've finished your book. (Nancy Kress)

[*Creating Character Emotion*](#) will help you find fresh, creative images, words, and gestures to evoke feelings in your fiction. (Ann Hood)

[*Telling Lies: Clues to Deceit in the Marketplace, Politics, and Marriage*](#) discusses how a person's body language, voice, and facial expressions can give away a lie but still fool others—helpful information when you need to write a character who isn't being honest with others and with readers. (Paul Ekman)

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~ **Michael Hauge, Hollywood script consultant and
author of *Writing Screenplays That Sell***

THE URBAN AND RURAL SETTING THESAURUSES

“The one thing I always appreciate about Ackerman and Puglisi's Thesauri series is how comprehensive they are. They never stop at just the obvious, and they always over-deliver. Their Setting Thesauri are no different, offering not just the obvious notes of the various settings they've covered but going into easy-to-miss details like smells and tastes. They even offer to jumpstart the brainstorming with categories on potential sources of conflict.”

~ K.M. Weiland, best-selling author of *Creating Character Arcs* and *Structuring Your Novel*

THE EMOTIONAL WOUND THESAURUS

“This is far more than a brilliant, thorough, insightful, and unique thesaurus. This is the best primer on story—and what REALLY hooks and holds readers—that I have ever read.”

~ Lisa Cron, TEDx Speaker and best-selling author of *Wired For Story* and *Story Genius*

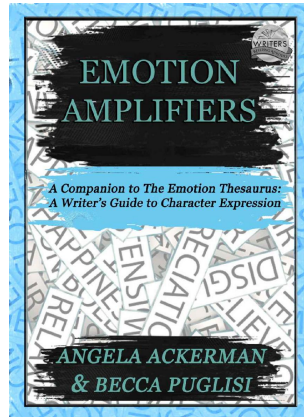


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EMOTION AMPLIFIERS



Did you know there's a companion to *The Emotion Thesaurus*?

While *The Emotion Thesaurus* was written to help authors convey character emotions to readers, there are also ways to amplify what a character is feeling, thereby heightening their responses. In *Emotion Amplifiers*, a complementary ebooklet to *The Emotion Thesaurus*, we explore common conditions that naturally galvanize emotion. Exhaustion, boredom, illness, pain, extreme hunger, and the like can push characters to their limits, compromising their decision-making abilities and decreasing the likelihood of them reaching their goals.

Emotion Amplifiers is a great tool for any writer wishing to tighten the screws on their characters and ramp up the tension in their stories. Here are the amplifiers you can find in this publication:

Addiction
Attraction
Boredom
Cold
Dehydration
Distraction
Exhaustion
Hangover
Heat

Hunger
Illness
Inebriation
Lethargy
Overstimulation
Pain
Relaxation
Stress

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Happy writing!

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ABOUT THE AUTHORS

Angela Ackerman and Becca Puglisi are best-selling authors, writing coaches, and international speakers. Their books are available in multiple languages, are sourced by US universities, and are used by novelists, screenwriters, editors, and psychologists around the world. They also co-founded the popular [Writers Helping Writers](#)[®] site as well as [One Stop for Writers](#)[®], both of which contain innumerable resources for writers looking to hone their craft.

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